Lives of the Bible

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A Small-Group Study of 170 People in Scripture

VOLUME I

The Old Testament

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Lives of the Bible: A Small-Group Study of 170 People in Scripture. Volume I: The Old Testament.

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Scripture quotations are from the King James Version (KJV).

Dates are approximate. Later tradition and debated views are labelled as such and are not presented as Scripture.

Free printable handouts for every chapter: mramachandran.github.io/sermon_notes

How to use this book

Lives of the Bible is a small-group study of 170 people in Scripture, from Adam to the early church. This volume covers the old testament.

One person, four pages

Every chapter follows the same pattern, so a group always knows what to expect:

1. **Overview.** Who they were, key facts at a glance, and a key verse.
2. **Timeline.** The main moments of their life, each with its reference.
3. **Key activities.** What they actually did, numbered and referenced.
4. **Across Scripture.** Every Old and New Testament passage that mentions them, plus four discussion questions.

Direct references are kept separate from thematic echoes, and later tradition is labelled so it is never passed off as Scripture.

Using it in a group

One chapter fits one meeting of about 45 minutes. Lined space for group notes is left on the pages wherever it fits.

Scripture

Quotations are from the King James Version. Dates are approximate and follow common scholarly estimates.

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I Adam

The first man, formed from dust, who lost paradise and became the pattern for "the last Adam."

Adam is the first human being in the Bible and the father of the human family. God formed him from the dust, breathed life into him, and placed him in a garden with good work to do and one command to keep. With Eve, he broke that command, and the story of sin and death begins. Yet God sought him out, clothed him, and promised that the serpent would one day be crushed. Paul calls Jesus "the last Adam," the one who undoes what the first Adam did.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *adam*, "man," linked with *adamah*, "ground"
Family	Wife Eve; sons Cain, Abel, Seth and others (Genesis 5:4)
When	At the beginning; no calendar date given
Key places	The garden "eastward in Eden" (Genesis 2:8)
Key people	Eve, the serpent, Cain, Abel, Seth
Lifespan	930 years (Genesis 5:5)
Main passages	Genesis 1:26–5:5
New Testament	Luke 3:38; Romans 5:12–21; 1 Corinthians 15

"And the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul."

Genesis 2:7, KJV

The life of Adam

Genesis gives no calendar dates for Adam. Ages follow the Hebrew text; the Septuagint differs. Ussher (1650) placed creation at 4004 BC. Christians differ on reading Genesis 1–3 as six ordinary days or as real history told in a literary way.

Day six

Created in God's image

God creates humankind in his image; the LORD God forms the man from dust and breathes life into him. *Genesis 1:26–31; 2:7*

In Eden

Given work and a command

God puts the man in the garden "to dress it and to keep it," forbidding only the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. *Genesis 2:8–17*

In Eden

Names the animals; Eve is made

No fitting helper is found among the beasts. God makes the woman from Adam's rib, and Adam welcomes her. *Genesis 2:18–25*

In Eden

The fall

The woman eats and gives also "unto her husband with her; and he did eat." They hide from God among the trees. *Genesis 3:1–8*

In Eden

Judged, clothed and sent out

Adam blames the woman. God curses the ground, makes coats of skins, and sends them out. *Genesis 3:9–24*

After Eden

Father of Cain and Abel

Cain kills his brother, and sin reaches the next generation. *Genesis 4:1–16*

Age 130

Seth is born

Adam fathers a son "in his own likeness, after his image," and names him Seth. *Genesis 4:25; 5:3*

Age 930

Dies

After 800 more years and more children, Adam dies, returning to the dust as God said. *Genesis 3:19; 5:4–5*

Key activities

The Bible never says the forbidden fruit was an apple. That idea comes from later tradition and art.

1. **Received the breath of life.** Adam did not make himself. God formed him from dust and gave him life. *Genesis 2:7*
2. **Bore God's image.** He and the woman were made in God's image and told to fill the earth and rule over it. *Genesis 1:26–28*
3. **Worked the garden.** God put him in Eden to tend and guard it. Work was part of life before sin entered. *Genesis 2:15*
4. **Received one command.** He could eat from every tree but one. Disobedience would bring death. *Genesis 2:16–17*
5. **Named the animals.** He named every living creature God brought to him, but found no helper fit for him. *Genesis 2:19–20*
6. **Welcomed his wife.** He greeted the woman as "bone of my bones, and flesh of my flesh." The text then gives the pattern for marriage. *Genesis 2:22–24*
7. **Ate the forbidden fruit.** He was with his wife when she ate, and he took the fruit from her and ate. *Genesis 3:6*
8. **Hid in fear.** He sewed fig leaves and hid among the trees. "I was afraid, because I was naked; and I hid myself." *Genesis 3:7–10*
9. **Shifted the blame.** He answered God, "The woman whom thou gavest to be with me, she gave me of the tree, and I did eat." *Genesis 3:11–12*
10. **Named his wife Eve.** After hearing the sentence of death, he named her Eve, "because she was the mother of all living." *Genesis 3:20*
11. **Left the garden.** He was sent out to till the ground from which he was taken. *Genesis 3:23–24*
12. **Raised a family.** He fathered Cain, Abel, Seth, and other sons and daughters. Through Seth the line continues toward Noah. *Genesis 4:1–2, 25; 5:3–4*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Adam.

Old Testament

Genesis 1:26–5:5	The main account of his life
Genesis 3:15	The woman's seed will bruise the serpent's head
Genesis 5:1–5	"The book of the generations of Adam"
1 Chronicles 1:1	Israel's genealogies start with Adam
Job 31:33; Hosea 6:7	*Adam* or "man"? Translators differ
Echo: Psalm 8:4–6	Humankind crowned to rule God's works

New Testament

Luke 3:38	Jesus' genealogy ends "the son of Adam"
Romans 5:12–21	Sin entered by one man; Adam a figure of Christ
1 Corinthians 15:22, 45	"In Adam all die"; Christ "the last Adam"
1 Timothy 2:13–14	Adam formed first; churches differ on application
Echo: Revelation 22:2–3	The tree of life and "no more curse"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Adam answer when God asked, "Where art thou?" (Genesis 3:9–12)?
2. *Understand:* Adam blamed the woman and, in a way, God. Why is blame so natural?
3. *Apply:* God gave Adam work before the fall (Genesis 2:15). How does that shape how you see your work?
4. *Apply:* In Christ all are made alive (1 Corinthians 15:22). Where do you need that hope this week?

2 Eve

The first woman and "the mother of all living," who was deceived and yet received the first promise of hope.

Eve is the first woman in Scripture, made by God from Adam's side to be his partner. Her story holds both the goodness of creation and the tragedy of the fall. She listened to the serpent, doubted God's word, and ate the forbidden fruit. She then shared it with her husband. Yet Eve is also the woman whose "seed" God promised would bruise the serpent's head. She became a mother, grieved a murdered son, and still named her third son as a sign of God's faithfulness. Her life shows how temptation works, how sin spreads through a family, and how God's promise keeps going anyway.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Chavvah*, linked with "living" (Genesis 3:20). Adam first calls her "Woman" (Genesis 2:23)
Family	Husband Adam; sons Cain, Abel and Seth, plus other sons and daughters (Genesis 4:1–2, 25; 5:4)
When	At the beginning. Scripture gives no calendar date (see the note on the next page)
Key places	The garden of Eden; the land outside Eden
Key people	Adam, the serpent, Cain, Abel, Seth
Death	Not recorded
Main passages	Genesis 2:18–4:2; 4:25
New Testament	2 Corinthians 11:3; 1 Timothy 2:13–14

"And Adam called his wife's name Eve; because she was the mother of all living."

Genesis 3:20, KJV

The life of Eve

Genesis gives no calendar dates or ages for Eve. The order below follows the text. As with Adam, Christians differ on whether Genesis 1–3 is best read as literal history or as history told in a more literary way.

Day six

Made in God's image

God creates humankind "male and female" in his image and blesses them together. *Genesis 1:27–28*

In Eden

Made from Adam's side

It is not good for the man to be alone. God makes the woman from Adam's rib, and Adam receives her with joy. *Genesis 2:18–25*

In Eden

Tempted

The serpent asks, "Yea, hath God said…?" Eve adds to God's command ("neither shall ye touch it"). The serpent then denies that she will die. *Genesis 3:1–5*

In Eden

Eats and gives

She sees that the tree is good for food, pleasant to the eyes and desirable to make one wise. She eats and gives to her husband with her. *Genesis 3:6–7*

In Eden

Judged and named

Eve says, "The serpent beguiled me, and I did eat." God promises enmity between the serpent and her seed, and pain in childbearing. Adam names her Eve. *Genesis 3:13–20*

After Eden

Clothed and sent out

God makes coats of skins for Adam and his wife and sends them out of the garden. *Genesis 3:21–24*

After Eden

Mother of Cain and Abel

She bears Cain, saying, "I have gotten a man from the LORD," and then Abel. Later Cain kills Abel. *Genesis 4:1–8*

After Eden

Mother of Seth

She bears Seth, saying God has appointed "another seed instead of Abel, whom Cain slew." *Genesis 4:25*

Key activities

Genesis does not name the serpent as Satan. The New Testament makes that link (Revelation 12:9; 20:2).

1. **Shared God's image and blessing.** She was made in God's image and received the command to fill and rule the earth with Adam. *Genesis 1:27–28*
2. **Became Adam's partner.** God made her as "an help meet for him," a helper fit for him, and brought her to the man. *Genesis 2:18, 21–22*
3. **Listened to the serpent.** She entered a conversation that questioned God's goodness and his word. *Genesis 3:1–3*
4. **Misquoted God's command.** She added "neither shall ye touch it," words God had not said to Adam in Genesis 2. *Genesis 2:17; 3:3*
5. **Ate the forbidden fruit.** Drawn by what looked good, pleasant and wise, she took and ate. *Genesis 3:6*
6. **Gave to her husband.** She passed the fruit to Adam, who was with her. *Genesis 3:6*
7. **Hid from God.** With Adam she sewed fig leaves and hid among the trees. *Genesis 3:7–8*
8. **Told what happened.** When God questioned her, she answered, "The serpent beguiled me, and I did eat." *Genesis 3:13*
9. **Heard the first promise.** God said her seed would bruise the serpent's head. Many Christians read this as the first promise of the gospel. *Genesis 3:15*
10. **Received her name.** Adam named her Eve, "the mother of all living," even after the sentence of death. *Genesis 3:20*
11. **Gave birth.** She bore Cain and Abel and credited the LORD with the gift of a son. *Genesis 4:1–2*
12. **Hoped again after grief.** After Abel's death she named Seth as God's appointed seed. *Genesis 4:25*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Eve.

Old Testament

Genesis 2:18–4:2; 4:25	The main account of her life
Genesis 5:1–2	Male and female, blessed and "called their name Adam"
Echo: Isaiah 26:17–18	Pain in childbirth as longing for rescue

New Testament

2 Corinthians 11:3	"As the serpent beguiled Eve through his subtilty"
1 Timothy 2:13–15	Eve deceived; churches differ on how it applies
Matthew 19:4–6	Jesus quotes Genesis on marriage, without naming Eve
Revelation 12:9; 20:2	The "old serpent" identified as Satan
Echo: Romans 16:20	God will crush Satan under his people's feet
Echo: Galatians 4:4	Jesus "made of a woman"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did Eve see in the tree before she ate (Genesis 3:6)?
2. *Understand:* The serpent began by questioning God's word. Why is that doubt such a powerful first step?
3. *Apply:* Eve added to God's command. Where are we tempted to make God's word harsher or softer?
4. *Apply:* Eve named Seth in hope after loss (Genesis 4:25). Where do you need to see God's faithfulness?

3 Cain

The first son and the first murderer, warned by God that sin was crouching at his door.

Cain was the firstborn of Adam and Eve and the first person born in the Bible. He worked the ground like his father. When God accepted his brother Abel's offering but not his own, Cain grew angry. God warned him that sin was waiting to master him, but Cain killed Abel in the field. Even then, God questioned him, judged him, and protected him from being killed in turn. Cain went out from God's presence, built a city, and fathered a line known for both skill and violence. His story shows how quickly sin grew after Eden, and how God speaks to us before we fall.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Qayin*. It sounds like Eve's word "gotten" in Genesis 4:1
Family	Son of Adam and Eve; brother of Abel and Seth; father of Enoch (Genesis 4:1–2, 17)
Work	"A tiller of the ground" (Genesis 4:2)
Key places	The field; the land of Nod, east of Eden; the city he named Enoch (Genesis 4:8, 16–17)
Key people	Adam, Eve, Abel, his son Enoch, his descendant Lamech
Main passages	Genesis 4:1–24
New Testament	Hebrews 11:4; 1 John 3:12; Jude 11

> *"If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted? and if thou doest not well, sin lieth at the door. And unto thee shall be his desire, and thou shalt rule over him."*
>
> Genesis 4:7, KJV

The life of Cain

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Cain. The order below follows the text.

After Eden

Born to Eve

Eve bears her first son and says, "I have gotten a man from the LORD." *Genesis 4:1*

Grown

Works the ground

Abel keeps sheep, "but Cain was a tiller of the ground." *Genesis 4:2*

Later

Brings an offering

Cain brings fruit of the ground to the LORD. God respects Abel's offering but not Cain's, and Cain's face falls in anger. *Genesis 4:3–5*

Then

Warned by God

God asks why he is angry and warns that sin is lying at the door, but that he must rule over it. *Genesis 4:6–7*

In the field

Kills Abel

Cain talks with his brother, and in the field he rises up against Abel and kills him. *Genesis 4:8*

Afterward

Judged and marked

God asks, "Where is Abel thy brother?" Cain says, "Am I my brother's keeper?" God curses him to be a wanderer. When Cain fears being killed, God sets a mark on him for protection. *Genesis 4:9–15*

East of Eden

Settles in Nod

Cain goes out from the presence of the LORD to the land of Nod. He fathers Enoch and builds a city named after him. *Genesis 4:16–17*

Group notes

Key activities

Genesis does not say why God rejected Cain's offering. Some point to the kind of gift; Hebrews 11:4 points to faith. Genesis also does not name Cain's wife. A common view is that she was one of Adam's daughters (Genesis 5:4). Scripture does not say what the mark was.

1. **Worked the ground.** He took up the work given to Adam after the fall. *Genesis 3:23; 4:2*
2. **Brought an offering.** He brought "of the fruit of the ground" to the LORD, but it was not accepted. *Genesis 4:3–5*
3. **Grew angry.** He was very angry, and his face fell. *Genesis 4:5*
4. **Ignored God's warning.** God urged him to do well and to master sin before it mastered him. *Genesis 4:6–7*
5. **Killed his brother.** He attacked Abel in the field, the first murder in Scripture. *Genesis 4:8*
6. **Denied and dodged.** He lied ("I know not") and asked, "Am I my brother's keeper?" *Genesis 4:9*
7. **Cried out under judgment.** He said, "My punishment is greater than I can bear," and feared for his life. *Genesis 4:13–14*
8. **Built a city.** He fathered Enoch and named a city after him. *Genesis 4:17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Cain.

Old Testament

Genesis 4:1–16	The whole account of Cain
Genesis 4:17–24	His line, down to boastful, violent Lamech
Genesis 4:25	Seth given "instead of Abel, whom Cain slew"
Echo: Genesis 9:6	Shedding blood forbidden; humans bear God's image

New Testament

Hebrews 11:4	Abel's "more excellent sacrifice than Cain"
1 John 3:12	"Not as Cain, who was of that wicked one"
Jude 11	False teachers "have gone in the way of Cain"
Echo: Matthew 5:21–22	Anger in the heart linked to murder

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God say to Cain before he killed Abel (Genesis 4:6–7)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God protected Cain with a mark?
3. *Apply:* Sin waits at the door. What "doors" in your life need watching?
4. *Apply:* "Am I my brother's keeper?" Who has God given you to care for this week?

Group notes

4 Abel

The shepherd whose offering pleased God, the first to die, and one who "being dead yet speaketh."

Abel was the second son of Adam and Eve and the first shepherd in Scripture. He brought God the firstborn of his flock and their fat portions, and God accepted him and his gift. His brother Cain, angry and jealous, killed him in the field. Abel never speaks a single recorded word in Genesis. Yet the New Testament calls him righteous, lists him first among the heroes of faith, and says that through his faith he still speaks. His short life raises big questions about worship, faith and justice, and it points ahead to another innocent death whose blood "speaketh better things."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Hevel*, probably meaning "breath" or "vapor"
Family	Son of Adam and Eve; younger brother of Cain (Genesis 4:1–2)
Work	"A keeper of sheep" (Genesis 4:2)
Key places	The field where he was killed (Genesis 4:8)
Key people	Adam, Eve, Cain
Main passages	Genesis 4:2–10, 25
New Testament	Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:50–51; Hebrews 11:4; 12:24; 1 John 3:12

> *"By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, by which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts: and by it he being dead yet speaketh."*
>
> Hebrews 11:4, KJV

The life of Abel

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Abel. The order below follows the text.

After Eden

Born to Eve

Eve bears Abel after his brother Cain. *Genesis 4:2*

Grown

Keeps sheep

"Abel was a keeper of sheep, but Cain was a tiller of the ground." *Genesis 4:2*

Later

Brings an offering

Abel brings the firstlings of his flock and their fat. "The LORD had respect unto Abel and to his offering." *Genesis 4:4*

In the field

Killed by Cain

Cain talks with Abel, then rises up against him in the field and kills him. *Genesis 4:8*

Afterward

His blood cries out

God tells Cain that the voice of his brother's blood cries to him from the ground. *Genesis 4:10*

Later

Remembered by Eve

Eve names Seth as "another seed instead of Abel, whom Cain slew." *Genesis 4:25*

Group notes

Key activities

Genesis does not explain why Abel's offering was accepted. Hebrews 11:4 says it was offered by faith. Some also note that he brought the firstborn and the best parts.

1. **Kept sheep.** He was the first shepherd named in the Bible. *Genesis 4:2*
2. **Brought the firstborn and the best.** He offered the firstlings of his flock and the fat of them. *Genesis 4:4*
3. **Offered in faith.** His gift was "a more excellent sacrifice," and God counted him righteous. *Hebrews 11:4*
4. **Was accepted by God.** The LORD had respect to Abel himself and to his offering. *Genesis 4:4*
5. **Died an innocent death.** He was killed by his own brother, the first death recorded in Scripture. *Genesis 4:8*
6. **Still speaks.** His blood cried out to God, and his faith still speaks to readers today. *Genesis 4:10; Hebrews 11:4*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abel.

Old Testament

Genesis 4:2–10	The whole account of his life and death
Genesis 4:25	Eve names Seth in Abel's place
Echoes	Firstborn and fat belong to God (Exodus 13:12; Leviticus 3:16)

New Testament

Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:50–51	"From the blood of Abel unto the blood of Zacharias"
Hebrews 11:4	Abel heads the list of the faithful
Hebrews 12:24	Jesus' blood "speaketh better things than that of Abel"
1 John 3:12	Cain's works evil, "and his brother's righteous"
Echo: John 10:11	The Good Shepherd lays down his life

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Abel bring to God, and how did God respond (Genesis 4:4)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews says Abel "being dead yet speaketh." What does his life still say?
3. *Apply:* Abel gave God the first and best. What would giving God your first and best look like this week?
4. *Apply:* Abel was righteous and still suffered. How does his story help you when doing right does not seem to pay off?

5 Seth

The son given "instead of Abel," through whom the line of promise continued.

Seth was the third son of Adam and Eve named in Scripture. He was born after Cain killed Abel, when the family's future seemed broken. Eve saw him as a gift from God, "another seed instead of Abel." Genesis says little about what Seth did. But his line matters: in the days of his son Enos, "then began men to call upon the name of the LORD." Through Seth the genealogy runs to Noah, then to Abraham, David and, in Luke's Gospel, to Jesus. Seth's story is a quiet reminder that God keeps his promises through ordinary faithful families.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Shet*. It sounds like Eve's word "appointed" in Genesis 4:25
Family	Son of Adam and Eve; father of Enos, plus other sons and daughters (Genesis 4:25–26; 5:6–7)
When	Born when Adam was 130 (Genesis 5:3)
Lifespan	912 years (Genesis 5:8)
Key people	Adam, Eve, Enos
Main passages	Genesis 4:25–26; 5:3–8
New Testament	Luke 3:38

> *"And to Seth, to him also there was born a son; and he called his name Enos: then began men to call upon the name of the LORD."*
>
> Genesis 4:26, KJV

The life of Seth

Ages come from Genesis 5 in the Hebrew text. The Greek Septuagint gives different numbers.

Adam's 130th year

Born

Adam fathers a son "in his own likeness, after his image" and names him Seth. Eve says God has appointed him "instead of Abel, whom Cain slew." *Genesis 4:25; 5:3*

Age 105

Father of Enos

Seth fathers Enos. In his days people begin to call on the name of the LORD. *Genesis 4:26; 5:6*

The next 807 years

Raises a family

Seth lives on and fathers sons and daughters. *Genesis 5:7*

Age 912

Dies

"All the days of Seth were nine hundred and twelve years: and he died." *Genesis 5:8*

Group notes

Key activities

Genesis 6:2 speaks of "the sons of God" marrying "the daughters of men." One view says these were Seth's godly descendants marrying Cain's line. Others see them as angels or as powerful rulers. Genesis does not say.

1. **Was received as God's gift.** Eve named him as the seed God appointed after Abel's death. *Genesis 4:25*
2. **Bore Adam's likeness.** He was born in Adam's likeness and image, echoing how Adam was made in God's likeness. *Genesis 5:1–3*
3. **Fathered Enos.** He named his son Enos, whose name means "man." *Genesis 4:26*
4. **Saw worship begin.** In his son's days, people began to call on the name of the LORD. *Genesis 4:26*
5. **Carried the line to Noah.** Genesis 5 traces the family from Seth through Enoch and Methuselah to Noah. *Genesis 5:6–32*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Seth.

Old Testament

Genesis 4:25–26	and **5:3–8.** These are the main passages about Seth.
Genesis 5:9–32	His descendants run from Enos to Noah.
1 Chronicles 1:1	The genealogy begins "Adam, Sheth, Enosh."
Echoes	Calling on the name of the LORD becomes a mark of true worship. Abraham builds altars and calls on the name of the LORD (Genesis 12:8).

New Testament

Luke 3:38	Luke traces Jesus back "which was the son of Enos, which was the son of Seth, which was the son of Adam."
Echoes	"Whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved" (Romans 10:13, quoting Joel 2:32).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Eve say when Seth was born (Genesis 4:25)?
2. *Understand:* Why might it matter that people began to call on the LORD in the days of Seth's son?
3. *Apply:* Seth's family carried faith forward quietly. Who passed faith on to you?
4. *Apply:* What is one way you can help the next generation "call upon the name of the LORD"?

6 Enoch

The man who walked with God, "and he was not; for God took him."

Enoch lived in the generations between Adam and Noah, and Genesis gives him only a few verses. Yet those verses stand out. In a chapter that repeats "and he died" again and again, Enoch's life ends differently: he "walked with God: and he was not; for God took him." Hebrews says he was taken without seeing death because he pleased God. Jude adds that he was a prophet who warned of the Lord's coming judgment. Enoch was also the father of Methuselah and the great-grandfather of Noah. His short story invites every reader to ask what it means to walk with God, day by day, for a lifetime.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Chanokh*, often explained as "dedicated"
Family	Son of Jared; father of Methuselah, plus other sons and daughters (Genesis 5:18–22)
Place in line	"The seventh from Adam" (Jude 14)
Lifespan	365 years on earth, then taken by God (Genesis 5:23–24)
Not the same as	Enoch son of Cain (Genesis 4:17)
Main passages	Genesis 5:18–24
New Testament	Luke 3:37; Hebrews 11:5; Jude 14–15

"And Enoch walked with God: and he was not; for God took him."

Genesis 5:24, KJV

The life of Enoch

Ages come from Genesis 5 in the Hebrew text. The Greek Septuagint gives different numbers.

Jared's 162nd year

Born

Jared fathers Enoch. *Genesis 5:18*

Age 65

Father of Methuselah

Enoch fathers Methuselah. *Genesis 5:21*

The next 300 years

Walks with God

Enoch walks with God and fathers sons and daughters. *Genesis 5:22*

Age 365

Taken by God

Enoch walks with God, "and he was not; for God took him." Hebrews says he did not see death. *Genesis 5:23–24; Hebrews 11:5*

Group notes

Key activities

Jude's words about Enoch closely match a passage in the book of 1 Enoch, a Jewish writing from the centuries before Christ. Most churches do not include 1 Enoch in the Bible, though the Ethiopian Orthodox Church does. Christians differ on how Jude used it.

1. **Walked with God.** Genesis says it twice. His life was marked by close, steady fellowship with God. *Genesis 5:22, 24*
2. **Raised a family.** He fathered Methuselah and other sons and daughters while walking with God. *Genesis 5:21–22*
3. **Pleased God by faith.** Hebrews says he had this testimony, that he pleased God. *Hebrews 11:5–6*
4. **Prophesied judgment.** He warned that the Lord would come "with ten thousands of his saints" to judge the ungodly. *Jude 14–15*
5. **Was taken without death.** God "translated" him so that he did not see death. *Genesis 5:24; Hebrews 11:5*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Enoch.

Old Testament

Genesis 5:18–24	This is the main account.
1 Chronicles 1:3	He is listed as "Henoch" in the line to Noah.
Echoes	Noah also "walked with God" (Genesis 6:9). Elijah is taken up into heaven without dying (2 Kings 2:11). "Can two walk together, except they be agreed?" (Amos 3:3).

New Testament

Luke 3:37	Enoch appears in the genealogy of Jesus.
Hebrews 11:5–6	"By faith Enoch was translated that he should not see death." The next verse adds that without faith it is impossible to please God.
Jude 14–15	Enoch, "the seventh from Adam," prophesied the Lord's coming in judgment.
Tradition	Some early Christian writers suggested Enoch and Elijah are the two witnesses of Revelation 11:3–12. The text does not name them.

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What phrase does Genesis repeat about Enoch (Genesis 5:22, 24)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews links Enoch's walk with faith (Hebrews 11:5–6). How are walking with God and trusting God connected?
3. *Apply:* Enoch walked with God while raising a family. What does walking with God look like in your ordinary week?
4. *Apply:* What is one habit that would help you walk more closely with God?

7 Methuselah

The oldest man in the Bible, son of Enoch and grandfather of Noah.

Methuselah is famous for one thing: he lived longer than anyone else recorded in Scripture, 969 years. Genesis tells us almost nothing else about him. He was the son of Enoch, who walked with God, and the father of Lamech, who named his son Noah in hope of comfort. So Methuselah stands between two great men of faith. By the numbers in the Hebrew text of Genesis 5, he died in the same year as the flood. Genesis does not say how he died or comment on the timing. His long life is a reminder that even the longest life ends, and that what matters is how our days are spent.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Metushelach*. Its meaning is uncertain; "man of the spear" or "man of the dart" are common suggestions
Family	Son of Enoch; father of Lamech, plus other sons and daughters; grandfather of Noah (Genesis 5:21, 25–29)
Lifespan	969 years, the longest recorded in Scripture (Genesis 5:27)
Key people	Enoch, Lamech, Noah
Main passages	Genesis 5:21–27
New Testament	Luke 3:37 ("Mathusala")

"And all the days of Methuselah were nine hundred sixty and nine years: and he died."

Genesis 5:27, KJV

The life of Methuselah

Ages come from Genesis 5 in the Hebrew text. The Greek Septuagint gives different numbers.

Enoch's 65th year

Born

Enoch fathers Methuselah and walks with God for 300 years afterward. *Genesis 5:21–22*

Age 187

Father of Lamech

Methuselah fathers Lamech. *Genesis 5:25*

Age 369

Grandfather of Noah

Lamech fathers Noah at 182, naming him in hope of comfort from the cursed ground. *Genesis 5:28–29 (age by calculation)*

The next 782 years

Raises a family

Methuselah fathers sons and daughters. *Genesis 5:26*

Age 969

Dies

"All the days of Methuselah were nine hundred sixty and nine years: and he died." *Genesis 5:27*

Group notes

Key activities

A popular teaching says Methuselah's name means "when he dies, it shall be sent," pointing to the flood. This is not certain and is not stated in Scripture. The link between his death and the flood year comes only from adding up the ages in Genesis 5 (187 + 182 + 600 = 969).

1. **Was raised by a man who walked with God.** Genesis says his father Enoch walked with God for 300 years after Methuselah was born. *Genesis 5:21–22*
2. **Fathered Lamech.** Through Lamech, the line continued to Noah. *Genesis 5:25, 28–29*
3. **Raised a large family.** He fathered other sons and daughters. *Genesis 5:26*
4. **Lived 969 years.** No one in Scripture is recorded as living longer. *Genesis 5:27*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Methuselah.

Old Testament

Genesis 5:21–27	This is the whole account.
1 Chronicles 1:3	He is listed in the line "Henoch, Methuselah, Lamech."
Echoes	Human lifespans shorten after the flood (Genesis 11:10–32). Moses writes, "So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom" (Psalm 90:12).

New Testament

Luke 3:37	He appears as "Mathusala" in the genealogy of Jesus.
Echoes	"One day is with the Lord as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day" (2 Peter 3:8).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What two things does Genesis tell us about Methuselah's life besides his age (Genesis 5:25–26)?
2. *Understand:* Methuselah lived between Enoch and Noah. What might he have learned from his father, and passed on to his grandson?
3. *Apply:* Psalm 90:12 asks God to teach us to number our days. How would you live differently if you counted your days?
4. *Apply:* What legacy of faith do you hope to leave, whether your life is long or short?

8 Noah

The righteous man who found grace, built the ark, and received God's covenant with every living creature.

Noah lived when "the wickedness of man was great in the earth," and God resolved to send a flood. But Noah found grace in the eyes of the LORD. A just man who walked with God, he built an ark, brought his family and the animals inside, and came through the flood alive. Afterward God made a covenant never again to destroy the earth by flood, sealed with the rainbow. His story ends honestly, with drunkenness and a family rift. Scripture treats him as a model of faith and a warning about the days before Christ's return.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Noach*, linked to "rest" and "comfort"
Family	Son of Lamech; sons Shem, Ham and Japheth
Household saved	Eight people (Genesis 7:13; 1 Peter 3:20)
Key places	The ark; "the mountains of Ararat" (Genesis 8:4)
Key people	Shem, Ham, Japheth, Canaan
Lifespan	950 years (Genesis 9:29)
Main passages	Genesis 5:28–9:29
New Testament	Matthew 24:37–39; Hebrews 11:7; 1 Peter 3:20

"Thus did Noah; according to all that God commanded him, so did he."

Genesis 6:22, KJV

The life of Noah

Ages come from the Hebrew text of Genesis. The Greek Septuagint gives different numbers for earlier generations. Christians differ on whether the flood covered the whole globe or the whole region known to Noah.

Lamech's 182nd year

Born

Lamech names him Noah, saying, "This same shall comfort us concerning our work and toil of our hands." *Genesis 5:28–29*

Age 500

Father of three sons

Noah fathers Shem, Ham and Japheth. *Genesis 5:32*

Before the flood

Finds grace

God sees the earth filled with violence and resolves to destroy it. "But Noah found grace in the eyes of the LORD." *Genesis 6:5–13*

Before the flood

Builds the ark

God gives the ark's plan: 300 cubits long, 50 wide and 30 high. Noah does all that God commands. *Genesis 6:14–22*

Age 600

Enters the ark

Noah's family and the animals go in, and the LORD shuts them in. Rain falls forty days and forty nights. *Genesis 7:1–16*

Age 600

The ark rests

After the waters prevail 150 days, the ark rests on the mountains of Ararat. Noah sends out a raven and then a dove. *Genesis 7:24–8:12*

Age 601

Leaves the ark

The earth is dry. Noah builds an altar, and God makes his covenant, sealed with the rainbow. *Genesis 8:13–9:17*

Age 950

Dies

Noah lives 350 years after the flood. *Genesis 9:28–29*

Key activities

"The mountains of Ararat" names a region, later called Urartu. Genesis does not say which peak. The curse in Genesis 9 falls on Canaan, not on Ham, and gives no basis for later claims that it applied to any race.

1. **Found grace.** Amid a violent world, God looked on Noah with favor. *Genesis 6:8*
2. **Walked with God.** He was "a just man and perfect in his generations." *Genesis 6:9*
3. **Built the ark.** He built it to God's exact plan. *Genesis 6:14–22*
4. **Preached righteousness.** Peter calls him "a preacher of righteousness." *2 Peter 2:5*
5. **Gathered the animals.** He brought pairs of every kind, and the clean animals by sevens. *Genesis 6:19–20; 7:2–3*
6. **Obeyed and entered.** He went in with his family, and the LORD shut them in. *Genesis 7:5–16*
7. **Waited and watched.** He sent out a raven and then a dove. The dove brought back an olive leaf, and the next time it did not return. *Genesis 8:6–12*
8. **Waited for God's word.** He left the ark only when God told him to. *Genesis 8:15–19*
9. **Built an altar.** He offered burnt offerings of every clean beast and fowl. *Genesis 8:20–21*
10. **Received the covenant.** God blessed him and promised never again to flood the earth. The rainbow is the token. *Genesis 9:1–17*
11. **Planted a vineyard and fell.** He became drunk and lay uncovered in his tent. Ham saw and told his brothers, who covered their father. *Genesis 9:20–23*
12. **Spoke blessing and curse.** He cursed Canaan and blessed Shem and Japheth. *Genesis 9:24–27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Noah.

Old Testament

Genesis 5:28–9:29	The main account of his life
Genesis 10	The nations descend from Noah's three sons
Isaiah 54:9	God's promise is "as the waters of Noah unto me"
Ezekiel 14:14, 20	Noah, Daniel and Job named as righteous men

New Testament

Matthew 24:37–39; Luke 17:26–27	"As the days of Noe were"
Luke 3:36	Noah in the genealogy of Jesus
Hebrews 11:7	By faith he "prepared an ark to the saving of his house"
1 Peter 3:20–21	"Eight souls were saved by water," a picture of baptism
2 Peter 2:5; 3:5–7	God spared Noah and will judge again
Echo: Revelation 4:3	A rainbow surrounds God's throne

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Genesis describe Noah's obedience (Genesis 6:22; 7:5)?
2. *Understand:* Noah "found grace" before he built anything. Why does that order matter?
3. *Apply:* Where do you need courage to obey when others around you won't?
4. *Apply:* Noah's family covered his shame (Genesis 9:23). How can you show grace when someone you love fails?

9 Nimrod

"A mighty hunter before the LORD," the first empire-builder in Scripture.

Nimrod appears in the Table of Nations, the list of Noah's descendants in Genesis 10. He was a great-grandson of Noah through Ham and Cush. Genesis calls him the first "mighty one in the earth" and "a mighty hunter before the LORD," a phrase that became a proverb. He founded a kingdom in Shinar, the land of Babylon, including the city of Babel. Scripture gives him only a few verses and never describes his character directly. Later tradition made him the builder of the tower of Babel, but Genesis does not say so. His story marks a new stage after the flood: the rise of cities, kingdoms and human power.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Nimrod*. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Cush; grandson of Ham; great-grandson of Noah (Genesis 10:1, 6, 8)
Known as	"A mighty one in the earth" and "a mighty hunter before the LORD" (Genesis 10:8–9)
Kingdom	Babel, Erech, Accad and Calneh, in the land of Shinar (Genesis 10:10)
Main passages	Genesis 10:8–12; 1 Chronicles 1:10
Later reference	"The land of Nimrod," meaning Assyria (Micah 5:6)
New Testament	Not named

"He was a mighty hunter before the LORD: wherefore it is said, Even as Nimrod the mighty hunter before the LORD."

Genesis 10:9, KJV

The life of Nimrod

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Nimrod. The order below follows the text. Scholars have tried to match him with various ancient kings, but no match is certain.

After the flood

Born to Cush

Cush, son of Ham, fathers Nimrod. *Genesis 10:6–8*

Grown

Becomes a mighty one

"He began to be a mighty one in the earth." *Genesis 10:8*

Known far and wide

A mighty hunter

His skill as a hunter becomes a saying: "Even as Nimrod the mighty hunter before the LORD." *Genesis 10:9*

In Shinar

Founds a kingdom

His kingdom begins with Babel, Erech, Accad and Calneh in Shinar. *Genesis 10:10*

Later

Expands north

Nineveh, Rehoboth, Calah and Resen are built. It is unclear whether Nimrod built them or Asshur did (see next page). *Genesis 10:11–12*

Group notes

Key activities

Genesis 10:11 can be read two ways. The KJV says "Out of that land went forth Asshur," but its margin and many modern readers take it as "he went out into Assyria," meaning Nimrod. The phrase "before the LORD" is also debated: some read it as "in God's sight," others as "in defiance of God."

1. **Rose to power.** He was the first person Genesis calls "a mighty one in the earth." *Genesis 10:8*
2. **Hunted.** He became famous as a mighty hunter, so famous that people used his name as a saying. *Genesis 10:9*
3. **Ruled a kingdom.** He founded the first kingdom named in Scripture, in the land of Shinar. *Genesis 10:10*
4. **Built cities.** His kingdom included Babel, and possibly Nineveh and the Assyrian cities too. *Genesis 10:10–12*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nimrod.

Old Testament

Genesis 10:8–12	This is the main account.
1 Chronicles 1:10	"And Cush begat Nimrod: he began to be mighty upon the earth."
Micah 5:6	The prophet speaks of "the land of Nimrod," a name for Assyria.
Echoes	Babel in Shinar is where people build a tower to "make us a name" (Genesis 11:1–9). Babylon later becomes the great enemy of God's people (2 Kings 25; Daniel 1–5). Nineveh is the city Jonah is sent to warn (Jonah 1:2).

New Testament

Echoes	"Babylon the great" is a picture of proud human power set against God (Revelation 17–18). God "hath put down the mighty from their seats, and exalted them of low degree" (Luke 1:52).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does Genesis use to describe Nimrod (Genesis 10:8–10)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Scripture tracks cities like Babel and Nineveh from their very beginning?
3. *Apply:* Nimrod became a byword for strength and fame. What do you most want to be known for?
4. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to trust human power, whether your own or someone else's, more than God?

10 Abraham

The man who left everything at God's word, believed an impossible promise, and became "the Friend of God."

After the scattering at Babel, God speaks to one man and promises that through him "all families of the earth" will be blessed. Abram left his country with no map and no children, and lived in tents in a land he never owned. He waited twenty-five years for the promised son. He was brave and generous, but also fearful and impatient. Then God asked him to give up that son. Israel called him "our father," and the New Testament calls him the father of all who believe. His life shows what faith looks like when it has to wait.

At a glance

Name	Abram, "exalted father"; Abraham, "father of a great multitude"
Family	Son of Terah; wife Sarah; sons Ishmael, Isaac, and Keturah's six
When	Traditionally c. 2166–1991 BC; many scholars c. 2000–1700 BC
Key places	Ur, Haran, Bethel, Egypt, Hebron (Mamre), Beersheba, Moriah
Key people	Sarah, Lot, Hagar, Ishmael, Isaac, Melchizedek
Lifespan	175 years (Genesis 25:7)
Main passages	Genesis 11:26–25:11
New Testament	Romans 4; Galatians 3; Hebrews 11:8–19; James 2:21–23

"And he believed in the LORD; and he counted it to him for righteousness."

Genesis 15:6, KJV

The life of Abraham

Ages come from Genesis. The traditional chronology (from 1 Kings 6:1) has Abraham born c. 2166 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

In Ur

Sets out with Terah

Terah takes Abram, barren Sarai and Lot from Ur toward Canaan, but they settle in Haran, where Terah dies. *Genesis 11:26–32*

Age 75

Leaves Haran

God says, "Get thee out of thy country," promising land, a nation and blessing for all families. Abram goes. *Genesis 12:1–5*

In Canaan

Believes the promise

Still childless, Abram is shown the stars: "So shall thy seed be." He believes, and God makes a covenant. *Genesis 15:1–21*

Age 86

Ishmael is born

Sarai gives Abram her Egyptian maid Hagar, who bears Ishmael. *Genesis 16:1–16*

Age 99

Renamed Abraham

God renames Abram and Sarai, gives circumcision as the covenant sign, and promises a son through Sarah. *Genesis 17:1–27*

Age 100

Isaac is born

The LORD does for Sarah "as he had spoken," and she bears Isaac in their old age. *Genesis 21:1–7*

On Moriah

The great test

God tells Abraham to offer Isaac. The angel of the LORD stops him, and a ram is offered instead. *Genesis 22:1–19*

Age 175

Dies

Abraham dies "full of years." Isaac and Ishmael bury him beside Sarah at Machpelah. *Genesis 25:7–10*

Key activities

Stephen says God first called Abraham in Mesopotamia, before Haran (Acts 7:2–4). Many think Abram was not Terah's eldest son, though listed first.

1. **Obeyed the call.** He left country and kin for a land God had not yet shown him. *Genesis 12:1–5; Hebrews 11:8*
2. **Built altars.** At Shechem, Bethel and Hebron he called on the name of the LORD. *Genesis 12:7–8; 13:18*
3. **Passed off Sarai as his sister.** Afraid, he let Pharaoh and later Abimelech take her; God protected her. *Genesis 12:10–20; 20:1–18*
4. **Gave Lot first choice.** To end strife he let his nephew choose; Lot took the plain near Sodom. *Genesis 13:5–12*
5. **Rescued Lot.** He armed 318 trained servants and brought back the captives. *Genesis 14:12–16*
6. **Honored Melchizedek.** He gave the priest-king a tenth and refused reward from Sodom's king. *Genesis 14:17–24*
7. **Believed God.** With no child and no land, he trusted God's word. *Genesis 15:1–6*
8. **Took a shortcut.** He had a child by Hagar, and years later sent her and Ishmael away, grieving. *Genesis 16:1–4; 21:9–14*
9. **Welcomed strangers.** He served three visitors at Mamre; one was the LORD. *Genesis 18:1–15*
10. **Pleaded for Sodom.** "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do right?" *Genesis 18:22–33*
11. **Offered Isaac.** Trusting that "God will provide himself a lamb," he named the place Jehovah-jireh. *Genesis 22:1–14*
12. **Bought a grave.** The cave of Machpelah was the first land he owned in Canaan. *Genesis 23:1–20*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abraham.

Old Testament

Genesis 11:26–25:11	The main account of his life
Exodus 3:6	"The God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob"
Joshua 24:2–3	Terah's family "served other gods"
Isaiah 41:8	God calls him "Abraham my friend"
Isaiah 51:2	"Look unto Abraham your father"

New Testament

Matthew 1:1	Jesus "the son of David, the son of Abraham"
John 8:56–58	"Before Abraham was, I am"
Romans 4; Galatians 3:6–9	Righteous by faith; father of all who believe
Hebrews 11:8–19	He went out "not knowing whither he went"
James 2:21–23	"He was called the Friend of God"
Echo: Romans 8:32	A father gives his own Son

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God promise Abram in Genesis 12:1–3, and what did he have to leave?
2. *Understand:* Abraham believed, yet lied and took shortcuts. What does that say about the faith God counts as righteousness?
3. *Apply:* What step of obedience are you putting off because you can't see the whole path?
4. *Apply:* Abraham let Lot choose first. Where could you give up your rights to keep peace?

II Sarah

The barren wife who laughed at God's promise, then laughed for joy when it came true.

Sarah was Abraham's wife and half-sister, and she shared every step of his journey of faith. She is introduced with one hard line: "But Sarai was barren; she had no child." She left home at sixty-five, was twice taken into a king's household because of her husband's fear, and tried to build a family through Hagar, with painful results. When God said she would bear a son at ninety, she laughed. Yet God kept his word, and Isaac, whose name sounds like "laughter," was born. Scripture remembers her doubts honestly, but names her among the heroes of faith.

At a glance

Name	Sarai, renamed Sarah; KJV margin: "Princess"
Family	Wife and half-sister of Abraham; mother of Isaac
When	Ten years younger than Abraham; traditionally c. 2156–2029 BC
Key places	Ur, Haran, Egypt, Gerar, Hebron (Mamre)
Key people	Abraham, Hagar, Ishmael, Isaac, Abimelech
Lifespan	127 years (Genesis 23:1)
Main passages	Genesis 11:29–23:20
New Testament	Romans 4:19; Hebrews 11:11; 1 Peter 3:6

"Through faith also Sara herself received strength to conceive seed, and was delivered of a child when she was past age, because she judged him faithful who had promised."

Hebrews 11:11, KJV

The life of Sarah

Ages are worked out from Genesis 17:17. Many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

In Ur

Married and barren

Sarai marries Abram; she is barren. She leaves Ur with Terah's family and settles in Haran. *Genesis 11:29–31*

Age 65

Leaves Haran

When God calls Abram, Sarai goes with him into Canaan, leaving home and relatives behind. *Genesis 12:4–5*

In Egypt

Taken by Pharaoh

Abram has her say she is his sister. She is taken until the LORD sends plagues. *Genesis 12:10–20*

Age 75

Gives Hagar to Abram

When Hagar conceives and despises her, Sarai treats her harshly, and Hagar runs away. *Genesis 16:1–6*

Age 89

Named Sarah; laughs

God promises she will be "a mother of nations." At Mamre she overhears and laughs within herself. *Genesis 17:15–21; 18:9–15*

In Gerar

Taken again

King Abimelech takes her; God warns him in a dream, and he returns her untouched. *Genesis 20:1–18*

Age 90

Isaac is born

She says, "God hath made me to laugh, so that all that hear will laugh with me." *Genesis 21:1–7*

Age 127

Dies at Hebron

Abraham weeps for her and buries her in the cave of Machpelah. *Genesis 23:1–20*

Key activities

In the KJV, Hebrews 11:11 speaks of Sarah's own faith. Some scholars read the Greek as describing Abraham's faith, with Sarah named alongside him. Either way, the verse honors the promise God kept to them both.

1. **Left home by faith.** She went with Abram from Haran into Canaan, sharing his wandering life in tents. *Genesis 12:5; Hebrews 11:9*
2. **Went along with a half-truth.** She was Abram's half-sister, and she agreed to hide that she was his wife, first in Egypt and then in Gerar. *Genesis 12:11–15; 20:2, 5, 12–13*
3. **Was protected by God.** Twice God struck the royal house that took her, and twice she was given back. *Genesis 12:17; 20:3–7, 18*
4. **Tried to build a family her own way.** She said, "It may be that I may obtain children by her," and gave Hagar to Abram. *Genesis 16:1–3*
5. **Blamed and afflicted.** When Hagar looked down on her, she said to Abram, "My wrong be upon thee," and dealt hardly with Hagar. *Genesis 16:4–6*
6. **Received a new name.** God called her Sarah and promised that kings would come from her. *Genesis 17:15–16*
7. **Laughed and denied it.** She laughed at the idea of a child in old age. Then, afraid, she said, "I laughed not." God asked, "Is any thing too hard for the LORD?" *Genesis 18:9–15*
8. **Bore Isaac.** She conceived and bore a son at ninety, and her laughter of doubt became laughter of joy. *Genesis 21:1–7*
9. **Demanded Hagar's departure.** At Isaac's weaning feast she saw Ishmael mocking and said, "Cast out this bondwoman and her son." God told Abraham to listen to her. *Genesis 21:8–12*
10. **Was mourned and buried.** Abraham wept for her and bought the cave of Machpelah as her grave. *Genesis 23:1–2, 19*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Sarah.

Old Testament

Genesis 11:29–23:20	The main account of her life
Genesis 24:67	Rebekah brought into "his mother Sarah's tent"
Genesis 25:10; 49:31	Buried with Abraham at Machpelah
Isaiah 51:2	"Unto Sarah that bare you"

New Testament

Romans 4:19; 9:9	"The deadness of Sara's womb"; the promised son
Galatians 4:21–31	The free woman in Paul's allegory, unnamed
Hebrews 11:11	"Through faith also Sara herself received strength"
1 Peter 3:5–6	A model for wives: "Even as Sara obeyed Abraham"
Echo: Luke 1:36–37	"With God nothing shall be impossible"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Sarah respond when she overheard the promise of a son (Genesis 18:10–15)?
2. *Understand:* Sarah laughed in doubt, yet Hebrews 11:11 praises her faith. How can both be true?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to force an answer instead of waiting on God?
4. *Apply:* "Is any thing too hard for the LORD?" What situation do you need to bring to him this week?

12 Hagar

The runaway servant who met the God who sees.

Hagar was an Egyptian servant in Sarai's household. She had no say in the biggest events of her life. Her mistress gave her to Abram to bear a child, then treated her so harshly that she ran away. Years later she was sent into the desert with her son and a single bottle of water. Yet Genesis gives Hagar something remarkable. She is the first person in Scripture to whom "the angel of the LORD" appears, and she gives the LORD a name: "Thou God seest me." Twice, when she was alone and in despair, God met her, promised a future for her son, and provided water in the wilderness. Her story reminds readers that God notices those whom others overlook.

At a glance

Name	Hagar. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Mother of Ishmael by Abram; she later found an Egyptian wife for her son (Genesis 16:15; 21:21)
Background	An Egyptian handmaid of Sarai (Genesis 16:1)
Key places	Abram's camp in Canaan; a spring on the way to Shur; the wilderness of Beersheba; the wilderness of Paran
Key people	Sarah, Abraham, Ishmael, the angel of the LORD
Main passages	Genesis 16:1–16; 21:8–21
New Testament	Galatians 4:21–31, where the KJV spells her name "Agar"

"And she called the name of the LORD that spake unto her, Thou God seest me: for she said, Have I also here looked after him that seeth me?"

Genesis 16:13, KJV

The life of Hagar

Genesis gives no dates for Hagar. Ages below are Abraham's, taken from Genesis 16:16 and 21:5.

Abram age 85

Given to Abram

After ten years in Canaan without a child, Sarai gives Hagar to Abram "to be his wife." Hagar conceives and begins to look down on her mistress. *Genesis 16:1–4*

Soon after

Runs away

Sarai deals harshly with her, and Hagar flees into the wilderness. By a spring on the way to Shur, the angel of the LORD finds her, tells her to return, and promises countless descendants. *Genesis 16:5–12*

At the well

Names the God who sees

Hagar calls the LORD "Thou God seest me." The well is named Beer-lahai-roi. *Genesis 16:13–14*

Abram age 86

Bears Ishmael

Hagar returns and bears Abram a son. He is named Ishmael, "God shall hear," as the angel said. *Genesis 16:15–16*

At Isaac's weaning

Sent away

Sarah sees Ishmael mocking and demands that Hagar and her son be cast out. Abraham gives Hagar bread and a bottle of water and sends them away. *Genesis 21:8–14*

In the wilderness of Beersheba

Rescued again

The water runs out. Hagar sets the boy under a shrub and weeps. God hears the lad, opens her eyes to a well, and promises to make him a great nation. *Genesis 21:15–21*

Key activities

Genesis 21:14 has puzzled readers. Ishmael was probably a teenager by then, yet the verse seems to picture Hagar carrying "the child." Many think the verse means she carried the bread and water on her shoulder while the boy walked with her.

1. **Bore a child for another woman.** She was given to Abram as a second wife so that Sarai might "obtain children by her." *Genesis 16:2–4*
2. **Despised her mistress.** Once pregnant, she looked down on Sarai, and the household fell into conflict. *Genesis 16:4–5*
3. **Fled and was found.** She ran from harsh treatment, and the angel of the LORD met her by a spring. *Genesis 16:6–8*
4. **Returned and submitted.** At the angel's word she went back to Sarai, carrying a promise for her unborn son. *Genesis 16:9–12*
5. **Named God.** She called him "Thou God seest me," the God who had seen her misery. *Genesis 16:13*
6. **Wept in the desert.** Sent away, she could not bear to watch her son die, and she cried aloud. *Genesis 21:14–16*
7. **Saw the well.** God opened her eyes, and she filled the bottle and gave the boy a drink. *Genesis 21:17–19*
8. **Raised her son.** She lived with Ishmael in the wilderness of Paran and found him a wife from Egypt. *Genesis 21:20–21*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Hagar.

Old Testament

Genesis 16:1–16; 21:8–21	The two accounts of her story
Genesis 25:12	Ishmael's line begins with "Hagar the Egyptian"
1 Chronicles 5:10; Psalm 83:6	"Hagarites," often linked to her, though unstated
Echo: Exodus 3:7	God sees and hears the afflicted

New Testament

Galatians 4:21–31	"Agar" as an allegory of the covenant from Sinai
Echo: John 4:5–14	Jesus offers living water to a woman at a well
Echo: Luke 12:6–7	God knows even the sparrows

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What questions did the angel ask Hagar at the spring (Genesis 16:8)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the angel sent Hagar back to Sarai instead of simply rescuing her?
3. *Apply:* Hagar learned that God saw her. When have you felt unseen, and how does her story speak to that?
4. *Apply:* Who in your church or neighborhood might feel overlooked, and how could you see them this week?

13 Lot

Abraham's nephew, who chose the well-watered plain and was pulled out of Sodom by the hand.

Lot was Abraham's nephew, the son of his brother Haran, who died in Ur. He traveled with his uncle into Canaan and grew rich alongside him. When their herds became too large to share the land, Abram let Lot choose first. Lot chose the green plain near Sodom, a city known for great wickedness. Step by step he moved closer, until he sat in Sodom's gate. When God judged the city, angels had to take Lot by the hand and lead him out. Yet the New Testament calls him "just Lot," a righteous man troubled by the evil around him.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Lot*. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Haran; nephew of Abraham; two daughters
Key places	Ur, Haran, Bethel, the Jordan plain, Sodom, Zoar
Key people	Abraham, Sarah, the king of Sodom, two angels, his wife and daughters
Descendants	The Moabites and the Ammonites (Genesis 19:37–38)
Main passages	Genesis 11:27–31; 12:4–5; 13:1–14:16; 19:1–38
New Testament	Luke 17:28–32; 2 Peter 2:6–9

"And while he lingered, the men laid hold upon his hand, and upon the hand of his wife, and upon the hand of his two daughters; the LORD being merciful unto him: and they brought him forth, and set him without the city."

Genesis 19:16, KJV

The life of Lot

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Lot. The order below follows the text.

In Ur

Loses his father

Lot's father Haran dies in Ur of the Chaldees. Terah takes his grandson Lot with Abram and Sarai toward Canaan, and they settle in Haran. *Genesis 11:27–31*

Leaving Haran

Goes with Abram

When Abram obeys God's call, "Lot went with him." They arrive in Canaan and later return together from Egypt, both rich in flocks and herds. *Genesis 12:4–5; 13:1–5*

Near Bethel

Chooses the plain

Their herdsmen quarrel. Abram offers Lot his pick of the land, and Lot chooses the well-watered plain of the Jordan and pitches his tent toward Sodom. *Genesis 13:6–13*

In Sodom

Taken captive

Four eastern kings defeat Sodom and carry off Lot, now living in the city. Abram pursues them, rescues Lot and brings back his goods. *Genesis 14:11–16*

In Sodom

Receives two angels

Lot takes two visitors into his house. The men of the city surround it, and the angels strike them with blindness and warn Lot to leave. *Genesis 19:1–14*

At dawn

Led out

Lot lingers, and the angels take him, his wife and his daughters by the hand. Fire falls on Sodom and Gomorrah. His wife looks back and becomes a pillar of salt. *Genesis 19:15–26*

In a cave

A shameful end

Afraid to stay in Zoar, Lot lives in a mountain cave. His daughters make him drunk and conceive by him. Their sons become the fathers of Moab and Ammon. *Genesis 19:30–38*

Key activities

Genesis 19:8 records that Lot offered his daughters to the mob to protect his guests. Scripture reports this without approving it. Many readers see in it how deeply life in Sodom had shaped him.

1. **Followed his uncle.** He went with Abram from Haran into Canaan and shared in his blessing. *Genesis 12:4–5; 13:5*
2. **Chose by sight.** He "lifted up his eyes" and chose the richest land, even though the men of Sodom were "wicked and sinners before the LORD exceedingly." *Genesis 13:10–13*
3. **Moved into Sodom.** He first pitched his tent toward Sodom, then lived in the city and sat in its gate. *Genesis 13:12; 14:12; 19:1*
4. **Welcomed strangers.** He urged two travelers to stay under his roof and baked them a meal. *Genesis 19:1–3*
5. **Stood at the door.** He went out to the crowd and pleaded, "Do not so wickedly," but his own offer was shameful. *Genesis 19:4–9*
6. **Warned his family.** He urged his sons-in-law to flee, but they thought he was joking. *Genesis 19:12–14*
7. **Lingered.** Even at the last moment he hesitated, and the angels pulled him out "the LORD being merciful unto him." *Genesis 19:15–16*
8. **Bargained for Zoar.** He asked to flee to a small town instead of the mountains, and the angel spared it for his sake. *Genesis 19:17–23*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Lot.

Old Testament

Genesis 18:22–33	Abraham pleads for Sodom, where Lot lives
Genesis 19:29	"God remembered Abraham, and sent Lot out"
Deuteronomy 2:9, 19	Land given to "the children of Lot"
Psalm 83:8	The "children of Lot" among Israel's enemies
Echo: Ruth 4:13–17	Ruth the Moabitess, ancestor of David

New Testament

Luke 17:28–32	"The days of Lot"; "Remember Lot's wife"
2 Peter 2:6–9	God "delivered just Lot," vexed by the wicked's way of life
Echo: Hebrews 11:10	Abraham "looked for a city which hath foundations"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Lot see when he chose the plain, and what does Genesis add right after (Genesis 13:10–13)?
2. *Understand:* Peter calls Lot "righteous." How does that fit with what Genesis shows about his choices?
3. *Apply:* Lot moved toward Sodom one step at a time. What small step toward something harmful do you need to reverse?
4. *Apply:* Lot lingered even when rescue was offered. Where are you delaying something God has already made clear?

14 Melchizedek

The mysterious king of Salem and priest of the most high God, who blessed Abraham and pointed ahead to Christ.

Melchizedek appears in only three verses of Genesis, and then he is gone. After Abram rescued Lot, this king of Salem, "the priest of the most high God," came out with bread and wine. He blessed Abram, praised God for the victory, and received a tenth of everything. Genesis gives him no parents, birth or death. Centuries later a psalm of David promises "a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek," and Hebrews builds a whole chapter on him to explain how Jesus is our great High Priest. Few people say so little and are remembered so long.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Malki-tsedeq*, "king of righteousness" (Hebrews 7:2)
Title	King of Salem, "which is, King of peace" (Hebrews 7:2)
Office	"The priest of the most high God" (Genesis 14:18)
Family	Not recorded. Hebrews calls him "without father, without mother, without descent" (Hebrews 7:3)
Key place	Salem, probably Jerusalem (Psalm 76:2); the king's dale (Genesis 14:17)
Key people	Abraham, the king of Sodom
Main passages	Genesis 14:17–24; Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 5:6–10; 6:20–7:28
New Testament	Hebrews 5–7, where the KJV spells his name "Melchisedec"

"And Melchizedek king of Salem brought forth bread and wine: and he was the priest of the most high God."

Genesis 14:18, KJV

The life of Melchizedek

Genesis records one meeting and gives no dates or ages. It took place after Abram entered Canaan at 75 and before Ishmael was born when Abram was 86 (Genesis 12:4; 16:16).

After the battle

Comes out to meet Abram

Abram returns from defeating Chedorlaomer and the kings with him. At the valley of Shaveh, the king's dale, the king of Sodom meets him, and Melchizedek brings out bread and wine. *Genesis 14:17–18*

The same day

Blesses Abram

He says, "Blessed be Abram of the most high God, possessor of heaven and earth." Then he blesses God, who delivered Abram's enemies into his hand. *Genesis 14:19–20*

The same day

Receives a tenth

Abram gives him "tithes of all." Then Abram refuses the king of Sodom's offer, swearing by "the LORD, the most high God." *Genesis 14:20–24*

In a psalm of David

A priest for ever

God swears to David's Lord, "Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek." *Psalm 110:1–4*

In Hebrews

A pattern of Christ

Hebrews quotes Psalm 110 and explains that Jesus is a high priest of Melchizedek's kind, not of Aaron's. *Hebrews 5:6–10; 6:20–7:28*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians hold different views of who Melchizedek was. Many see him as a real Canaanite king-priest whose missing family record Hebrews uses as a picture of Christ. Some believe he was an appearance of the Son of God before the incarnation. Hebrews says he was "made like unto the Son of God" (Hebrews 7:3).

1. **Brought bread and wine.** He met the weary victors with food and drink. *Genesis 14:18*
2. **Served the most high God.** He was a priest of the true God outside Abram's family, before Israel or the law existed. *Genesis 14:18*
3. **Blessed Abram.** He spoke a blessing over the man who carried God's promises. Hebrews notes that "the less is blessed of the better." *Genesis 14:19; Hebrews 7:6–7*
4. **Gave God the credit.** He praised God, not Abram, for delivering Abram's enemies. *Genesis 14:20*
5. **Received the tithe.** Abram gave him a tenth of all, and Hebrews says Levi in a sense paid tithes through Abraham. *Genesis 14:20; Hebrews 7:4–10*
6. **Became a pattern.** His priesthood, not based on family line, became the model for a priest who lives for ever. *Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 7:15–17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Melchizedek.

Old Testament

Genesis 14:17–24	The only account of his life
Psalm 110:4	"Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek"

New Testament

Hebrews 5:5–10	Christ "called of God an high priest after the order of Melchisedec"
Hebrews 6:19–20	Jesus our forerunner, within the veil, a priest for ever
Hebrews 7:1–10	His blessing and tithe show him greater than Abraham
Hebrews 7:11–28	A priest "after the power of an endless life"
Echo: Matthew 22:41–45	Jesus applies Psalm 110 to himself
Echo: Matthew 26:26–29	Bread and wine, though not linked to Melchizedek

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Melchizedek bring and say when he met Abram (Genesis 14:18–20)?
2. *Understand:* Why does Hebrews make so much of the fact that Genesis gives Melchizedek no family line?
3. *Apply:* Melchizedek gave God the credit for Abram's victory. What recent success should you thank God for?
4. *Apply:* Jesus "ever liveth to make intercession" (Hebrews 7:25). How could that truth change the way you pray this week?

15 Ishmael

Abraham's firstborn son, not the child of promise, yet heard and blessed by God.

Ishmael was Abraham's first son, born to Hagar, Sarah's Egyptian servant. When God promised a son through Sarah, Abraham prayed, "O that Ishmael might live before thee!" God answered that the covenant would pass through Isaac, but Ishmael too would become a great nation. After Isaac was born, conflict drove Ishmael and his mother into the desert. There God heard the boy's cry and saved him. He grew up an archer, fathered twelve princes, and stood beside Isaac at their father's grave. His name means "God shall hear," and God heard him all his life.

At a glance

Name	Ishmael, "God shall hear" (KJV margin)
Family	Son of Abraham and Hagar; half-brother of Isaac
Work	An archer in the wilderness (Genesis 21:20)
Key places	The wilderness of Beersheba; the wilderness of Paran
Key people	Abraham, Hagar, Sarah, Isaac, Esau
Lifespan	137 years (Genesis 25:17)
Main passages	Genesis 16; 17:18–27; 21:8–21; 25:9–18
New Testament	Unnamed son of the bondwoman (Galatians 4)

> *"And as for Ishmael, I have heard thee: Behold, I have blessed him, and will make him fruitful, and will multiply him exceedingly; twelve princes shall he beget, and I will make him a great nation."*
>
> Genesis 17:20, KJV

The life of Ishmael

Ages are worked out from Genesis 16:16, 17:25 and 25:7–9. Traditional dates put his birth c. 2080 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Before birth

Named by God

The angel of the LORD tells Hagar she will bear a son and call him Ishmael, "because the LORD hath heard thy affliction." *Genesis 16:11–12*

Birth

Born to Abram

Hagar bears Abram a son when Abram is eighty-six, and Abram names him Ishmael. *Genesis 16:15–16*

Age 13

Circumcised

On the day God gives the covenant sign, Abraham circumcises Ishmael and all the males of his house. *Genesis 17:23–26*

At Isaac's weaning

Sent away

Sarah sees Ishmael mocking and demands that he and his mother leave. Abraham is deeply grieved but obeys God's word and sends them into the wilderness. *Genesis 21:8–14*

In the wilderness

Heard by God

The water runs out, and God hears "the voice of the lad." A well appears, and God promises to make him a great nation. He grows up an archer in Paran and marries an Egyptian. *Genesis 21:15–21*

Age 89

Buries his father

Ishmael and Isaac together bury Abraham in the cave of Machpelah. *Genesis 25:8–9*

Age 137

Dies

His twelve sons have become princes of tribes. He dies and is "gathered unto his people." *Genesis 25:12–18*

Key activities

The word for "mocking" in Genesis 21:9 comes from the same root as Isaac's name, which means "he laughs." Some read it as mild teasing, others as scorn. Paul describes it as persecution (Galatians 4:29).

1. **Received a name from God.** Before he was born, God named him for the way he had heard his mother's distress. *Genesis 16:11*
2. **Was prayed for.** Abraham pleaded that Ishmael might live before God, and God said, "I have heard thee." *Genesis 17:18–20*
3. **Received the covenant sign.** He was circumcised at thirteen on the same day as Abraham. *Genesis 17:23–26*
4. **Mocked his brother.** At Isaac's weaning feast he was seen mocking, and his home was lost. *Genesis 21:8–10*
5. **Cried in the desert.** Near death from thirst, he was heard by God, who saved him through his mother. *Genesis 21:15–19*
6. **Grew up with God's help.** "God was with the lad," and he became an archer in the wilderness. *Genesis 21:20–21*
7. **Honored his father.** He stood with Isaac to bury Abraham. *Genesis 25:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Ishmael.

Old Testament

Genesis 25:12–18; 1 Chronicles 1:28–31	His twelve sons listed
Genesis 28:9; 36:3	Esau marries Ishmael's daughter
Genesis 37:25–28	Ishmaelite traders carry Joseph to Egypt
Judges 8:24	Midianite raiders called Ishmaelites
Psalm 83:6	Ishmaelites among Israel's enemies

New Testament

Galatians 4:22–31	The son "born after the flesh" in Paul's allegory
Romans 9:6–9	"In Isaac shall thy seed be called"
Echo: Psalm 34:6	God hears the cry of the needy

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God promise concerning Ishmael (Genesis 17:20; 21:13, 18)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God chose Isaac for the covenant but still blessed Ishmael?
3. *Apply:* Ishmael grew up with a painful family story. How can God be at work in someone whose family life is broken?
4. *Apply:* Isaac and Ishmael stood together at their father's grave. Is there a family member you need to stand with again?

16 Isaac

The long-awaited son of promise, laid on the altar and given back, who carried God's covenant quietly for a lifetime.

Isaac was the son Abraham and Sarah waited twenty-five years to hold, and his name echoes their laughter. On Mount Moriah he was bound on the altar, until God stopped Abraham's hand and provided a ram. His own story is quieter than his father's or his son's. He married Rebekah, prayed for her when she was barren, dug wells, and chose peace with his neighbors. He also repeated his father's lie and favored one son, which split his family. Yet God called himself "the God of Isaac," and the promise passed through him intact.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yitschaq*, "he laughs"
Family	Son of Abraham and Sarah; husband of Rebekah; father of twins
When	Traditionally c. 2066–1886 BC; many scholars c. 2000–1700 BC
Key places	Beersheba, Moriah, Beer-lahai-roi, Gerar, Hebron
Key people	Abraham, Sarah, Rebekah, Esau, Jacob, Abimelech
Lifespan	180 years (Genesis 35:28)
Main passages	Genesis 21–22; 24:62–67; 25:19–28:5; 35:27–29
New Testament	Romans 9:7–10; Galatians 4:28; Hebrews 11:17–20

> *"I am the God of Abraham thy father: fear not, for I am with thee, and will bless thee, and multiply thy seed for my servant Abraham's sake."*
>
> Genesis 26:24, KJV

The life of Isaac

Ages come from Genesis. The traditional chronology (from 1 Kings 6:1) has Isaac born c. 2066 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Birth

The promised son

Sarah bears Isaac when Abraham is a hundred; at his weaning Abraham holds a great feast. *Genesis 21:1–8*

On Moriah

Laid on the altar

Isaac asks, "Where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" The angel of the LORD stops Abraham, and a ram is offered. *Genesis 22:1–14*

Age 40

Marries Rebekah

Meditating in the field at evening, Isaac meets her, loves her, and is comforted after his mother's death. *Genesis 24:62–67; 25:20*

Age 60

Father of twins

After twenty barren years, Isaac prays, and Rebekah bears Esau and Jacob. *Genesis 25:20–26*

Age 75

Buries Abraham

Isaac and Ishmael bury their father at Machpelah, and God blesses Isaac. *Genesis 25:7–11*

In Gerar

Blessed in famine

God renews Abraham's promises. Isaac reaps a hundredfold, reopens wells and makes peace with Abimelech. *Genesis 26:1–33*

Old and blind

Blesses Jacob

Deceived by Rebekah and Jacob, he trembles at the truth, yet confirms the blessing. *Genesis 27:1–28:5*

Age 180

Dies

Isaac dies "old and full of days," and Esau and Jacob bury him together. *Genesis 35:27–29*

Key activities

Genesis does not give Isaac's age on Moriah. He is called "the lad" and is strong enough to carry the wood. Jewish tradition later made him a grown man who went willingly. The text itself stays silent about what he felt.

1. **Carried the wood.** He climbed the mountain with his father, carrying the wood for his own sacrifice. *Genesis 22:6–8*
2. **Was bound on the altar.** He was laid on the wood, and God provided a ram in his place. *Genesis 22:9–13*
3. **Received a wife by prayer.** Abraham's servant prayed for guidance, and Isaac received Rebekah as God's choice. *Genesis 24:12–27, 62–67*
4. **Loved his wife.** Genesis says plainly that "he loved her," and she comforted him after Sarah's death. *Genesis 24:67*
5. **Prayed for his barren wife.** He "intreated the LORD for his wife," and the LORD answered. *Genesis 25:21*
6. **Buried his father with Ishmael.** The two half-brothers laid Abraham to rest together. *Genesis 25:9*
7. **Favored Esau.** He loved Esau "because he did eat of his venison," while Rebekah loved Jacob. *Genesis 25:28*
8. **Repeated his father's lie.** In Gerar he said Rebekah was his sister, until Abimelech saw them together. *Genesis 26:6–11*
9. **Reaped a hundredfold.** He sowed in a year of famine, "and the LORD blessed him." *Genesis 26:12–14*
10. **Chose peace over quarrels.** When herdsmen fought over his wells, he moved on until he found room at Rehoboth. *Genesis 26:15–22*
11. **Worshiped at Beersheba.** God appeared to him there. He built an altar and made a covenant of peace with Abimelech. *Genesis 26:23–31*
12. **Blessed both sons.** He blessed Jacob and Esau "concerning things to come." *Genesis 27:27–40; Hebrews 11:20*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Isaac.

Old Testament

Genesis 21–35	The main account of his life
Genesis 17:19–21	God's covenant promised to Isaac before birth
Exodus 3:6	"The God of Isaac"
Genesis 31:42, 53	Jacob calls God "the fear of Isaac"
Psalm 105:8–10	The covenant sworn to Isaac

New Testament

Matthew 22:32	"Not the God of the dead, but of the living"
Romans 9:7–10	"In Isaac shall thy seed be called"
Galatians 4:28	"As Isaac was, are the children of promise"
Hebrews 11:17–20	Offered by faith; Isaac blessed his sons by faith
Echo: John 19:17	A beloved son carries the wood up a hill

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Isaac do each time the herdsmen quarreled over his wells (Genesis 26:17–22)?
2. *Understand:* Isaac repeated his father's faith and his mistakes. Why are family patterns so hard to break?
3. *Apply:* Isaac loved Esau more. Where might you be showing favoritism?
4. *Apply:* Isaac moved on until he found "room." Is there a quarrel you could step away from for peace?

17 Rebekah

The bold young woman who said "I will go," and later took her family's future into her own hands.

Rebekah enters the Bible at a well, drawing water for a stranger and all ten of his camels. He was Abraham's servant, sent to find a wife for Isaac, and he saw her kindness as God's answer to prayer. Asked whether she would leave home at once, she said simply, "I will go." She became Isaac's beloved wife and received a word from God about her twin sons. Later she planned the deception that won Jacob his father's blessing. It cost her dearly: she sent Jacob away, and Genesis never records that she saw him again.

At a glance

Name	Rebekah; "Rebecca" in Romans 9:10; meaning uncertain
Family	Daughter of Bethuel; sister of Laban; wife of Isaac
Home	"The city of Nahor" in Padan-aram (Genesis 24:10)
Key places	The well at Nahor; Beer-lahai-roi; Gerar; Beersheba
Key people	Isaac, Abraham's servant, Laban, Esau, Jacob, her nurse Deborah
Burial	The cave of Machpelah (Genesis 49:31)
Main passages	Genesis 24:1–67; 25:19–28; 26:6–11, 34–35; 27:1–28:5
New Testament	Romans 9:10–12

"And they called Rebekah, and said unto her, Wilt thou go with this man? And she said, I will go."

Genesis 24:58, KJV

The life of Rebekah

Genesis gives no ages for Rebekah. Isaac's ages come from Genesis 25:20 and 25:26.

At the well

Waters the camels

Abraham's servant prays for a sign. Before he finishes, Rebekah comes out, gives him a drink, and offers to draw water for all his camels. *Genesis 24:12–27*

At home

Agrees to go

Her brother Laban and father Bethuel agree that "the thing proceedeth from the LORD." Asked if she will go, she agrees, and her family blesses her. *Genesis 24:28–61*

Isaac age 40

Marries Isaac

She sees Isaac in the field, covers herself with a veil, and becomes his wife. He loves her and is comforted after his mother's death. *Genesis 24:62–67; 25:20*

Isaac age 60

Bears twins

After twenty years of barrenness, Isaac prays and she conceives. The children struggle within her, so she asks the LORD why. He tells her, "The elder shall serve the younger." *Genesis 25:21–26*

In Gerar

Called a sister

During a famine Isaac tells the men of Gerar that she is his sister, until King Abimelech sees them together and protects her. *Genesis 26:6–11*

Isaac old and blind

Plans the deception

She overhears Isaac promise Esau a blessing. She dresses Jacob in Esau's clothes, covers his hands with goatskins, and cooks the meal herself. *Genesis 27:1–17*

After the blessing

Sends Jacob away

Learning that Esau plans to kill Jacob, she urges Jacob to flee to Laban and persuades Isaac to send him there to find a wife. *Genesis 27:41–28:5*

Key activities

Many readers believe Rebekah acted because of God's word that "the elder shall serve the younger" (Genesis 25:23). Genesis does not say so. It shows both God's purpose and the harm done by deceit.

1. **Served a stranger.** She gave a traveler a drink and then offered, unasked, to water all his camels too. *Genesis 24:17–20*
2. **Chose to go.** She left her family at once for a husband she had never met. *Genesis 24:57–61*
3. **Comforted Isaac.** She became the wife Isaac loved, and she comforted him after Sarah's death. *Genesis 24:67*
4. **Took her question to God.** When her pregnancy troubled her, "she went to enquire of the LORD." *Genesis 25:22–23*
5. **Loved Jacob.** "Rebekah loved Jacob," while Isaac loved Esau. *Genesis 25:28*
6. **Grieved over Esau's wives.** His Hittite wives were "a grief of mind unto Isaac and to Rebekah." *Genesis 26:34–35; 27:46*
7. **Directed the deception.** She told Jacob, "Upon me be thy curse, my son: only obey my voice." *Genesis 27:5–17*
8. **Protected Jacob.** She sent him away to Haran "a few days" that became twenty years. *Genesis 27:42–45; 31:41*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rebekah.

Old Testament

Genesis 22:20–23	Her birth is reported to Abraham: "Bethuel begat Rebekah."
Genesis 24–27	This is the main account of her life.
Genesis 35:8	"Deborah Rebekah's nurse" dies and is buried near Bethel.
Genesis 49:31	Jacob says, "There they buried Isaac and Rebekah his wife."

New Testament

Romans 9:10–13	Paul points out that God's word came to Rebecca before her sons were born, "neither having done any good or evil," so that God's choice would rest "not of works, but of him that calleth."
Echoes	Like the servant at the well, Jesus meets a woman at a well (John 4:6–7). Mary, mother of Jesus, also gives a ready yes to God's call: "be it unto me according to thy word" (Luke 1:38).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Rebekah do for Abraham's servant beyond what he asked (Genesis 24:17–20)?
2. *Understand:* God had told Rebekah that the elder would serve the younger. Do you think she needed to scheme for it to happen? Why or why not?
3. *Apply:* Rebekah said, "I will go." Where is God asking you for a ready yes right now?
4. *Apply:* Rebekah favored one son. How can you show each person in your family that they are loved?

18 Esau

The firstborn twin who sold his birthright for a meal, lost his father's blessing, and still ran to embrace the brother who wronged him.

Esau was the elder twin son of Isaac and Rebekah, born red and hairy, with Jacob gripping his heel. He grew into a skilled hunter and his father's favorite. Coming in hungry one day, he traded his birthright for a bowl of red stew. Later Jacob took the blessing Isaac meant for Esau, and Esau swore to kill him. Yet twenty years later Esau ran to meet his brother and embraced him with tears. He became the father of the Edomites. Scripture remembers him as a warning against despising what is holy, but his story also shows a surprising grace.

At a glance

Name	Esau, probably "hairy"; also Edom, "red" (Genesis 25:25, 30)
Family	Elder twin of Jacob; Hittite wives and a daughter of Ishmael
Work	"A cunning hunter, a man of the field" (Genesis 25:27)
Key places	Beersheba, the land of Seir (Edom), Hebron (Mamre)
Key people	Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, Ishmael
Descendants	The Edomites (Genesis 36:1–43)
Main passages	Genesis 25:19–34; 27:1–28:9; 32:3–33:16; 36
New Testament	Romans 9:10–13; Hebrews 11:20; 12:16–17

"And Esau ran to meet him, and embraced him, and fell on his neck, and kissed him: and they wept."

Genesis 33:4, KJV

The life of Esau

Isaac's ages come from Genesis 25:26 and 35:28; Esau's age at marriage from Genesis 26:34. On the traditional chronology the twins were born c. 2006 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Isaac age 60

Born first

Esau comes out "red, all over like an hairy garment," and his twin follows, holding his heel. *Genesis 25:24–26*

Grown

A man of the field

Esau becomes a skilled hunter. Isaac loves him for the game he brings home. *Genesis 25:27–28*

Coming in hungry

Sells his birthright

Faint from the field, Esau asks for Jacob's red stew. Jacob demands the birthright, and Esau swears it away. "Thus Esau despised his birthright." *Genesis 25:29–34*

Age 40

Marries Hittite wives

Esau marries Judith and Bashemath, and they become "a grief of mind" to his parents. *Genesis 26:34–35*

Isaac old and blind

Loses the blessing

Esau returns from hunting to find that Jacob has taken his blessing. He cries, "Bless me, even me also, O my father." *Genesis 27:30–40*

After the blessing

Plots revenge

Esau plans to kill Jacob after Isaac's death. Seeing that Canaanite wives displease his father, he also marries a daughter of Ishmael. *Genesis 27:41; 28:6–9*

Twenty years later

Embraces Jacob

Esau comes from Seir with four hundred men. Instead of attacking, he runs to Jacob, kisses him, and they weep together. *Genesis 32:3–6; 33:1–16*

Isaac age 180

Buries his father

Isaac dies at Mamre, and Esau and Jacob bury him together. Esau later settles in mount Seir. *Genesis 35:27–29; 36:6–8*

Key activities

Malachi 1:2–3 and Romans 9:13 say "Esau have I hated." Many read "hated" as a Hebrew way of saying "loved less" or "did not choose" (compare Genesis 29:30–31). Christians differ on whether Paul means the choice of individuals for salvation or of nations for a role in God's plan.

1. **Hunted.** He became "a cunning hunter, a man of the field," his father's favorite. *Genesis 25:27–28*
2. **Traded his birthright.** He sold it for "bread and pottage of lentiles," saying, "What profit shall this birthright do to me?" *Genesis 25:29–34*
3. **Married outside the family.** His Hittite wives grieved Isaac and Rebekah. *Genesis 26:34–35*
4. **Wept for a lost blessing.** He "cried with a great and exceeding bitter cry" but could not undo it. *Genesis 27:34–38; Hebrews 12:17*
5. **Nursed a grudge.** He hated Jacob and planned to kill him once Isaac was dead. *Genesis 27:41*
6. **Tried to please his father.** He married Mahalath, Ishmael's daughter, because Canaanite wives displeased Isaac. *Genesis 28:6–9*
7. **Forgave his brother.** He ran to meet Jacob, embraced him, and said, "I have enough, my brother." *Genesis 33:4–9*
8. **Founded a nation.** His family grew into the Edomites of mount Seir. *Genesis 36:1–43*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Esau.

Old Testament

Genesis 36:1–43	"The generations of Esau, who is Edom"
Numbers 20:14–21	Edom refuses Israel passage
Deuteronomy 23:7	Do not abhor an Edomite, "for he is thy brother"
Obadiah 10	Edom's violence "against thy brother Jacob"
Malachi 1:2–3	"Yet I loved Jacob, And I hated Esau"

New Testament

Romans 9:10–13	God's choice "not of works, but of him that calleth"
Hebrews 11:20	Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau by faith
Hebrews 12:16–17	"For one morsel of meat sold his birthright"
Echo: Luke 15:20	A father runs to embrace his returning son

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Esau say about his birthright when he was hungry (Genesis 25:32)?
2. *Understand:* Esau had every reason for revenge. What do you think changed his heart by Genesis 33?
3. *Apply:* What "bowl of stew" tempts you to trade away what matters most?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone you need to meet with grace instead of a grudge?

19 Jacob

The schemer who wrestled with God, limped away blessed, and gave his new name, Israel, to a nation.

Jacob was born grasping his twin brother's heel, and for much of his life he kept grasping. He bought Esau's birthright and stole his father's blessing, then ran for his life. On the road God met him in a dream and promised never to leave him. In Haran the deceiver was himself deceived by Laban. Coming home, he wrestled through the night and would not let go without a blessing. He left with a limp and a new name, Israel, and his twelve sons became the twelve tribes. "The God of Jacob" gives hope to every flawed believer.

At a glance

Name	Jacob, "supplanter" (Genesis 27:36); renamed Israel
Family	Twin of Esau; wives Leah and Rachel; twelve sons, Dinah
When	Traditionally c. 2006–1859 BC; many scholars c. 2000–1700 BC
Key places	Bethel, Haran, Peniel, Shechem, Hebron, Goshen
Key people	Isaac, Rebekah, Esau, Laban, Leah, Rachel, Joseph
Lifespan	147 years (Genesis 47:28)
Main passages	Genesis 25:19–35:29; 37; 42–50
New Testament	John 1:51; 4:5–12; Romans 9:10–13; Hebrews 11:21

"And he said, Thy name shall be called no more Jacob, but Israel: for as a prince hast thou power with God and with men, and hast prevailed."

Genesis 32:28, KJV

The life of Jacob

Ages come from Genesis. The traditional chronology (from 1 Kings 6:1) has Jacob entering Egypt c. 1876 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Isaac age 60

Born second

Jacob is born holding Esau's heel and grows up "a plain man, dwelling in tents." *Genesis 25:21–27*

Isaac old and blind

Takes the blessing

In Esau's clothes Jacob says, "I am Esau thy firstborn." Esau vows to kill him, and Jacob flees. *Genesis 27:1–28:5*

On the road

Dreams at Bethel

He sees a ladder to heaven. God renews Abraham's promises: "I am with thee." Jacob makes a vow. *Genesis 28:10–22*

In Haran

Twenty years with Laban

Given Leah instead of Rachel, he serves fourteen years for his wives and six for flocks. *Genesis 29:1–31:55*

At the Jabbok

Wrestles and is renamed

Alone at night, he wrestles a man until dawn and is renamed Israel. Esau embraces him. *Genesis 32:1–33:17*

Back in Canaan

Loses Rachel and Joseph

Rachel dies bearing Benjamin. His sons sell Joseph, and Jacob refuses to be comforted. *Genesis 35:16–20; 37:2–35*

Age 130

Goes down to Egypt

God says, "Fear not to go down into Egypt." Jacob stands before Pharaoh and blesses him. *Genesis 45:25–47:10*

Age 147

Blesses his sons and dies

He blesses Joseph's sons and his twelve sons, and is buried at Machpelah. *Genesis 47:28–50:13*

Key activities

The man who wrestled Jacob is not named. Jacob says he has "seen God face to face" (Genesis 32:30), and Hosea 12:4 calls him "the angel." Many Christians see this as an appearance of God in human form; others see an angel sent by God.

1. **Bought the birthright.** He made hungry Esau swear it away for bread and lentil stew. *Genesis 25:29–34*
2. **Deceived his father.** He lied three times, even saying, "The LORD thy God brought it to me." *Genesis 27:18–29*
3. **Made a vow at Bethel.** He promised that the LORD would be his God and pledged a tenth of all God gave him. *Genesis 28:16–22*
4. **Served for love.** His seven years for Rachel "seemed unto him but a few days, for the love he had to her." *Genesis 29:18–20*
5. **Was deceived himself.** On the wedding night Laban gave him Leah instead of Rachel. *Genesis 29:21–30*
6. **Fathered twelve sons.** Through Leah, Rachel, Bilhah and Zilpah, amid bitter rivalry between the sisters, the family of Israel was born. *Genesis 29:31–30:24; 35:16–18*
7. **Prospered under pressure.** Though Laban changed his wages ten times, God made him rich. *Genesis 30:25–43; 31:38–42*
8. **Prayed in fear.** "I am not worthy of the least of all the mercies." *Genesis 32:9–12*
9. **Wrestled for a blessing.** "I will not let thee go, except thou bless me." He limped away renamed Israel. *Genesis 32:24–32*
10. **Returned to Bethel.** He told his household to put away their foreign gods and built an altar where God had first met him. *Genesis 35:1–15*
11. **Favored Joseph.** He loved Joseph most and gave him a coat of many colours, which stirred his brothers' hatred. *Genesis 37:3–4*
12. **Blessed by faith.** Dying, he blessed Joseph's sons and spoke over each of his own sons. *Genesis 48:1–49:33; Hebrews 11:21*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jacob.

Old Testament

Genesis 25–50	The main account of his life
Deuteronomy 26:5	"A Syrian ready to perish was my father," most take as Jacob
Psalm 46:7	"The God of Jacob is our refuge"
Hosea 12:3–4, 12	He took his brother by the heel, wept and prayed

New Testament

Matthew 8:11	He will sit with Abraham and Isaac in the kingdom
John 1:51	"Angels of God ascending and descending upon the Son of man"
John 4:5–12	Jesus sits at "Jacob's well"
Romans 9:10–13	God chose Jacob before the twins were born
Hebrews 11:21	He blessed Joseph's sons and "worshipped"
Echo: 2 Corinthians 12:9	Strength made perfect in weakness

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God promise Jacob at Bethel, though he was running from his own wrongdoing (Genesis 28:13–15)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God let Jacob walk away with a limp?
3. *Apply:* "I will not let thee go, except thou bless me." What should you keep praying about?
4. *Apply:* Jacob repeated his parents' favoritism. What family pattern do you want to stop with you?

20 Laban

Rebekah's brother and Jacob's father-in-law, a shrewd host who met his match.

Laban lived in Haran, in Padanaram, far to the north of Canaan. He was Rebekah's brother, Jacob's uncle, and the father of Leah and Rachel. He first appears welcoming Abraham's servant, who had come for a wife for Isaac. Years later he welcomed Jacob, who had fled from Esau. Laban gave Jacob work, two wives and a home, but tricked him on his wedding night and changed his wages again and again. In the end God warned Laban not to harm Jacob, and they parted with a covenant of peace. God kept his promise to Jacob even in a hard household.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Lavan*, meaning "white"
Family	Son of Bethuel; brother of Rebekah (Genesis 24:15, 29)
Children	Leah, Rachel, and sons who are not named (Genesis 29:16; 31:1)
Called	"Laban the Syrian," that is, the Aramean (Genesis 25:20; 31:20)
Home	Haran in Padanaram, northern Mesopotamia (Genesis 27:43; 28:2)
Key people	Abraham's servant, Rebekah, Jacob, Leah, Rachel
Main passages	Genesis 24:29–60; 29:1–31:55
New Testament	Not named

"The LORD watch between me and thee, when we are absent one from another."

Genesis 31:49, KJV

The life of Laban

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Laban. The order below follows the text. Jacob's stay with him lasted twenty years (Genesis 31:38, 41).

In Haran

Welcomes Abraham's servant

Seeing Rebekah's gold earring and bracelets, Laban runs out: "Come in, thou blessed of the LORD." *Genesis 24:28–33*

In Haran

Lets Rebekah go

Laban and Bethuel agree, "The thing proceedeth from the LORD," and Rebekah goes to marry Isaac. *Genesis 24:50–61*

Many years later

Welcomes Jacob

Laban runs to meet his fleeing nephew: "Surely thou art my bone and my flesh." *Genesis 29:13–14*

After seven years

Swaps the brides

Jacob serves seven years for Rachel. At the wedding Laban brings Leah instead, then gives Rachel a week later in exchange for seven more years of work. *Genesis 29:18–30*

Jacob's twenty years

Changes the wages

Laban admits the LORD has blessed him for Jacob's sake. He agrees to Jacob's wages, then removes the animals that would have been Jacob's share. Jacob says his wages were changed "ten times." *Genesis 30:25–36; 31:7, 41*

On the third day

Pursues Jacob

Jacob slips away with his family and flocks while Laban is shearing sheep. Laban chases him for seven days, but God warns him in a dream not to harm Jacob. *Genesis 31:19–35*

Mount Gilead

Makes a covenant

The two men set up a pillar and a heap of stones as a witness and a boundary. Early next morning Laban kisses his grandchildren and daughters, blesses them, and goes home. *Genesis 31:43–55*

Key activities

In Genesis 30:27 the KJV says Laban had "learned by experience" that God blessed him through Jacob. The Hebrew word often means "to practise divination," so some translate it "I have divined." Genesis 31:53 also hints that Laban honored other gods alongside the God of Abraham.

1. **Welcomed a stranger.** He ran to meet Abraham's servant and gave him lodging and food for his camels. *Genesis 24:29–32*
2. **Agreed to Rebekah's marriage.** He saw the LORD's hand in the servant's story and let his sister go to Isaac. *Genesis 24:50–51*
3. **Took Jacob into his home.** He received his nephew and asked him to name his wages. *Genesis 29:13–15*
4. **Deceived Jacob.** He gave Leah in place of Rachel and defended it: "It must not be so done in our country, to give the younger before the firstborn." *Genesis 29:22–26*
5. **Grew rich through Jacob.** His small flock increased greatly while Jacob cared for it. *Genesis 30:27–30*
6. **Tried to keep what was Jacob's.** He removed the spotted and speckled animals and set three days' journey between his flocks and Jacob's. *Genesis 30:31–36*
7. **Heard God's warning.** God told him in a dream, "Take heed that thou speak not to Jacob either good or bad." *Genesis 31:24, 29*
8. **Searched for his household gods.** He hunted through the tents for his missing images but did not find them, because Rachel had hidden them. *Genesis 31:30–35*
9. **Made peace.** He and Jacob swore a covenant, ate together, and agreed not to cross the boundary to harm each other. *Genesis 31:44–54*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Laban.

Old Testament

Genesis 24:29–60	Laban welcomes the servant and sends Rebekah
Genesis 27:43	Rebekah sends Jacob to "Laban my brother to Haran"
Genesis 29:1–31:55	Jacob's twenty years with Laban
Genesis 32:4	"I have sojourned with Laban"
Hosea 12:12	"For a wife he kept sheep"
Echo: Genesis 27:18–29	The deceiver deceived in turn

New Testament

Echo: Galatians 6:7	"Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap"
Echo: Matthew 6:24	No one can serve God and mammon

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Laban say when Jacob accused him of deceit (Genesis 29:25–27)?
2. *Understand:* Laban was blessed because of Jacob, yet kept cheating him. Why didn't gratitude change him?
3. *Apply:* God saw Jacob's mistreatment (Genesis 31:42). Where do you need to trust God with something unfair?
4. *Apply:* Is there a relationship where a clear, fair boundary would help keep the peace?

21 Leah

The unloved wife whom God saw, mother of Judah and Levi.

Leah was the elder daughter of Laban and the first wife of Jacob. She did not choose her marriage. Her father slipped her into the wedding in place of her sister Rachel, and Jacob made no secret that he loved Rachel more. Yet Genesis says the LORD saw that Leah was unloved and gave her children. Her sons' names tell her story, moving from longing for her husband's love to simple praise of God. Leah became the mother of six of Israel's twelve tribes, including Levi, the tribe of the priests, and Judah, the tribe of David and of Jesus. She was buried in the family tomb beside Abraham, Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, where Jacob later asked to be buried too.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Le'ah*. Its meaning is uncertain; "weary" and "wild cow" are common suggestions
Family	Elder daughter of Laban; sister of Rachel; wife of Jacob (Genesis 29:16, 23)
Children	Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun and a daughter, Dinah (Genesis 35:23; 30:21)
Her maid	Zilpah, mother of Gad and Asher (Genesis 29:24; 30:9–13)
Key places	Haran; Canaan; the cave of Machpelah (Genesis 49:31)
Main passages	Genesis 29:16–35; 30:9–21; 31:4–16; 49:31
New Testament	Not named

"And she conceived again, and bare a son: and she said, Now will I praise the LORD: therefore she called his name Judah; and left bearing."

Genesis 29:35, KJV

The life of Leah

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Leah. The order below follows the text. Her children were born during Jacob's twenty years in Haran (Genesis 31:41).

In Haran

The elder daughter

Laban has two daughters. Genesis says, "Leah was tender eyed; but Rachel was beautiful and well favoured." Jacob loves Rachel and agrees to serve seven years for her. *Genesis 29:16–18*

The wedding night

Given in Rachel's place

Laban brings Leah to Jacob in the evening. In the morning Jacob discovers the switch. A week later he also marries Rachel, whom he loves more. *Genesis 29:21–30*

The first years

Four sons

The LORD sees that Leah is unloved and opens her womb. She bears Reuben, Simeon, Levi and Judah, naming each one from her heart. *Genesis 29:31–35*

Later

Zilpah's sons

When Leah stops having children, she gives her maid Zilpah to Jacob, as Rachel had done with Bilhah. Zilpah bears Gad and Asher, and Leah names them. *Genesis 30:9–13*

Wheat harvest

More children

Leah trades Reuben's mandrakes to Rachel. God hears Leah, and she bears Issachar and Zebulun, and later a daughter, Dinah. *Genesis 30:14–21*

Leaving Haran

Stands with Jacob

Jacob calls Leah and Rachel to the field. The sisters agree that their father has treated them as strangers, and they leave with Jacob. *Genesis 31:4–17*

Before Jacob goes to Egypt

Buried at Machpelah

Genesis does not record her death. Near the end of his life, Jacob says, "there I buried Leah," in the family tomb. *Genesis 49:29–31*

Key activities

"Tender eyed" in Genesis 29:17 translates a Hebrew word meaning soft, delicate or weak. Some take it as a compliment (gentle eyes) and others as a flaw (weak or dull eyes). The text does not settle it.

1. **Kept quiet in her father's scheme.** She went along with Laban's switch on the wedding night. Genesis records nothing she said. *Genesis 29:23–25*
2. **Hoped for her husband's love.** At Reuben's birth she said, "now therefore my husband will love me." *Genesis 29:32*
3. **Knew that God had heard.** She named Simeon because the LORD had heard that she was unloved. *Genesis 29:33*
4. **Turned to praise.** At Judah's birth she said simply, "Now will I praise the LORD." *Genesis 29:35*
5. **Competed with her sister.** She gave Zilpah to Jacob, and she and Rachel struggled over Jacob and over children. *Genesis 30:9–16*
6. **Was heard by God again.** "And God hearkened unto Leah," and she bore Issachar and Zebulun. *Genesis 30:17–20*
7. **Chose to leave with Jacob.** With Rachel she answered, "whatsoever God hath said unto thee, do." *Genesis 31:14–16*
8. **Was honored in the family tomb.** Jacob buried her at Machpelah, the place he chose for his own burial. *Genesis 49:31*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Leah.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:16–31:55	The main account of her life in Haran
Genesis 33:1–2, 7	Second in line when Jacob meets Esau
Genesis 35:23; 46:15	Her sons listed among the sons of Israel
Genesis 49:31	"And there I buried Leah"
Ruth 4:11	"Like Rachel and like Leah," builders of Israel's house
Echo: Genesis 49:10	Kings to come from her son Judah

New Testament

Hebrews 7:14	"Our Lord sprang out of Juda," Leah's son
Echo: Revelation 5:5	"The Lion of the tribe of Juda"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Read the names of Leah's sons (Genesis 29:32–35). How does her focus change from Reuben to Judah?
2. *Understand:* The LORD "saw" that Leah was unloved (Genesis 29:31). What does this show about how God sees people?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to earn love that cannot be earned?
4. *Apply:* Who around you might feel unseen, and how could you notice them this week?

22 Rachel

Jacob's beloved wife, who waited long for children and died giving birth to Benjamin.

Rachel was the younger daughter of Laban and the wife Jacob loved most. Jacob met her at a well, tending her father's sheep, and worked fourteen years to marry her. Yet for years she had no children while her sister Leah had many, and the sisters became rivals. At last God remembered Rachel, and she bore Joseph. Later, near Bethlehem, she died giving birth to Benjamin. Her story holds love and longing, jealousy and faith. Jeremiah pictured her weeping for her children, and Matthew heard that cry again at the birth of Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Rachel*, meaning "ewe," a female sheep
Family	Younger daughter of Laban; sister of Leah; wife of Jacob (Genesis 29:16, 28)
Children	Joseph and Benjamin (Genesis 35:24)
Her maid	Bilhah, mother of Dan and Naphtali (Genesis 29:29; 30:3–8)
Key places	The well near Haran; the road to Ephrath, which is Bethlehem (Genesis 29:4–10; 35:19)
Main passages	Genesis 29:6–31:35; 35:16–20
Later references	Ruth 4:11; 1 Samuel 10:2; Jeremiah 31:15
New Testament	Matthew 2:18

"And God remembered Rachel, and God hearkened to her, and opened her womb."

Genesis 30:22, KJV

The life of Rachel

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Rachel. The order below follows the text. Joseph was born near the end of Jacob's first fourteen years in Haran (Genesis 30:25–26).

At the well

Meets Jacob

Rachel comes with her father's sheep. Jacob rolls the stone from the well, waters her flock, kisses her and weeps. She runs home to tell her father. *Genesis 29:6–12*

Seven years

Loved and waited for

Jacob offers to work seven years for Rachel. "They seemed unto him but a few days, for the love he had to her." *Genesis 29:18–20*

The wedding week

Married after Leah

Laban gives Leah to Jacob first. A week later Rachel becomes Jacob's wife too, and he works seven more years for her. *Genesis 29:21–30*

Childless years

Bilhah's sons

Rachel envies her sister and gives her maid Bilhah to Jacob. Bilhah bears Dan and Naphtali, and Rachel names them. *Genesis 30:1–8*

At last

Joseph is born

God remembers Rachel and she bears a son. She names him Joseph and prays, "The LORD shall add to me another son." *Genesis 30:22–24*

Leaving Haran

Takes the images

While Laban is away shearing sheep, Rachel steals his household images. When he searches her tent, she sits on them and stays hidden. *Genesis 31:19, 33–35*

Near Bethlehem

Dies giving birth

On the road to Ephrath she has a hard labor. Dying, she names the baby Benoni, but Jacob calls him Benjamin. Jacob sets a pillar on her grave. *Genesis 35:16–20*

Key activities

No one knows why Rachel took her father's images. Some suggest she wanted their protection or still trusted them. Others link them to family inheritance, or think she simply wanted to hurt Laban. Genesis does not say.

1. **Kept her father's sheep.** She was a working shepherdess when Jacob first saw her. *Genesis 29:9*
2. **Was deeply loved.** Jacob served fourteen years for her and loved her more than Leah. *Genesis 29:18, 30*
3. **Cried out for children.** In her envy she told Jacob, "Give me children, or else I die." *Genesis 30:1–2*
4. **Struggled with her sister.** At Naphtali's birth she said, "With great wrestlings have I wrestled with my sister, and I have prevailed." *Genesis 30:8*
5. **Bargained for mandrakes.** She traded a night with Jacob to Leah in exchange for Reuben's mandrakes. *Genesis 30:14–16*
6. **Received God's answer.** God remembered her, and she said, "God hath taken away my reproach." *Genesis 30:22–23*
7. **Stole and hid the images.** She took Laban's household gods and kept them hidden during his search. *Genesis 31:19, 34–35*
8. **Gave her life for a son.** She died bearing Benjamin, the only one of Jacob's sons born in Canaan. *Genesis 35:16–19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rachel.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:6–35:20	The main account
Genesis 48:7	Jacob grieves that she died on the way to Ephrath
Ruth 4:11	"Like Rachel and like Leah," builders of Israel's house
1 Samuel 10:2	"Rachel's sepulchre in the border of Benjamin"
Jeremiah 31:15–17	"Rahel weeping for her children"
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:19–20	Hannah too longed for a child

New Testament

Matthew 2:16–18	Herod's killings in Bethlehem: "Rachel weeping for her children"
Tradition	Rachel's Tomb near Bethlehem; some place the site farther north

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Rachel say to Jacob in Genesis 30:1, and how did he answer?
2. *Understand:* Rachel had Jacob's love; Leah had children. How did each want what the other had?
3. *Apply:* What do you tend to envy, and how could you bring that longing to God?
4. *Apply:* How could your group encourage someone who is still waiting?

23 Reuben

Jacob's firstborn, a man of good intentions who lost his place through one grave sin.

Reuben was the eldest of Jacob's twelve sons, born to Leah in Haran. As firstborn he should have led the family. He often meant well. He tried to rescue Joseph from his brothers, spoke up about their guilt, and offered his own sons as a pledge for Benjamin's safety. But he also committed a grave sin against his father, and at Jacob's deathbed he heard the words "Unstable as water, thou shalt not excel." The firstborn's rights passed to Joseph's sons, and leadership to Judah. His life shows that good intentions matter, but so do steady faithfulness and self-control.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Re'uven*, "See, a son" (Genesis 29:32)
Family	Firstborn of Jacob and Leah
Sons	Hanoch, Phallu, Hezron and Carmi (Genesis 46:9)
Key places	Haran; Canaan; Dothan; Egypt
Key people	Jacob, Leah, Joseph, Benjamin, Bilhah
Main passages	Genesis 35:22; 37:21–30; 42:22, 37; 49:3–4
His tribe	Settled east of the Jordan (Numbers 32:1–33)
New Testament	The tribe of Reuben in Revelation 7:5

> *"And Reuben said unto them, Shed no blood, but cast him into this pit that is in the wilderness, and lay no hand upon him; that he might rid him out of their hands, to deliver him to his father again."*
>
> Genesis 37:22, KJV

The life of Reuben

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Reuben. The order below follows the text. He was born early in Jacob's twenty years in Haran (Genesis 29:32; 31:41).

In Haran

Jacob's firstborn

Leah bears her first son. She names him Reuben, saying, "Surely the LORD hath looked upon my affliction; now therefore my husband will love me." *Genesis 29:31–32*

Wheat harvest

Brings mandrakes

Young Reuben finds mandrakes in the field and brings them to his mother. Leah and Rachel bargain over them. *Genesis 30:14–16*

Beyond the tower of Edar

Sins against his father

After Rachel's death, Reuben sleeps with Bilhah, his father's concubine. Genesis says only, "and Israel heard it." *Genesis 35:21–22*

At Dothan

Tries to save Joseph

The brothers plot to kill Joseph. Reuben talks them into throwing him into a pit instead, planning to rescue him. He returns to find Joseph gone. *Genesis 37:18–30*

In Egypt

Names the brothers' guilt

When the governor of Egypt treats them harshly, Reuben reminds his brothers that he had warned them not to sin against the boy. *Genesis 42:21–24*

Back in Canaan

Offers his sons

Jacob refuses to send Benjamin to Egypt. Reuben says, "Slay my two sons, if I bring him not to thee." Jacob still refuses. *Genesis 42:35–38*

Jacob's deathbed

Loses the firstborn's place

Jacob calls him "my might, and the beginning of my strength," but says he will not excel, because he defiled his father's bed. *Genesis 49:3–4*

Key activities

Some readers see Reuben's sin with Bilhah as lust. Others think he meant to stop Bilhah, Rachel's maid, from taking Rachel's place above his mother Leah, or to claim leadership early. Genesis gives no motive.

1. **Brought a gift to his mother.** He found mandrakes in the wheat harvest and gave them to Leah. *Genesis 30:14*
2. **Dishonored his father.** He slept with Bilhah, his father's concubine, and Jacob heard of it. *Genesis 35:22*
3. **Stopped a murder.** He said, "Let us not kill him," and persuaded his brothers to use the pit instead. *Genesis 37:21–22*
4. **Grieved for Joseph.** Finding the pit empty, he tore his clothes and cried, "The child is not; and I, whither shall I go?" *Genesis 37:29–30*
5. **Spoke up about guilt.** In Egypt he said, "Spake I not unto you, saying, Do not sin against the child; and ye would not hear?" *Genesis 42:22*
6. **Offered a costly pledge.** He offered his own two sons as surety for Benjamin's safe return. *Genesis 42:37*
7. **Went down to Egypt.** He moved to Egypt with his four sons and all Jacob's family. *Genesis 46:8–9*
8. **Received Jacob's hard word.** He heard that he was "Unstable as water" and would not excel. *Genesis 49:3–4*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Reuben.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:32–49:4	The main account of his life
Genesis 48:5	Joseph's sons adopted "as Reuben and Simeon"
1 Chronicles 5:1–2	His birthright "given unto the sons of Joseph"
Numbers 32:1–33	His tribe settles east of the Jordan
Deuteronomy 33:6	"Let Reuben live, and not die"
Judges 5:15–16	"Great searchings of heart" in Reuben
Echo: Proverbs 16:32	"He that ruleth his spirit"

New Testament

Revelation 7:5	Reuben among the sealed tribes, second after Judah
Echo: James 1:8	"Unstable in all his ways"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Reuben plan to do for Joseph (Genesis 37:22), and what happened instead?
2. *Understand:* Reuben meant well, yet is remembered as "unstable." What was missing?
3. *Apply:* Where do you need to speak up now rather than wait?
4. *Apply:* Reuben's tribe was still blessed (Deuteronomy 33:6). How does God's mercy give you hope after failure?

24 Judah

The brother who sold Joseph, was humbled, and offered his own life for Benjamin: father of the royal tribe.

Judah was Jacob's fourth son by Leah. His name means "praise," and his tribe would give Israel its kings, from David to the line of Jesus. But his early story is not praiseworthy. It was his idea to sell Joseph as a slave, and he treated his widowed daughter-in-law Tamar unjustly until she exposed him. Yet Judah changed. Years later in Egypt, when Benjamin faced slavery, Judah offered to take his place, and Joseph could hold back no longer. His life shows how God can reshape a selfish man into a leader who gives himself for others.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yehudah,* linked to "praise" (Genesis 29:35)
Family	Fourth son of Jacob and Leah
Wife	The daughter of Shuah, a Canaanite (Genesis 38:2)
Sons	Er, Onan, Shelah; twins Pharez and Zarah by Tamar
Key places	Dothan; Adullam and Timnath; Egypt; Goshen
Key people	Jacob, Joseph, Benjamin, Tamar
Main passages	Genesis 37:26–27; 38; 43–44; 49:8–12
New Testament	Matthew 1:2–3; Hebrews 7:14; Revelation 5:5

"The sceptre shall not depart from Judah, nor a lawgiver from between his feet, until Shiloh come; and unto him shall the gathering of the people be."

Genesis 49:10, KJV

The life of Judah

Genesis gives few ages for Judah. Tradition dates Jacob's move to Egypt c. 1876 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC. Genesis 38 may overlap Joseph's story.

In Haran

Born to Leah

Leah says, "Now will I praise the LORD: therefore she called his name Judah." *Genesis 29:35*

Near Dothan

Sells Joseph

Judah asks, "What profit is it if we slay our brother?" and suggests selling him instead. *Genesis 37:25–28*

At Adullam

Leaves his brothers

He marries the daughter of Shuah, a Canaanite; they have Er, Onan and Shelah. *Genesis 38:1–5*

Near Timnath

Confronted by Tamar

Shown his own signet and staff, he admits, "She hath been more righteous than I." *Genesis 38:6–30*

During the famine

Pledges himself for Benjamin

"I will be surety for him; of my hand shalt thou require him." *Genesis 43:1–14*

In Joseph's house

Offers his life

He asks to remain a slave in Benjamin's place, and Joseph reveals himself. *Genesis 44:14–45:3*

c. 1876 BC
Into Egypt

Leads the way to Goshen

Jacob sends Judah ahead to Joseph to show the way. *Genesis 46:12, 28*

Jacob's deathbed

Receives the royal blessing

Jacob calls him a lion's whelp and promises the sceptre will not depart from him. *Genesis 49:8–12*

Key activities

Genesis 49:10 is debated. "Shiloh" may be a name or title for a coming ruler, or may mean "until he comes to whom it belongs." Jews and Christians have long read the verse as a promise of the Messiah.

1. **Proposed selling Joseph.** He talked the brothers out of murder but into selling Joseph for twenty pieces of silver. *Genesis 37:26–28*
2. **Joined in deceiving Jacob.** The brothers let their father believe Joseph was dead. *Genesis 37:31–35*
3. **Went his own way.** He left his brothers and married a Canaanite woman. *Genesis 38:1–2*
4. **Buried two sons.** The LORD took the life of Er, who was wicked, and then of Onan, whose act displeased him. *Genesis 38:7–10*
5. **Failed his daughter-in-law.** He sent Tamar home to wait for Shelah but never gave her to him. *Genesis 38:11, 14*
6. **Confessed his wrong.** Faced with his own signet, bracelets and staff, he admitted, "She hath been more righteous than I." *Genesis 38:25–26*
7. **Spoke plainly to his father.** He insisted they could not return to Egypt without Benjamin, because the governor had warned them. *Genesis 43:3–5*
8. **Became surety for Benjamin.** He took full responsibility: "let me bear the blame for ever." *Genesis 43:8–10*
9. **Confessed the family's guilt.** Before Joseph he said, "God hath found out the iniquity of thy servants." *Genesis 44:16*
10. **Offered himself in Benjamin's place.** "Let thy servant abide instead of the lad a bondman to my lord; and let the lad go up with his brethren." *Genesis 44:18–34*
11. **Guided the family to Goshen.** Jacob trusted him to go ahead and prepare the way. *Genesis 46:28*
12. **Was named the royal tribe.** Jacob gave him the sceptre blessing, the promise of lasting rule. *Genesis 49:8–12*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Judah.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:35–50:26	The main account of his life
Ruth 4:12, 18–22	The line from Pharez to David
1 Chronicles 5:2	"Of him came the chief ruler"
Psalm 78:67–70	God "chose the tribe of Judah"
Micah 5:2	A ruler from Bethlehem, "little among the thousands of Judah"
Echo: Exodus 32:31–32	Moses offers himself for his people

New Testament

Matthew 1:2–3	Judah and "Phares" in Jesus' genealogy
Hebrews 7:14	"Our Lord sprang out of Juda"
Revelation 5:5	"The Lion of the tribe of Juda"
Echo: 1 Peter 3:18	Christ suffered, "the just for the unjust"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Compare Judah's words in Genesis 37:26–27 with Genesis 44:33–34. What changed?
2. *Understand:* Why is admitting wrong (Genesis 38:26) often the first step to real change?
3. *Apply:* Where do you need to take responsibility instead of shifting blame?
4. *Apply:* Judah protected the brother his father favored. Who could you stand up for, even at a cost?

25 Tamar

A wronged widow who claimed her place in Judah's family and became an ancestor of David and of Jesus.

Tamar was the daughter-in-law of Judah, one of Jacob's twelve sons. Her story in Genesis 38 is short, and it is not easy reading. She was married to Judah's eldest son, Er, who died. By family custom his brother Onan should have given her a child to carry on Er's name, but Onan refused, and he died too. Judah then promised her his youngest son, Shelah, but quietly broke that promise and left her alone and childless. Tamar took a bold and risky step that brought the truth to light. Judah confessed that she was more in the right than he was. Tamar bore twin sons, and through one of them, Pharez, came King David. Matthew names her in the family line of Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Tamar*, meaning "date palm"
Family	Wife of Er, then of Onan, both sons of Judah; her own family is not named (Genesis 38:6–8)
Children	Twin sons, Pharez and Zarah, by Judah (Genesis 38:27–30)
Key places	Canaan; her father's house; the road to Timnath (Genesis 38:11–14)
Key people	Judah, Er, Onan, Shelah, Hirah the Adullamite
Main passages	Genesis 38:6–30
Later references	Ruth 4:12; 1 Chronicles 2:4
New Testament	Matthew 1:3, as "Thamar"

"She hath been more righteous than I; because that I gave her not to Shelah my son."

Genesis 38:26, KJV

The life of Tamar

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Tamar. The order below follows the text. Genesis places her story right after Joseph is sold into Egypt, though the events may cover many years.

In Canaan

Married to Er

Judah chooses Tamar as a wife for his firstborn son, Er. Genesis says Er "was wicked in the sight of the LORD; and the LORD slew him," leaving Tamar a young widow. *Genesis 38:6–7*

After Er's death

Onan refuses

Judah tells his second son, Onan, to marry Tamar and give his brother an heir. Onan knows the child would not count as his own, so he refuses. The LORD takes his life as well. *Genesis 38:8–10*

Sent home

Told to wait

Judah sends Tamar back to her father's house to live as a widow until Shelah grows up. Privately, Judah is afraid Shelah will die like his brothers. *Genesis 38:11*

Shelah grown

Meets Judah on the road

Shelah is grown but not given to her. Veiled, Tamar waits by the road to Timnath. Not knowing her, Judah takes her for a prostitute, leaves his signet, bracelets and staff as a pledge, and she conceives. *Genesis 38:12–18*

Three months later

Accused and cleared

Tamar is found to be expecting. Judah orders her death. She sends him the pledge he had left with her. Judah recognizes his own belongings and admits he was wrong. *Genesis 38:24–26*

Months later

Twin sons are born

At the birth the midwife ties a scarlet thread on the hand of one twin, Zarah, but his brother Pharez is born first. *Genesis 38:27–30*

Key activities

Scripture does not praise Tamar's method, and readers have long debated it. Some see her mainly as a victim who acted in desperation. Others see a woman who risked her life for her family's future. Judah's words (Genesis 38:26) compare her with him; they do not approve everything she did.

1. **Married into Judah's family.** She became the wife of Judah's firstborn son, Er. *Genesis 38:6*
2. **Suffered loss twice.** She lost Er, and then Onan, who refused to give her a child for his brother. *Genesis 38:7–10*
3. **Waited as a widow.** She obeyed Judah and returned to her father's house to wait for Shelah. *Genesis 38:11*
4. **Took a bold step.** When the promise was broken, she disguised herself and asked Judah for a pledge: his signet, his bracelets and his staff. *Genesis 38:14–18*
5. **Kept the proof.** She kept Judah's pledge. When his friend came to trade it back for the promised young goat, she could not be found. *Genesis 38:20–23*
6. **Spoke the truth quietly.** Under sentence of death she sent the pledge to Judah: "Discern, I pray thee, whose are these." *Genesis 38:25*
7. **Bore twin sons.** Pharez and Zarah were born, and Pharez became an ancestor of David. *Genesis 38:27–30; Ruth 4:18–22*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Tamar.

Old Testament

Genesis 38:6–30	The main account
Genesis 46:12	Pharez and Zarah go down to Egypt
Ruth 4:12	"Let thy house be like the house of Pharez"
1 Chronicles 2:4	Tamar bore Judah Pharez and Zerah
Echo: Ruth 3:9–13	Another widow asks a kinsman to act

New Testament

Matthew 1:3	First of four women named in Jesus' line, as "Thamar"
Echo: Luke 5:32	Jesus came to call sinners to repentance

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What promise did Judah make to Tamar, and how did he break it (Genesis 38:11, 14)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Judah was quick to condemn Tamar but slow to see his own wrong (Genesis 38:24–26)?
3. *Apply:* Tamar was left without help by those who should have cared for her. Who around you is easily forgotten, and how could you help them this month?
4. *Apply:* Judah changed when he faced the truth. Is there a truth about yourself you have been avoiding? What would it look like to admit it?

26 Joseph

The favored son sold into slavery, who rose to rule Egypt and forgave the brothers who betrayed him.

Joseph was the elder son of Jacob and Rachel, and his father's favorite. His brothers hated him for it and sold him to traders bound for Egypt. There he was falsely accused and spent years in prison, yet Genesis says, "the LORD was with Joseph." At thirty he interpreted Pharaoh's dreams and was made ruler over all Egypt. When his brothers came to buy grain, he tested them, then forgave them and kept Jacob's whole family alive. His life shows God working through betrayal to save many people.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yoseph*, "may he add"; Egyptian Zaphnathpaaneah
Family	Son of Jacob and Rachel; full brother of Benjamin
Wife and sons	Asenath; Manasseh and Ephraim (Genesis 41:45, 50–52)
Key places	Dothan; Potiphar's house; the prison; Pharaoh's court; Goshen
Key people	Jacob, Reuben, Judah, Benjamin, Potiphar, Pharaoh
Lifespan	110 years (Genesis 50:26)
Main passages	Genesis 30:22–24; 37; 39–50
New Testament	John 4:5; Acts 7:9–18; Hebrews 11:21–22

"But as for you, ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good, to bring to pass, as it is this day, to save much people alive."

Genesis 50:20, KJV

The life of Joseph

Dates are approximate (BC), following the traditional chronology from 1 Kings 6:1. Many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC. Joseph's Pharaoh is not named.

c. 1915 BC
In Haran

Born to Rachel

Rachel bears her first son and names him Joseph: "The LORD shall add to me another son." *Genesis 30:22–24*

c. 1898 BC
Age 17

The coat and the dreams

Jacob gives Joseph a coat of many colours. Joseph dreams that his family bows to him, and his brothers hate him. *Genesis 37:2–11*

c. 1898 BC
Age 17

Sold into Egypt

At Dothan the brothers sell him for twenty pieces of silver and let Jacob believe a beast killed him. *Genesis 37:12–36*

Age 17 to 30

Slave and prisoner

Falsely accused by Potiphar's wife, he is imprisoned and interprets the butler's and baker's dreams. *Genesis 39:1–40:23*

c. 1885 BC
Age 30

Ruler of Egypt

Joseph explains Pharaoh's dreams of plenty and famine and is set over all the land. *Genesis 41:1–49*

The famine years

His brothers bow

Ten brothers come to buy grain and do not know him. He tests them and demands Benjamin. *Genesis 42:1–44:34*

c. 1876 BC
Age 39

Reveals himself

"I am Joseph." He forgives his brothers and settles Jacob's family in Goshen. *Genesis 45:1–46:30*

c. 1805 BC
Age 110

Dies in Egypt

He makes Israel promise to carry his bones to Canaan and is embalmed. *Genesis 50:22–26*

Key activities

Joseph's famine policy made Egyptians Pharaoh's servants (Genesis 47:13–26). Some see wise leadership; others a harsh deal. Genesis gives no comment.

1. **Told his dreams.** He shared dreams of his family bowing to him, which fed his brothers' envy. *Genesis 37:5–11*
2. **Worked faithfully as a slave.** Potiphar put him in charge of everything, and the LORD blessed the house. *Genesis 39:2–6*
3. **Refused temptation.** "How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?" He ran away. *Genesis 39:7–12*
4. **Served in prison.** The keeper of the prison trusted him with all the prisoners. *Genesis 39:20–23*
5. **Gave God the credit.** He told Pharaoh, "It is not in me: God shall give Pharaoh an answer of peace." *Genesis 41:14–16, 25–32*
6. **Planned for the famine.** He gathered a fifth of the harvest in the good years and stored grain in the cities. *Genesis 41:34–36, 47–49*
7. **Named his sons in faith.** Manasseh meant God had made him forget his toil; Ephraim meant God had made him fruitful in his affliction. *Genesis 41:50–52*
8. **Tested his brothers.** He held Simeon, demanded Benjamin, and hid his cup in Benjamin's sack to see if they had changed. *Genesis 42:18–44:17*
9. **Forgave and wept.** He told them, "God did send me before you to preserve life." *Genesis 45:1–15*
10. **Cared for his family.** He settled Jacob's household in Goshen and fed them through the famine. *Genesis 47:11–12*
11. **Brought his sons to be blessed.** Jacob adopted Ephraim and Manasseh as his own and put the younger first. *Genesis 48:1–20*
12. **Looked ahead in faith.** Dying, he said, "God will surely visit you," and asked that his bones go to Canaan. *Genesis 50:24–25*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joseph.

Old Testament

Genesis 37–50	The main account
Exodus 1:8	A new king arises "which knew not Joseph"
Exodus 13:19; Joshua 24:32	His bones carried out and buried at Shechem
Psalm 105:16–22	God "sent a man before them, even Joseph"
Echo: Daniel 2:46–48	Another dream-reader raised high by a foreign king

New Testament

John 4:5	Sychar, near the ground Jacob gave Joseph
Acts 7:9–16	Stephen: sold by envious brothers, "but God was with him"
Hebrews 11:22	By faith he gave commandment concerning his bones
Echo: Romans 8:28	Many Christians see Joseph as a picture of Christ

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Where was the LORD with Joseph in Genesis 39:2–3 and 21–23, and what did that look like?
2. *Understand:* "Ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good" (Genesis 50:20). How can both be true?
3. *Apply:* Joseph ran from temptation when no one would have known. What helps you do right when unseen?
4. *Apply:* Joseph forgave those who hurt him most. Is there someone you need to forgive?

27 Benjamin

Jacob's youngest son, born in sorrow, whose safety became the test of his brothers' hearts.

Benjamin was the youngest son of Jacob, and the second son of Rachel, who died giving birth to him on the road to Bethlehem. After Joseph disappeared, Jacob guarded him closely. Genesis never records a word Benjamin spoke, yet he stands at the story's turning point. Joseph's test came down to one question: would the brothers abandon Rachel's other son as they had abandoned Joseph? Their answer showed they had changed. His tribe later gave Israel King Saul, and much later the apostle Paul.

At a glance

Name	*Binyamin*, "son of the right hand"; first Benoni, "son of my sorrow"
Family	Youngest son of Jacob and Rachel; full brother of Joseph
Sons	Ten sons listed when the family goes to Egypt (Genesis 46:21)
Key places	The road to Ephrath (Bethlehem); Canaan; Joseph's house
Key people	Jacob, Rachel, Joseph, Judah
Main passages	Genesis 35:16–20; 42:4, 36–38; 43:1–45:15; 49:27
Descendants	Ehud, Saul, Mordecai and Paul
New Testament	Acts 13:21; Romans 11:1; Philippians 3:5; Revelation 7:8

"And he fell upon his brother Benjamin's neck, and wept; and Benjamin wept upon his neck."

Genesis 45:14, KJV

The life of Benjamin

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Benjamin. The order below follows the text. He was born after Jacob returned to Canaan, the only son of Jacob born there.

On the road to Ephrath

Born as Rachel dies

Rachel has a hard labor. As she dies, she names her son Benoni, "son of my sorrow," but Jacob names him Benjamin. *Genesis 35:16–20*

The first famine journey

Kept at home

Jacob sends ten sons to buy grain in Egypt but keeps Benjamin back, "Lest peradventure mischief befall him." *Genesis 42:1–4*

Back in Canaan

Demanded by Egypt

The governor of Egypt holds Simeon and insists that Benjamin come. Jacob cries, "Joseph is not, and Simeon is not, and ye will take Benjamin away." *Genesis 42:24, 34–38*

The second journey

Goes down to Egypt

As the famine grows worse, Judah pledges himself for Benjamin's safety. Jacob lets him go: "If I be bereaved of my children, I am bereaved." *Genesis 43:1–15*

In Joseph's house

Honored at the feast

Joseph sees Benjamin and says, "God be gracious unto thee, my son." Then he leaves the room to weep. Benjamin's portion is five times larger than the others'. *Genesis 43:16–34*

On the road home

The cup is found

Joseph's silver cup is hidden in Benjamin's sack. When it is found, the brothers tear their clothes and all return to face the governor together. *Genesis 44:1–13*

In Joseph's house

Reunited

Joseph reveals himself, embraces Benjamin, and weeps. He gives Benjamin three hundred pieces of silver and five changes of clothing. *Genesis 45:1–15, 22*

Key activities

Genesis 46:21 lists ten sons of Benjamin when Jacob's family goes to Egypt, though Genesis calls him "the lad." Some think he was a grown man by then; others think the list includes descendants born later in Egypt. The lists in Numbers 26:38–41 and 1 Chronicles 8:1–5 differ somewhat.

1. **Was born at great cost.** His birth took his mother's life. *Genesis 35:16–19*
2. **Was his father's comfort.** After Joseph was lost, Jacob held him close, saying "he is left alone." *Genesis 42:4, 38; 44:20*
3. **Went to Egypt.** He traveled with his brothers on the second journey, under Judah's pledge. *Genesis 43:8–15*
4. **Received special honor.** At Joseph's table he was given five times as much as anyone else. *Genesis 43:34*
5. **Was accused of theft.** The steward found Joseph's silver cup in his sack. *Genesis 44:12*
6. **Was defended by his brothers.** Judah offered to become a slave in his place. *Genesis 44:18–34*
7. **Wept with Joseph.** The two sons of Rachel embraced after more than twenty years apart. *Genesis 45:14–15*
8. **Received Jacob's blessing.** "Benjamin shall ravin as a wolf: in the morning he shall devour the prey, and at night he shall divide the spoil." *Genesis 49:27*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Benjamin.

Old Testament

Genesis 35:16–45:22	The main account
Deuteronomy 33:12	"The beloved of the LORD shall dwell in safety by him"
Judges 3:15; 20:16	Ehud, and the tribe's left-handed slingers
Judges 19–21	Nearly wiped out after the crime at Gibeah
1 Samuel 9:21	Saul: "Am not I a Benjamite … ?"
Psalm 68:27	"There is little Benjamin with their ruler"
1 Kings 12:21	Benjamin stays with Judah when the kingdom divides

New Testament

Acts 13:21	Saul, "a man of the tribe of Benjamin"
Romans 11:1; Philippians 3:5	Paul is "of the tribe of Benjamin"
Echo: 1 Corinthians 15:9	Paul, "the least of the apostles"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the brothers do when the cup was found (Genesis 44:13)?
2. *Understand:* How did God use the silent Benjamin to show his brothers had changed?
3. *Apply:* How do you respond when someone else is treated better than you?
4. *Apply:* Judah stood by Benjamin when it cost him. Who needs you to stand by them now?

28 Job

A blameless man who lost everything, wrestled honestly with God, and met him in the whirlwind.

Job lived in the land of Uz, rich, respected and devoted to God. In a single day he lost his flocks, his servants and all ten children; then sores covered his body. Three friends insisted he must have sinned. Job refused their answer, poured out grief and hope, and demanded a hearing with God. God spoke out of a whirlwind, not explaining the suffering but showing his wisdom in creation, and Job bowed in trust. God said Job, not his friends, had spoken rightly, and restored him. The book shows how to hold on to God in the dark.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Iyyov*; meaning uncertain
Home	The land of Uz; location uncertain, perhaps near Edom
Described as	"Perfect and upright" (Job 1:1)
Family	Seven sons and three daughters, twice (Job 1:2; 42:13)
Friends	Eliphaz, Bildad, Zophar; later Elihu (Job 2:11; 32:2)
Lifespan	Lived 140 years after his trials (Job 42:16)
Main passages	Job 1–2; 19; 38–42
New Testament	James 5:11; 1 Corinthians 3:19 quotes Job 5:13

"Naked came I out of my mother's womb, and naked shall I return thither: the LORD gave, and the LORD hath taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

Job 1:21, KJV

The life of Job

Scripture gives no date or author for Job. Many place him in the age of the patriarchs; others date the book's writing much later. Chapters 3–42:6 are poetry framed by prose.

In Uz

A blameless man

Job is the greatest man of the east. He offers burnt offerings for his ten children in case they have sinned. *Job 1:1–5*

The first test

Loses everything

Satan asks, "Doth Job fear God for nought?" In one day Job loses wealth and children, yet he worships. *Job 1:6–22*

The second test

Struck with sores

His wife says, "Curse God, and die." He answers, "shall we receive good at the hand of God, and shall we not receive evil?" *Job 2:1–10*

Seven days

Friends sit in silence

Eliphaz, Bildad and Zophar sit with him seven days and nights, and no one speaks. *Job 2:11–13*

The long debate

Job answers his friends

They insist suffering comes from sin. Job protests his innocence yet hopes: "I know that my redeemer liveth." *Job 3:1–31:40*

A younger voice

Elihu speaks

Elihu argues that God uses suffering to warn and teach, and is always just. *Job 32:1–37:24*

Out of the whirlwind

God answers

"Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth?" Job repents in dust and ashes. *Job 38:1–42:6*

Afterward

Prays and is restored

Job prays for his friends, and the LORD gives him twice as much as before. *Job 42:7–17*

Key activities

In Job 1–2 the Hebrew calls Job's accuser "the satan," meaning "the adversary." Most Christians identify him with Satan; some scholars see an accusing angel in God's court. Christians also differ over the book's date and whether it is history, poetry based on real events, or both.

1. **Lived with integrity.** He feared God and turned away from evil, and God himself called him blameless. *Job 1:1, 8*
2. **Prayed for his children.** He regularly offered sacrifices for them, in case they had sinned in their hearts. *Job 1:5*
3. **Worshipped in loss.** He tore his robe, fell to the ground and said, "blessed be the name of the LORD." *Job 1:20–22*
4. **Held on in pain.** He would not curse God: "In all this did not Job sin with his lips." *Job 2:9–10*
5. **Grieved honestly.** He cursed the day of his birth and poured out his anguish before God. *Job 3:1–26*
6. **Refused false comfort.** He called his accusing friends "miserable comforters." *Job 16:1–5*
7. **Clung to hope.** "For I know that my redeemer liveth, and that he shall stand at the latter day upon the earth." *Job 19:25–27*
8. **Trusted God's refining.** "When he hath tried me, I shall come forth as gold." *Job 23:10*
9. **Defended his life.** He described how he had helped the poor, the fatherless and the widow. *Job 29:11–17; 31:16–22*
10. **Humbled himself before God.** "I have heard of thee by the hearing of the ear: but now mine eye seeth thee." *Job 42:5–6*
11. **Prayed for his friends.** He prayed for the men who had wronged him, and God accepted his prayer. *Job 42:8–10*
12. **Gave his daughters an inheritance.** In a world where daughters rarely inherited, he gave them an inheritance among their brothers. *Job 42:13–15*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Job.

Old Testament

Job 1–42	The main account
Ezekiel 14:14, 20	"Noah, Daniel, and Job" as righteous men
Echo: Proverbs 1:7	Fear of the Lord as wisdom, as in Job 28:28
Echo: Psalm 73; Habakkuk 1	Why do the righteous suffer?

New Testament

James 5:11	"Ye have heard of the patience of Job"
1 Corinthians 3:19	Paul quotes Eliphaz's words in Job 5:13
Echo: John 9:1–3	Blindness not proof of sin
Echo: Hebrews 7:25	Job's living redeemer answered in Christ
Tradition	The Talmud names Moses as author; the book does not say

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Job respond to his first losses (Job 1:20–22), and how did his words change in chapter 3?
2. *Understand:* God said the friends had not spoken rightly (Job 42:7). Why was their answer wrong?
3. *Apply:* The friends did best in silence (Job 2:13). How can you be present with someone grieving?
4. *Apply:* What honest question or complaint do you need to bring to God in prayer?

29 Moses

The reluctant shepherd who led Israel out of Egypt and spoke with God face to face.

Moses was born a Hebrew slave under a death sentence, raised in Pharaoh's household, and trained as a shepherd in the desert. At eighty he met God in a burning bush and was sent to say, "Let my people go." Through him God brought Israel out of slavery, gave the Law at Sinai, and built a nation in the wilderness. He was prophet, lawgiver and intercessor, yet also a man who argued, lost his temper, and was kept out of the Promised Land. The New Testament names him more than any other Old Testament person.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Moshe*, linked to "drew out" (Exodus 2:10)
Family	Son of Amram and Jochebed; brother of Aaron and Miriam
Wife and sons	Zipporah; Gershom and Eliezer (Exodus 2:21–22; 18:2–4)
Lifespan	120 years: 40 in Egypt, 40 in Midian, 40 in the wilderness
Key places	Egypt, Midian, Sinai (Horeb), Kadesh, Moab, Mount Nebo
Key people	Pharaoh of the Exodus, Aaron, Miriam, Jethro, Joshua, Caleb
New Testament	Named about 80 times, more than any other Old Testament figure

"And there arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face,"

Deuteronomy 34:10, KJV

The life of Moses

Dates are approximate (BC), following the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC (1 Kings 6:1). Many scholars prefer c. 1260 BC, about 185 years later.

c. 1526 BC
Birth

Hidden and drawn out

Hidden from Pharaoh's decree in a basket among the reeds, he is found and raised by Pharaoh's daughter. *Exodus 1:22–2:10*

c. 1486 BC
Age 40

Flees to Midian

He kills an Egyptian who was beating a Hebrew, and flees when Pharaoh seeks his life. *Exodus 2:11–15; Acts 7:23–29*

c. 1486–1446 BC
Age 40 to 80

Shepherd in Midian

He marries Zipporah and keeps Jethro's flock in the desert for forty years. *Exodus 2:16–22; 3:1; Acts 7:29–30*

c. 1446 BC
Age 80

The burning bush

At Horeb God reveals his name, "I AM THAT I AM," and sends a reluctant Moses to Egypt. *Exodus 3:1–4:17; 7:7*

c. 1446 BC
Age 80

Out of Egypt

Ten plagues fall and Israel leaves after the Passover, crossing the sea on dry ground. *Exodus 5:1–15:21*

c. 1446–1445 BC
At Sinai

Law and tabernacle

He receives the Law, breaks the tablets over the golden calf, and builds the tabernacle. *Exodus 19–40*

c. 1445 BC
Second year

Turned back at Kadesh

Ten spies spread fear, and that generation is sentenced to wander forty years. *Numbers 10:11; 13:1–14:38*

c. 1406 BC
Age 120

Death on Nebo

He commissions Joshua, sees the land from Mount Nebo, and dies; God buries him. *Deuteronomy 31–34*

Key activities

Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy tell Moses' story together. Deuteronomy 1–4 retells some events from Moses' own point of view.

1. **Chose God's people over Egypt.** He refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter. *Exodus 2:11–12; Hebrews 11:24–26*
2. **Protected the helpless.** At a desert well he defended seven sisters and watered their flock. *Exodus 2:16–17*
3. **Argued with God, then obeyed.** "I am slow of speech, and of a slow tongue." God answered each objection. *Exodus 3:11–4:17*
4. **Confronted Pharaoh.** He carried one message from God: let my people go. *Exodus 5:1–11:10*
5. **Led the first Passover.** Each household marked its doorposts with a lamb's blood. *Exodus 12:1–28*
6. **Stood firm at the sea.** "Fear ye not, stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD." *Exodus 14:13–15:18*
7. **Shared the load.** He appointed judges on Jethro's advice; later seventy elders helped him. *Exodus 18:13–26; Numbers 11:16–17, 24–29*
8. **Received the Law.** On Sinai he received the Ten Commandments and sealed the covenant with blood. *Exodus 19:1–24:8; 20:1–17*
9. **Stood in the gap.** After the golden calf he asked to be blotted out of God's book in Israel's place. *Exodus 32:11–14, 30–32; Psalm 106:23*
10. **Spoke with God as a friend.** "The LORD spake unto Moses face to face, as a man speaketh unto his friend." *Exodus 33:11, 18–23; 34:5–8*
11. **Struck the rock.** At Meribah he struck the rock in anger and was barred from the land. *Numbers 20:7–12*
12. **Handed on the work.** He laid his hands on Joshua and urged Israel to "choose life." *Numbers 27:18–23; Deuteronomy 30:19; 31:7–8*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Moses.

Old Testament

Exodus – Deuteronomy	His life from birth to death
Joshua 1:1–9	"As I was with Moses, so I will be with thee"
Psalm 90	"A Prayer of Moses the man of God"
Psalm 106:23	Moses "stood before him in the breach"
Jeremiah 15:1	Moses and Samuel as great intercessors
Malachi 4:4	"Remember ye the law of Moses my servant"

New Testament

Matthew 17:1–8	With Elijah at the transfiguration
John 1:17	Law by Moses; grace and truth by Jesus Christ
John 3:14	The serpent lifted up in the wilderness
Acts 7:20–44	Stephen retells his life
Hebrews 11:23–29	His faith praised
Tradition	Moses wrote the first five books; many think they were completed later

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Moses give for not going back to Egypt (Exodus 3:11–4:13)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God kept Moses out of the land (Numbers 20:7–12)?
3. *Apply:* Who could help carry something you are holding alone, as Jethro helped Moses?
4. *Apply:* Moses pleaded for people who let him down. Who could you pray for by name?

30 Jochebed

The mother who hid her baby, set him on the Nile, and was paid to nurse her own son.

Jochebed was a woman of the tribe of Levi, living as a slave in Egypt when Pharaoh ordered every Hebrew baby boy thrown into the Nile. She is named only twice, in family lists, but Exodus 2 tells her story without using her name. She hid her newborn son for three months, then made a small basket, sealed it, and placed him among the reeds. God used her quiet courage to save the child who would become Moses. She was also the mother of Aaron and Miriam, so the leader, the priest and the prophetess of the Exodus all came from her home. Hebrews counts her act as faith.

At a glance

Name	*Yokheved*, perhaps "the LORD is glory" (debated)
Family	Daughter of Levi; wife of Amram, her nephew (Exodus 6:20)
Children	Miriam, Aaron and Moses (Numbers 26:59; 1 Chronicles 6:3)
When	The oppression in Egypt, c. 1526 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Key places	Egypt, the banks of the Nile
Main passages	Exodus 2:1–10; 6:20; Numbers 26:59
New Testament	Not named. Hebrews 11:23 praises the faith of Moses' parents

"By faith Moses, when he was born, was hid three months of his parents, because they saw he was a proper child; and they were not afraid of the king's commandment."

Hebrews 11:23, KJV

The life of Jochebed

Only Moses' birth can be roughly dated: c. 1526 BC on the early Exodus date, or about 185 years later on the late date. Exodus 2 calls her "a daughter of Levi" and "the child's mother"; her name comes from Exodus 6:20 and Numbers 26:59.

In Egypt

A daughter of Levi

She is born into the tribe of Levi during Israel's long stay in Egypt. Numbers says her mother bore her to Levi in Egypt. *Numbers 26:59*

In Egypt

Marries Amram

She marries Amram, a Levite of the family of Kohath. Exodus notes that she was his father's sister. *Exodus 2:1; 6:18, 20*

Before the decree

Mother of Miriam and Aaron

She bears a daughter, Miriam, and a son, Aaron, who is three years older than Moses. *Exodus 7:7; Numbers 26:59*

c. 1526 BC

Hides her newborn

Pharaoh has ordered every Hebrew son cast into the river. When she sees her baby is "a goodly child," she hides him for three months. *Exodus 1:22–2:2*

c. 1526 BC

The basket in the reeds

When she can hide him no longer, she makes an ark of bulrushes, seals it with slime and pitch, and lays it by the river's brink. His sister watches from a distance. *Exodus 2:3–4*

c. 1526 BC and after

Nurses her own son

Pharaoh's daughter finds the child. His sister offers to fetch a Hebrew nurse and brings his mother. She nurses him for wages until he is grown enough to go to the palace. *Exodus 2:5–10*

Key activities

Exodus 6:20 says Amram married his father's sister. The later law forbade such marriages (Leviticus 18:12), but this was before that law was given. Some scholars also think the family list in Exodus 6 skips generations.

1. **Saw something special in her son.** She saw that he was "a goodly child." Hebrews says both parents saw it and acted in faith. *Exodus 2:2; Hebrews 11:23*
2. **Defied the king.** She and Amram hid their son for three months and "were not afraid of the king's commandment." *Exodus 2:2; Hebrews 11:23*
3. **Built a little ark.** She took a basket of bulrushes, sealed it with slime and pitch, and laid it among the reeds. *Exodus 2:3*
4. **Trusted and waited.** She let go of her son, while his sister stood at a distance to see what would happen. *Exodus 2:3–4*
5. **Nursed him for Pharaoh's daughter.** Called by her daughter, she took her own child home and was paid to nurse him. *Exodus 2:7–9*
6. **Gave him up a second time.** When the child grew, she brought him to Pharaoh's daughter, who named him Moses. *Exodus 2:10*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jochebed.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:1–10	Her story, told without her name
Exodus 6:20	Amram's wife, "his father's sister," mother of Aaron and Moses
Numbers 26:59	Levi's daughter, mother of Aaron, Moses and Miriam
1 Chronicles 6:3	Her three children listed as Amram's
Echo: Genesis 6–8	Noah, too, is saved in an ark
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:22–28	Hannah gives her weaned son back to God

New Testament

Hebrews 11:23	The faith of Moses' parents (she is not named)
Acts 7:20–21	Moses nourished in his father's house three months
Echo: Matthew 2:13–16	Another king kills baby boys; a family hides a child
Echo: 2 Timothy 1:5	Faith learned from a mother and grandmother

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What practical steps did Jochebed take to protect her son (Exodus 2:2–4)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews calls her actions faith. What makes an ordinary, practical choice an act of faith?
3. *Apply:* Jochebed had to let go of her child twice. What is one thing you need to place in God's hands right now?
4. *Apply:* Her quiet work shaped three leaders. Who are the young people you could invest in this month, and how?

31 Aaron

Moses' older brother and spokesman, and the first high priest of Israel.

Aaron was three years older than Moses, and God gave him to his brother as a voice when Moses said he could not speak well. Together they stood before Pharaoh, and Aaron's rod swallowed the magicians' rods. At Sinai he became Israel's first high priest, the man who would bring the people's offerings to God and God's blessing to the people. Yet the same Aaron made the golden calf, joined Miriam in criticizing Moses, and shared Moses' failure at Meribah. His life shows both the dignity and the weakness of priesthood. The New Testament uses his office to explain the work of Christ, a greater high priest.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Aharon*. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Amram and Jochebed; brother of Moses and Miriam (Exodus 6:20; Numbers 26:59)
Wife and sons	Elisheba; sons Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar (Exodus 6:23)
Office	Israel's first high priest (Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8)
Lifespan	123 years; he died on Mount Hor in the fortieth year after the Exodus (Numbers 33:38–39)
Key people	Moses, Miriam, Nadab and Abihu, Korah, Eleazar, Hur
New Testament	Luke 1:5; Acts 7:40; Hebrews 5:4; 7:11; 9:4

"The LORD bless thee, and keep thee: The LORD make his face shine upon thee, and be gracious unto thee: The LORD lift up his countenance upon thee, and give thee peace."

Numbers 6:24–26, KJV

The life of Aaron

Dates are approximate (BC), on the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC; the late date moves them about 185 years later. Ages from Exodus 7:7 and Numbers 33:39.

c. 1529 BC
Birth

Born in Egypt

Aaron is born to Amram and Jochebed, three years before Moses. *Exodus 6:20; 7:7*

c. 1446 BC
Age 83

Meets his brother

Aaron meets Moses at the mountain of God, and they tell Israel's elders what God has said. *Exodus 4:14–16, 27–31*

c. 1446 BC
Age 83

Before Pharaoh

His rod swallows the magicians' rods, and he stretches it out to bring the first plagues. *Exodus 7:1–20; 8:5–6, 16–17*

c. 1446 BC
Wilderness

Holds up Moses' hands

At Rephidim Aaron and Hur hold up Moses' hands until sunset, and Israel wins. *Exodus 17:8–13*

c. 1446 BC
At Sinai

The golden calf

He sees the God of Israel with the elders, but later gives in and makes a golden calf. *Exodus 24:9–11; 32:1–6*

c. 1445 BC
Second year

Ordained high priest

He offers the first sacrifices, and fire comes from the LORD; that day Nadab and Abihu die. *Exodus 40:17; Leviticus 8:1–10:7*

c. 1445 BC
Hazeroth

Speaks against Moses

With Miriam he criticizes Moses, then pleads for her when she is struck with leprosy. *Numbers 11:35; 12:1–12*

c. 1406 BC
Age 123

Dies on Mount Hor

His garments are put on Eleazar, and Israel mourns him thirty days. *Numbers 20:23–29; 33:38–39*

Key activities

Some events, such as Korah's rebellion and the budding rod, are undated in Numbers.

1. **Spoke for Moses.** "I know that he can speak well." *Exodus 4:14–16; 7:1–2*
2. **Worked signs before Pharaoh.** He threw down his rod and stretched it over Egypt's waters. *Exodus 7:10–12, 19–20*
3. **Held up his brother's hands.** With Hur he held up Moses' hands all day at Rephidim. *Exodus 17:10–12*
4. **Saw God on the mountain.** He went up Sinai with the elders, and they saw the God of Israel and ate and drank. *Exodus 24:1, 9–11*
5. **Made the golden calf.** "I cast it into the fire, and there came out this calf." *Exodus 32:1–6, 21–24*
6. **Was clothed for glory.** He wore the ephod, the breastplate, and "HOLINESS TO THE LORD." *Exodus 28:1–38; Leviticus 8:6–12*
7. **Blessed the people.** After the first sacrifices he lifted his hands and blessed Israel, and God's fire consumed the offering. *Leviticus 9:22–24; Numbers 6:22–27*
8. **Held his peace.** When fire killed Nadab and Abihu, "Aaron held his peace." *Leviticus 10:1–3*
9. **Challenged Moses.** He and Miriam asked, "Hath the LORD indeed spoken only by Moses?" Then he begged Moses to pray for her. *Numbers 12:1–12*
10. **Stopped a plague.** He ran with his censer into the camp, "and he stood between the dead and the living; and the plague was stayed." *Numbers 16:46–48*
11. **Was confirmed by a budding rod.** Among twelve rods, his alone budded, blossomed and bore almonds overnight. *Numbers 17:1–10*
12. **Handed on the priesthood.** On Mount Hor his garments were placed on Eleazar before he died. *Numbers 20:25–28*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Aaron.

Old Testament

Exodus 28–29; Leviticus 8–10	His garments and ordination
Deuteronomy 9:20	Moses prayed for him after the calf
Deuteronomy 10:6	His death at Mosera, probably near Hor
Psalm 77:20	God led his people "by the hand of Moses and Aaron"
Psalm 133:2	His anointing a picture of unity
Micah 6:4	God sent "Moses, Aaron, and Miriam"

New Testament

Luke 1:5	Elisabeth is "of the daughters of Aaron"
Hebrews 5:4	Called of God, "as was Aaron"
Hebrews 7:11–28	Christ a priest after Melchisedec, not Aaron
Hebrews 9:4	His budded rod kept in the ark
Echo: Hebrews 4:14–16	Christ the "great high priest"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Aaron explain the golden calf to Moses (Exodus 32:21–24)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God still made Aaron high priest after the calf?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to give people what they want instead of what is right?
4. *Apply:* Aaron and Hur held up Moses' hands. Whose hands could you hold up this week?

32 Miriam

The prophetess who led Israel's women in song beside the sea.

Miriam was the sister of Moses and Aaron and the first woman in the Bible called a prophetess. Most readers take her to be the unnamed sister who watched over baby Moses on the Nile and boldly offered to find a nurse for him. After the crossing of the sea, she took a timbrel and led the women of Israel in dancing and praise. Micah later names her with her brothers as one of the three leaders God sent to Israel. But Miriam also spoke against Moses, and God struck her with leprosy for seven days. She died at Kadesh before Israel entered the land. Her life joins courage, worship and leadership with a sobering warning about envy.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Miryam*. Its meaning is uncertain; many suggestions have been made
Family	Daughter of Amram and Jochebed; sister of Aaron and Moses (Numbers 26:59; 1 Chronicles 6:3)
Role	Prophetess and leader of worship (Exodus 15:20; Micah 6:4)
When	From Moses' birth, c. 1526 BC, to the wilderness years, on the early date
Key places	The Nile, the shore of the Red Sea, Hazeroth, Kadesh
Main passages	Exodus 2:4–8; 15:20–21; Numbers 12:1–15; 20:1
New Testament	Not named

"And Miriam answered them, Sing ye to the LORD, for he hath triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider hath he thrown into the sea."

Exodus 15:21, KJV

The life of Miriam

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Exodus 2 does not name Moses' sister, but Miriam is the only sister Scripture gives him.

c. 1526 BC

Watches over her brother

She stands at a distance to see what will happen to the baby in the basket. When Pharaoh's daughter finds him, she offers to call a Hebrew nurse and brings their mother. *Exodus 2:4–8*

c. 1446 BC

Leads the song

After Israel crosses the sea, "Miriam the prophetess, the sister of Aaron" takes a timbrel. All the women follow her with timbrels and dances as she sings. *Exodus 15:20–21*

c. 1445 BC
Hazeroth

Speaks against Moses

She and Aaron criticize Moses because of his Cushite wife and ask whether God speaks only through him. God calls the three to the tabernacle and rebukes her and Aaron. *Numbers 11:35; 12:1–9*

c. 1445 BC
Hazeroth

Struck and healed

She becomes leprous, "white as snow." Moses cries out, "Heal her now, O God." She is shut outside the camp for seven days, and the people wait for her. *Numbers 12:10–16*

c. 1406 BC
Probably the fortieth year

Dies at Kadesh

Israel comes to the wilderness of Zin in the first month. Miriam dies at Kadesh and is buried there. *Numbers 20:1*

Group notes

Key activities

The year of Miriam's death is not stated. Numbers 20:1 names only "the first month," but it comes just before Aaron's death in the fortieth year, so most scholars place it in that year.

1. **Kept watch.** As a girl she watched over her baby brother in the reeds. *Exodus 2:4*
2. **Spoke up at the right moment.** She asked Pharaoh's daughter, "Shall I go and call to thee a nurse of the Hebrew women?" *Exodus 2:7–8*
3. **Led worship.** She led the women in praise with timbrels and dancing after the sea crossing. *Exodus 15:20–21*
4. **Served as a leader.** God said he sent "Moses, Aaron, and Miriam" before his people. *Micah 6:4*
5. **Spoke against Moses.** She and Aaron questioned his marriage and his unique standing. She is named first, and she alone is punished. *Numbers 12:1–10*
6. **Was restored.** After seven days outside the camp she was brought back in, and Israel did not move on until she returned. *Numbers 12:14–15*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Miriam.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:4–8	The unnamed sister, usually taken to be Miriam
Exodus 15:20–21	She leads the women in the song of victory
Numbers 12:1–15	She speaks against Moses and is struck with leprosy
Numbers 20:1; 26:59	Her death at Kadesh; her place in the family
Deuteronomy 24:9	"Remember what the LORD thy God did unto Miriam"
Micah 6:4	Sent with Moses and Aaron to lead Israel
1 Chronicles 4:17	A different Miriam, of Judah

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:46–55	Mary sings of God's triumph over the proud
Echo: Revelation 15:2–3	The redeemed sing "the song of Moses"
Echo: James 3:5–10	A warning about the tongue

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Miriam do at the sea, and who followed her (Exodus 15:20–21)?
2. *Understand:* Numbers 12 mentions Moses' wife, but God's answer is about Moses' role. What do you think the real issue was?
3. *Apply:* Miriam spoke up to protect her brother. When might you need to speak up for someone this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone whose role or gifts you are tempted to resent? What would it look like to honor them instead?

33 Pharaoh of the Exodus

The king who asked, "Who is the LORD?" and learned the answer through ten plagues.

Exodus never names the Pharaoh who faced Moses. He ruled the greatest power of his day and was honored as divine. When Moses brought God's command to let Israel go, he refused, made the slaves' work harder, and hardened his heart through plague after plague. He bargained, confessed his sin, promised freedom, then took it back. Only after Egypt's firstborn died did he let the people leave, and then he chased them to the sea, where his army was lost. His story is a study in pride.

At a glance

Name	Not given. "Pharaoh" is a title meaning "great house"
Identity	Debated: Amenhotep II (early date) or Ramesses II (late)
When	c. 1446 BC (early date) or c. 1260 BC (late date)
Key places	Egypt, the land of Goshen, the Red Sea
Key people	Moses, Aaron, his magicians, his servants and officials
Main passages	Exodus 5–14
New Testament	Acts 7:18–36; Romans 9:17; Hebrews 11:27

"And Pharaoh said, Who is the LORD, that I should obey his voice to let Israel go? I know not the LORD, neither will I let Israel go."

Exodus 5:2, KJV

The life of Pharaoh of the Exodus

The text never names him, so any identification is a theory. On the early date, c. 1446 BC, many point to Amenhotep II, with Thutmose III as the earlier oppressor. On the late date, c. 1260 BC, most point to Ramesses II, with Seti I before him, though some suggest his son Merneptah. Other views exist. Exodus 2:23 says the king who sought Moses' life died, so the Pharaoh of the plagues was probably his successor.

c. 1446 BC
Moses returns

Refuses God

Moses and Aaron ask him to let Israel go to worship. He answers, "Who is the LORD?" and orders the slaves to gather their own straw while making the same number of bricks. *Exodus 5:1–21*

c. 1446 BC
The first plagues

Hardens his heart

His magicians copy the rod that becomes a serpent, the water turned to blood and the frogs. When the plagues ease, he hardens his heart and will not listen. *Exodus 7:8–8:15*

c. 1446 BC
The later plagues

Bargains and breaks his word

He offers to let Israel sacrifice in Egypt, then only the men, then all but the flocks. Twice he admits, "I have sinned," but each time he goes back on his promise. *Exodus 8:25–10:29*

c. 1446 BC
Passover night

Lets Israel go

At midnight every firstborn in Egypt dies, from Pharaoh's own son to the prisoner's. He calls for Moses by night and tells him to take the people and go. *Exodus 11:1–12:32*

c. 1446 BC
At the sea

Pursues and is overthrown

He regrets losing his slaves and chases Israel with six hundred chosen chariots. The sea parts for Israel and returns on the Egyptians. *Exodus 14:5–28; 15:4*

Key activities

Exodus describes the hardening three ways. Pharaoh hardened his own heart (Exodus 8:15, 32), his heart was hardened (Exodus 7:14, 22), and the LORD hardened it (Exodus 9:12; 10:20; 14:8). Christians have long discussed how these fit together.

1. **Defied God.** He said he did not know the LORD and would not let Israel go. *Exodus 5:2*
2. **Increased the burden.** He called the Israelites idle and made them find their own straw for bricks. *Exodus 5:6–18*
3. **Relied on his magicians.** His wise men copied the first signs, but by the third plague they told him, "This is the finger of God." *Exodus 7:11–12, 22; 8:18–19*
4. **Bargained with God.** He offered partial obedience again and again, but never full release. *Exodus 8:25–28; 10:8–11, 24*
5. **Confessed without changing.** He said, "I have sinned," but when the plague stopped he sinned yet more. *Exodus 9:27–35; 10:16–20*
6. **Lost his firstborn.** The final plague struck his own house, and he sent Israel away. *Exodus 12:29–32*
7. **Chased Israel.** He and his servants asked, "Why have we done this?" and led the army after them. *Exodus 14:5–9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names this Pharaoh.

Old Testament

Exodus 1–14	The main account, from oppression to the sea
Exodus 15:1–19	Moses' song over "Pharaoh's chariots and his host"
Nehemiah 9:10	Signs shown on Pharaoh and his servants
Psalm 105:26–38; 135:8–9	The plagues retold
Psalm 136:15	Pharaoh overthrown in the sea (whether he drowned is debated)

New Testament

Acts 7:18–36	Stephen retells the oppression and Exodus
Romans 9:17–18	"For this same purpose have I raised thee up"
Hebrews 11:27–29	Moses did not fear "the wrath of the king"
2 Timothy 3:8	Jannes and Jambres "withstood Moses"
Echo: Matthew 2:16	Herod also kills children to guard his power

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Pharaoh say when he confessed or bargained (Exodus 9:27–28; 10:16–17)?
2. *Understand:* What do you think it means that both Pharaoh and God hardened his heart?
3. *Apply:* Pharaoh offered partial obedience. Where are you tempted to obey God only halfway?
4. *Apply:* What promise did you make to God in a hard time that you need to keep?

34 Jethro

The priest of Midian who welcomed a fugitive, rejoiced in God's rescue, and gave Moses wise advice.

Jethro was a priest in the land of Midian and the father of seven daughters. When a young Egyptian-looking stranger defended his daughters at a well, Jethro invited him home, gave him his daughter Zipporah, and employed him as a shepherd for forty years. That stranger was Moses. Later, after the Exodus, Jethro brought Moses' wife and sons to the camp near Sinai. He listened to the story of Israel's rescue, praised the LORD, and offered sacrifices. The next day he saw Moses judging the people from morning to evening and gave him practical advice that shaped Israel's leadership. He was an outsider, yet he worshipped Israel's God and blessed Israel's leader.

At a glance

Name	*Jethro*, also called Reuel (Raguel in Numbers 10:29, KJV) (Exodus 2:18; 3:1)
Role	"The priest of Midian" (Exodus 2:16; 3:1; 18:1)
Family	Father of seven daughters, including Zipporah; father-in-law of Moses (Exodus 2:16, 21)
Descendants	Probably the Kenites, who lived among Israel (Judges 1:16; 4:11)
Key places	Midian, the mountain of God (Horeb or Sinai)
Main passages	Exodus 2:15–22; 3:1; 4:18; 18:1–27
New Testament	Not named

"Now I know that the LORD is greater than all gods: for in the thing wherein they dealt proudly he was above them."

Exodus 18:11, KJV

The life of Jethro

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Exodus 18 may be placed out of order: Deuteronomy 1:9–15 links the choosing of judges to the time Israel was about to leave Horeb.

c. 1486 BC
Moses age 40

Welcomes a stranger

His daughters come home early and say an Egyptian rescued them from the shepherds. Jethro asks why they left the man behind and invites him to eat bread. *Exodus 2:15–20*

c. 1486 BC
Soon after

Gives his daughter

Moses agrees to live with him. Jethro gives him his daughter Zipporah as a wife, and she bears a son, Gershom. *Exodus 2:21–22*

c. 1486–1446 BC
Forty years

Employs Moses

Moses keeps Jethro's flock in the desert. It is while tending this flock that Moses sees the burning bush at Horeb. *Exodus 3:1; Acts 7:29–30*

c. 1446 BC
Moses leaves

Blesses his return

Moses asks to go back to his people in Egypt. Jethro answers, "Go in peace." *Exodus 4:18*

c. 1446 BC
Near Sinai

Visits the camp

Hearing all that God has done, he brings Zipporah and her two sons to Moses. He rejoices, praises the LORD, and offers sacrifices. *Exodus 18:1–12*

c. 1446 BC
The next day

Advises Moses and goes home

He sees Moses judging all day and suggests he appoint capable leaders under him. Moses agrees, and Jethro returns to his own land. *Exodus 18:13–27*

Key activities

His names are debated. Reuel may be a family or clan name. Numbers 10:29 speaks of "Hobab, the son of Raguel," and Judges 4:11 calls Hobab Moses' father-in-law. Some think Hobab was Moses' brother-in-law.

1. **Showed hospitality.** He scolded his daughters for leaving their rescuer at the well and brought Moses home to eat. *Exodus 2:20*
2. **Took in a fugitive.** He gave Moses a home, a wife and work for forty years. *Exodus 2:21; 3:1*
3. **Let Moses go in peace.** When Moses wanted to return to Egypt, Jethro did not hold him back. *Exodus 4:18*
4. **Reunited a family.** He brought Zipporah, Gershom and Eliezer back to Moses. *Exodus 18:2–6*
5. **Praised Israel's God.** He said, "Blessed be the LORD, who hath delivered you." *Exodus 18:9–11*
6. **Worshipped with Israel.** He offered a burnt offering, and Aaron and the elders ate bread with him "before God." *Exodus 18:12*
7. **Told Moses the hard truth.** "The thing that thou doest is not good." He urged Moses to teach the people and share the judging. *Exodus 18:17–23*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jethro.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:15–22; 3:1; 4:18	He welcomes Moses and blesses his return to Egypt
Exodus 18:1–27	His visit, praise, sacrifice and advice
Numbers 10:29–32	Moses invites Hobab, "the son of Raguel," to come along
Deuteronomy 1:9–18	Moses recalls appointing leaders to share the load
Judges 1:16; 4:11; 1 Samuel 15:6	His descendants, the Kenites, live alongside Israel

New Testament

Acts 7:29	Moses "a stranger in the land of Madian"
Echo: Joshua 2:9–11; 1 Kings 10:9	Other outsiders praise Israel's God
Echo: Acts 6:1–4	The apostles appoint seven to share the work

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jethro do when he heard what God had done for Israel (Exodus 18:9–12)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Moses listened to advice from his father-in-law, a priest of Midian?
3. *Apply:* Jethro told Moses, "Thou wilt surely wear away." Where are you carrying too much alone, and what could you hand to others?
4. *Apply:* Who is a wise older person who could speak honestly into your life? When could you ask for their advice?

35 Zipporah

The Midianite wife of Moses who acted quickly in a strange and dangerous night.

Zipporah was one of the seven daughters of Jethro, the priest of Midian. She met Moses when he drove off shepherds who were bullying her and her sisters at a well. Her father gave her to Moses as his wife, and she bore him two sons, Gershom and Eliezer. On the road back to Egypt, when the LORD met Moses and sought to kill him, it was Zipporah who took a flint knife and circumcised their son. Later she was sent back to her father and then brought again to Moses in the wilderness. Scripture says little about her, and several parts of her story are hard to understand. Yet at one crucial moment she saved her husband's life.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Tsipporah*, meaning "bird"
Family	Daughter of Jethro (Reuel), priest of Midian; one of seven sisters (Exodus 2:16–21)
Husband	Moses (Exodus 2:21)
Sons	Gershom and Eliezer (Exodus 2:22; 18:3–4; 1 Chronicles 23:15)
Key places	Midian, a lodging place on the road to Egypt, the mountain of God
Main passages	Exodus 2:16–22; 4:20–26; 18:2–6
New Testament	Not named

"And Moses was content to dwell with the man: and he gave Moses Zipporah his daughter."

Exodus 2:21, KJV

The life of Zipporah

Zipporah's story is not dated in Scripture. On the early Exodus date, Moses fled to Midian c. 1486 BC and returned to Egypt c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move both about 185 years later.

In Midian

At the well

She and her sisters come to water their father's flock. Shepherds drive them away, but Moses stands up for them and waters their sheep. *Exodus 2:16–19*

In Midian

Married to Moses

Her father invites the stranger home. Moses agrees to stay, and Jethro gives him Zipporah as his wife. *Exodus 2:20–21*

In Midian

Mother of Gershom

She bears a son. Moses names him Gershom, saying, "I have been a stranger in a strange land." A second son, Eliezer, is born later. *Exodus 2:22; 18:3–4*

c. 1446 BC
On the road

Circumcises her son

Moses sets out for Egypt with his wife and sons on a donkey. At a lodging place the LORD meets him and seeks to kill him. Zipporah circumcises her son, and the LORD lets him go. *Exodus 4:20, 24–26*

Before the Exodus

Sent back

At some point Moses sends Zipporah and the boys back to her father. Scripture does not say when or why. *Exodus 18:2*

c. 1446 BC
Near Sinai

Reunited

After Israel leaves Egypt, Jethro brings Zipporah and her two sons to Moses at the mountain of God. *Exodus 18:1–6*

Key activities

Exodus 4:24–26 is one of the hardest passages in the Bible. It is unclear whether the LORD sought to kill Moses or his son, whose feet Zipporah touched, and what "a bloody husband" means. Most readers agree the crisis was about the missing sign of the covenant.

1. **Worked with her sisters.** She helped water her father's flock and was rescued by Moses at the well. *Exodus 2:16–17*
2. **Married a foreigner.** She married Moses, a fugitive who looked like an Egyptian to her family. *Exodus 2:19–21*
3. **Raised two sons.** She bore Gershom and Eliezer, whose names recall Moses' life as a stranger and God's help. *Exodus 2:22; 18:3–4*
4. **Traveled toward Egypt.** She set out with Moses and the boys on the journey back to Egypt. *Exodus 4:20*
5. **Acted in a crisis.** She "took a sharp stone, and cut off the foreskin of her son," and the LORD let Moses go. *Exodus 4:24–26*
6. **Returned to Moses.** After a time back with her father, she came to Moses in the wilderness. *Exodus 18:2–6*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Zipporah.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:16–22	She meets and marries Moses
Exodus 4:20–26	The journey to Egypt and her son's circumcision
Exodus 18:2–6	Brought back to Moses in the wilderness
Numbers 12:1	"The Ethiopian woman"; whether this is Zipporah is debated
1 Chronicles 23:14–17	Her sons counted among the Levites

New Testament

Acts 7:29	Moses lived as a stranger in Midian, "where he begat two sons."
Echoes	God commands Joshua to circumcise Israel before they enter the land (Joshua 5:2–9). Paul speaks of circumcision "of the heart" (Romans 2:28–29).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Zipporah do when the LORD met Moses on the road (Exodus 4:24–26)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God took the sign of the covenant so seriously in the family of Israel's leader?
3. *Apply:* Zipporah acted when her husband could not. When has someone close to you needed you to step in?
4. *Apply:* Is there an act of obedience you have been putting off, as Moses had? What will you do about it this week?

36 Bezalel

The craftsman God filled with his Spirit to build the tabernacle.

Bezalel was a craftsman from the tribe of Judah. At Mount Sinai, God called him by name to build the tabernacle, the tent where God would dwell among his people. He is the first person Scripture names as "filled ... with the spirit of God," and the Spirit gave him wisdom and skill in gold, silver, bronze, stone and wood. With his partner Aholiab and many skilled workers, he turned the people's generous gifts into the ark, the altars, the lampstand and the tent itself. Bezalel never speaks in Scripture, and he never leads a battle. His story shows that practical, creative work can be a calling from God.

At a glance

Name	*Betsalel*, "in the shadow of God"; KJV Bezaleel
Family	Son of Uri, son of Hur, of Judah (Exodus 31:2)
Role	Chief craftsman of the tabernacle (Exodus 31:1–5; 38:22)
Partner	Aholiab son of Ahisamach, of the tribe of Dan (Exodus 31:6; 38:23)
When	At Sinai, c. 1446–1445 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Main passages	Exodus 31:1–11; 35:30–38:23
New Testament	Not named

> *"See, I have called by name Bezaleel the son of Uri, the son of Hur, of the tribe of Judah: And I have filled him with the spirit of God, in wisdom, and in understanding, and in knowledge, and in all manner of workmanship,"*
>
> Exodus 31:2–3, KJV

The life of Bezalel

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. The tabernacle was set up on the first day of the first month of the second year (Exodus 40:17).

c. 1446 BC
At Sinai

Called by name

While Moses is on the mountain, God names Bezalel as the builder of the tabernacle and all its furnishings, with Aholiab to help him. *Exodus 31:1–11*

c. 1446 BC
After the golden calf

Presented to the people

Moses tells Israel that the LORD has called Bezalel and filled him with his Spirit. God has also given him and Aholiab the ability to teach others. *Exodus 35:30–35*

c. 1446 BC
At Sinai

Receives the gifts

The people bring freewill offerings every morning. Soon the workers report that there is more than enough, and Moses tells the people to stop giving. *Exodus 36:1–7*

c. 1446–1445 BC
At Sinai

Builds

Bezalel and the skilled workers make the curtains, boards and veil. He makes the ark and mercy seat, the table, the lampstand, the altars and the laver. *Exodus 36:8–38:20*

c. 1445 BC
Second year

The work is finished

The finished pieces are brought to Moses. He sees that everything is done as the LORD commanded and blesses the workers. The tabernacle is raised. *Exodus 38:22; 39:32–43; 40:17*

Group notes

Key activities

Some think Bezalel's grandfather Hur is the same Hur who held up Moses' hands (Exodus 17:10–12; 24:14). The text does not say, and Hur was a common name.

1. **Was called by name.** God chose him personally for this work. *Exodus 31:2; 35:30*
2. **Was filled with the Spirit.** God gave him wisdom, understanding and knowledge for craftsmanship. *Exodus 31:3–5; 35:31–33*
3. **Taught others.** God put it in his heart to teach, along with Aholiab. *Exodus 35:34–35*
4. **Led a team.** He worked with Aholiab and "every wise hearted man" whom God had gifted. *Exodus 36:1–2, 8*
5. **Made the ark.** He made the ark of acacia wood overlaid with gold, the mercy seat, and the two cherubim. *Exodus 37:1–9*
6. **Made the furnishings.** He made the table, the golden lampstand, the incense altar, the anointing oil and the incense. *Exodus 37:10–29*
7. **Made the altar and laver.** He built the bronze altar, and he made the laver from the mirrors of the women who served at the door. *Exodus 38:1–8*
8. **Did everything as commanded.** He "made all that the LORD commanded Moses." *Exodus 38:22*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Bezalel.

Old Testament

Exodus 31:1–11	God calls and equips him
Exodus 35:30–38:23	He and the workers build the tabernacle
1 Chronicles 2:18–20	His family line in Judah
2 Chronicles 1:5	His bronze altar still at Gibeon in Solomon's day
Ezra 10:30	A different Bezaleel, after the exile
Echo: 1 Kings 7:13–14	Hiram, "filled with wisdom," works bronze for the temple

New Testament

Hebrews 8:5	and **Acts 7:44.** Moses made the tabernacle according to the pattern shown on the mountain.
Hebrews 9:1–5	The tabernacle and its furniture are described.
Echoes	The Spirit gives different gifts for the good of all (1 Corinthians 12:4–11). "Whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord" (Colossians 3:23).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words does God use to describe the gifts he gave Bezalel (Exodus 31:3–5)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God filled a craftsman with his Spirit, not only prophets and leaders?
3. *Apply:* What practical skill has God given you? How could you use it to serve your church or neighbors this month?
4. *Apply:* Bezalel also taught others. Who could you train or encourage in a skill you have?

37 Nadab and Abihu

Aaron's two oldest sons, who saw God on the mountain and died for offering "strange fire."

Nadab and Abihu were the two oldest sons of Aaron, Israel's first high priest. Few were given more privilege. They climbed Sinai with Moses and the elders, saw the God of Israel, and ate and drank in his presence. They were ordained as priests and served at the first sacrifices in the tabernacle. Then, on that very day or soon after, they offered "strange fire before the LORD, which he commanded them not," and fire from the LORD killed them. Their story shows that God's nearness must be treated as holy.

At a glance

Names	*Nadab*, probably "generous"; *Abihu*, "he is my father"
Family	Sons of Aaron and Elisheba (Exodus 6:23)
Role	Priests, ordained with their father (Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8)
When	At Sinai, c. 1446–1445 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Children	None (Numbers 3:4; 1 Chronicles 24:2)
Not the same as	Nadab, king of Israel (1 Kings 15:25)
Main passages	Exodus 24:1, 9–11; Leviticus 10:1–7
New Testament	Not named

> *"Then Moses said unto Aaron, This is it that the LORD spake, saying, I will be sanctified in them that come nigh me, and before all the people I will be glorified. And Aaron held his peace."*
>
> Leviticus 10:3, KJV

The life of Nadab and Abihu

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Leviticus 10 seems to follow straight after the eighth day of the ordination (Leviticus 9:1), but the exact day is not stated.

In Egypt

Born to Aaron

Aaron marries Elisheba, and she bears Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar. Nadab is the firstborn. *Exodus 6:23; Numbers 3:2*

c. 1446 BC
At Sinai

See the God of Israel

They are called up the mountain with Moses, Aaron and seventy elders. They see the God of Israel, and they eat and drink before him. *Exodus 24:1, 9–11*

c. 1446 BC
At Sinai

Chosen as priests

God tells Moses to set apart Aaron and his four sons to serve as priests, with holy garments made for them. *Exodus 28:1–4, 40–43*

c. 1445 BC
Second year

Ordained

Moses washes, clothes and anoints them with their father. For seven days they stay at the door of the tabernacle. *Leviticus 8:1–36*

c. 1445 BC
The eighth day

The first service

They help Aaron offer the first sacrifices. The glory of the LORD appears, and fire comes out from the LORD and consumes the offering. *Leviticus 9:1, 8–24*

c. 1445 BC
Soon after

Strange fire

Each takes his censer, puts fire and incense in it, and offers strange fire. Fire from the LORD devours them. Two of Aaron's cousins carry them out of the camp in their coats. *Leviticus 10:1–5*

Key activities

Scripture does not say exactly what made the fire "strange." Suggestions include fire not taken from the altar, incense offered at the wrong time or place, or acting without being told. Because God warns priests against wine right afterward (Leviticus 10:8–11), some think they were drunk. The text does not settle it.

1. **Went up the mountain.** They were among the few invited to come near on Sinai. *Exodus 24:1, 9*
2. **Saw God and ate before him.** "They saw God, and did eat and drink." *Exodus 24:10–11*
3. **Were set apart as priests.** They were clothed, anointed and ordained with their father. *Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8:13, 30*
4. **Served at the first sacrifices.** They brought the blood to Aaron at the altar. *Leviticus 9:9, 12, 18*
5. **Offered strange fire.** Each took his own censer and offered fire "which he commanded them not." *Leviticus 10:1*
6. **Died before the LORD.** "There went out fire from the LORD, and devoured them." *Leviticus 10:2*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nadab and Abihu.

Old Testament

Exodus 6:23; 28:1	Their birth and calling as priests
Exodus 24:1, 9–11	They see God on the mountain
Leviticus 10:1–7	Their death and Aaron's silent grief
Leviticus 16:1–2	Atonement rules "after the death of the two sons of Aaron"
Numbers 3:2–4; 1 Chronicles 24:1–2	Childless; Eleazar and Ithamar carry on
Echo: 2 Samuel 6:6–7	Uzzah dies for touching the ark
Echo: 2 Chronicles 26:16–21	Uzziah struck for burning incense

New Testament

Echoes	Ananias and Sapphira die for lying to the Holy Spirit (Acts 5:1–11). "Our God is a consuming fire" (Hebrews 12:28–29). Through Christ believers may now "come boldly unto the throne of grace" (Hebrews 4:16).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Nadab and Abihu experience in Exodus 24:9–11, and what did they do in Leviticus 10:1?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God judged them so severely, and so quickly?
3. *Apply:* Nadab and Abihu had been given great closeness to God. Where might you have grown careless with worship or prayer?
4. *Apply:* Aaron "held his peace" in his grief. How can your group support someone facing a loss they cannot explain?

38 Korah

The Levite who led a revolt against Moses and Aaron and was swallowed by the earth.

Korah was a Levite of the family of Kohath, a cousin of Moses and Aaron. His family already carried the most holy furnishings of the tabernacle, but Korah wanted more. With Dathan, Abiram and 250 leaders of Israel, he accused Moses and Aaron of lifting themselves above God's people. The earth opened and swallowed the rebels' households, and fire consumed the 250 offering incense. Korah became a byword for rebellion. Yet his sons did not die, and their descendants gave their name to some of Israel's best-loved psalms.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Qorach*, possibly "bald"; KJV Core in Jude 11
Family	Son of Izhar, son of Kohath; cousin of Moses and Aaron
Allies	Dathan, Abiram, On and 250 princes (Numbers 16:1–2)
When	In the wilderness years; date not given
Descendants	The sons of Korah, temple singers and gatekeepers
Main passages	Numbers 16:1–50; 26:9–11
New Testament	Jude 11

> *"And they gathered themselves together against Moses and against Aaron, and said unto them, Ye take too much upon you, seeing all the congregation are holy, every one of them, and the LORD is among them: wherefore then lift ye up yourselves above the congregation of the LORD?"*
>
> Numbers 16:3, KJV

The life of Korah

Numbers does not date Korah's revolt. It is placed after the failure at Kadesh (Numbers 13–14), somewhere in the forty years of wandering. That period is c. 1445–1406 BC on the early Exodus date, or about 185 years later on the late date.

In Egypt

Born a Kohathite

Korah is born to Izhar, brother of Amram. So he is a first cousin of Moses, Aaron and Miriam. *Exodus 6:18, 21*

At Sinai

Given holy work

The Kohathites are appointed to carry the ark, the table, the lampstand and the altars when Israel travels. Only the priests may cover and handle these holy things. *Numbers 3:27–31; 4:1–20*

In the wilderness

Leads a revolt

With Dathan, Abiram, On and 250 well-known leaders, he confronts Moses and Aaron: "Ye take too much upon you." Moses falls on his face. *Numbers 16:1–4*

The next day

The test of the censers

Moses tells Korah's company to come back with censers, fire and incense, so the LORD can show who is his. Korah gathers the whole congregation at the tabernacle door, and God's glory appears. *Numbers 16:5–7, 16–19*

That same day

Judgment

The ground splits open and swallows Dathan, Abiram and the households of Korah. Fire from the LORD consumes the 250 men offering incense. *Numbers 16:20–35; 26:10*

Group notes

Key activities

Numbers 16 weaves together two protests. Korah and his Levites wanted the priesthood. Dathan and Abiram rejected Moses' leadership. Numbers 16:32 says the earth swallowed "all the men that appertained unto Korah," but Numbers 26:11 adds that his sons did not die.

1. **Resented his place.** Though given holy work, he and his followers sought the priesthood as well. *Numbers 16:8–10*
2. **Gathered a following.** He drew 250 famous leaders of the congregation into his cause. *Numbers 16:1–2*
3. **Used true words wrongly.** He said all the congregation was holy, turning a true teaching into a weapon against God's chosen leaders. *Numbers 16:3; Exodus 19:6*
4. **Stood with his censer.** He gathered the whole congregation against Moses and Aaron at the door of the tabernacle. *Numbers 16:18–19*
5. **Was judged by God.** The earth opened, and the rebels "went down alive into the pit." *Numbers 16:31–33*
6. **Left a warning.** The censers of the 250 men were hammered into plates to cover the altar, as a memorial to Israel. *Numbers 16:36–40*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Korah.

Old Testament

Exodus 6:21, 24	His family line
Numbers 16:1–50	The revolt, the judgment, and the plague
Numbers 17:1–10	Aaron's rod buds to settle who is chosen
Numbers 26:9–11	"Notwithstanding the children of Korah died not"
Numbers 27:3	Zelophehad was not "in the company of Korah"
Psalm 106:16–18	Dathan and Abiram swallowed by the earth
Psalms 42; 44–49; 84–85; 87–88	Titled "for the sons of Korah"
1 Chronicles 6:33–38; 9:19	Heman the singer and gatekeepers descend from him

New Testament

Jude 11	False teachers "perished in the gainsaying of Core"
Echo: 2 Timothy 2:19	"The Lord knoweth them that are his" (Numbers 16:5)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Korah and his followers accuse Moses and Aaron of (Numbers 16:3)?
2. *Understand:* The Levites already had great privilege (Numbers 16:9–10). Why was that not enough?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to compare your role with someone else's?
4. *Apply:* Korah's sons became singers in God's house. What do you want to pass on?

39 Caleb

The spy who "wholly followed the LORD" and at eighty-five asked for a mountain.

Caleb was one of twelve men Moses sent to explore Canaan. Ten came back afraid of giants and walled cities. Only Caleb and Joshua urged the people to trust God and go in. The people wanted to stone them, and God sentenced that whole generation to die in the wilderness. But he made an exception for Caleb, because he "hath followed me fully." Forty-five years later, at eighty-five, Caleb was still strong. He asked for the hill country of Hebron, where the giants lived, and he took it. His story is about faith that does not fade with age, and about a man who waited decades for a promise and never gave up on it.

At a glance

Name	*Kalev*, linked to "dog," perhaps "faithful" or "bold"
Family	Son of Jephunneh the Kenezite, of the tribe of Judah (Numbers 13:6; 32:12)
Daughter	Achsah, wife of Othniel (Joshua 15:16–17)
Lifespan	Age 40 as a spy; still strong at 85 (Joshua 14:7, 10–11)
Inheritance	Hebron and the hill country around it (Joshua 14:13–14)
Key people	Moses, Joshua, Othniel, the sons of Anak
Main passages	Numbers 13–14; Joshua 14:6–15; 15:13–19
New Testament	Not named

"But my servant Caleb, because he had another spirit with him, and hath followed me fully, him will I bring into the land whereinto he went; and his seed shall possess it."

Numbers 14:24, KJV

The life of Caleb

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. His ages come from Joshua 14:7–10.

c. 1445 BC
Age 40

Sent as a spy

Moses chooses one leader from each tribe to search the land of Canaan. Caleb represents Judah. For forty days the spies explore the land, including Hebron. *Numbers 13:1–25; Joshua 14:7*

c. 1445 BC
Age 40

Calls for courage

Ten spies say the people are too strong. Caleb quiets the crowd: "Let us go up at once, and possess it; for we are well able to overcome it." *Numbers 13:26–33*

c. 1445 BC
Age 40

Spared from the sentence

The people weep and want new leaders. Caleb and Joshua tear their clothes and plead with them. God declares that of all the adults only these two will enter the land. *Numbers 14:1–38*

c. 1406 BC
Age 79

Chosen to divide the land

On the plains of Moab, God names Caleb as Judah's leader for dividing the land of Canaan among the tribes. *Numbers 26:65; 34:16–19*

c. 1400 BC
Age 85

Asks for the mountain

At Gilgal he reminds Joshua of Moses' promise and asks for the hill country where the giants live. Joshua blesses him and gives him Hebron. *Joshua 14:6–15*

c. 1400 BC or later

Takes Hebron

He drives out the three sons of Anak and offers his daughter Achsah to whoever takes Kirjath-sepher. Othniel wins her, and Caleb gives her springs of water. *Joshua 15:13–19*

Key activities

Caleb is called "the Kenezite." Kenaz is also an Edomite clan name (Genesis 36:11, 42), so some think Caleb's family was not Israelite by birth but joined the tribe of Judah. Others think Kenaz was simply an ancestor in Judah. The text does not say.

1. **Saw the same land differently.** He saw the same giants as the others but trusted God's promise. *Numbers 13:30; 14:6–9*
2. **Stood against the crowd.** He and Joshua told the people, "the LORD is with us: fear them not," even as the people talked of stoning them. *Numbers 14:9–10*
3. **Followed the LORD fully.** God himself gave Caleb this testimony, and Moses and Joshua repeated it. *Numbers 14:24; Deuteronomy 1:36; Joshua 14:8–9, 14*
4. **Waited forty-five years.** He wandered with a faithless generation for a sin that was not his, then fought for the land. *Joshua 14:10*
5. **Asked for the hardest place.** "Now therefore give me this mountain," he said, where the Anakim lived. *Joshua 14:12*
6. **Won Hebron.** He drove out Sheshai, Ahiman and Talmai, the three sons of Anak. *Joshua 15:13–14; Judges 1:20*
7. **Blessed his daughter.** When Achsah asked for springs, he gave her "the upper springs, and the nether springs." *Joshua 15:18–19; Judges 1:12–15*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Caleb.

Old Testament

Numbers 13–14	The spying of the land and God's verdict
Numbers 32:11–12; Deuteronomy 1:34–36	Only Caleb and Joshua will see the land
Numbers 34:19	Judah's leader for dividing the land
Joshua 14:6–15; 15:13–19; 21:11–12	He receives Hebron's fields
Judges 1:10–15, 20	Hebron taken; Achsah's springs
1 Samuel 25:3; 1 Chronicles 4:15	Nabal of Caleb's house; Caleb's sons

New Testament

Hebrews 3:16–4:2	That generation could not enter "because of unbelief"
1 Corinthians 10:1–11	Wilderness events written "for our admonition"
Echo: 2 Timothy 4:7	"I have kept the faith"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Caleb see in Canaan, and what did he say about it (Numbers 13:30; 14:6–9)?
2. *Understand:* What do you think it means that Caleb had "another spirit" and "wholly followed the LORD"?
3. *Apply:* Caleb asked for the hardest place at 85. What challenge might God be giving you now?
4. *Apply:* Where do you need to speak up for faith when the crowd around you is afraid?

40 Balaam

The hired prophet who came to curse Israel and could only bless.

Balaam son of Beor was a famous seer from Pethor, near the Euphrates River. When Israel camped on the plains of Moab, Balak king of Moab offered him rich rewards to curse them. God told Balaam not to go, then allowed him to go but only to speak God's word. On the way, his donkey saw the angel of the LORD blocking the road and spoke to him. Three times Balak built altars, and three times Balaam blessed Israel instead. His fourth oracle foretold "a Star out of Jacob." Yet the New Testament remembers Balaam as a man who loved money. He later advised Moab to lead Israel into sin at Peor, and he died in battle.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Bil'am*. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Beor (Numbers 22:5), spelled Bosor in 2 Peter 2:15, KJV
Home	Pethor, by the Euphrates (Numbers 22:5; 23:7)
Role	Seer for hire; a "soothsayer" (Joshua 13:22)
When	c. 1406 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Key people	Balak king of Moab, the princes of Moab and Midian
Main passages	Numbers 22–24; 31:8, 16
New Testament	2 Peter 2:15–16; Jude 11; Revelation 2:14

"God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good?"

Numbers 23:19, KJV

The life of Balaam

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, with Israel on the plains of Moab c. 1406 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. The order of events after Numbers 24 comes from Numbers 31.

c. 1406 BC
At Pethor

Summoned by Balak

Moab is afraid of Israel. Balak sends elders with "the rewards of divination" to hire Balaam. God tells him, "Thou shalt not curse the people: for they are blessed." *Numbers 22:1–14*

c. 1406 BC
At Pethor

Sent the second time

Balak sends greater princes and promises great honor. Balaam says he cannot go beyond the LORD's word, yet asks again. God lets him go but only to speak what he is told. *Numbers 22:15–21*

c. 1406 BC
On the road

The donkey and the angel

The angel of the LORD blocks the road three times. The donkey turns aside and is beaten, then speaks. Balaam's eyes are opened, and he sees the angel with a drawn sword. *Numbers 22:22–35*

c. 1406 BC
Hills of Moab

Blesses Israel

From three high places Balak offers sacrifices, and three times Balaam blesses Israel. A fourth oracle foretells a star and sceptre from Israel. *Numbers 22:36–24:25*

c. 1406 BC
Peor

Counsels sin

Israel falls into immorality and idol worship with the women of Moab and Midian. Moses later says this happened "through the counsel of Balaam." *Numbers 25:1–3; 31:16*

c. 1406 BC
Midian

Killed in battle

Israel wars against Midian. Balaam son of Beor is killed with the sword along with the five kings of Midian. *Numbers 31:8; Joshua 13:22*

Key activities

Christians and Jews have long debated Balaam. Was he a true prophet of the LORD who went wrong, or a pagan diviner whom God used against his will? Readers also ask why God allowed him to go (Numbers 22:20) and then was angry that he went (Numbers 22:22).

1. **Sought God's word.** He asked the LORD and at first refused to go. *Numbers 22:8–13*
2. **Kept the door open for reward.** He said he could not go beyond God's word "if Balak would give me his house full of silver and gold," yet he asked God a second time. *Numbers 22:18–19*
3. **Was rebuked by a donkey.** "The LORD opened the mouth of the ass," and Balaam finally saw the angel. *Numbers 22:28–31*
4. **Blessed instead of cursing.** He said, "How shall I curse, whom God hath not cursed?" *Numbers 23:7–10*
5. **Spoke of God's faithfulness.** He declared that God does not lie or change his mind. *Numbers 23:18–24*
6. **Foretold a coming ruler.** "There shall come a Star out of Jacob, and a Sceptre shall rise out of Israel." *Numbers 24:15–19*
7. **Taught Balak to trap Israel.** His counsel led Israel into sin at Baal-peor. *Numbers 31:16; Revelation 2:14*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Balaam.

Old Testament

Numbers 22–24	The main account
Numbers 31:8, 16	His death and his role at Peor
Deuteronomy 23:4–5	God "turned the curse into a blessing"
Joshua 13:22; 24:9–10	A soothsayer God would not listen to
Nehemiah 13:2; Micah 6:5	Balak's plot and Balaam's answer recalled

New Testament

2 Peter 2:15–16	He "loved the wages of unrighteousness"
Jude 11	"The error of Balaam for reward"
Revelation 2:14	He "taught Balac to cast a stumblingblock"
Echo: Revelation 22:16	Many see Numbers 24:17's star fulfilled in Jesus

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Balaam's donkey see that Balaam could not (Numbers 22:22–31)?
2. *Understand:* Balaam spoke true words yet is remembered as a warning. What does that teach about gifts and character?
3. *Apply:* Is there a decision where you keep hoping God will change his mind?
4. *Apply:* Where might money or approval be pulling you away from what is right?

41 Phinehas

The zealous priest who stopped a plague and was given a covenant of peace.

Phinehas, son of Eleazar and grandson of Aaron, stepped onto the stage at one of the darkest moments of the wilderness years. On the plains of Moab many Israelites joined the women of Moab and Midian in immorality and in worship of Baal-peor, and a plague broke out. While the people wept at the tabernacle door, an Israelite leader brought a Midianite woman into his tent. Phinehas killed them both, and the plague stopped. God gave him "my covenant of peace." Later he served as a peacemaker between the tribes and as high priest.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Pinchas*, probably from an Egyptian name meaning "the Nubian"
Family	Son of Eleazar; grandson of Aaron; his mother was a daughter of Putiel (Exodus 6:25)
Role	Priest, and later high priest (Numbers 25:11–13; Judges 20:28)
When	c. 1406 BC at Peor (early date), into the judges' time
Key places	The plains of Moab, Shiloh, the Jordan River, Bethel
Not the same as	Phinehas son of Eli (1 Samuel 1:3; 4:11)
Main passages	Numbers 25:1–18; 31:6; Joshua 22:10–34
New Testament	Not named

"Then stood up Phinehas, and executed judgment: and so the plague was stayed."

Psalm 106:30, KJV

The life of Phinehas

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, with Israel on the plains of Moab c. 1406 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. Joshua 22 and Judges 20 are not dated.

Family

Born to Eleazar

Eleazar, Aaron's son, marries one of the daughters of Putiel, and she bears Phinehas. He grows up in the priestly family. *Exodus 6:25*

c. 1406 BC
Plains of Moab

Stops the plague

Israel joins in the worship of Baal-peor, and a plague spreads. When Zimri brings Cozbi, a Midianite, into his tent, Phinehas kills them both with a javelin. The plague stops after 24,000 have died. *Numbers 25:1–9, 14–15*

c. 1406 BC
Plains of Moab

Given a covenant

God says Phinehas has turned away his wrath. He gives him a covenant of peace and a lasting priesthood for his descendants. *Numbers 25:10–13*

c. 1406 BC
Midian

Goes to war

Moses sends Phinehas with the army against Midian, carrying the holy instruments and the trumpets. *Numbers 31:1–8*

After the conquest

Prevents a civil war

The eastern tribes build a large altar by the Jordan. Phinehas leads a delegation, listens to their explanation, and brings back a report of peace. *Joshua 22:10–34*

Days of the judges

Serves before the ark

In the war against Benjamin, Phinehas stands before the ark at Bethel (the KJV reads "the house of God") and asks the LORD whether Israel should fight. *Judges 20:26–28*

Key activities

Many readers today find Numbers 25 troubling. The text presents Phinehas's act as God's judgment in a unique crisis, and later Scripture praises it. Christians differ on how such passages should shape life under the new covenant, where believers are told not to take vengeance (Romans 12:19).

1. **Acted when others stood still.** While the congregation wept, he rose up and acted. *Numbers 25:6–7*
2. **Turned away God's wrath.** God said he had been "zealous for my sake" and had "made an atonement for the children of Israel." *Numbers 25:11–13*
3. **Received a covenant of peace.** God promised him and his descendants an everlasting priesthood. *Numbers 25:12–13*
4. **Went out with the army.** He carried the holy instruments and trumpets in the war against Midian. *Numbers 31:6*
5. **Listened before judging.** He heard the eastern tribes explain their altar and said, "This day we perceive that the LORD is among us." *Joshua 22:30–31*
6. **Gave his father a resting place.** Eleazar was buried in a hill that belonged to Phinehas in Ephraim. *Joshua 24:33*
7. **Led in worship.** He served before the ark and sought God's guidance for Israel. *Judges 20:27–28*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Phinehas.

Old Testament

Exodus 6:25	His birth in Aaron's family
Numbers 25:1–18; 31:6	Peor, the covenant of peace, the war with Midian
Joshua 22:10–34	He settles the dispute over the altar by the Jordan
Judges 20:27–28	Priest before the ark
1 Chronicles 6:4, 50; Ezra 7:1–5	In the high priestly line to Zadok and Ezra
1 Chronicles 9:20	"The LORD was with him"
Psalm 106:30–31	"Counted unto him for righteousness"

New Testament

Echo: John 2:17	"The zeal of thine house hath eaten me up"
Echo: 1 Corinthians 10:8	Paul probably recalls Peor
Echo: Ephesians 2:14–17	Jesus the one who makes peace

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What were Moses and the people doing when Phinehas acted (Numbers 25:6–8)?
2. *Understand:* How do you understand Phinehas's zeal at Peor alongside his careful listening in Joshua 22?
3. *Apply:* Where do you see a slow drift into compromise? What firm step can you take against it?
4. *Apply:* Is there a conflict where you need to ask questions, as Phinehas did, before drawing conclusions?

42 Joshua

Moses' faithful servant who led Israel across the Jordan and into the promised land.

Joshua spent forty years in Moses' shadow before he led the nation. He fought Amalek, waited on the mountain while Moses met God, and stayed near the tent of meeting. As a spy he trusted God's promise when ten others spread fear, and he was one of only two adults of his generation to enter Canaan. After Moses died, God told him to be strong and of a good courage. Joshua led Israel through the Jordan, saw Jericho fall, won the land and divided it, and in old age called the people to choose whom they would serve.

At a glance

Name	*Yehoshua*, "the LORD is salvation"; first Oshea
Family	Son of Nun, of the tribe of Ephraim (Numbers 13:8)
When	Entry into Canaan c. 1406 BC (late-date view c. 1220 BC)
Roles	Moses' minister, spy, army commander, Moses' successor
Key places	Rephidim, Sinai, Kadesh, the Jordan, Jericho, Ai, Shechem
Key people	Moses, Caleb, Eleazar the priest, Rahab, Achan
Death	Age 110; buried at Timnath-serah (Joshua 24:29–30)
New Testament	Acts 7:45; Hebrews 4:8 (KJV "Jesus"); Hebrews 11:30

> *"Have not I commanded thee? Be strong and of a good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the LORD thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest."*
>
> Joshua 1:9, KJV

The life of Joshua

Dates follow the early Exodus date (c. 1446 BC); on the late date, the entry is c. 1220 BC. Scripture gives Joshua's age only at his death.

c. 1446 BC
At Rephidim

Defeats Amalek
Joshua leads the fighting men while Moses holds up his hands on the hill. *Exodus 17:8–16*

c. 1446 BC
At Sinai

Moses' servant
A "young man" who "departed not out of the tabernacle." *Exodus 24:13; 32:17; 33:11*

c. 1445 BC
At Kadesh

One of the spies
With Caleb he urges Israel to trust God, and the people want to stone them. *Numbers 13:1–16; 14:6–10, 30*

c. 1406 BC
Plains of Moab

Commissioned
Moses lays hands on him, and he is "full of the spirit of wisdom." *Numbers 27:18–23; Deuteronomy 31:7–8; 34:9*

c. 1406 BC
At the Jordan

Crosses over
The waters stop for the ark, and Israel crosses on dry ground to Gilgal. *Joshua 3:1–5:12*

c. 1406 BC
Jericho and Ai

First victories
Jericho's walls fall; after Achan's sin, Ai is taken at the second attempt. *Joshua 6:1–8:29*

c. 1400 BC (rough)
Years of war

The land is taken
He defeats the southern and northern kings and divides the land. *Joshua 10–11; 14:6–10; 18:1–10*

Age 110
At Shechem

Covenant and death
He renews the covenant, then dies and is buried in his inheritance. *Joshua 24:1–31*

Group notes

Key activities

Caleb's ages (40 at the spying, 85 at the division) suggest about 45 years between (Joshua 14:7, 10).

1. **Fought Amalek.** He fought while Moses prayed, and the victory was rehearsed "in the ears of Joshua." *Exodus 17:9–14*
2. **Served Moses.** He learned to lead by first learning to follow. *Exodus 24:13; 33:11*
3. **Guarded Moses' honour.** He asked Moses to forbid Eldad and Medad; Moses wished all were prophets. *Numbers 11:26–29*
4. **Gave a faithful report.** He and Caleb said the land was "exceeding good" and urged the people not to fear. *Numbers 14:6–9*
5. **Received his charge.** Moses laid hands on him, and God told him to be strong and courageous and to keep the book of the law. *Deuteronomy 31:7–8; Joshua 1:1–9*
6. **Crossed the Jordan.** He set up twelve stones at Gilgal so children would ask what they meant. *Joshua 4:1–7, 19–24*
7. **Met the captain of the host.** Near Jericho he fell down and took off his shoes. *Joshua 5:13–15*
8. **Took Jericho.** He followed God's unusual battle plan and spared Rahab and her family. *Joshua 6:1–25*
9. **Dealt with Achan.** After the defeat at Ai, he sought God and brought hidden sin into the open. *Joshua 7:6–26*
10. **Was deceived by Gibeon.** He made a treaty without asking "counsel at the mouth of the LORD," but he kept his word. *Joshua 9:3–27*
11. **Prayed for the sun to stand still.** At Gibeon he said, "Sun, stand thou still upon Gibeon." Christians read this as a miracle in different ways. *Joshua 10:12–14*
12. **Called Israel to choose.** At Shechem he declared, "as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD." *Joshua 24:14–27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joshua.

Old Testament

Numbers 27:15–23; Deuteronomy 34:9	Moses hands leadership to him
Joshua 1–24	The conquest and division of the land
Joshua 21:43–45	"There failed not ought of any good thing"
Judges 2:6–9	Israel served the LORD all the days of Joshua
1 Kings 16:34	His curse on Jericho's rebuilder comes true
Tradition	The Talmud says Joshua wrote most of his book; it names no author

New Testament

Acts 7:45	The tabernacle came in "with Jesus," meaning Joshua
Hebrews 4:8	"If Jesus had given them rest"; again Joshua
Hebrews 11:30	"By faith the walls of Jericho fell down"
Echo: Hebrews 4:9–11	"Jesus" is the Greek form of Joshua

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How many times does God tell Joshua to be strong and courageous (Joshua 1:1–9)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Joshua spent so many years as Moses' servant?
3. *Apply:* What reminders of God's help could you share with someone younger?
4. *Apply:* "Choose you this day." What choice about serving God is in front of you?

43 Rahab

The Canaanite woman of Jericho who hid Israel's spies and was saved by faith.

Rahab lived in Jericho, the first city Israel faced across the Jordan. Scripture calls her a harlot, and her house was built into the city wall. When Joshua sent two spies into the city, she hid them on her roof and sent the king's men the wrong way. She had heard what the LORD had done for Israel, and she confessed that he is God in heaven above and in earth beneath. She asked for mercy for her family, and the spies gave her a sign: a scarlet cord in her window. When Jericho fell, she and her household were spared. The New Testament names her among the heroes of faith and in the family line of Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Rachav*, usually explained as "broad" or "wide"
People	A Canaanite of Jericho
Known as	"Rahab the harlot" (Joshua 6:17; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25)
When	The fall of Jericho, c. 1406 BC (late-date view c. 1220 BC)
Key places	Jericho; her house on the town wall (Joshua 2:15)
Key people	The two spies, Joshua, her father's household
Main passages	Joshua 2:1–24; 6:17, 22–25
New Testament	Matthew 1:5 ("Rachab"); Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25

"By faith the harlot Rahab perished not with them that believed not, when she had received the spies with peace."

Hebrews 11:31, KJV

The life of Rahab

Dates follow the early date of the Exodus. On the late date, Jericho falls c. 1220 BC. Scripture gives no age for Rahab.

c. 1406 BC
In Jericho

Hears the news

Word reaches Jericho of the Red Sea and of Israel's victory over Sihon and Og. The people's hearts melt with fear. *Joshua 2:9–11*

c. 1406 BC
On her roof

Hides the spies

Two men sent by Joshua lodge at her house. She hides them under stalks of flax and tells the king's men they have already gone. *Joshua 2:1–7*

c. 1406 BC
At the window

Makes a pact

She confesses faith in the LORD and asks for her family's lives. She lets the spies down by a cord, and they tell her to tie a scarlet line in the window. *Joshua 2:8–21*

c. 1406 BC
When Jericho falls

Saved

Joshua orders that she be spared. The two spies bring out Rahab, her parents, her brothers and all she has. *Joshua 6:17, 22–23*

Afterward

Lives in Israel

She and her family are settled outside the camp at first. The writer adds that she "dwelleth in Israel even unto this day." *Joshua 6:23, 25*

Group notes

Key activities

Some ancient writers, including Josephus, called Rahab an innkeeper. The Hebrew word and the New Testament both call her a harlot. Christians also differ on how to judge her lie to the king's men: some see it as wrong but forgiven, others as a lesser wrong to protect life.

1. **Welcomed the spies.** She took them into her house and hid them on the roof. *Joshua 2:1–6*
2. **Misled the king's men.** She sent the searchers toward the Jordan while the spies were still hidden. *Joshua 2:3–7*
3. **Confessed the LORD.** She said, "for the LORD your God, he is God in heaven above, and in earth beneath." *Joshua 2:11*
4. **Asked for mercy.** She asked for a "true token" that her father's house would be spared. *Joshua 2:12–14*
5. **Helped them escape.** She let them down through the window and told them to hide in the mountain three days. *Joshua 2:15–16, 22*
6. **Kept the sign.** She tied the scarlet line in the window and gathered her family inside. *Joshua 2:18–21; 6:22–23*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rahab.

Old Testament

Joshua 2:1–24	She hides the spies and makes a pact with them
Joshua 6:17, 22–25	She and her household are spared
Echo: Exodus 12:13, 22–23	Blood on the doorposts marks the saved houses
Echo: Ruth 1:16	Another foreign woman chooses Israel's God

New Testament

Matthew 1:5	"Salmon begat Booz of Rachab"; most take her as Boaz's mother, though the time gap is debated
Hebrews 11:31	Named among the heroes of faith
James 2:25	"Justified by works, when she had received the messengers"
Echo: Matthew 21:31–32	Harlots enter the kingdom before the leaders
Tradition	Clement of Rome saw the scarlet cord as a picture of Christ's blood

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What had Rahab heard about Israel's God, and what did she conclude (Joshua 2:9–11)?
2. *Understand:* Hebrews praises her faith and James her works. Why does her story fit both?
3. *Apply:* Rahab's past did not keep her out of God's people. How should we welcome others?
4. *Apply:* Rahab acted on her belief at real risk. What step of faith could you take this week?

44 Achan

The soldier whose hidden theft at Jericho brought defeat on all Israel.

Achan was a man of Judah who fought at Jericho. God had said everything in the city was devoted to him, and nothing was to be kept. Achan saw a fine robe, silver and a bar of gold, wanted them, and buried them under his tent. No one knew. But when Israel attacked the small town of Ai, the army ran and thirty-six men died. By lot the guilt was traced to one man. Achan confessed, and he died in the valley of Achor, "trouble." His story shows how one person's secret sin can harm a whole community.

At a glance

Name	*Akhan*, meaning uncertain; "Achar" in 1 Chronicles 2:7
Family	Son of Carmi, of the tribe of Judah (Joshua 7:1, 18)
When	Just after Jericho fell, c. 1406 BC (late view c. 1220 BC)
Key places	Jericho, Ai, the valley of Achor
Key people	Joshua; the men of Ai; his sons and daughters
What he took	A garment, 200 shekels of silver, a wedge of gold (Joshua 7:21)
Main passages	Joshua 7; 22:20; 1 Chronicles 2:7
New Testament	Not named

"And Achan answered Joshua, and said, Indeed I have sinned against the LORD God of Israel, and thus and thus have I done:"

Joshua 7:20, KJV

The life of Achan

Dates follow the early date of the Exodus. On the late date, these events fall c. 1220 BC. Scripture gives no age for Achan. All of his story comes from a few days.

c. 1406 BC
At Jericho

Takes the devoted things

Israel is told that Jericho and all in it are devoted to the LORD. Achan takes some of the spoil for himself, and God's anger burns against Israel. *Joshua 6:17–19; 7:1*

c. 1406 BC
At Ai

Israel is routed

Spies advise sending only two or three thousand men. About three thousand go up, flee before the men of Ai, and lose thirty-six men. *Joshua 7:2–5*

c. 1406 BC
The next morning

Taken by lot

Joshua brings Israel near by tribes. Judah is taken, then the Zarhites, then Zabdi's household, and finally Achan. *Joshua 7:10–18*

c. 1406 BC
Before Joshua

Confesses

Achan admits what he saw, coveted, took and hid. Messengers run to his tent and find the goods buried there. *Joshua 7:19–23*

c. 1406 BC
In the valley of Achor

Dies

Achan is stoned, and a great heap of stones is raised over him. Then the LORD turns from his anger. *Joshua 7:24–26*

Group notes

Key activities

Joshua 7:24–25 says Achan's sons and daughters were taken to the valley with him, and "all Israel stoned him." Readers differ on whether the family was put to death with him, and if so whether they shared in hiding the goods. Deuteronomy 24:16 forbids punishing children for a parent's sin.

1. **Fought at Jericho.** He was among the men who marched and saw the walls fall. *Joshua 6:1–21*
2. **Coveted and took.** In his own words: "I saw … then I coveted them, and took them." *Joshua 7:21*
3. **Hid the goods.** He buried them in the ground inside his tent, with the silver underneath. *Joshua 7:21–22*
4. **Stayed silent.** He said nothing while Israel was routed at Ai and Joshua lay on his face before the ark. *Joshua 7:5–9*
5. **Was found out.** God pointed him out step by step through the lot. *Joshua 7:14–18*
6. **Confessed.** Joshua called him "My son" and urged him to give glory to God and tell the truth. He did. *Joshua 7:19–21*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Achan.

Old Testament

Joshua 7:1–26	The main account
Joshua 22:20	"That man perished not alone in his iniquity"
1 Chronicles 2:7	"Achar, the troubler of Israel"
Hosea 2:15; Isaiah 65:10	Achor becomes a "door of hope"
Echo: Genesis 3:6	Eve also saw, desired and took
Echo: 1 Samuel 15:9–23	Saul also kept what was devoted

New Testament

Echo: Acts 5:1–11	Ananias and Sapphira keep back part and lie
Echo: James 1:14–15	Sin traced from desire to action
Echo: 1 Corinthians 5:6	"A little leaven leaveneth the whole lump"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* List the four verbs in Achan's confession (Joshua 7:21). What does each step show?
2. *Understand:* Why did God treat Achan's private sin as the sin of all Israel (Joshua 7:1, 11)?
3. *Apply:* Achan buried what he took under his own tent. What might people "bury" today and hope no one finds?
4. *Apply:* Hosea turns the valley of trouble into a door of hope. Where do you need to hear that confession can lead to a fresh start?

45 Othniel

The first of the judges, a proven warrior on whom the Spirit of the LORD came.

Othniel first appears in Caleb's day, capturing Kirjath-sepher and winning Caleb's daughter Achsah as his wife. Years later Israel forgot the LORD, and God gave them into the hand of a foreign king for eight years. When they cried out, God raised up Othniel. The Spirit of the LORD came on him, he judged Israel, went to war, and won. The land had rest forty years. His short story sets the pattern of the book of Judges: sin, oppression, a cry for help, and a deliverer sent by God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Othniel*; meaning uncertain, perhaps "strength of God"
Family	Son of Kenaz, "Caleb's younger brother" (Judges 3:9)
Wife	Achsah, daughter of Caleb (Joshua 15:16–17)
Son	Hathath (1 Chronicles 4:13)
When	The first judge; any BC date is rough
Enemy	Chushan-rishathaim, king of Mesopotamia (Judges 3:8)
Main passages	Joshua 15:13–19; Judges 1:11–15; 3:7–11
New Testament	Not named

> *"And when the children of Israel cried unto the LORD, the LORD raised up a deliverer to the children of Israel, who delivered them, even Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother."*
>
> Judges 3:9, KJV

The life of Othniel

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges ruled c. 1375–1050 BC, and Othniel comes first, so his work probably falls near the start of that span. Treat any date as rough.

In Caleb's day

Takes Kirjath-sepher

Caleb promises his daughter to the man who captures Kirjath-sepher, later called Debir. Othniel takes the city and marries Achsah. *Joshua 15:15–17; Judges 1:11–13*

Soon after

Achsah asks for springs

Achsah urges him to ask Caleb for a field. She then asks her father for springs of water, and Caleb gives the upper and nether springs. *Joshua 15:18–19; Judges 1:14–15*

Eight years

Israel is oppressed

Israel forgets the LORD and serves the Baals and the groves. God sells them into the hand of Chushan-rishathaim, and they serve him eight years. *Judges 3:7–8*

When Israel cries out

Raised up to deliver

The Spirit of the LORD comes on Othniel. He judges Israel, goes out to war, and defeats Chushan-rishathaim. *Judges 3:9–10*

Forty years

Rest and death

The land has rest for forty years, and then Othniel dies. *Judges 3:11*

Group notes

Key activities

"Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother" can be read two ways. Some take Othniel as Caleb's younger brother. Others take Kenaz as the younger brother, which would make Othniel Caleb's nephew. Judges 1:1 also places the capture of Debir after Joshua's death, while Joshua 15 tells it within Caleb's story, and readers explain the order differently.

1. **Took a fortified city.** He captured Kirjath-sepher, one of the towns in Caleb's allotment. *Joshua 15:15–17*
2. **Married Achsah.** He received Caleb's daughter as the promised reward. *Judges 1:12–13*
3. **Received land and water.** With Achsah's help the family gained a field and springs. *Judges 1:14–15*
4. **Was filled by the Spirit.** "The Spirit of the LORD came upon him." He is the first judge of whom this is said. *Judges 3:10*
5. **Judged Israel.** He led the people before he led them in battle. *Judges 3:10*
6. **Defeated a foreign king.** "His hand prevailed against Chushan-rishathaim." *Judges 3:10*
7. **Brought rest.** The land had rest forty years while he lived. *Judges 3:11*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Othniel.

Old Testament

Joshua 15:15–19; Judges 1:11–15	He takes Kirjath-sepher and marries Achsah
Judges 3:7–11	His time as judge, the book's first full pattern
1 Chronicles 4:13	Named with his son Hathath
1 Chronicles 27:15	Heldai, David's commander, "of Othniel," probably a descendant
Echo: Numbers 14:24; Joshua 14:6–14	Caleb's faith carried on in his family
Echo: Judges 6:34; 11:29; 14:6	The Spirit later comes on other judges

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:68–71	God again raises up a deliverer for his people
Echo: Hebrews 11:32–34	Judges who "out of weakness were made strong"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What four things does Judges 3:10 say happened when the Spirit of the LORD came on Othniel?
2. *Understand:* Othniel had already proved himself in battle years before. Why do you think God chose someone with that history?
3. *Apply:* Judges 2:10 describes a generation that "knew not the LORD." What can you do to pass on faith to the next generation?
4. *Apply:* Israel cried out after eight years. Is there an area of your life where you need to stop struggling alone and cry out to God?

46 Ehud

The left-handed Benjamite who brought a hidden dagger and a message from God to the king of Moab.

Ehud was the second judge of Israel. After Othniel died, Israel again did evil, and God strengthened Eglon king of Moab against them for eighteen years. When the people cried out, God raised up Ehud, a left-handed Benjamite. Sent with Israel's tribute to Eglon, he strapped a two-edged dagger to his right thigh. Alone with the king, he said, "I have a message from God unto thee," and struck him down. Then he escaped, rallied Israel, and won a victory that brought eighty years of rest.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Ehud*. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Gera, of the tribe of Benjamin (Judges 3:15)
Known as	"A man lefthanded" (Judges 3:15)
When	The second judge; any BC date is rough
Enemy	Eglon king of Moab (Judges 3:12–13)
Key places	City of palm trees, Gilgal, Seirath, fords of Jordan
Result	The land had rest eighty years (Judges 3:30)
New Testament	Not named

"But when the children of Israel cried unto the LORD, the LORD raised them up a deliverer, Ehud the son of Gera, a Benjamite, a man lefthanded: and by him the children of Israel sent a present unto Eglon the king of Moab."

Judges 3:15, KJV

The life of Ehud

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC. Ehud follows Othniel, but any date for him is rough.

Eighteen years

Moab rules Israel

Israel does evil again. Eglon of Moab, joined by Ammon and Amalek, defeats Israel and takes the city of palm trees. *Judges 3:12–14*

When Israel cries

Raised up

God raises up Ehud, who is chosen to bring Israel's present to Eglon. He makes a dagger a cubit long and hides it on his right thigh. *Judges 3:15–18*

In the summer parlour

Strikes Eglon

Ehud returns alone from the quarries by Gilgal. Claiming a secret errand and a message from God, he kills the king and locks the doors behind him. *Judges 3:19–23*

While the servants wait

Escapes

The servants think the king is resting and wait until they are ashamed. By then Ehud has passed the quarries and fled to Seirath. *Judges 3:24–26*

At the fords of Jordan

Wins the battle

He blows a trumpet in mount Ephraim and leads Israel down. They seize the fords and kill about ten thousand Moabites. *Judges 3:27–29*

Eighty years

Rest

Moab is subdued, and the land has rest for eighty years. *Judges 3:30*

Group notes

Key activities

This is one of the most vivid and even darkly humorous stories in Scripture. Readers differ on whether Ehud's deception should be seen as approved, or simply reported. The text says God raised him up, but it does not comment on each of his methods.

1. **Answered God's call.** He was the deliverer God raised up when Israel cried out. *Judges 3:15*
2. **Made a weapon.** He made a two-edged dagger "of a cubit length" and girded it under his clothes. *Judges 3:16*
3. **Delivered the tribute.** He presented Israel's gift to Eglon, "a very fat man." *Judges 3:17–18*
4. **Went back alone.** At the quarries by Gilgal he turned back and asked to see the king privately. *Judges 3:19*
5. **Struck the king.** He said, "I have a message from God unto thee," and thrust the dagger into Eglon's belly. *Judges 3:20–22*
6. **Rallied Israel.** He told them, "Follow after me: for the LORD hath delivered your enemies the Moabites into your hand." *Judges 3:27–28*
7. **Held the fords.** Israel seized the Jordan crossings, and not a Moabite escaped. *Judges 3:28–29*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Ehud.

Old Testament

Judges 3:12–30	The main account
Judges 3:31	Shamgar follows him, killing six hundred Philistines
Judges 4:1	Israel again did evil "when Ehud was dead"
1 Chronicles 7:10; 8:6	Benjamites named Ehud; unclear if either is the judge
Echo: 1 Samuel 9:1–2; 14:1–14	Saul and Jonathan, later Benjamite fighters
Echo: Judges 6:15	God chooses the overlooked, like Gideon

New Testament

Echo: Hebrews 4:12	God's word "sharper than any twoedged sword"
Echo: 1 Corinthians 1:27	God chooses "the weak things of the world"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What details does Judges 3:15–16 give about Ehud and his weapon?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the writer includes so many unusual, even humorous, details?
3. *Apply:* Ehud's left hand may have looked like a weakness. What trait of yours might God use in a way you did not expect?
4. *Apply:* Israel lived under Moab for eighteen years before the cry of Judges 3:15. What keeps people today from asking God for help sooner?

47 Deborah

The prophetess and judge who called Israel to battle and sang of the LORD's victory.

Deborah is the only judge in the book of Judges who is also called a prophet, and the only woman among them. She held court under a palm tree in the hill country of Ephraim, and the people came to her to settle their disputes. For twenty years Jabin king of Canaan had crushed Israel with nine hundred iron chariots. God gave Deborah a message for Barak: gather an army at Mount Tabor, and the LORD would deliver Sisera, Jabin's general, into his hand. Barak would not go without her, so she went. God routed the chariots at the river Kishon, and Deborah and Barak sang one of the oldest songs in the Bible. The land had rest forty years.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Devorah*, "bee"
Family	Wife of Lapidoth (Judges 4:4)
Roles	Prophetess, judge, singer; "a mother in Israel" (Judges 5:7)
When	After Ehud and Shamgar. Any BC date is rough
Key places	The palm tree of Deborah between Ramah and Bethel; Mount Tabor; the river Kishon
Key people	Barak, Jael, Sisera, Jabin king of Canaan
Main passages	Judges 4–5
New Testament	Not named

> *"The inhabitants of the villages ceased, they ceased in Israel, until that I Deborah arose, that I arose a mother in Israel."*
>
> Judges 5:7, KJV

The life of Deborah

Judges gives no calendar dates; on the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC. Any date for Deborah is rough.

Twenty years

Jabin oppresses Israel

Israel does evil again. Jabin king of Canaan and his captain Sisera oppress Israel with nine hundred chariots of iron. *Judges 4:1–3*

Under the palm tree

Judges Israel

Deborah, a prophetess, sits under a palm tree in mount Ephraim, and the people come to her for judgment. *Judges 4:4–5*

A word from God

Summons Barak

She calls Barak and gives God's command: take ten thousand men to Mount Tabor, and Sisera will be given into his hand. *Judges 4:6–7*

At Kedesh

Goes with Barak

Barak will not go unless she goes too. She agrees, but warns that the honour will go to a woman. *Judges 4:8–10*

At Mount Tabor

Gives the signal

Sisera gathers his chariots by the Kishon. Deborah tells Barak, "Up; for this is the day." *Judges 4:12–14*

By the Kishon

The LORD routs Sisera

The LORD throws Sisera's army into confusion. Sisera flees on foot and is killed by Jael in her tent. *Judges 4:15–22*

That day

Sings the song

Deborah and Barak sing of God's victory, praising the willing and blessing Jael. *Judges 5:1–31*

Forty years

The land rests

Jabin is destroyed, and the land has rest forty years. *Judges 4:23–24; 5:31*

Key activities

Judges 4 tells the battle as a story, Judges 5 as a poem. The poem adds rain and a river that swept the enemy away; many readers think a storm bogged down the chariots (Judges 5:4, 20–21).

1. **Judged the people.** She settled Israel's disputes under the palm tree that bore her name. *Judges 4:4–5*
2. **Spoke for God.** As a prophetess she gave Barak God's command and promise. *Judges 4:6–7*
3. **Went with Barak.** She replied, "I will surely go with thee." *Judges 4:8–9*
4. **Named the day.** She told Barak, "is not the LORD gone out before thee?" *Judges 4:14*
5. **Saw God fight.** The LORD "discomfited Sisera, and all his chariots." *Judges 4:15*
6. **Sang praise first to God.** Her song begins, "Praise ye the LORD for the avenging of Israel." *Judges 5:1–5*
7. **Remembered hard times.** She recalled empty highways and villages, until she "arose a mother in Israel." *Judges 5:6–8*
8. **Honoured the willing.** She praised the leaders and people who "offered themselves willingly." *Judges 5:2, 9, 14–15, 18*
9. **Rebuked the absent.** Reuben, Gilead, Dan and Asher stayed home, and Meroz was cursed for not coming "to the help of the LORD." *Judges 5:15–17, 23*
10. **Blessed Jael.** She sang, "Blessed above women shall Jael the wife of Heber the Kenite be." *Judges 5:24–27*
11. **Imagined the enemy's mother.** The song ends with Sisera's mother at the window, waiting for a son who will not come home. *Judges 5:28–30*
12. **Closed with a prayer.** "So let all thine enemies perish, O LORD." *Judges 5:31*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Deborah.

Old Testament

Judges 4:1–24	The battle against Sisera, told as a story
Judges 5:1–31	Her song, counted by many among the oldest poems
Psalm 83:9–10	"As to Sisera, as to Jabin, at the brook of Kison"
Joshua 11:1–11	An earlier Jabin of Hazor; perhaps a royal title (debated)
Genesis 35:8	A different Deborah, Rebekah's nurse
Echo: Exodus 15:20–21; 2 Kings 22:14	Miriam and Huldah, other prophetesses
Echo: 1 Samuel 2:1–10	Hannah's song of reversed fortunes

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32	Deborah is not named, but Barak is
Echo: Luke 2:36–38; Acts 21:9	Anna and Philip's daughters prophesied
Echo: Luke 1:46–55	Mary's song: God "hath put down the mighty"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What roles did Deborah fill for Israel (Judges 4:4–6; 5:7)?
2. *Understand:* Her song praises God first and people second. Why is that order important?
3. *Apply:* Deborah honoured those who "offered themselves willingly." Where could you volunteer this month?
4. *Apply:* Reuben had "great searchings of heart" but stayed home (Judges 5:16). What good intention do you need to turn into action?

48 Barak

The hesitant commander who led ten thousand men down Mount Tabor and is remembered for his faith.

Barak came from Kedesh in Naphtali. When Jabin king of Canaan had oppressed Israel for twenty years, the prophetess Deborah brought him God's command: gather ten thousand men at Mount Tabor, and the LORD would give Sisera into his hand. Barak agreed, but only if Deborah went with him. She went, warning that the honour would go to a woman. At her word Barak charged down the mountain, and the LORD routed Sisera's army, though Sisera died at the hand of Jael. Hebrews lists Barak among the people of faith.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Baraq*, "lightning"
Family	Son of Abinoam, of Kedesh-naphtali (Judges 4:6)
When	In Deborah's time; any BC date is rough
Key places	Kedesh, Mount Tabor, the Kishon, Harosheth
Key people	Deborah, Jael, Sisera, Jabin king of Canaan
Army	Ten thousand of Naphtali and Zebulun (Judges 4:6, 10)
Main passages	Judges 4–5
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32

> *"And Deborah said unto Barak, Up; for this is the day in which the LORD hath delivered Sisera into thine hand: is not the LORD gone out before thee? So Barak went down from mount Tabor, and ten thousand men after him."*
>
> Judges 4:14, KJV

The life of Barak

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC, but any single date for Barak is rough.

At Kedesh-naphtali

Called by Deborah

Deborah sends for Barak and gives him God's command to take ten thousand men to Mount Tabor. *Judges 4:6–7*

Before the battle

Asks Deborah to come

Barak says he will go only if she goes with him. She agrees, but says the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a woman. *Judges 4:8–9*

At Kedesh

Gathers the army

Barak calls Zebulun and Naphtali to Kedesh, and ten thousand men go up with him and Deborah. *Judges 4:10*

From Mount Tabor

Charges down

At Deborah's word he leads his men down the mountain. The LORD throws Sisera's army into confusion before Barak's sword. *Judges 4:14–15*

To Harosheth

Pursues the enemy

Barak chases the chariots to Harosheth, and not a man of Sisera's army is left. He follows Sisera to Jael's tent and finds him dead. *Judges 4:16, 22*

That day

Sings with Deborah

Barak and Deborah sing of God's victory together. *Judges 5:1, 12*

Group notes

Key activities

Readers judge Barak's request in different ways. Some see weak faith, since Deborah said the honour would pass to a woman. Others see a wise wish to have God's prophet with him. Hebrews 11:32 names him among those who acted by faith.

1. **Heard God's command.** Through Deborah, God told him where to go and whom to take. *Judges 4:6–7*
2. **Asked for Deborah.** "If thou wilt go with me, then I will go: but if thou wilt not go with me, then I will not go." *Judges 4:8*
3. **Raised the army.** He called ten thousand men of Zebulun and Naphtali. *Judges 4:10*
4. **Went down at God's word.** When Deborah said, "Up," he left the high ground and attacked. *Judges 4:14*
5. **Won the battle.** The LORD discomfited Sisera's chariots "before Barak." *Judges 4:15–16*
6. **Found Sisera dead.** Jael showed him the man he was chasing, already slain. *Judges 4:22*
7. **Sang God's praise.** The song calls, "arise, Barak, and lead thy captivity captive, thou son of Abinoam." *Judges 5:1, 12*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Barak.

Old Testament

Judges 4:6–24	The main account of his call and battle
Judges 5:1, 12, 15	He sings with Deborah; the song names him
1 Samuel 12:11	"Bedan"; Greek and Syriac read "Barak" (debated)
Psalm 83:9–10	The victory at the Kishon remembered in prayer
Echo: Exodus 33:15; Judges 6:36–40	Moses and Gideon also sought assurance
Echo: Ecclesiastes 4:9	"Two are better than one"

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–34	Named among those who "through faith subdued kingdoms"
Echo: Luke 10:1	Jesus sent his followers out in pairs

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What exact condition did Barak give Deborah, and what was her reply (Judges 4:8–9)?
2. *Understand:* Barak did not get the honour of killing Sisera, yet Hebrews honours his faith. What does that say about how God measures faith?
3. *Apply:* Barak wanted Deborah beside him. Whose presence or prayers help you obey God when you are afraid?
4. *Apply:* Barak had to leave the safety of Mount Tabor. What "high ground" might God be asking you to leave this week?

49 Jael

The Kenite woman who killed Sisera in her tent and fulfilled Deborah's word.

Jael was the wife of Heber the Kenite, a man from the clan of Moses' in-laws who had moved north and pitched his tent near Kedesh. Heber's household was at peace with Jabin king of Canaan. So when Jabin's general Sisera fled on foot from Barak's army, he ran to Jael's tent, expecting safety. She invited him in, covered him, and gave him milk when he asked for water. When he fell asleep, she drove a tent peg through his temples. Deborah had said that the LORD would sell Sisera into the hand of a woman, and Jael was that woman. Deborah's song calls her "blessed above women," though readers still wrestle with how she broke the rules of hospitality.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yael*, "mountain goat" or "wild goat"
Family	Wife of Heber the Kenite (Judges 4:17)
People	The Kenites, descended from Hobab, Moses' father-in-law (Judges 4:11)
When	In the days of Deborah and Barak. Any BC date is rough
Key places	Her tent near the plain of Zaanaim, by Kedesh (Judges 4:11)
Key people	Sisera, Barak, Deborah, Heber
Main passages	Judges 4:11, 17–22; 5:6, 24–27
New Testament	Not named

"Blessed above women shall Jael the wife of Heber the Kenite be, blessed shall she be above women in the tent."

Judges 5:24, KJV

The life of Jael

Judges gives no calendar dates. On the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC, but any single date for Jael is rough. Her whole story takes place in a single day.

Before the battle

Living near Kedesh

Heber has separated from the other Kenites and pitched his tent near Kedesh. His house is at peace with Jabin. *Judges 4:11, 17*

The day of the battle

Welcomes Sisera

Sisera flees on foot to her tent. She goes out to meet him and says, "Turn in, my lord, turn in to me; fear not." She covers him with a mantle. *Judges 4:17–18*

In the tent

Gives him milk

He asks for a little water, and she opens a bottle of milk and covers him again. He tells her to stand at the door and turn away anyone who asks. *Judges 4:19–20*

While he sleeps

Kills Sisera

She takes a tent peg and a hammer, goes softly to him, and drives the peg through his temples into the ground. *Judges 4:21*

When Barak arrives

Shows him Sisera

She goes out to meet Barak and says, "Come, and I will shew thee the man whom thou seekest." *Judges 4:22*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians have judged Jael in different ways. Some see her as a brave woman who sided with God's people at great risk. Others are troubled that she broke the customs of hospitality. The text itself praises her in Deborah's song and does not comment further.

1. **Went out to meet Sisera.** She took the first step and invited him in. *Judges 4:18*
2. **Covered him.** She hid him under a mantle in her tent. *Judges 4:18*
3. **Gave more than he asked.** "He asked water, and she gave him milk; she brought forth butter in a lordly dish." *Judges 5:25*
4. **Struck the enemy.** She "took a nail of the tent, and took an hammer in her hand," and killed him as he slept. *Judges 4:21; 5:26–27*
5. **Showed Barak.** She met the pursuing commander at her door and led him to Sisera's body. *Judges 4:22*
6. **Fulfilled prophecy.** Deborah had said, "the LORD shall sell Sisera into the hand of a woman." *Judges 4:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jael.

Old Testament

Judges 4:17–22	This is the main account.
Judges 5:6	Deborah's song dates hard times to "the days of Jael," when highways were empty.
Judges 5:24–27	The song blesses Jael and retells Sisera's death in poetry.
Echoes	Another woman ends a battle by striking a leader's head: at Thebez a woman drops a millstone on Abimelech (Judges 9:53). Some Christian readers link the crushing of the enemy's head with the promise in Genesis 3:15.

New Testament

Echoes	Elisabeth greets Mary with similar words: "Blessed art thou among women" (Luke 1:42). Hebrews 11:34 speaks of those who "out of weakness were made strong" and "turned to flight the armies of the aliens."

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Sisera ask for, and what did Jael give him (Judges 4:19; 5:25)?
2. *Understand:* Heber's house was at peace with Jabin. What might it have cost Jael to take Israel's side?
3. *Apply:* Jael acted with what was in her tent. What ordinary tools, skills or places has God given you to serve him?
4. *Apply:* Her story leaves hard questions. How can your group honour Scripture while talking honestly about passages that trouble you?

50 Gideon

The fearful farmer whom God called a mighty man of valour and used to rout Midian with three hundred men.

Gideon was threshing wheat in a winepress, hiding it from Midianite raiders, when the angel of the LORD greeted him as a "mighty man of valour." Gideon felt weak and asked many questions, and God answered with signs and patience. Gideon tore down his father's altar to Baal, gathered an army, and watched God cut it from thirty-two thousand men to three hundred. With trumpets, jars and torches they put the enemy to flight. He refused to be king, but a golden ephod he made became a snare.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Gid'on*, often explained as "hewer"
Other name	Jerubbaal, "let Baal plead" (Judges 6:32)
Family	Son of Joash the Abiezrite, of Manasseh (Judges 6:11, 15)
When	After Deborah; any BC date is rough
Key places	Ophrah, valley of Jezreel, well of Harod
Enemies	Oreb and Zeeb, Zebah and Zalmunna
Sons	Seventy, and Abimelech by a concubine (Judges 8:30–31)
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32 ("Gedeon")

"And the angel of the LORD appeared unto him, and said unto him, The LORD is with thee, thou mighty man of valour."

Judges 6:12, KJV

The life of Gideon

Judges gives no calendar dates; on the early chronology the judges span c. 1375–1050 BC. Any date for Gideon is rough.

Seven years

Midian oppresses Israel

Midianites and their allies invade each harvest, destroying crops and livestock. Israel hides in caves and cries to the LORD. *Judges 6:1–6*

At Ophrah

Called by God

The angel of the LORD finds Gideon threshing wheat. Gideon protests he is the least in his father's house; fire consumes his offering. *Judges 6:11–24*

That night

Tears down Baal's altar

He breaks down his father's altar to Baal. The townsmen want him killed, but Joash defends him. *Judges 6:25–32*

In the valley of Jezreel

Gathers an army

The Spirit of the LORD comes on Gideon, and he summons the tribes. He asks for signs with a fleece, and God gives them. *Judges 6:33–40*

At the well of Harod

Three hundred chosen

God reduces the army from thirty-two thousand to ten thousand, and then to three hundred men who lapped the water. *Judges 7:1–8*

At night

Midian is routed

After overhearing a Midianite's dream, Gideon attacks. His men blow trumpets, break jars and shout, and the enemy turns on itself. *Judges 7:9–22*

Across the Jordan

Pursues the kings

"Faint, yet pursuing," he captures and kills Zebah and Zalmunna, and punishes Succoth and Penuel. *Judges 7:23–8:21*

Forty years

Rest, ephod and death

He refuses the crown but makes an ephod that becomes a snare. The land is quiet forty years, and he dies "in a good old age." *Judges 8:22–32*

Key activities

Christians read the fleece in different ways. Some see it as weak faith that God kindly answered. Others see it as a sincere request for assurance. Scripture records it without comment, since God had already given Gideon his promise (Judges 6:14–16).

1. **Hid his harvest.** He threshed wheat in a winepress to keep it from the Midianites. *Judges 6:11*
2. **Questioned God.** He asked, "if the LORD be with us, why then is all this befallen us?" *Judges 6:13*
3. **Confessed his weakness.** "My family is poor in Manasseh, and I am the least in my father's house." *Judges 6:15*
4. **Built an altar.** He named it Jehovah-shalom, "the LORD is peace." *Judges 6:22–24*
5. **Obeyed by night.** Afraid of his family and the town, he tore down Baal's altar under cover of darkness. *Judges 6:25–27*
6. **Earned a new name.** His father said, "if he be a god, let him plead for himself," and called him Jerubbaal. *Judges 6:31–32*
7. **Sought signs.** He asked for dew on the fleece and then on the ground, and God did both. *Judges 6:36–40*
8. **Trusted God with fewer men.** God said too many soldiers would let Israel say, "Mine own hand hath saved me." *Judges 7:2–8*
9. **Led a night attack.** His men cried, "The sword of the LORD, and of Gideon." *Judges 7:16–22*
10. **Calmed Ephraim.** He answered their anger with humility, and "their anger was abated toward him." *Judges 8:1–3*
11. **Refused the crown.** "I will not rule over you, neither shall my son rule over you: the LORD shall rule over you." *Judges 8:22–23*
12. **Made a golden ephod.** He set it up in Ophrah, and "all Israel went thither a whoring after it." *Judges 8:24–27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Gideon.

Old Testament

Judges 6–8	The main account
Judges 8:33–9:57	After his death, Abimelech kills his brothers
1 Samuel 12:11	"Jerubbaal" among the deliverers God sent
2 Samuel 11:21	Called "Jerubbesheth," Baal replaced by "shame"
Psalm 83:9–12	Enemies like Oreb, Zeeb, Zebah and Zalmunna
Isaiah 9:4; 10:26	"The day of Midian" recalled as God's saving power

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–34	"Gedeon" first among judges made strong out of weakness
Echo: 2 Corinthians 12:9	"My strength is made perfect in weakness"
Echo: 2 Corinthians 4:7	Some link the broken jars to "earthen vessels"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did God reduce Gideon's army, and what reason did he give (Judges 7:2–7)?
2. *Understand:* God called Gideon a "mighty man of valour" while he was hiding. What does that show about how God sees people?
3. *Apply:* Gideon's first act of obedience was at home, at his father's altar. What needs to change close to home before you serve more widely?
4. *Apply:* Gideon's ephod turned a victory into a snare. What good gift or success could pull your heart away from God?

51 Abimelech

Gideon's son who killed his brothers to become king, and died under a millstone dropped by a woman.

Abimelech was a son of Gideon, the judge who had refused to be king, by a concubine from Shechem. After Gideon died, Abimelech won Shechem's backing, hired reckless men, and killed seventy of his brothers on one stone. Only the youngest, Jotham, escaped. Shechem made Abimelech king for three years. Jotham's fable of the trees and the bramble came true: Abimelech and Shechem turned on each other, and Abimelech died when a woman dropped a millstone on his head. Judges tells it as God repaying evil.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Avimelekh*, "my father is king"
Family	Son of Gideon by a concubine in Shechem (Judges 8:31)
When	Soon after Gideon's death; no firm date
Key places	Shechem, Ophrah, Mount Gerizim, Thebez
Key people	Jotham, Gaal son of Ebed, Zebul
Reign	Three years (Judges 9:22)
Not the same as	Abimelech king of Gerar (Genesis 20; 26)
New Testament	Not named

> *"Thus God rendered the wickedness of Abimelech, which he did unto his father, in slaying his seventy brethren: And all the evil of the men of Shechem did God render upon their heads: and upon them came the curse of Jotham the son of Jerubbaal."*
>
> Judges 9:56–57, KJV

The life of Abimelech

Judges gives no calendar dates; on the early date of the Exodus the judges run c. 1375–1050 BC.

In Gideon's lifetime

Born in Shechem

Gideon has seventy sons by many wives. A concubine in Shechem bears him another son, Abimelech. *Judges 8:22–23, 30–31*

After Gideon's death

Wins over Shechem

Abimelech asks Shechem: seventy rulers, or one who is "your bone and your flesh"? They side with him and give him seventy pieces of silver. *Judges 8:33–9:4*

At Ophrah

Kills his brothers

With hired men he kills his brothers "upon one stone." Jotham, the youngest, hides and survives. *Judges 9:4–5*

At Shechem

Made king

Shechem makes Abimelech king. From Mount Gerizim, Jotham tells his fable of the trees and the bramble, then flees. *Judges 9:6–21*

Three years on

Shechem turns

God sends an evil spirit between Abimelech and Shechem. Gaal son of Ebed boasts against him, and Zebul secretly warns Abimelech. *Judges 9:22–33*

The next days

Destroys Shechem

Abimelech takes the city and sows it with salt. About a thousand die when he burns the stronghold of the god Berith. *Judges 9:34–49*

At Thebez

Dies

A woman drops a piece of millstone on his head from a tower. He orders his armor-bearer to kill him, so no one will say a woman slew him. *Judges 9:50–55*

Key activities

Judges says Abimelech killed "threescore and ten" sons of Gideon, yet Jotham escaped, so many readers take seventy as a round figure. Judges never calls Abimelech a judge; his story works as a warning.

1. **Played on family ties.** He asked Shechem's leaders to choose one ruler from their own kin instead of seventy. *Judges 9:1–3*
2. **Paid with temple silver.** He hired "vain and light persons" with seventy pieces of silver from the house of Baal-berith. *Judges 9:4*
3. **Murdered his brothers.** He killed Gideon's sons on one stone at Ophrah, and only Jotham escaped by hiding. *Judges 9:5*
4. **Took the title of king.** Shechem crowned him, and he reigned over Israel three years. *Judges 9:6, 22*
5. **Crushed a revolt.** He set ambushes against Gaal's forces and drove them back, then took Shechem the next day. *Judges 9:34–45*
6. **Burned the tower of Shechem.** He cut boughs on Mount Zalmon, piled them against the stronghold and set it on fire. *Judges 9:46–49*
7. **Died by his own order.** Struck by a millstone at Thebez, he had his young armor-bearer thrust him through. *Judges 9:50–54*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abimelech.

Old Testament

Judges 8:29–9:57	This is the main account.
Judges 10:1	Tola arises "after Abimelech" to defend Israel.
2 Samuel 11:21	Joab expects David to recall how a woman on the wall killed Abimelech at Thebez. There Gideon is called Jerubbesheth.
Echoes	A similar fable of a thistle and a cedar appears in 2 Kings 14:9. "He that rolleth a stone, it will return upon him" (Proverbs 26:27).

New Testament

Echoes	"All they that take the sword shall perish with the sword" (Matthew 26:52). "Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap" (Galatians 6:7). Jesus teaches that the one who would be great must serve (Mark 10:42–45), the opposite of Abimelech's grab for power.

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Abimelech give the men of Shechem for choosing him (Judges 9:1–3)?
2. *Understand:* In Jotham's fable the useful trees would not leave their work to rule, but the bramble would. What was he saying about Abimelech?
3. *Apply:* Abimelech used family loyalty to get what he wanted. Where are you tempted to use people to get ahead?
4. *Apply:* Judges says God repaid both Abimelech and Shechem. Is there a wrong you need to leave in God's hands this week instead of paying it back yourself?

52 Jephthah

An outcast who became Gilead's deliverer, and whose rash vow ended in grief.

Jephthah was a warrior from Gilead, east of the Jordan. He was the son of a harlot, and his half-brothers drove him from home. He gathered a band of men in the land of Tob. Years later, when the Ammonites pressed Israel, the elders who had rejected him came asking for help. Jephthah became their head, argued Israel's case with the king of Ammon, and then won a great victory when the Spirit of the LORD came upon him. But before the battle he made a vow, and his only daughter was the first to come out to meet him. His story holds real faith and tragic rashness side by side. Hebrews still names him among the heroes of faith.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yiphtach,* usually explained as "he opens"
Family	Son of Gilead by a harlot; one daughter, his only child (Judges 11:1, 34)
When	The period of the judges, after Jair. No firm date
Judged	Six years (Judges 12:7)
Key places	Gilead, the land of Tob, Mizpeh of Gilead, the fords of the Jordan
Key people	The elders of Gilead, the king of Ammon, his daughter, the men of Ephraim
Main passages	Judges 10:6–12:7
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32

"Now Jephthah the Gileadite was a mighty man of valour, and he was the son of an harlot: and Gilead begat Jephthah."

Judges 11:1, KJV

The life of Jephthah

No calendar dates. Jephthah's "300 years" (Judges 11:26) is cited for the early Exodus date; others take it as a round number.

Before his call

Ammon oppresses Gilead

For eighteen years the Philistines and Ammonites oppress Israel. Israel cries out, puts away its idols, and serves the LORD again. *Judges 10:6–16*

Early life

Driven out

Gilead's sons by his wife thrust him out. He flees to the land of Tob, where "vain men" gather to him. *Judges 11:1–3*

Ammon attacks

Called home

The elders of Gilead ask him to be their captain. He agrees if he becomes their head, sealed before the LORD in Mizpeh. *Judges 11:4–11*

Before the battle

Argues Israel's case

He tells the king of Ammon that Israel took the land from the Amorites, and leaves the case to "the LORD the Judge." *Judges 11:12–28*

The campaign

Vows and wins

The Spirit of the LORD comes upon him. He vows that whatever comes out of his house to meet him will be the LORD's, offered as a burnt offering. He defeats Ammon across twenty cities. *Judges 11:29–33*

Coming home

His daughter meets him

His only child comes out with timbrels and dances. He tears his clothes. She asks for two months to mourn her virginity on the mountains, and then he does "according to his vow." *Judges 11:34–40*

Afterward

War with Ephraim

Ephraim complains that it was not called to fight. Jephthah's men hold the Jordan fords and test fugitives with the word "Shibboleth." He judges Israel six years, dies, and is buried in Gilead. *Judges 12:1–7*

Key activities

Readers differ on what Jephthah's vow meant for his daughter. Many believe he offered her as a burnt offering, a grave sin the law forbade; others believe he gave her to lifelong, unmarried service of the LORD, pointing to the stress on her virginity (Judges 11:37–39).

1. **Rose from rejection.** Thrust out by his brothers, he became leader of a band of men in Tob. *Judges 11:1–3*
2. **Made terms with the elders.** He agreed to fight only if Gilead made him head, and he spoke all his words before the LORD in Mizpeh. *Judges 11:4–11*
3. **Tried words before war.** He sent messengers to the king of Ammon and argued from Israel's history. *Judges 11:12–27*
4. **Trusted the Judge.** He left the dispute with "the LORD the Judge." *Judges 11:27*
5. **Led by the Spirit.** The Spirit of the LORD came upon him, and he passed through Gilead and Manasseh to meet Ammon. *Judges 11:29*
6. **Made a rash vow.** He promised God whatever first met him as a burnt offering if he gave victory. *Judges 11:30–31*
7. **Won the victory.** The LORD delivered Ammon into his hands, from Aroer to Minnith. *Judges 11:32–33*
8. **Kept his word in grief.** "I have opened my mouth unto the LORD, and I cannot go back." *Judges 11:35*
9. **Fought fellow Israelites.** When Ephraim threatened him, forty-two thousand Ephraimites fell at the Jordan. *Judges 12:1–6*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jephthah.

Old Testament

Judges 10:6–12:7	The main account
1 Samuel 12:11	Named among the deliverers God sent
Numbers 21:21–31; Deuteronomy 2:26–36	The history he retold to Ammon
Echo: Ecclesiastes 5:5	Better not to vow than to vow and not pay
Echo: Genesis 22:11–12	God stopped Abraham's hand over Isaac

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–33	Named among those who "through faith subdued kingdoms"
Echo: Matthew 5:33–37	Jesus warns against careless oaths
Echo: Matthew 21:42	"The stone which the builders rejected"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the elders of Gilead promise Jephthah, and where was it sealed (Judges 11:8–11)?
2. *Understand:* Jephthah had real faith (Hebrews 11:32), yet he made a rash vow. How can both be true of the same person?
3. *Apply:* Jephthah was rejected by his family and later called back. How might God use a hard part of your past?
4. *Apply:* Is there a promise you made quickly, to God or to someone else, that you need to think through or keep this week?

53 Samson

The Nazarite strongman whose great gifts were matched by great weakness, and who died defeating the Philistines.

Samson's birth was announced by the angel of the LORD to a childless woman of Dan. He was to be a Nazarite from the womb, and he would "begin to deliver Israel out of the hand of the Philistines." The Spirit of the LORD gave him astonishing strength: he tore a lion apart, killed a thousand men with a jawbone and carried off a city gate. Yet he was ruled by his appetites. Delilah drew out his secret, and he was blinded and imprisoned. In his death he prayed once more and brought down the house of Dagon.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Shimshon*, probably linked to *shemesh*, "sun"
Family	Son of Manoah of Zorah, of Dan (Judges 13:2)
When	During Philistine rule (Judges 13:1); no firm date
Key places	Zorah, Timnath, Lehi, Gaza, the valley of Sorek
Key people	Manoah and his wife, Delilah, the Philistine lords
Judged	Twenty years (Judges 15:20; 16:31)
Main passages	Judges 13–16
New Testament	Hebrews 11:32

"And Samson called unto the LORD, and said, O Lord GOD, remember me, I pray thee, and strengthen me, I pray thee, only this once, O God, that I may be at once avenged of the Philistines for my two eyes."

Judges 16:28, KJV

The life of Samson

No calendar dates. Many think Samson overlapped with Eli and Samuel, but the text does not say.

Before his birth

Announced by an angel

The angel tells Manoah's barren wife she will bear a Nazarite son. The boy grows, and the Spirit begins to move him. *Judges 13:2–25*

Young man

A wife from Timnath

He demands a Philistine wife and tears apart a lion. His bride betrays his riddle, and he kills thirty men at Ashkelon to pay the wager. *Judges 14:1–20*

Wheat harvest

Foxes and fire

With three hundred foxes and firebrands he burns the Philistines' grain. They burn his wife, and he strikes back "hip and thigh." *Judges 15:1–8*

At Lehi

The jawbone

Judah hands him over bound. The Spirit comes upon him, and he kills a thousand men with a jawbone of an ass. *Judges 15:9–20*

Later

Gaza and Delilah

He carries off Gaza's gates, then loves Delilah, who is paid to learn his secret. Shaved, he is blinded and set to grind in prison. *Judges 16:1–21*

His death

The house of Dagon

At a feast to Dagon, Samson prays for strength once more and pulls down the pillars, killing the lords and about three thousand people. *Judges 16:22–31*

Group notes

Key activities

A Nazarite (Numbers 6:1–21) took no wine or grapes, let no razor touch his head, and kept away from dead bodies. Samson's vow was lifelong and set by God before his birth. Readers differ on how far he broke it before his hair was cut.

1. **Set apart from birth.** He was to be a Nazarite to God from the womb, with no razor on his head. *Judges 13:5*
2. **Chose by sight.** He insisted on a Philistine wife because "she pleaseth me well." Judges adds that the LORD was seeking an occasion against the Philistines. *Judges 14:1–4*
3. **Tore a lion apart.** The Spirit came mightily upon him, and he rent a young lion with his bare hands, telling no one. *Judges 14:5–6*
4. **Took honey from the carcase.** He scooped honey from the lion's body and shared it with his parents without saying where it came from. *Judges 14:8–9*
5. **Told a riddle.** "Out of the eater came forth meat, and out of the strong came forth sweetness." *Judges 14:12–18*
6. **Paid his debt in blood.** He killed thirty men at Ashkelon and gave their garments to those who had answered the riddle. *Judges 14:19*
7. **Burned the harvest.** He used three hundred foxes and firebrands to burn Philistine fields, vineyards and olive groves. *Judges 15:3–5*
8. **Let his own people bind him.** He allowed three thousand men of Judah to tie him up and hand him over. *Judges 15:9–13*
9. **Struck with a jawbone.** He killed a thousand Philistines at Lehi, then cried to the LORD in his thirst. *Judges 15:14–19*
10. **Carried off Gaza's gates.** He lifted the city gate, posts and bar, and carried them to the top of a hill before Hebron. *Judges 16:1–3*
11. **Gave away his secret.** Worn down by Delilah, he "told her all his heart," and she had his head shaved. *Judges 16:15–19*
12. **Prayed and died.** Blind and captive, he asked God to remember him, then brought down Dagon's house. *Judges 16:28–30*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Samson.

Old Testament

Judges 13–16	The main account
Numbers 6:1–21	The Nazarite law that shaped his life
1 Samuel 12:11	Tradition: some Jewish readers take "Bedan" as Samson
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:11	Hannah vows no razor on her son's head
Echo: Genesis 18:9–14; 25:21	Barren Sarah and Rebekah given sons

New Testament

Hebrews 11:32–34	Among those who "out of weakness were made strong"
Echo: Luke 1:15	John the Baptist, to "drink neither wine nor strong drink"
Echo: Colossians 2:15	Many see Jesus, victorious through his death

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What instructions did the angel give Samson's mother (Judges 13:3–5)?
2. *Understand:* Samson's strength came from the Spirit, not his hair alone (Judges 14:6; 16:20). Why does it matter that "the LORD was departed from him"?
3. *Apply:* Samson often did what was right in his own eyes. Where do your feelings tend to overrule wisdom?
4. *Apply:* God answered Samson's last prayer after his great failure. What would it look like for you to turn back to God this week after a failure?

54 Delilah

The woman of Sorek who sold Samson's secret for Philistine silver.

Delilah lived in the valley of Sorek, and Samson loved her. She is the only woman in Samson's story whom Judges names. The lords of the Philistines each offered her eleven hundred pieces of silver to find out the secret of his great strength. Three times Samson lied to her, and three times she tested his answer while men waited in hiding. Then she pressed him day after day until he told her all his heart. While he slept on her knees, she had his hair shaved, and the Philistines took him. Scripture does not tell us her nation, her feelings for him, or what became of her. Her story is a sober lesson about betrayal and about playing with temptation.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Delilah*. Its meaning is uncertain
Home	The valley of Sorek (Judges 16:4)
Nation	Not stated; many assume a Philistine
When	Late in Samson's life; no firm date
Key people	Samson; the lords of the Philistines
Price	Eleven hundred pieces of silver from each lord (Judges 16:5)
Main passages	Judges 16:4–21
New Testament	Not named

> *"And she said unto him, How canst thou say, I love thee, when thine heart is not with me? thou hast mocked me these three times, and hast not told me wherein thy great strength lieth."*
>
> Judges 16:15, KJV

The life of Delilah

Judges gives no dates or ages for Delilah. The events below follow Judges 16 in order, and they may have taken place over days or weeks.

Late in Samson's life

Loved by Samson

After Samson escapes from Gaza, he loves a woman in the valley of Sorek whose name is Delilah. Judges says plainly that he loved her, but it never says that she loved him. *Judges 16:1–4*

The offer

Bribed by the lords

The lords of the Philistines come up to her. They ask her to entice him and learn where his great strength lies and how they may bind him. Each lord promises her eleven hundred pieces of silver. *Judges 16:5*

Three attempts

Three lies

Samson tells her to bind him with seven green withs, then with new ropes, then to weave his seven locks into the web. Each time she cries, "The Philistines be upon thee, Samson," and he breaks free. *Judges 16:6–14*

Day after day

Presses him

She accuses him of mocking her and asks how he can say he loves her. She presses him daily until "his soul was vexed unto death," and he tells her the truth about the razor. *Judges 16:15–17*

The last night

Betrays him

She sends for the lords, who come with the money. She makes him sleep on her knees and calls a man to shave his seven locks. The LORD has departed from Samson, and he is taken. *Judges 16:18–21*

Group notes

Key activities

Judges does not say whether Delilah loved Samson, whether she was a Philistine or an Israelite, or what happened to her after his capture. Later writers and artists have filled these gaps, but the text is silent.

1. **Accepted a bribe.** She agreed to the lords' offer to discover Samson's secret for money. *Judges 16:5*
2. **Tested his answers.** Three times she bound him as he described, with men lying in wait in the chamber. *Judges 16:6–14*
3. **Used his love as leverage.** "How canst thou say, I love thee, when thine heart is not with me?" *Judges 16:15*
4. **Wore him down.** She pressed him daily with her words until he gave in. *Judges 16:16–17*
5. **Knew when he told the truth.** She saw that he had told her all his heart and called the lords to come up "this once." *Judges 16:18*
6. **Handed him over.** She had his hair shaved while he slept and began to afflict him, and his strength went from him. *Judges 16:19–21*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Delilah.

Old Testament

Judges 16:4–21	This is the whole account.
Echoes	Samson's first wife was also pressed to get a secret from him for the Philistines (Judges 14:15–17). Proverbs warns of flattering words that lead a young man astray (Proverbs 7:21–23). Joseph refused temptation and fled (Genesis 39:7–12).

New Testament

Echoes	Judas Iscariot agrees to betray Jesus for money: "What will ye give me, and I will deliver him unto you?" (Matthew 26:14–16). "The love of money is the root of all evil" (1 Timothy 6:10).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How many times did Delilah try to learn Samson's secret, and what did she say each time (Judges 16:6–20)?
2. *Understand:* Samson saw the traps each time and still stayed. Why do you think he did?
3. *Apply:* Delilah wore Samson down little by little. What pressure in your life is slowly wearing you down?
4. *Apply:* Delilah traded a relationship for money. What would help you put people ahead of gain this week?

Group notes

55 Naomi

The widow who went out full, came home empty, and lived to hold her grandson in her arms.

Naomi of Bethlehem left home in a famine with her husband Elimelech and their two sons. In Moab her husband died, her sons married Moabite women, and then both sons died too. Naomi came home a grieving widow and asked to be called Mara, "bitter." Yet her daughter-in-law Ruth refused to leave her. As Ruth gleaned in Boaz's fields, Naomi saw God's kindness again and guided Ruth toward marriage with this kinsman. The book ends with Naomi holding Obed, the grandfather of King David.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Naomi*, "pleasant"; later *Mara*, "bitter" (Ruth 1:20)
Family	Wife of Elimelech; mother of Mahlon and Chilion (Ruth 1:2)
When	"When the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1); no firm date
Key places	Bethlehem-judah, the country of Moab
Key people	Ruth, Orpah, Boaz, the women of Bethlehem
Grandson	Obed, grandfather of David (Ruth 4:16–17)
Main passages	Ruth 1–4
New Testament	Not named

"And the women said unto Naomi, Blessed be the LORD, which hath not left thee this day without a kinsman, that his name may be famous in Israel."

Ruth 4:14, KJV

The life of Naomi

No calendar date. Boaz as David's great-grandfather may point to the later judges, though the list may skip generations.

In a famine

Leaves Bethlehem

In a famine Elimelech takes Naomi and their sons Mahlon and Chilion from Bethlehem-judah to live in Moab. *Ruth 1:1–2*

About ten years in Moab

Loses her family

Elimelech dies. The sons marry Orpah and Ruth, and after about ten years both sons die. *Ruth 1:3–5*

On the road

Turns for home

Hearing that the LORD has given his people bread, she sets out for Judah. Orpah goes back, but Ruth clings to her. *Ruth 1:6–18*

Barley harvest

Asks to be called Mara

All Bethlehem is stirred. She tells the women she went out full, and the LORD has brought her home empty. *Ruth 1:19–22*

That evening

Sees God's kindness

Ruth comes home from Boaz's field with an ephah of barley. Naomi blesses the LORD, who "hath not left off his kindness," and explains that Boaz is a near kinsman. *Ruth 2:17–23*

End of harvest

Plans for Ruth's rest

Naomi sends Ruth to the threshing floor to ask Boaz, their kinsman, to take her under his care. *Ruth 3:1–5, 16–18*

Later

Holds her grandson

Boaz redeems Elimelech's land and marries Ruth. When Obed is born, Naomi lays the child in her bosom and becomes his nurse. *Ruth 4:9–17*

Key activities

Ruth 1:1 says "Bethlehem-judah" to set this Bethlehem apart from another in Zebulun (Joshua 19:15). Some readers see the move to Moab as a lapse of faith. The book itself does not judge it.

1. **Moved her family to survive.** She went with Elimelech to Moab when famine struck. *Ruth 1:1–2*
2. **Blessed her daughters-in-law.** She prayed that the LORD would deal kindly with them and give them rest in new homes. *Ruth 1:8–9*
3. **Spoke her grief honestly.** She said "the hand of the LORD is gone out against me," and asked to be called Mara. *Ruth 1:13, 20–21*
4. **Came home.** She returned to Bethlehem because the LORD had visited his people with bread. *Ruth 1:6, 22*
5. **Recognized God's hand.** When she heard of Boaz, she praised the LORD's kindness "to the living and to the dead." *Ruth 2:19–20*
6. **Sought Ruth's future.** She planned for Ruth to find rest and a home with Boaz. *Ruth 3:1–4*
7. **Waited wisely.** "Sit still, my daughter, until thou know how the matter will fall." *Ruth 3:18*
8. **Nursed Obed.** She cared for Ruth's son, and the neighbor women said, "There is a son born to Naomi." *Ruth 4:16–17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Naomi.

Old Testament

Ruth 1–4	Naomi appears throughout the book.
Echoes	Job also refused to hide his pain: "I will complain in the bitterness of my soul" (Job 7:11). "Weeping may endure for a night, but joy cometh in the morning" (Psalm 30:5).

New Testament

Echoes	Her grandson Obed appears in Jesus' family line (Matthew 1:5; Luke 3:32). Jesus meets a grieving widow at Nain and gives her son back to her (Luke 7:11–15). "All things work together for good to them that love God" (Romans 8:28).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Naomi say to the women of Bethlehem when she came home (Ruth 1:20–21)?
2. *Understand:* Naomi said God had afflicted her, yet she still prayed for and blessed others. What does that show about honest faith?
3. *Apply:* Naomi said she came home "empty," but Ruth was beside her. Who has God placed beside you in a hard season?
4. *Apply:* Naomi helped plan Ruth's future. Whom could you encourage or help toward a good future this week?

Group notes

56 Ruth

The foreign widow whose loyalty placed her in the family line of King David.

Ruth was a Moabite, an outsider to Israel, who lost her husband and had every reason to go home. Instead she bound herself to her bitter, grieving mother-in-law and to Naomi's God. In the fields of Bethlehem her quiet faithfulness met the kindness of Boaz, a kinsman who redeemed the family's land and married her. Her son became the grandfather of David.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Rut*; meaning uncertain, perhaps "friend"
People	A Moabite, from the country east of the Dead Sea
When	c. 1100 BC, "when the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1)
Family	Widow of Mahlon; later wife of Boaz (Ruth 4:10, 13)
Descendants	Son Obed; great-grandson King David (Ruth 4:17)
Key places	Moab, Bethlehem, Boaz's field, the city gate
Main passage	The Book of Ruth, chapters 1–4
New Testament	Named in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:5)

"Intreat me not to leave thee, or to return from following after thee: for whither thou goest, I will go … thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God."

Ruth 1:16, KJV

The life of Ruth

The book gives places and seasons rather than exact years. The date is approximate.

c. 1100 BC
Days of the judges

Famine drives a family to Moab

Elimelech of Bethlehem moves to Moab with his wife Naomi and their sons Mahlon and Chilion. *Ruth 1:1–2*

In Moab
About 10 years

Marriage and loss

Ruth marries Mahlon; Orpah marries Chilion. Elimelech dies, then both sons, leaving three widows. *Ruth 1:3–5; 4:10*

On the road

The great choice

Naomi urges both daughters-in-law to go home. Orpah kisses her and returns; Ruth clings to Naomi and vows to stay. *Ruth 1:6–18*

Bethlehem
Barley harvest

Arrival

The town stirs at their return. Naomi asks to be called Mara, "bitter," for the Almighty has dealt bitterly with her. *Ruth 1:19–22*

Boaz's field
Barley and wheat harvests

Gleaning

Ruth gleans behind the reapers. Boaz, a relative of Elimelech, protects her and lets extra grain fall for her. *Ruth 2:1–23*

Threshing floor
End of harvest

A request at midnight

On Naomi's advice Ruth lies at Boaz's feet and asks him to spread his covering over her as near kinsman. *Ruth 3:1–18*

City gate
The next day

Redeemed

A nearer kinsman declines. Boaz buys Elimelech's land before the elders and takes Ruth as his wife. *Ruth 4:1–12*

Bethlehem
Later

A son for Naomi

Ruth bears Obed. The women bless Naomi; Obed becomes the father of Jesse, the father of David. *Ruth 4:13–22*

Key activities

What Ruth did, in the order the book tells it.

1. **Married into an Israelite family.** As a Moabite she joined a family from Bethlehem living in her country. *Ruth 1:4; 4:10*
2. **Stayed when she could have left.** Orpah went back to her people; Ruth clung to Naomi. *Ruth 1:14*
3. **Chose Naomi's God.** She vowed to share Naomi's people, her God, and even her grave. *Ruth 1:16–17*
4. **Took the initiative to provide.** She asked to glean in the fields so the two widows could eat. *Ruth 2:2*
5. **Worked from morning to evening.** The overseer noticed she had barely rested since dawn. *Ruth 2:7, 17*
6. **Answered kindness with humility.** She bowed before Boaz and asked why a foreigner had found favour. *Ruth 2:10, 13*
7. **Shared what she was given.** She brought home her grain and saved food from her meal for Naomi. *Ruth 2:14, 18*
8. **Trusted Naomi's counsel.** "All that thou sayest unto me I will do." *Ruth 3:5*
9. **Asked Boaz to redeem.** She appealed to his role as near kinsman, and he called her a virtuous woman. *Ruth 3:9–11*
10. **Became a mother in David's line.** Her son Obed was the grandfather of Israel's greatest king. *Ruth 4:13, 17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Ruth.

Old Testament

Ruth 1–4	The whole of her story
Genesis 19:36–37	Where the Moabites came from
Deuteronomy 23:3	Moabites barred from Israel's assembly
Leviticus 19:9–10	The gleaning law that fed her
Deut 25:5–10; Lev 25:25	Kinsman duties and redeeming land
1 Chronicles 2:11–15	Boaz to David; Ruth is not named

New Testament

Matthew 1:5	One of four women named in Jesus' line
Luke 3:32	Boaz and Obed appear; Ruth does not
Echo: Ephesians 2:12–19	Outsiders brought near and made fellow citizens
Echo: Galatians 4:4–5	Christ as the one who redeems

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Naomi give for sending her daughters-in-law home (Ruth 1:8–13)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Ruth stayed when Orpah, just as loving, went back?
3. *Apply:* Ruth's faith showed up as hard work and loyalty. Where could yours show up that way this week?
4. *Apply:* Who is an "outsider" in your church or neighbourhood you could welcome as Boaz welcomed Ruth?

57 Boaz

The generous landowner of Bethlehem who became Ruth's kinsman-redeemer.

Boaz was "a mighty man of wealth" in Bethlehem and a relative of Naomi's late husband, Elimelech. When the Moabite widow Ruth came to glean in his field, he protected her, fed her and quietly left extra grain for her. When she came to him at night on the threshing floor, he treated her with honor and promised to act. At the city gate he settled the matter before the elders, bought Elimelech's land and married Ruth. Their son Obed became King David's grandfather.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Boaz*, often explained as "in him is strength"
Family	Son of Salmon; husband of Ruth; father of Obed (Ruth 4:21)
Described as	"A mighty man of wealth, of the family of Elimelech" (Ruth 2:1)
When	"When the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1); no firm date
Key places	Bethlehem, his barley field, the threshing floor, the city gate
Key people	Ruth, Naomi, the nearer kinsman, the elders
Descendants	Great-grandfather of David (Ruth 4:21–22)
New Testament	Matthew 1:5; Luke 3:32 (as "Booz")

> *"The LORD recompense thy work, and a full reward be given thee of the LORD God of Israel, under whose wings thou art come to trust."*
>
> Ruth 2:12, KJV

The life of Boaz

Ruth gives no calendar date. Matthew 1:5 names Boaz's mother as Rachab, usually taken to be Rahab of Jericho. If so, Boaz lived early in the judges' period, and the family list from Boaz to David may skip generations.

Barley harvest

Meets Ruth

Boaz comes from Bethlehem and greets his reapers, "The LORD be with you." He asks about the young woman gleaning and learns she is the Moabitess who came back with Naomi. *Ruth 2:1–7*

That day

Shows her kindness

He tells Ruth to stay in his field and orders the young men not to touch her. He invites her to eat with the reapers, and he tells them to let fall handfuls of grain on purpose for her. *Ruth 2:8–16*

At the threshing floor

Makes a promise

Waking at midnight, he finds Ruth at his feet. He blesses her kindness and promises to act, but notes that a nearer kinsman comes first. He sends her home with six measures of barley. *Ruth 3:7–15*

At the gate

Redeems the land

Before ten elders he offers the nearer kinsman Elimelech's land. When the man learns he must also marry Ruth, he declines and draws off his shoe. Boaz buys the land and takes Ruth as his wife. *Ruth 4:1–10*

Afterward

Father of Obed

The elders bless him, praying that his house will be like the house of Pharez. Ruth bears a son, Obed, who becomes the father of Jesse and the grandfather of David. *Ruth 4:11–17*

Group notes

Key activities

A "kinsman" (Hebrew go'el, often called a kinsman-redeemer) was a close relative who could buy back family land or rescue a relative in need (Leviticus 25:25). Ruth 4 also draws on the custom of raising up a dead man's name through his widow (Deuteronomy 25:5–10), though Boaz was not a brother-in-law.

1. **Blessed his workers.** He greeted his reapers with "The LORD be with you," and they blessed him in return. *Ruth 2:4*
2. **Noticed the outsider.** He asked about Ruth and learned of her loyalty to Naomi. *Ruth 2:5–11*
3. **Protected her.** He told her to stay with his young women and ordered the young men not to touch her. *Ruth 2:8–9*
4. **Prayed for her.** He asked the LORD to reward her, "under whose wings thou art come to trust." *Ruth 2:12*
5. **Gave more than required.** He let her glean among the sheaves and had handfuls dropped on purpose for her. *Ruth 2:15–16*
6. **Acted with honor at night.** He guarded Ruth's good name and sent her home before anyone could recognize her. *Ruth 3:10–14*
7. **Did things in order.** He gave the nearer kinsman the first right before acting himself. *Ruth 3:12–13; 4:1–4*
8. **Redeemed publicly.** Before elders and people he bought the land and took Ruth, "to raise up the name of the dead." *Ruth 4:9–10*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Boaz.

Old Testament

Ruth 2–4	This is the main account.
Ruth 4:18–22	and **1 Chronicles 2:11–12.** Boaz is listed between Salmon (Salma) and Obed.
1 Kings 7:21	and **2 Chronicles 3:17.** One of the bronze pillars at Solomon's temple was named Boaz. Scripture does not say whether it was named after him.
Echoes	The laws of gleaning (Leviticus 19:9–10) and of redeeming land (Leviticus 25:25) come to life in his field and at his gate.

New Testament

Matthew 1:5	"Salmon begat Booz of Rachab; and Booz begat Obed of Ruth."
Luke 3:32	Booz appears in Luke's genealogy of Jesus.
Echoes	Many Christians see Boaz as a picture of Christ the Redeemer, "who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity" (Titus 2:14).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Boaz tell his young men to do for Ruth (Ruth 2:8–9, 15–16)?
2. *Understand:* Boaz could have married Ruth quietly. Why do you think he gave the nearer kinsman the first chance?
3. *Apply:* Boaz went beyond what the law required. Where could you be generous beyond what is expected this week?
4. *Apply:* Boaz greeted his workers with a blessing. How do you speak to the people who work for you or with you?

58 Eli

The aging priest of Shiloh who trained Samuel but would not restrain his own sons.

Eli was the priest at Shiloh, where the ark of God stood in the last days of the judges, and he judged Israel forty years. He blessed a weeping Hannah, raised her son Samuel, and taught the boy to answer God's call. But his own sons, Hophni and Phinehas, were corrupt priests who treated the LORD's offerings with contempt, and Eli only scolded them. God warned him twice that judgment would fall on his house. In one day the ark was captured, both sons were killed, and Eli fell and died. His life shows both humble faith and the cost of failing to act.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Eli*, possibly meaning "high" or "lifted up"
Office	Priest at Shiloh; judged Israel forty years (1 Samuel 1:9; 4:18)
Family	Sons Hophni and Phinehas; grandson Ichabod (1 Samuel 1:3; 4:21)
When	End of the judges, in Samuel's childhood; no firm date
Key places	Shiloh, Ebenezer and Aphek
Key people	Hannah, Samuel, Hophni and Phinehas, a man of God
Age at death	Ninety-eight (1 Samuel 4:15)
New Testament	Not named

"And Samuel told him every whit, and hid nothing from him. And he said, It is the LORD: let him do what seemeth him good."

1 Samuel 3:18, KJV

The life of Eli

Scripture gives no calendar dates for Eli. He died at 98 after judging Israel forty years. Samuel was born c. 1100 BC (a rough date), and Eli died some years later, while Samuel was still young.

At Shiloh

Blesses Hannah

Eli sits by a post of the temple of the LORD. He mistakes Hannah's silent prayer for drunkenness, then hears her story and blesses her: "the God of Israel grant thee thy petition." *1 Samuel 1:9–18*

Some years later

Receives Samuel

Hannah brings her weaned son to Shiloh and gives him to the LORD. The child ministers to the LORD before Eli, and each year Eli blesses Elkanah and Hannah when they come up to sacrifice. *1 Samuel 1:24–2:11, 19–21*

Very old

Rebukes his sons

Eli hears of his sons' greed with the sacrifices and their sin with the women who served at the tabernacle door. He warns them that no one can plead for a man who sins against the LORD, but they will not listen. *1 Samuel 2:12–17, 22–25*

A warning

The man of God

A prophet tells Eli that he honors his sons above God. Both sons will die on one day, and God will raise up a faithful priest who will do all that is in God's heart. *1 Samuel 2:27–36*

One night

Samuel's call

When the LORD calls Samuel three times, Eli perceives that it is God. He tells the boy to answer, "Speak, LORD; for thy servant heareth." In the morning he accepts God's word of judgment. *1 Samuel 3:1–18*

Age 98

Dies at the news

Israel loses to the Philistines, the ark is taken, and Hophni and Phinehas are killed. When Eli hears that the ark is taken, he falls backward from his seat, breaks his neck and dies. *1 Samuel 4:1–18*

Key activities

Scripture does not state Eli's ancestry. Many trace it to Aaron's son Ithamar, because a later priest in his line is counted among Ithamar's sons (1 Chronicles 24:3). The judgment on his house was fulfilled when Solomon removed Abiathar (1 Kings 2:27).

1. **Served at Shiloh.** He sat at the temple of the LORD as priest and judged Israel forty years. *1 Samuel 1:9; 4:18*
2. **Misjudged, then blessed.** He first thought Hannah was drunk, but he listened and sent her away in peace. *1 Samuel 1:12–17*
3. **Raised Samuel.** The boy ministered to the LORD under Eli's care. *1 Samuel 2:11, 18; 3:1*
4. **Rebuked too little.** He asked his sons, "Why do ye such things?" but did not stop them. *1 Samuel 2:23–25; 3:13*
5. **Honored his sons above God.** The man of God charged him with making himself fat on the best of Israel's offerings. *1 Samuel 2:29*
6. **Taught Samuel to listen.** He helped the boy recognize God's voice and respond. *1 Samuel 3:8–10*
7. **Accepted God's judgment.** He insisted that Samuel tell him everything, then said, "It is the LORD." *1 Samuel 3:17–18*
8. **Trembled for the ark.** He waited by the wayside, "for his heart trembled for the ark of God." *1 Samuel 4:13*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Eli.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 1–4	This is the main account.
1 Samuel 14:3	Eli's great-grandson Ahiah serves as priest in Saul's day.
1 Kings 2:27	Solomon removes Abiathar, fulfilling "the word of the LORD, which he spake concerning the house of Eli in Shiloh."
Psalm 78:60–64	and **Jeremiah 7:12–14.** God forsook the tabernacle at Shiloh, and "their priests fell by the sword."

New Testament

Echoes	"Whom the Lord loveth he chasteneth" (Hebrews 12:6). A church leader must be one who rules his own house well (1 Timothy 3:4–5).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Eli tell Samuel to say when the LORD called again (1 Samuel 3:9)?
2. *Understand:* Eli spoke to his sons but "restrained them not" (1 Samuel 3:13). What is the difference between rebuking and restraining?
3. *Apply:* Eli helped a young person learn to hear God. Whom could you encourage in faith this month?
4. *Apply:* Is there a wrong you have put up with because confronting it feels hard? What is one step you could take?

59 Hannah

The childless woman who poured out her soul to God and gave her son Samuel back to him.

Hannah was one of the two wives of Elkanah of Ephraim. Her rival, Peninnah, had children, but Hannah had none, and every year at Shiloh Peninnah provoked her until she wept. One year Hannah prayed in deep distress and vowed that if God gave her a son, she would give him to the LORD for life. Eli thought she was drunk, then blessed her. God remembered Hannah, and she bore Samuel. When he was weaned she left him at Shiloh and sang a song of praise later echoed in Mary's song.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Channah*, "grace" or "favor"
Family	Wife of Elkanah; mother of Samuel and five more (1 Samuel 2:21)
When	Late in the judges; Samuel born c. 1100 BC (rough)
Key places	Ramah in mount Ephraim; Shiloh
Key people	Elkanah, Peninnah, Eli, Samuel
Known for	Her prayer, her vow and her song (1 Samuel 1:10–11; 2:1–10)
Main passages	1 Samuel 1:1–2:21
New Testament	Not named; her song is echoed in Luke 1:46–55

"For this child I prayed; and the LORD hath given me my petition which I asked of him: Therefore also I have lent him to the LORD; as long as he liveth he shall be lent to the LORD. And he worshipped the LORD there."

1 Samuel 1:27–28, KJV

The life of Hannah

Dates are rough; the house chronology places Samuel's birth c. 1100 BC.

Year by year

Provoked at Shiloh

Elkanah loves Hannah, but Peninnah provokes her because the LORD has shut up her womb. Hannah weeps and will not eat. *1 Samuel 1:1–9*

At the temple

Prays and vows

In bitterness of soul she vows to give a son to the LORD for life. Eli thinks she is drunk, then blesses her. *1 Samuel 1:10–18*

c. 1100 BC
At Ramah

Samuel is born

She bears a son and names him Samuel, "Because I have asked him of the LORD." *1 Samuel 1:19–23*

After weaning

Gives Samuel to the LORD

She brings him to Shiloh and tells Eli, "For this child I prayed," lending him to the LORD. *1 Samuel 1:24–28*

That day

Sings her song

She rejoices in God's salvation: he humbles the proud, raises the poor, and will exalt his anointed. *1 Samuel 2:1–10*

Each year after

More children

She brings Samuel a little coat each year. The LORD visits her, and she bears three sons and two daughters. *1 Samuel 2:18–21*

Group notes

Key activities

Hannah speaks of God exalting "the horn of his anointed" (1 Samuel 2:10) before Israel has any king. Some read this as looking ahead to Israel's kings, others as pointing beyond them to the Messiah; many see both.

1. **Worshipped faithfully.** She went up to Shiloh year after year, even though the trip brought her pain. *1 Samuel 1:3–7*
2. **Endured provocation.** Peninnah "provoked her sore," yet Scripture records no reply from Hannah. *1 Samuel 1:6–7*
3. **Poured out her soul.** She brought her grief to God in prayer and tears. *1 Samuel 1:10, 15*
4. **Made a vow.** She promised to give her son to the LORD for life. *1 Samuel 1:11*
5. **Answered respectfully.** When Eli accused her, she explained herself gently and did not argue. *1 Samuel 1:14–16*
6. **Left her burden with God.** After Eli's blessing she ate, "and her countenance was no more sad." *1 Samuel 1:18*
7. **Named her son.** She called him Samuel as a reminder that she had asked him of the LORD. *1 Samuel 1:20*
8. **Kept her vow.** She weaned Samuel, then brought him to Shiloh and left him in the LORD's service. *1 Samuel 1:24–28*
9. **Sang God's praise.** "There is none holy as the LORD: for there is none beside thee." *1 Samuel 2:1–2*
10. **Cared from a distance.** Each year she made Samuel a little coat and brought it to him. *1 Samuel 2:19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Hannah.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 1:1–2:21	The main account
Echo: Genesis 21:1–2; 25:21; 30:22–24	Sarah, Rebekah, Rachel given children
Echo: Judges 13:2–3	Samson's mother, also once barren
Echo: Psalm 113:7–9	Lifting the poor; "the barren woman" made joyful

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:46–55	Mary's song follows the pattern of Hannah's
Echo: Luke 1:7, 13	Elizabeth, long childless, bears a promised son
Echo: Luke 2:36	Anna bears the Greek form of Hannah's name
Echo: 1 Peter 5:7	"Casting all your care upon him"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Hannah describe what she was doing when Eli thought she was drunk (1 Samuel 1:15–16)?
2. *Understand:* Hannah asked God for a son, then gave him back. What does that show about how she saw her gift?
3. *Apply:* Hannah took her deepest pain to God in honest prayer. What would it look like for you to pour out your soul to God this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there something God has given you, such as a child, a skill or your time, that you need to offer back to him?

60 Samuel

The last of the judges and a faithful prophet, who anointed Israel's first two kings.

Samuel was born in answer to his mother Hannah's prayer and grew up serving God at the tabernacle in Shiloh. As a boy he heard the LORD call him by name, and all Israel came to know him as a prophet. He called Israel away from idols and judged the nation all his life, traveling a yearly circuit of towns. When the people demanded a king, Samuel warned them and prayed, and then he anointed Saul. When Saul disobeyed, Samuel rebuked him, and later he anointed young David. Samuel bridged the time of the judges and the time of the kings. Scripture remembers him beside Moses as a man who prayed for his people.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Shemuel*; "asked of the LORD" (1 Samuel 1:20)
Family	Son of Elkanah and Hannah; sons Joel and Abiah (1 Samuel 1:19–20; 8:2)
When	Born c. 1100 BC (rough); died late in Saul's reign
Roles	Prophet, judge, and minister before the LORD (1 Samuel 2:18; 3:20; 7:15)
Key places	Ramah, Shiloh, Mizpeh, Bethel, Gilgal, Bethlehem
Key people	Hannah, Eli, Saul, David
Main passages	1 Samuel 1–25; 28
New Testament	Acts 3:24; 13:20; Hebrews 11:32

"And Samuel grew, and the LORD was with him, and did let none of his words fall to the ground."

1 Samuel 3:19, KJV

The life of Samuel

Dates are rough: Samuel born c. 1100 BC; Saul's reign c. 1050–1010 BC.

c. 1100 BC
Infancy

Asked of the LORD

Hannah's prayed-for son is brought to Eli at Shiloh and ministers before the LORD. *1 Samuel 1:20–28; 2:11, 18*

Childhood

Called by name

God calls Samuel by night. He answers, "Speak; for thy servant heareth," and receives a hard message about Eli's house. *1 Samuel 3:1–18*

Growing up

Known as a prophet

All Israel from Dan to Beersheba knows Samuel is established as a prophet of the LORD. *1 Samuel 3:19–4:1*

Twenty years on

Victory at Mizpeh

Samuel calls Israel to put away foreign gods. He prays, the LORD thunders against the Philistines, and he sets up Ebenezer. *1 Samuel 7:2–14*

All his life

Judges Israel

Each year he travels a circuit to Bethel, Gilgal and Mizpeh, then returns home to Ramah. *1 Samuel 7:15–17*

c. 1050 BC
Old age

Anoints Saul

His sons take bribes, and the elders ask for a king. Samuel warns them, then anoints Saul. *1 Samuel 8:1–10:25*

Saul's reign

Rebukes and grieves

He rebukes Saul for an unlawful sacrifice and for sparing Agag: "to obey is better than sacrifice." *1 Samuel 13:8–14; 15:1–35*

Late in Saul's reign

Anoints David and dies

He anoints Jesse's youngest son, David, and later shelters him at Ramah. All Israel mourns his death. *1 Samuel 16:1–13; 19:18–24; 25:1*

Key activities

After Samuel's death, Saul asks a medium at Endor to bring him up, and "Samuel" speaks to Saul (1 Samuel 28:3–20). Many Christians believe God truly allowed Samuel to appear; others think it was a deception or a spirit posing as him.

1. **Ministered from childhood.** As a boy he served before the LORD at Shiloh, girded with a linen ephod. *1 Samuel 2:18*
2. **Listened to God.** He answered God's call and told Eli the hard message in full. *1 Samuel 3:10–18*
3. **Called Israel to repent.** He urged them to put away Baalim and Ashtaroth and serve the LORD only. *1 Samuel 7:3–4*
4. **Prayed for the nation.** At Mizpeh he cried to the LORD for Israel, and the LORD heard him. *1 Samuel 7:5–10*
5. **Set up Ebenezer.** He named the stone, saying, "Hitherto hath the LORD helped us." *1 Samuel 7:12*
6. **Judged Israel all his life.** He rode a yearly circuit and built an altar at Ramah. *1 Samuel 7:15–17*
7. **Warned against a king.** He told the people how a king would take their sons, daughters, fields and flocks. *1 Samuel 8:10–18*
8. **Anointed Saul.** He poured oil on Saul's head and kissed him. *1 Samuel 10:1*
9. **Defended his integrity.** At Gilgal he asked whose ox or ass he had taken, and the people said he had defrauded no one. *1 Samuel 12:1–5*
10. **Kept praying.** "God forbid that I should sin against the LORD in ceasing to pray for you." *1 Samuel 12:23*
11. **Rebuked Saul.** He declared that God had rejected Saul as king because Saul had rejected God's word. *1 Samuel 15:22–28*
12. **Anointed David.** He learned that "the LORD looketh on the heart" and anointed Jesse's youngest son. *1 Samuel 16:6–13*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Samuel.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 1–25	The main account; his death in 25:1 and 28:3
1 Chronicles 6:27–28, 33	Listed among the Levites of Kohath
1 Chronicles 9:22; 29:29	"Samuel the seer" and his book
Psalm 99:6; Jeremiah 15:1	Named with Moses as one who prayed
2 Chronicles 35:18	No Passover like Josiah's since Samuel's days

New Testament

Acts 3:24; 13:20	"All the prophets from Samuel"; judges "until Samuel"
Hebrews 11:32	Named among the heroes of faith
Echo: Luke 2:52	Jesus grows in favour, as Samuel did (1 Samuel 2:26)
Tradition	The Talmud credits him with Judges and Ruth; Scripture does not say

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Samuel set up after the victory at Mizpeh, and what did he say (1 Samuel 7:12)?
2. *Understand:* Samuel warned against a king, yet anointed Saul and kept praying. What does that show about his heart?
3. *Apply:* Samuel said failing to pray for others would be sin (1 Samuel 12:23). Whom will you commit to pray for this week?
4. *Apply:* "The LORD looketh on the heart" (1 Samuel 16:7). Where do you judge by outward looks, and how could you look deeper?

61 Saul

Israel's first king, who began small in his own eyes and ended at war with God's word.

Saul was a tall, handsome young man from the small tribe of Benjamin. He went out looking for his father's lost donkeys and came home anointed as king. Israel had asked for "a king to judge us like all the nations" (1 Samuel 8:5), and Saul looked the part. He started well, rescuing a besieged town and fighting the Philistines all his days. But again and again he put his own plans above God's clear commands. He offered a sacrifice he was told to wait for. He spared what he was told to destroy. Then jealousy of David ate away at him. His story is a sober study in how a gifted leader can lose his way one small disobedience at a time.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Sha'ul*, "asked for"
Family	Son of Kish, of Benjamin; wife Ahinoam (1 Samuel 9:1; 14:50)
Children	Jonathan, Ish-bosheth and others; Merab, Michal (1 Samuel 14:49)
Reign	c. 1050–1010 BC; "forty years" (Acts 13:21)
Key places	Gibeah, Mizpeh, Gilgal, Jabesh-gilead, Endor, Mount Gilboa
Key people	Samuel, Jonathan, David, Michal, Abner his commander
New Testament	Acts 13:21–22

"Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams."

1 Samuel 15:22, KJV

The life of Saul

Dates are approximate. The Hebrew of 1 Samuel 13:1 is unclear, so Saul's age at his crowning is unknown.

c. 1050 BC
Young man

Anointed in secret

Looking for his father's lost donkeys, Saul meets Samuel, who anoints him with oil. *1 Samuel 9:1–10:16*

c. 1050 BC
Start of reign

Chosen by lot

At Mizpeh the lot falls on Saul. He is found hiding "among the stuff." *1 Samuel 10:17–27*

Early reign

Rescues Jabesh-gilead

Nahash the Ammonite threatens the town. The Spirit of God comes on Saul, and he rallies Israel to save it. *1 Samuel 11:1–15*

Early reign

Offers the sacrifice himself

Facing the Philistines, Saul tires of waiting for Samuel and offers the burnt offering himself. His kingdom will not continue. *1 Samuel 13:5–14*

Later

Spares Agag

Saul spares Agag and the best animals. Because he rejected the LORD's word, the LORD rejects him as king. *1 Samuel 15:1–35*

Middle years

David arrives

The Spirit leaves Saul, and an evil spirit troubles him. David plays the harp for him, kills Goliath, and wins the women's praise. *1 Samuel 16:14–18:9*

Last years

Hunts David

Saul throws his spear at David and chases him through the wilderness. Twice David spares Saul's life. *1 Samuel 18:10–26:25*

c. 1010 BC
End of reign

Endor and Gilboa

With God silent, Saul consults a medium at Endor. On Mount Gilboa his sons die, and he falls on his own sword. *1 Samuel 28:3–25; 31:1–13*

Key activities

1 Samuel 31 says Saul fell on his own sword. In 2 Samuel 1 an Amalekite claims he finished Saul off. Many readers think the Amalekite lied, hoping for a reward from David.

1. **Began humbly.** He called Benjamin the smallest tribe and hid when the lot fell on him. *1 Samuel 9:21; 10:21–22*
2. **Prophesied.** God gave him "another heart," and he prophesied among the prophets. *1 Samuel 10:9–12*
3. **Saved Jabesh-gilead.** He summoned the tribes, routed Ammon, and spared those who had mocked him. *1 Samuel 11:5–13*
4. **Ran ahead of God.** He offered the burnt offering instead of waiting for Samuel. *1 Samuel 13:8–14*
5. **Made a rash oath.** He forbade his army to eat and nearly put Jonathan to death. *1 Samuel 14:24–45*
6. **Fought Israel's enemies.** There was sore war with the Philistines all his days. *1 Samuel 14:47–52*
7. **Spared what God condemned.** He kept Agag and the best flocks, yet claimed he had obeyed. *1 Samuel 15:7–21*
8. **Fed his jealousy.** Saul "eyed David from that day and forward." *1 Samuel 18:6–11; 19:9–10*
9. **Killed the priests of Nob.** Doeg put to death eighty-five priests at his command. *1 Samuel 22:9–19*
10. **Admitted his wrong, briefly.** "I have played the fool, and have erred exceedingly." *1 Samuel 24:16–22; 26:21*
11. **Sought a medium.** He had banned mediums, but in fear he went to one at Endor. *1 Samuel 28:3–19*
12. **Died on Gilboa.** Wounded, he fell on his sword; Jabesh-gilead buried him. *1 Samuel 31:1–13*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Saul.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 8–31	The main account, from the request for a king to his death
2 Samuel 1:17–27	David's lament: "how are the mighty fallen!"
2 Samuel 21:1–14	Famine for his killing of the Gibeonites
1 Samuel 28:11–19	"Samuel" at Endor; Christians differ on what appeared
1 Chronicles 10:1–14	He died for unfaithfulness and consulting a medium
Echo: Deuteronomy 17:14–20	What Israel's king should be

New Testament

Acts 13:21–22	"Saul the son of Cis" reigned forty years, then removed
Echo: Philippians 3:5	Paul, also Saul, of the tribe of Benjamin
Echo: Luke 6:46	Calling Jesus "Lord" yet not doing what he says

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Saul give for offering the sacrifice and for sparing Agag (1 Samuel 13:11–12; 15:15, 20–21)?
2. *Understand:* Samuel said "to obey is better than sacrifice." Why might religious activity be easier than obedience?
3. *Apply:* Saul's jealousy began with a song about someone else's success. Whose success is hard for you to celebrate right now?
4. *Apply:* Saul acted under pressure instead of waiting. Where are you tempted to rush ahead of God this week?

62 Jonathan

The king's son who could have been jealous, and chose to be a friend.

Jonathan was Saul's son and in line for Israel's throne. He was a brave soldier who trusted God enough to attack a Philistine garrison with only his armor-bearer beside him. When David killed Goliath and won the people's love, Jonathan had every reason to see him as a rival. Instead he made a covenant of friendship with him, gave him his own robe and weapons, and defended him before his angry father. He stayed loyal to both father and friend, and died beside Saul in battle.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yehonatan*, "the LORD has given"
Family	Son of Saul and Ahinoam; sisters Merab and Michal (1 Samuel 14:49–50)
Son	Mephibosheth, or Merib-baal (2 Samuel 4:4; 1 Chronicles 8:34)
When	Saul's reign, c. 1050–1010 BC
Key places	Gibeah, Geba, Michmash, Ziph, Mount Gilboa
Key people	Saul, David, his armor-bearer, Mephibosheth
New Testament	Not named

"And it came to pass, when he had made an end of speaking unto Saul, that the soul of Jonathan was knit with the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as his own soul."

1 Samuel 18:1, KJV

The life of Jonathan

Dates are approximate; Scripture does not give Jonathan's age.

Early in Saul's reign

Strikes the garrison at Geba

Jonathan attacks a Philistine garrison at Geba, and the Philistines gather a vast army in reply. *1 Samuel 13:2–5*

Early in Saul's reign

Climbs to Michmash

With only his armor-bearer, he climbs to a Philistine outpost, and panic spreads through the camp. *1 Samuel 14:1–23*

The same day

Tastes the honey

Not knowing Saul's oath, he eats wild honey. The army rescues him from death. *1 Samuel 14:24–45*

After Goliath's defeat

Makes a covenant

He loves David as his own soul, makes a covenant with him, and gives him his robe and weapons. *1 Samuel 18:1–4*

Saul's rage grows

Defends David

He speaks well of David to Saul. Later Saul throws a spear at him, and Jonathan warns David with arrows. *1 Samuel 19:1–7; 20:1–42*

David in hiding

The last meeting

In the wilderness of Ziph he strengthens David in God and says David will be king. *1 Samuel 23:15–18*

c. 1010 BC

Dies on Mount Gilboa

The Philistines kill Jonathan and two brothers; Saul dies the same day. *1 Samuel 31:1–13*

Afterwards

Mourned and honored

David laments them in a song, and later shows kindness to Jonathan's son. *2 Samuel 1:17–27; 9:1–13; 21:12–14*

Key activities

Jonathan's love for David is a covenant friendship between two men pledged to each other before God. David's lament calls it "wonderful, passing the love of women" (2 Samuel 1:26), a way of speaking about the depth of their loyalty.

1. **Led the first blow.** He struck the Philistine garrison at Geba, opening the war for Israel's freedom. *1 Samuel 13:3*
2. **Trusted God against the odds.** He told his armor-bearer, "there is no restraint to the LORD to save by many or by few." *1 Samuel 14:6*
3. **Asked God for a sign.** He agreed that if the Philistines said "Come up," they would go, and took it as the LORD's answer. *1 Samuel 14:8–12*
4. **Spoke honestly about a bad order.** When he learned of the oath, he said, "My father hath troubled the land." *1 Samuel 14:27–30*
5. **Bound himself to David.** He made a covenant with David and gave him the robe and weapons of a king's son. *1 Samuel 18:1–4*
6. **Stood up for his friend.** He reminded Saul that David had risked his life and done Saul only good. *1 Samuel 19:1–7*
7. **Kept watch and sent a warning.** He tested his father's mood at the new moon feast and warned David with arrows shot in the field. *1 Samuel 20:18–42*
8. **Asked for kindness to his family.** He asked David to show kindness to his house for ever, and they swore, "The LORD be between me and thee, and between my seed and thy seed for ever." *1 Samuel 20:14–17, 42*
9. **Strengthened David in God.** In the wilderness he "strengthened his hand in God" and told him, "thou shalt be king over Israel, and I shall be next unto thee." *1 Samuel 23:16–17*
10. **Stayed by his father.** Though he knew David would be king, he fought beside Saul to the end. *1 Samuel 31:2*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jonathan.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 13–31	The main account of his life
2 Samuel 1:17–27	David's lament: "in their death they were not divided"
2 Samuel 4:4; 9:1–13	David cares for Mephibosheth "for Jonathan's sake"
2 Samuel 21:7, 12–14	David keeps his oath and buries Jonathan's bones
1 Chronicles 8:33–34; 10:2	His family and his death at Gilboa
Echo: Proverbs 17:17; 18:24	"A friend loveth at all times"

New Testament

Echo: John 15:13	Laying down one's life for one's friends
Echo: John 3:30	"He must increase, but I must decrease"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jonathan give David when they made their covenant, and what did those gifts mean (1 Samuel 18:3–4)?
2. *Understand:* Jonathan stayed loyal to both Saul and David. How did he manage two loyalties that pulled against each other?
3. *Apply:* Jonathan "strengthened his hand in God." Who needs that kind of visit or message from you this week?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone whose gifts or success could make you feel threatened? What would it look like to act as Jonathan did toward them?

63 Goliath

The giant of Gath who defied the armies of the living God, and fell to a shepherd's sling.

Goliath was the Philistine champion from Gath. A giant in heavy bronze armor, for forty days he dared Israel to send someone to fight him, and Saul's soldiers were terrified. Then David, a young shepherd bringing food to his brothers, heard the challenge and saw it differently. To him Goliath was not first a giant but a man who had defied the living God. Nearly all we know of Goliath is his size, his weapons and his boasting. In Scripture his fall shows what God can do through someone who trusts him.

At a glance

Name	*Goliath.* The meaning of the name is uncertain
From	Gath, one of the five chief Philistine cities (1 Samuel 17:4)
Height	"Six cubits and a span," about 9 ft 9 in; some copies read four (17:4)
Weapons	Bronze armor; a spear "like a weaver's beam" (1 Samuel 17:5–7)
Key place	The valley of Elah (1 Samuel 17:1–2)
Key people	David, Saul, Goliath's shield-bearer
New Testament	Not named

"Then said David to the Philistine, Thou comest to me with a sword, and with a spear, and with a shield: but I come to thee in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom thou hast defied."

1 Samuel 17:45, KJV

The life of Goliath

Scripture gives no dates or ages for Goliath. The battle took place in Saul's reign (c. 1050–1010 BC), while David was still a youth.

Before the battle

Champion of the Philistines

Goliath of Gath stands out as the Philistine champion. He is covered in bronze, his spearhead alone weighs six hundred shekels of iron, and a shield-bearer walks in front of him. *1 Samuel 17:4–7*

Forty days

Defies Israel

Morning and evening he calls across the valley: "choose you a man for you," and the loser's people will serve the winner's. Saul and all Israel are dismayed and greatly afraid. *1 Samuel 17:8–11, 16*

The fortieth day

Meets a shepherd

David arrives with food for his brothers and hears the challenge. When Goliath sees him coming with a staff and a sling, he despises him as a mere youth and curses him by his gods. *1 Samuel 17:20–44*

That day

Falls in the valley

David slings a single stone, which sinks into Goliath's forehead. He falls on his face, and David kills him with his own sword. The Philistines flee, and Israel chases them to Gath and Ekron. *1 Samuel 17:48–53*

Afterwards

His sword is kept

David takes Goliath's head to Jerusalem and his armor to his tent. Later his sword is kept wrapped in a cloth at Nob, and the priest gives it to David. *1 Samuel 17:54; 21:8–9*

Group notes

Key activities

1 Samuel 17:4 in the standard Hebrew text gives Goliath's height as six cubits and a span. The Dead Sea Scrolls copy of Samuel, the Greek Septuagint and the historian Josephus give four cubits and a span, about 6 feet 9 inches (about 2 meters). Either way, he was far taller than the men around him.

1. **Boasted in his armor.** He trusted his bronze armor, his great spear and his shield-bearer. *1 Samuel 17:5–7*
2. **Defied Israel for forty days.** He cried, "I defy the armies of Israel this day; give me a man, that we may fight together." *1 Samuel 17:10, 16*
3. **Paralyzed an army with fear.** When the men of Israel saw him, they fled and were sore afraid. *1 Samuel 17:11, 24*
4. **Despised the youth sent against him.** He asked, "Am I a dog, that thou comest to me with staves?" and cursed David by his gods. *1 Samuel 17:42–43*
5. **Threatened to feed David to the birds.** He promised to give David's flesh "unto the fowls of the air, and to the beasts of the field." *1 Samuel 17:44*
6. **Fell to one stone.** He fell on his face, and David, who had no sword in his hand, used Goliath's own. *1 Samuel 17:49–51*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Goliath.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 17	The main account
1 Samuel 21:9; 22:10	His sword kept at Nob and given to David
2 Samuel 21:19; 1 Chronicles 20:5	Elhanan and "the brother of Goliath"; copying debated
2 Samuel 21:15–22	David's men kill four other giants of Gath
Echo: Numbers 13:33	The spies felt like grasshoppers before giants
Echo: Psalm 20:7	"Some trust in chariots, and some in horses"

New Testament

Echo: 1 Corinthians 1:27	God chooses the weak to confound the mighty
Echo: Colossians 2:15	Christ "spoiled principalities and powers"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How is Goliath's armor described, and why so much detail (1 Samuel 17:4–7)?
2. *Understand:* David called Goliath one who "defied the armies of the living God" (1 Samuel 17:26, 36). How did that change the way he saw the fight?
3. *Apply:* Israel listened to Goliath's threats for forty days. What fear has been shouting at you for a long time?
4. *Apply:* David used the tools he had practiced with as a shepherd. What ordinary skill or experience might God use in the challenge in front of you?

64 David

Shepherd, giant-killer, king and psalm-writer, a man after God's own heart who fell hard and turned back to God.

David was the youngest son of Jesse of Bethlehem, a shepherd boy no one expected to be chosen. Samuel anointed him while Saul still reigned. David killed Goliath, then spent years on the run from Saul's jealousy. He became king over all Israel, made Jerusalem his capital, and received God's promise of a throne for ever. He also fell into adultery and murder, and his family suffered for it. Yet he confessed honestly and threw himself on God's mercy. The Messiah would be called "the son of David."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *David*, usually explained as "beloved"
Family	Youngest son of Jesse, of Judah; great-grandson of Ruth (Ruth 4:17)
Wives named	Michal, Abigail, Bathsheba and others (2 Samuel 3:2–5)
Reign	c. 1010–970 BC: 7½ years in Hebron, 33 in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 5:4–5)
Key places	Bethlehem, Elah, Adullam, Ziklag, Hebron, Jerusalem
Key people	Saul, Jonathan, Nathan, Bathsheba, Absalom, Solomon
Writings	73 psalms carry his name in their Hebrew titles
New Testament	Often; Jesus is "son of David" (Matthew 1:1)

"For the LORD seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart."

1 Samuel 16:7, KJV

The life of David

Dates are approximate. He was 30 when he became king and reigned 40 years (2 Samuel 5:4).

Youth

Anointed in Bethlehem

Samuel passes over Jesse's older sons and anoints the youngest. The Spirit of the LORD comes on David. *1 Samuel 16:1–23*

Youth

Faces Goliath

David hears Goliath's challenge and kills him with a sling in the name of the LORD. *1 Samuel 17:1–58*

Saul's last years

A hunted man

Saul's jealousy drives David from court. He hides in the wilderness, spares Saul twice, and settles at Ziklag. *1 Samuel 18–30*

c. 1010 BC
Age 30

King in Hebron

After Saul dies, the men of Judah anoint David king in Hebron. *2 Samuel 1:1–2:11; 5:4–5*

c. 1003 BC
Age 37

King in Jerusalem

All the tribes anoint David. He takes Zion, makes Jerusalem his capital, and brings up the ark. *2 Samuel 5:1–10; 6:1–19*

Middle of his reign

Sin and repentance

David takes Bathsheba and arranges Uriah's death. Nathan confronts him, and David confesses. *2 Samuel 11:1–12:25*

Later years

Absalom's revolt

Absalom seizes the throne and David flees. Absalom is killed, and David mourns him bitterly. *2 Samuel 13:1–19:8*

c. 970 BC
Age 70

Solomon crowned

When Adonijah grasps at the throne, David has Solomon anointed, charges him, and dies. *1 Kings 1:1–2:11*

Key activities

73 psalm titles include "of David"; some read authorship in every case, others "for" or "in the style of" David. The New Testament names him as speaker of several (Mark 12:36; Acts 2:25).

1. **Guarded the flock.** He fought off a lion and a bear, and trusted God against Goliath too. *1 Samuel 17:34–37*
2. **Defeated Goliath.** He came "in the name of the LORD of hosts." *1 Samuel 17:45–47*
3. **Made a covenant with Jonathan.** Saul's son became his closest friend and protector. *1 Samuel 18:1–4; 20:1–42*
4. **Spared the LORD's anointed.** Twice he had Saul at his mercy and refused to harm him. *1 Samuel 24:1–22; 26:1–25*
5. **Strengthened himself in God.** At burned Ziklag, "David encouraged himself in the LORD his God." *1 Samuel 30:1–20*
6. **Took Jerusalem and brought the ark.** He made Zion his capital and "danced before the LORD with all his might" as the ark came in. *2 Samuel 5:6–10; 6:12–15*
7. **Received God's covenant.** God promised to build David's house, a kingdom for ever. *2 Samuel 7:1–29*
8. **Showed kindness to Saul's family.** He brought Jonathan's lame son Mephibosheth to eat at the king's table. *2 Samuel 9:1–13*
9. **Fell and repented.** Confronted, he said, "I have sinned against the LORD." *2 Samuel 11–12; Psalm 51:10*
10. **Grieved for a rebel son.** He wept, "O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom!" *2 Samuel 18:33*
11. **Bought a place for the altar.** He refused to offer what "doth cost me nothing"; it became the temple site. *2 Samuel 24:1–25; 2 Chronicles 3:1*
12. **Prepared for the temple.** Not allowed to build it himself, he gathered materials and gave Solomon the plans. *1 Chronicles 22:1–19; 28:1–29:9*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names David.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 16 – 1 Kings 2; 1 Chronicles 11–29	The two main accounts
2 Samuel 23:1	"The sweet psalmist of Israel"; see Psalms 3 and 51
1 Kings 15:5	Right "save only in the matter of Uriah the Hittite"
Isaiah 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5	A king from "the stem of Jesse"

New Testament

Matthew 1:1	Jesus Christ, "the son of David"
Luke 1:32; 2:4, 11	"The throne of his father David"; born in David's city
Matthew 22:41–45	How can David's son be David's Lord?
Acts 13:22	"A man after mine own heart"
Revelation 22:16	"I am the root and the offspring of David"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God look at when he chose David, and what did everyone else look at (1 Samuel 16:6–13)?
2. *Understand:* David sinned terribly, yet was a man after God's own heart. What does that say about what God values?
3. *Apply:* David wrote honest prayers in both joy and failure. What would an honest prayer from you sound like this week?
4. *Apply:* David twice refused to take a shortcut to the throne. Where are you tempted to grab something before God's time?

65 Michal

Saul's daughter, who loved David, saved his life, and later despised him.

Michal, King Saul's younger daughter, loved David, and Saul used her love as a trap. When her father's men came to kill David, Michal let him down through a window and bought him time with a trick. But while David was a fugitive, Saul gave her to another man. Years later David demanded her back, and her second husband followed her weeping. When David danced before the ark, Michal looked down from a window and despised him. Bitterness had closed her heart to joy.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Mikhal*; meaning uncertain, often linked with Michael
Family	Younger daughter of Saul; sister of Merab and Jonathan (1 Samuel 14:49)
Husbands	David; then Phalti son of Laish (1 Samuel 18:27; 25:44)
When	Saul's reign and David's early reign, c. 1050–1000 BC
Key places	Gibeah, Gallim, Bahurim, Jerusalem
Key people	Saul, David, Jonathan, Phaltiel, Abner
Children	"No child unto the day of her death" (2 Samuel 6:23)
New Testament	Not named

> *"And as the ark of the LORD came into the city of David, Michal Saul's daughter looked through a window, and saw king David leaping and dancing before the LORD; and she despised him in her heart."*
>
> 2 Samuel 6:16, KJV

The life of Michal

Dates are approximate and rough (BC). Her story runs from Saul's court to the early years of David's reign in Jerusalem.

Saul's court

Loves David

"Michal Saul's daughter loved David," and Saul is pleased. He asks as a bride-price proof that David has killed a hundred Philistines, hoping David will die. David brings double, and they marry. *1 Samuel 18:20–28*

One night

Saves David's life

Saul sends men to watch David's house and kill him in the morning. Michal lets David down through a window, puts an image in his bed with goats' hair at its head, and says he is sick. *1 Samuel 19:11–17*

While David is a fugitive

Given to another man

With David on the run in the wilderness, Saul gives Michal as wife to another man, Phalti son of Laish, of Gallim. Scripture does not record what Michal thought of it. *1 Samuel 25:44*

David at Hebron

Taken back

When Abner offers to bring Israel over to David, David demands Michal's return. Ish-bosheth takes her from Phaltiel, who follows weeping as far as Bahurim until Abner sends him home. *2 Samuel 3:12–16*

In Jerusalem

Despises David

As the ark comes into the city, Michal sees David dancing and despises him. She mocks him when he comes home, and David answers her sharply. *2 Samuel 6:16, 20–23*

Group notes

Key activities

2 Samuel 21:8 in the KJV mentions "the five sons of Michal the daughter of Saul" brought up for Adriel. But 1 Samuel 18:19 says Merab married Adriel, and 2 Samuel 6:23 says Michal had no child. A few Hebrew manuscripts and some Greek copies read Merab in 21:8, and most modern translations follow them. Others explain "Michal" as the aunt who raised them.

1. **Loved David.** Scripture says twice that Michal loved David, and Saul saw it. *1 Samuel 18:20, 28*
2. **Chose her husband over her father.** She warned David, "If thou save not thy life to night, to morrow thou shalt be slain." *1 Samuel 19:11*
3. **Deceived Saul's men.** She helped David escape through a window and used an image in the bed to delay the soldiers. *1 Samuel 19:12–16*
4. **Lied to protect herself.** When Saul confronted her, she claimed David had threatened to kill her. *1 Samuel 19:17*
5. **Was passed between men.** She was given to Phalti and then taken back to David, with no word of her own recorded. *1 Samuel 25:44; 2 Samuel 3:13–16*
6. **Despised worship.** She scorned David's dancing: "How glorious was the king of Israel to day." David replied, "I will yet be more vile than thus." *2 Samuel 6:20–22*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Michal.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 14:49	She is named as Saul's younger daughter.
1 Samuel 18:20–28; 19:11–17; 25:44	Her marriage to David, her rescue of him, and her marriage to Phalti.
2 Samuel 3:13–16	She is returned to David.
2 Samuel 6:16–23	and **1 Chronicles 15:29.** She despises David's dancing before the ark.
2 Samuel 21:8	KJV names her; most read Merab (see key activities note)
Echo: Joshua 2:15	Rahab also let men down through a window
Echo: Psalm 150:4	"Praise him with the timbrel and dance"

New Testament

Echo: Mark 14:3–9	Jesus defends a woman criticized for her costly worship
Echo: Luke 15:25–32	The elder brother refuses to join the celebration

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Michal do for David in 1 Samuel 19, and what did she say to him in 2 Samuel 6?
2. *Understand:* What might have happened in Michal's heart between those two scenes?
3. *Apply:* Michal watched worship from a window. What keeps you at a distance from wholehearted worship?
4. *Apply:* Is there an old hurt that is making you critical of someone else's joy? What step toward healing could you take?

66 Abigail

The wise woman who stepped between an angry David and a bloodbath.

Abigail was the wife of Nabal, a rich and harsh sheep owner in Judah. David's men had protected Nabal's shepherds, but when David asked for food at shearing time, Nabal insulted him, and David set out with four hundred men to kill every male in the household. Without telling her husband, Abigail loaded donkeys with food, rode out to meet David, and bowed at his feet. Her humble, wise words turned him from revenge. After Nabal died, David married her. She shows how a gentle answer can turn away great harm.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Avigayil*, usually explained as "my father is joy"
Home	Maon, with Nabal's business in Carmel (1 Samuel 25:2)
Husbands	Nabal of the house of Caleb; later David (1 Samuel 25:3, 39–42)
Son	Chileab, or Daniel (2 Samuel 3:3; 1 Chronicles 3:1)
When	Saul's last years, before c. 1010 BC
Key people	Nabal, David, a young servant of Nabal
New Testament	Not named

"And blessed be thy advice, and blessed be thou, which hast kept me this day from coming to shed blood, and from avenging myself with mine own hand."

1 Samuel 25:33, KJV

The life of Abigail

Scripture gives no dates or ages for Abigail. These events happened after Samuel's death, while David was a fugitive from Saul (before c. 1010 BC).

Before the story

Married to Nabal

She is "of good understanding, and of a beautiful countenance." Her husband is rich, with three thousand sheep and a thousand goats, but "churlish and evil in his doings." *1 Samuel 25:2–3*

Sheep-shearing

Warned by a servant

Nabal refuses David's request and insults him. A young man tells Abigail that David's men had been "a wall unto us both by night and day," and that trouble is coming. *1 Samuel 25:4–17*

That day

Rides out to David

She loads donkeys with bread, wine, sheep, grain, raisins and figs. She meets David on the way, bows to the ground, and speaks for peace. David blesses God for sending her. *1 Samuel 25:18–35*

Ten days later

Widowed

When she tells Nabal the next morning, "his heart died within him." About ten days later the LORD strikes him, and he dies. *1 Samuel 25:36–38*

Soon after

Marries David

David hears that Nabal is dead and blesses the LORD. He sends servants to ask for Abigail as his wife. She bows, rises quickly, and goes with five maidens to become his wife. *1 Samuel 25:39–42*

At Ziklag and Hebron

Captured, rescued, settled

Amalekites carry her off from Ziklag, and David rescues her. Later she lives with David in Hebron, where she bears his son Chileab. *1 Samuel 30:1–18; 2 Samuel 2:2; 3:3*

Key activities

Abigail's speech (1 Samuel 25:24–31) is one of the longest speeches by a woman in the Old Testament. She takes the blame on herself, calls Nabal a fool, and speaks of the "sure house" God will give David.

1. **Listened to a servant.** When a young servant warned her, she took him seriously and acted at once. *1 Samuel 25:14–18*
2. **Acted quickly and generously.** She "made haste" and sent ahead two hundred loaves, five dressed sheep and other food. *1 Samuel 25:18–19*
3. **Humbled herself.** She fell at David's feet and said, "Upon me, my lord, upon me let this iniquity be." *1 Samuel 25:23–24*
4. **Told the truth about Nabal.** "As his name is, so is he; Nabal is his name, and folly is with him." *1 Samuel 25:25*
5. **Reminded David of God's plan.** She said the LORD would make David a sure house and that he should not carry the grief of needless bloodshed. *1 Samuel 25:28–31*
6. **Waited for the right time.** She did not speak to Nabal while he was drunk at his feast, but told him in the morning. *1 Samuel 25:36–37*
7. **Accepted a new life.** She answered David's proposal humbly and went with his servants. *1 Samuel 25:40–42*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abigail.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 25	The main account
1 Samuel 27:3; 30:5, 18	With David among the Philistines; rescued at Ziklag
2 Samuel 2:2; 3:3	At Hebron she bears Chileab
1 Chronicles 2:16–17	A different Abigail, David's sister
Echo: Proverbs 15:1	"A soft answer turneth away wrath"
Echo: Deuteronomy 32:35	"To me belongeth vengeance"

New Testament

Echo: Matthew 5:9	"Blessed are the peacemakers"
Echo: Romans 12:19	"Avenge not yourselves"
Echo: James 3:17	Wisdom from above is "peaceable, gentle"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Abigail do and say when she met David (1 Samuel 25:18–31)?
2. *Understand:* David was about to do something terrible. Why did Abigail's words work when Nabal's words had made things worse?
3. *Apply:* Abigail stepped into a conflict that was not her fault. Is there a conflict around you where you could be a peacemaker this week?
4. *Apply:* David thanked God for someone who stopped him. Who has the freedom to tell you when you are about to make a mistake?

67 Joab

David's fierce and loyal general, who won his battles and settled his scores with the sword.

Joab was David's nephew and commander of his army for most of his reign. He was brave, shrewd and fiercely loyal to David's kingdom. He captured Jerusalem's stronghold, led Israel against the Ammonites and Syrians, and told David hard truths. But Joab also did as he pleased. He murdered two rival commanders, Abner and Amasa, arranged Uriah's death at David's order, and killed Absalom against David's command. In the end he backed the wrong son for the throne, and Solomon had him executed. Joab shows that usefulness is not the same as obedience to God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yo'av*, usually explained as "the LORD is father"
Family	Son of Zeruiah, David's sister; brothers Abishai and Asahel (1 Chronicles 2:16)
Role	Commander of David's army (2 Samuel 8:16)
When	David's reign, c. 1010–970 BC; killed c. 970 BC
Key places	Gibeon, Hebron, Jerusalem, Rabbah, Abel of Beth-maachah
Key people	David, Abner, Uriah, Absalom, Amasa, Adonijah, Solomon
New Testament	Not named

"Be of good courage, and let us play the men for our people, and for the cities of our God: and the LORD do that which seemeth him good."

2 Samuel 10:12, KJV

The life of Joab

Dates are approximate (BC). Joab served through David's whole reign, c. 1010–970 BC, and was killed early in Solomon's reign.

c. 1010 BC — *David at Hebron*

Battle at Gibeon

Joab leads David's men against Abner and Saul's forces at the pool of Gibeon. His swift brother Asahel chases Abner, and Abner kills him. *2 Samuel 2:12–32*

David at Hebron

Murders Abner

Abner comes to make peace with David. Joab calls him aside in the gate of Hebron and kills him to avenge Asahel. David mourns Abner publicly. *2 Samuel 3:22–39*

c. 1003 BC

First up at Jerusalem

David promises that whoever first strikes the Jebusites will be chief. Joab goes up first and becomes commander of the army. *1 Chronicles 11:4–6; 2 Samuel 8:16*

Ammonite wars

Rabbah and Uriah

Joab besieges Rabbah. At David's written order, he sets Uriah where the fighting is fiercest, and Uriah is killed. Then he calls David to come and take the city. *2 Samuel 11:1–25; 12:26–29*

Absalom's revolt

Kills Absalom

Joab arranges Absalom's return from exile. Later, when Absalom rebels and is caught in an oak, Joab kills him despite David's order to deal gently with him. *2 Samuel 14:1–33; 18:1–17*

After the revolt

Kills Amasa

David makes Amasa commander in Joab's place. Joab greets Amasa as a brother and stabs him, then ends Sheba's revolt at Abel. *2 Samuel 19:13; 20:4–22*

c. 970 BC

Backs Adonijah and dies

Joab supports Adonijah's bid for the throne. When Solomon is crowned, Joab flees to the altar, and Benaiah kills him there at Solomon's command. *1 Kings 1:7; 2:28–34*

Key activities

David's last charge to Solomon about Joab named the killings of Abner and Amasa: he "shed the blood of war in peace" (1 Kings 2:5–6). Joab's victories in battle could not cover what he did in peacetime.

1. **Took Jerusalem's stronghold.** He led the attack on the Jebusites and became chief. *1 Chronicles 11:6*
2. **Avenged his brother.** He killed Abner "for the blood of Asahel his brother," leaving David to say, "these men the sons of Zeruiah be too hard for me." *2 Samuel 3:27, 39*
3. **Fought with faith and courage.** Facing Ammonites and Syrians on two sides, he divided the army with Abishai and trusted the outcome to the LORD. *2 Samuel 10:9–14*
4. **Carried out David's evil order.** He placed Uriah in the hottest battle and let him die. *2 Samuel 11:14–17*
5. **Worked to bring Absalom home.** He sent a wise woman from Tekoa to persuade David with a story. *2 Samuel 14:1–23*
6. **Killed the king's son.** He thrust three darts into Absalom as he hung in the oak. *2 Samuel 18:9–15*
7. **Rebuked a grieving king.** He told David his mourning was shaming the men who had saved his life. *2 Samuel 19:1–8*
8. **Warned against the census.** He asked why David wanted to number the people, but David overruled him. *2 Samuel 24:1–4*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joab.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 2–24	Joab's career under David
1 Kings 1:7; 2:5–6, 28–35	Backs Adonijah; executed by Solomon's command
1 Kings 11:15–16	Six months in Edom, cutting off every male
1 Chronicles 11:6; 19:8–15; 21:2–6	Jerusalem, his wars, the census
Echo: Proverbs 16:32	Ruling one's spirit is better than taking a city

New Testament

Echo: Matthew 26:52	"All they that take the sword shall perish with the sword"
Echo: James 1:20	"The wrath of man worketh not the righteousness of God"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* List the men Joab killed with his own hand (2 Samuel 3:27; 18:14; 20:10). What reason lay behind each?
2. *Understand:* Joab was loyal to David's kingdom but often disobeyed David. What is the difference between being useful and being faithful?
3. *Apply:* Joab carried out an order he knew was wrong. Where might you be asked to go along with something wrong at work or at home?
4. *Apply:* Joab settled his grudges himself. What grudge do you need to hand over to God this week?

68 Bathsheba

Taken by a king, grieved as a mother, and honored at last as the queen mother of Solomon.

Bathsheba was the wife of Uriah the Hittite, one of David's best soldiers. While Uriah was at war, King David saw her from his roof, sent for her, and committed adultery with her. When she was pregnant, David had her husband killed. Bathsheba mourned Uriah, became David's wife, and lost the baby. Scripture places the blame firmly on David. Yet God gave her another son, Solomon, and years later she stepped forward with Nathan to make sure Solomon became king. She is last seen honored at her son's right hand, and Matthew names her in Jesus' family line.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Bat-sheva*, "daughter of an oath" or "of seven"
Family	Daughter of Eliam, or Ammiel (2 Samuel 11:3; 1 Chronicles 3:5)
Husbands	Uriah the Hittite; then King David (2 Samuel 11:3, 27)
Sons	Shimea, Shobab, Nathan and Solomon (1 Chronicles 3:5)
When	David's reign and the start of Solomon's, c. 1000–970 BC (rough)
Key people	David, Uriah the Hittite, Nathan the prophet, Solomon, Adonijah
New Testament	Matthew 1:6, as "her that had been the wife of Urias"

"And the king rose up to meet her, and bowed himself unto her, and sat down on his throne, and caused a seat to be set for the king's mother; and she sat on his right hand."

1 Kings 2:19, KJV

The life of Bathsheba

Dates are approximate and rough (BC). The events of 2 Samuel 11–12 fall in the middle of David's reign in Jerusalem. The events of 1 Kings 1–2 date to c. 970 BC.

During the Ammonite war

Taken by the king

David stays home while the army is at war. From his roof he sees Bathsheba bathing, learns she is Uriah's wife, sends for her and commits adultery with her. She sends word: "I am with child." *2 Samuel 11:1–5*

Soon after

Widowed and remarried

Uriah is killed at Rabbah on David's secret orders. Bathsheba mourns her husband. When the mourning is over, David brings her to his house as his wife, and she bears a son. *2 Samuel 11:26–27*

Seven days of illness

Loses her child

After Nathan the prophet confronts David, the child falls sick. David fasts and prays, but on the seventh day the child dies. *2 Samuel 12:14–23*

Afterwards

Mother of Solomon

David comforts Bathsheba, and she bears another son, Solomon. "The LORD loved him," and through Nathan God names him Jedidiah, "beloved of the LORD." *2 Samuel 12:24–25*

c. 970 BC

Speaks up for Solomon

When Adonijah claims the throne, Nathan urges Bathsheba to remind David of his promise. She speaks to the king, and David swears that Solomon will reign. *1 Kings 1:11–31*

c. 970 BC

Queen mother

Solomon bows to her and seats her at his right hand. She brings Adonijah's request for Abishag, and Solomon sees in it a new bid for the throne. *1 Kings 2:13–25*

Key activities

Readers differ on how much choice Bathsheba had when the king sent for her. Some see her as sharing the guilt. Others stress that a subject could hardly refuse a king. The text itself lays the blame on David: "the thing that David had done displeased the LORD" (2 Samuel 11:27; see 12:7–9).

1. **Told David the truth.** When she found she was pregnant, she sent word to the king. *2 Samuel 11:5*
2. **Mourned her husband.** When she heard that Uriah was dead, she "mourned for her husband." *2 Samuel 11:26*
3. **Grieved her first child.** Her son born to David died as Nathan had said. *2 Samuel 12:14–19*
4. **Bore Solomon.** She became the mother of the son God loved and chose to build the temple. *2 Samuel 12:24–25; 1 Chronicles 22:9–10*
5. **Reminded the king of his promise.** She told David, "thou swarest by the LORD thy God unto thine handmaid" that Solomon would reign. *1 Kings 1:15–21*
6. **Served as queen mother.** She sat at Solomon's right hand and brought requests to him. *1 Kings 2:19–20*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Bathsheba.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 11–12	David's sin, her lost child, Solomon's birth
1 Kings 1:11–31; 2:13–25	Secures Solomon's throne; serves as queen mother
1 Chronicles 3:5	Called Bath-shua, daughter of Ammiel, mother of four
Psalm 51	Its title links it to Nathan's visit after Bath-sheba
Echo: Psalm 147:3	He heals the broken in heart

New Testament

Matthew 1:6	"Her that had been the wife of Urias," with Tamar, Rahab, Ruth
Luke 3:31	Luke traces Jesus' line through her son Nathan
Echo: Luke 1:52	God exalts them of low degree

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does 2 Samuel 11 describe what David did, and what does it say of Bathsheba?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Matthew calls her "her that had been the wife of Urias" instead of using her name?
3. *Apply:* Bathsheba lived through loss she did not choose. How can your group support someone carrying grief caused by another person's sin?
4. *Apply:* Years later Bathsheba spoke up at a key moment. Is there a situation where you need to speak up for what is right?

69 Uriah the Hittite

A foreign-born soldier who kept faith with Israel's army while Israel's king broke faith with him.

Uriah was a Hittite of foreign descent, yet he was listed among David's mighty men. His name means "the LORD is my light," probably a sign that he or his family worshipped Israel's God. While Uriah was fighting for David at Rabbah, David took his wife, Bathsheba. To hide it, the king called Uriah home and urged him to go to his house. Uriah refused comforts his fellow soldiers could not have. So David sent him back to the front carrying his own death warrant. Uriah's quiet integrity shines against the king's scheming, and Scripture never forgets it.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Uriyah*, "the LORD is my light"
People	A Hittite, in Canaan since Abraham's day (Genesis 23:10)
Wife	Bathsheba, daughter of Eliam (2 Samuel 11:3)
Rank	One of David's mighty men (2 Samuel 23:39)
When	Middle of David's reign, during the Ammonite war (rough)
Key people	David, Bathsheba, Joab
New Testament	Matthew 1:6, as "Urias"

"Because David did that which was right in the eyes of the LORD, and turned not aside from any thing that he commanded him all the days of his life, save only in the matter of Uriah the Hittite."

1 Kings 15:5, KJV

The life of Uriah the Hittite

Scripture gives no dates or ages for Uriah. These events fall in the middle of David's reign (c. 1010–970 BC), during the war with Ammon.

Earlier

A mighty man

Uriah the Hittite is listed among David's mighty men, his most honored warriors. He is married to Bathsheba, and his house in Jerusalem is within view of the palace roof. *2 Samuel 23:39; 11:2–3, 8*

Spring

At war

"At the time when kings go forth to battle," David sends Joab and the army to besiege Rabbah. Uriah goes with them, while David stays in Jerusalem. *2 Samuel 11:1*

Called home

Refuses his comforts

David calls Uriah back, asks about the war, and tells him to go home. Uriah sleeps at the palace door instead. The next night David gets him drunk, but he still will not go home. *2 Samuel 11:6–13*

The letter

Carries his own death warrant

David writes to Joab: put Uriah where the battle is hottest, then pull back from him. Uriah carries the sealed letter back to the camp himself. *2 Samuel 11:14–15*

At Rabbah

Killed in battle

Joab sends Uriah near the city wall. Some of David's soldiers fall, and "Uriah the Hittite died also." Joab sends word to David. *2 Samuel 11:16–25*

Group notes

Key activities

David's mighty men were a band of his best warriors, many of whom had been with him since his days as a fugitive. Uriah is the last name on the list in 2 Samuel 23, which ends, "Uriah the Hittite: thirty and seven in all."

1. **Served a foreign king faithfully.** Though a Hittite by descent, he fought among David's best soldiers. *2 Samuel 23:39; 1 Chronicles 11:41*
2. **Stood with his comrades.** He slept at the king's door, saying he would not go home to eat, drink and be with his wife while the ark and the army were in tents. *2 Samuel 11:9–11*
3. **Kept his word.** He swore, "as thou livest, and as thy soul liveth, I will not do this thing." *2 Samuel 11:11*
4. **Held firm when drunk.** Even when David made him drunk, he did not go down to his house. *2 Samuel 11:13*
5. **Obeyed the king to the end.** He carried David's letter to Joab and went where he was sent. *2 Samuel 11:14–17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Uriah.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 11	The main account
2 Samuel 12:9–10	Nathan: "thou hast killed Uriah the Hittite with the sword"
2 Samuel 23:39; 1 Chronicles 11:41	Listed among David's mighty men
1 Kings 15:5	David right "save only in the matter of Uriah"
Echo: Proverbs 28:6	The poor who walk uprightly are better than the perverse

New Testament

Matthew 1:6	Matthew keeps "Urias" in the family line of Jesus
Echo: 2 Timothy 2:3–4	A soldier of Christ endures hardness

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Uriah give for not going home (2 Samuel 11:11)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the writer lets Uriah, a foreigner, show more integrity than the king of Israel?
3. *Apply:* Uriah refused comforts his friends did not have. Where could you stand with people who are going through a hard time?
4. *Apply:* Uriah's goodness is remembered in Scripture even though he was wronged. When have you had to keep doing right while someone treated you unfairly?

70 Nathan the prophet

The prophet who brought David God's greatest promise and his hardest rebuke.

Nathan was a prophet at David's court in Jerusalem. Scripture shows him at three turning points in David's reign. First, he brought God's promise that David's house and throne would last for ever. Second, after David's sin with Bathsheba and the killing of Uriah, he told the king a story about a rich man who stole a poor man's only lamb, then said, "Thou art the man." Third, in David's old age, he made sure Solomon, not Adonijah, took the throne. He spoke God's word faithfully, in comfort and in rebuke.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Natan*, "he has given" or "gift"
Role	Prophet at the court of David and at the start of Solomon's reign
When	David's reign in Jerusalem to c. 970 BC
Key places	Jerusalem, the spring of Gihon
Key people	David, Bathsheba, Solomon, Zadok the priest, Adonijah
Writings	"The book of Nathan the prophet," not preserved (1 Chronicles 29:29)
Not the same as	Nathan son of David and Bathsheba (1 Chronicles 3:5; Luke 3:31)
New Testament	Not named

"And Nathan said to David, Thou art the man."

2 Samuel 12:7, KJV

The life of Nathan the prophet

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture gives no dates for Nathan's first two scenes. They fall in David's reign in Jerusalem (c. 1003–970 BC). The last scene is c. 970 BC.

David at rest in Jerusalem

Brings God's covenant

David wants to build a house for the ark. Nathan first says, "Go, do all that is in thine heart." That night God tells Nathan that David's son will build it, and God will build David a lasting house. *2 Samuel 7:1–17*

After Uriah's death

Confronts the king

God sends Nathan to David. He tells the story of the rich man and the poor man's lamb, then says, "Thou art the man." David confesses, and Nathan announces both forgiveness and consequences. *2 Samuel 12:1–15*

At Solomon's birth

Names the child

God sends word by Nathan, and through him the baby is named Jedidiah, "beloved of the LORD." The LORD loves the child. *2 Samuel 12:24–25*

c. 970 BC

Warns of Adonijah

Adonijah proclaims himself king and leaves Nathan out. Nathan tells Bathsheba to remind David of his promise, then comes in himself to confirm her words. *1 Kings 1:5–27*

c. 970 BC

Anoints Solomon

At David's command, Nathan and Zadok take Solomon on the king's mule to Gihon and anoint him king. The trumpet sounds, and the people shout, "God save king Solomon." *1 Kings 1:32–45*

Group notes

Key activities

2 Chronicles 29:25 says the temple music was arranged by command of David, Gad the seer and Nathan the prophet. 1 Kings 4:5 names two officials who were sons of a Nathan, but it is not certain which Nathan is meant.

1. **Brought back a changed message.** He first told David to go ahead with the temple. After God spoke to him that night, he returned with God's own answer. *2 Samuel 7:3–5*
2. **Delivered God's covenant.** He told David that God would raise up his son and establish his throne for ever. *2 Samuel 7:8–17*
3. **Told a story that opened a heart.** "The rich man had exceeding many flocks and herds: But the poor man had nothing, save one little ewe lamb." *2 Samuel 12:1–4*
4. **Named the sin plainly.** He said, "Thou art the man," and listed what God had given David and what David had done. *2 Samuel 12:7–12*
5. **Announced forgiveness.** When David said, "I have sinned against the LORD," Nathan replied, "The LORD also hath put away thy sin; thou shalt not die." *2 Samuel 12:13*
6. **Protected God's choice of king.** He planned with Bathsheba to warn David about Adonijah. *1 Kings 1:11–27*
7. **Anointed Solomon.** With Zadok the priest, he anointed Solomon at Gihon. *1 Kings 1:38–45*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Nathan.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 7:1–17; 1 Chronicles 17:1–15	God's covenant with David
2 Samuel 12:1–25	The parable, the rebuke and Solomon's naming
1 Kings 1:8–45	Nathan helps secure Solomon's throne
1 Chronicles 29:29; 2 Chronicles 9:29	His writings cited as sources
Psalm 51	Title: "when Nathan the prophet came unto him"
Echo: Proverbs 27:6	"Faithful are the wounds of a friend"

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:32–33	Jesus promised "the throne of his father David"
Echo: Matthew 18:15	Telling a brother his fault privately

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Nathan approach David in 2 Samuel 12:1–7, and how did David react before he knew the story was about him?
2. *Understand:* Nathan's first answer in 2 Samuel 7:3 was changed by God's word that night. What does it show that he went back to David with a different message?
3. *Apply:* Nathan loved David enough to confront him. Who in your life has that freedom, and do you give it to them?
4. *Apply:* Is there a hard but loving word you need to speak to someone? How could you say it wisely?

71 Mephibosheth

Jonathan's lame son, who was brought from hiding to eat at the king's table.

Mephibosheth was the son of Jonathan and grandson of King Saul. He was five when his father and grandfather died on Mount Gilboa. His nurse fled with him in panic, he fell, and he was lame in both feet for life. He grew up in hiding, with every reason to fear David, since a new king often wiped out the old king's family. Instead, David sought someone from Saul's house to show kindness to "for Jonathan's sake." He gave Mephibosheth back his land and a place at the royal table: a clear picture of grace, given because of a promise.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Mefiboshet*; also Merib-baal (1 Chronicles 8:34)
Family	Son of Jonathan; grandson of Saul; father of Micha
Disability	Lame in both feet from a fall at age five (2 Samuel 4:4)
When	Born c. 1015 BC; lived through David's reign
Key places	Lo-debar, Jerusalem
Key people	David, Jonathan, Ziba, Machir son of Ammiel
Not the same as	Saul's son by Rizpah (2 Samuel 21:8)
New Testament	Not named

"Fear not: for I will surely shew thee kindness for Jonathan thy father's sake … and thou shalt eat bread at my table continually."

2 Samuel 9:7, KJV

The life of Mephibosheth

Dates are approximate (BC). He was five when Saul and Jonathan died (c. 1010 BC), so he was born c. 1015 BC. Later events cannot be dated closely.

c. 1010 BC
Age 5

Lamed in the escape

Word comes from Jezreel that Saul and Jonathan are dead. His nurse picks him up and flees, but in her haste he falls and becomes lame. *2 Samuel 4:4*

Growing up

Hidden in Lo-debar

He lives in the house of Machir son of Ammiel, at Lo-debar east of the Jordan. By the time David finds him, he has a young son named Micha. *2 Samuel 9:4, 12*

David's reign

Brought to the king

David asks whether anyone is left of Saul's house. Saul's servant Ziba names Mephibosheth. David restores Saul's land to him and seats him at the king's table "as one of the king's sons." *2 Samuel 9:1–13*

Absalom's revolt

Accused by Ziba

As David flees Jerusalem, Ziba meets him with supplies and claims that Mephibosheth has stayed behind, hoping to regain Saul's kingdom. David gives Ziba all that was Mephibosheth's. *2 Samuel 16:1–4*

The king's return

Meets David

Mephibosheth comes out unwashed, with feet undressed and beard untrimmed, as he has been since David left. He says Ziba deceived him. David divides the land between them. *2 Samuel 19:24–30*

The famine years

Spared

A three-year famine is traced to Saul's wrong against the Gibeonites. When they demand seven of Saul's descendants, David spares Mephibosheth because of his oath to Jonathan. *2 Samuel 21:1–9*

Key activities

Ziba and Mephibosheth gave David opposite stories (2 Samuel 16:1–4; 19:24–30). Many readers believe Mephibosheth, since his long mourning shows loyalty. Others think Ziba may have been telling the truth. David himself seemed unsure and divided the land, and Scripture does not settle it.

1. **Survived a disaster as a child.** He lived through his family's fall, but it left him lame. *2 Samuel 4:4*
2. **Came when the king called.** He came before David, fell on his face and said, "Behold thy servant!" *2 Samuel 9:6*
3. **Saw himself as unworthy.** "What is thy servant, that thou shouldest look upon such a dead dog as I am?" *2 Samuel 9:8*
4. **Ate at the king's table.** He lived in Jerusalem and ate "continually at the king's table." *2 Samuel 9:11–13*
5. **Mourned while the king was away.** He did not care for his feet, trim his beard or wash his clothes until David returned in peace. *2 Samuel 19:24*
6. **Cared more for the king than the land.** "Yea, let him take all, forasmuch as my lord the king is come again in peace unto his own house." *2 Samuel 19:30*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Mephibosheth.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 4:4	How he became lame
2 Samuel 9:1–13	David's kindness to him
2 Samuel 16:1–4; 19:24–30	Ziba's accusation and Mephibosheth's answer
2 Samuel 21:7	Spared because of "the LORD's oath" with Jonathan
1 Chronicles 8:34; 9:40	As Merib-baal, listed with son Micah
Echo: 1 Samuel 20:14–17	Jonathan asks kindness for his house for ever
Echo: Psalm 23:5	"Thou preparest a table before me"

New Testament

Echo: Luke 14:21	The maimed and the halt invited to the banquet
Echo: Ephesians 2:8	Saved by grace, the gift of God

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did David give Mephibosheth, and why (2 Samuel 9:1, 7)?
2. *Understand:* Mephibosheth called himself a "dead dog." How does his view of himself make David's kindness stand out?
3. *Apply:* David kept a promise to a friend long after the friend was gone. Is there a promise you have made that still needs keeping?
4. *Apply:* Who is "hidden in Lo-debar" around you, overlooked or afraid, and how could you welcome them to your table?

72 Absalom

David's handsome, charming son, who stole the people's hearts and rose up against his father.

Absalom was David's third son, famous for his good looks and thick hair. When his half-brother Amnon wronged his sister Tamar and David took no action, Absalom waited two years and had Amnon killed, then fled into exile. Back home, he won Israel's heart at the city gate, then had himself proclaimed king in Hebron and drove David out of Jerusalem. His rebellion ended in a forest battle, where he was caught in an oak and killed. David's cry of grief for him is one of the saddest lines in the Bible.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Avshalom*, "father of peace" or "my father is peace"
Family	David's third son; mother Maacah of Geshur (2 Samuel 3:3)
Children	Three sons and a daughter, Tamar (2 Samuel 14:27)
When	Born in Hebron, c. 1010–1003 BC; died in David's later reign
Key places	Hebron, Jerusalem, Geshur, the wood of Ephraim
Key people	David, Tamar, Amnon, Joab, Ahithophel, Hushai
New Testament	Not named

"And on this manner did Absalom to all Israel that came to the king for judgment: so Absalom stole the hearts of the men of Israel."

2 Samuel 15:6, KJV

The life of Absalom

Dates are approximate and rough (BC). Absalom was born during David's years in Hebron (c. 1010–1003 BC). The Bible counts the later years of his story in relation to each other, not in calendar dates.

c. 1010–1003 BC

Born in Hebron

While David reigns over Judah in Hebron, Absalom is born as his third son. His mother is Maacah, daughter of Talmai, king of Geshur, so Absalom has royal blood on both sides. *2 Samuel 3:2–5*

In Jerusalem

Tamar is wronged

Amnon, David's eldest son, forces himself on Absalom's sister Tamar and then throws her out. David is very angry, but the text records no action. Absalom takes Tamar into his house and says nothing to Amnon. *2 Samuel 13:1–22*

Two years later

Amnon is killed

Absalom invites the king's sons to his sheep-shearing at Baal-hazor. At his command his servants kill Amnon. Absalom flees to his grandfather in Geshur and stays three years. *2 Samuel 13:23–39*

After three years

Returns home

Joab arranges his return, but for two years Absalom does not see the king. After he burns Joab's field to get attention, David receives him and kisses him. *2 Samuel 14:1–33*

Later

Steals Israel's heart

He gathers chariots and runners and sits at the gate, winning over all who come for justice. Then he has himself proclaimed king in Hebron, and David flees Jerusalem. *2 Samuel 15:1–16:22*

The final battle

Caught in an oak

David's men defeat Absalom's army in the wood of Ephraim. Riding his mule under an oak, Absalom is caught by the head and left hanging. Joab kills him. *2 Samuel 18:1–17*

Key activities

2 Samuel 15:7 in the KJV says "after forty years." Some Greek and Syriac copies and the historian Josephus read "four years," which fits the story better, and many translations follow them. 2 Samuel 18:18 says Absalom had no son to carry his name, though 14:27 says he had three sons. They may have died young.

1. **Protected his sister.** After Tamar was wronged, he took her into his home, where she lived "desolate." *2 Samuel 13:20*
2. **Nursed his hatred.** He hated Amnon and waited two full years for revenge. *2 Samuel 13:22–29*
3. **Won the crowd.** He told each person with a complaint, "See, thy matters are good and right," and wished aloud that he were judge. *2 Samuel 15:1–6*
4. **Used a vow as cover.** He asked leave to go to Hebron to pay a vow, then sent spies through Israel to proclaim him king. *2 Samuel 15:7–12*
5. **Took bad advice over good.** He preferred Hushai's plan to Ahithophel's, because "the LORD had appointed to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel." *2 Samuel 17:1–14*
6. **Built his own monument.** Having no son to keep his name alive, he set up a pillar in the king's dale and called it "Absalom's place." *2 Samuel 18:18*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Absalom.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 3:3; 1 Chronicles 3:2	David's third son, born in Hebron
2 Samuel 13–19	The main account, through David's return
2 Samuel 18:33	"O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom!"
1 Kings 2:7, 28	Barzillai's kindness; Joab "turned not after Absalom"
Psalm 3	Title: "when he fled from Absalom his son"
Echo: 2 Samuel 12:10	The sword would never depart from David's house

New Testament

Echo: Luke 15:20	The prodigal's father runs to meet his son
Tradition	"Absalom's Tomb" in the Kidron Valley was built centuries later

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Absalom win the hearts of the people (2 Samuel 15:1–6)?
2. *Understand:* David was angry about Tamar but took no action. How might his silence have fed Absalom's bitterness?
3. *Apply:* Absalom nursed a grudge for years. Is there a wrong you keep replaying that you need to bring to God?
4. *Apply:* David grieved his son even after the rebellion. Who in your family needs your love even when relationships are hard?

73 Solomon

The king who asked God for wisdom, built the temple, and let his heart be turned away.

Solomon, son of David and Bathsheba, was Israel's third king. Early in his reign God appeared to him in a dream and said, "Ask what I shall give thee." Solomon asked for an understanding heart, and God gave him wisdom, along with riches and honor. He became famous for his wisdom, proverbs and wealth, and built the temple David had longed to build. Israel lived in peace and plenty. But Solomon married many foreign wives, and in his old age they turned his heart toward other gods. A great beginning does not guarantee a faithful ending.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Shelomoh*, related to *shalom*, "peace"; also Jedidiah
Family	Son of David and Bathsheba; father of Rehoboam
Reign	c. 970–931 BC, forty years over all Israel (1 Kings 11:42)
Great work	The temple in Jerusalem, begun c. 966 BC (1 Kings 6:1)
Key places	Jerusalem, Gibeon, Gihon, Ezion-geber
Key people	Nathan, Adonijah, Hiram of Tyre, the Queen of Sheba, Jeroboam
Writings	Named in Proverbs, Song of Solomon, Psalms 72 and 127
New Testament	Matthew 1:6–7; 6:29; 12:42; Acts 7:47

"Give therefore thy servant an understanding heart to judge thy people, that I may discern between good and bad: for who is able to judge this thy so great a people?"

1 Kings 3:9, KJV

The life of Solomon

Dates are approximate (BC). His age at crowning is not given; Rehoboam was 41 when Solomon died (1 Kings 14:21).

In Jerusalem

Born and named

After David and Bathsheba's first child dies, Solomon is born. "The LORD loved him," and Nathan brings the name Jedidiah. *2 Samuel 12:24–25*

c. 970 BC

Anointed and secures the throne

When Adonijah claims the throne, Solomon is anointed at Gihon. After David dies, he executes Adonijah and Joab and banishes Abiathar. *1 Kings 1:5–2:46*

Early reign

Asks for wisdom

At Gibeon God says, "Ask what I shall give thee." Solomon asks for an understanding heart, and God adds riches and honor. *1 Kings 3:4–15*

c. 966 BC
4th year

Begins the temple

In the 480th year after the Exodus, he begins the house of the LORD on Mount Moriah. *1 Kings 5:1–6:1; 2 Chronicles 3:1*

c. 959 BC
11th year

Temple dedicated

After seven years the temple is finished. The glory cloud fills the house, and Solomon prays before all Israel. *1 Kings 6:37–38; 8:1–66*

Later years

His heart turns

"When Solomon was old," his many wives turn his heart after other gods, and God says the kingdom will be torn from his son. *1 Kings 11:1–13*

c. 931 BC
40th year

Dies

Adversaries rise, including Jeroboam. Solomon dies after forty years and is buried in the city of David. *1 Kings 11:14–43*

Key activities

Christians have long linked Solomon with Ecclesiastes, which is written by "the Preacher, the son of David, king in Jerusalem" (Ecclesiastes 1:1) but does not name him. Many scholars think a later writer wrote it in Solomon's voice. Views also differ on how much of Proverbs and the Song of Solomon he wrote himself.

1. **Loved the LORD.** He walked in the statutes of David, "only he sacrificed and burnt incense in high places." *1 Kings 3:3*
2. **Asked for wisdom, not riches.** God was pleased that he did not ask for long life, wealth or his enemies' lives. *1 Kings 3:5–14*
3. **Judged between two mothers.** He called for a sword to divide a baby, and the true mother gave up her claim to save the child. *1 Kings 3:16–28*
4. **Spoke wisely and ruled in peace.** He spoke three thousand proverbs, and Israel dwelt safely, "every man under his vine and under his fig tree." *1 Kings 4:25, 29–34*
5. **Built the temple.** It was built of stone prepared at the quarry, so no hammer or axe was heard at the site. *1 Kings 6:1–38*
6. **Prayed at the dedication.** "Behold, the heaven and heaven of heavens cannot contain thee; how much less this house that I have builded?" *1 Kings 8:22–53*
7. **Received a warning.** God appeared a second time, promising blessing for obedience and ruin for turning away. *1 Kings 9:1–9*
8. **Built great wealth.** He built ships at Ezion-geber, brought gold from Ophir, and answered the Queen of Sheba's hard questions. *1 Kings 9:26–10:29*
9. **Built altars for foreign gods.** For his wives he built high places for Chemosh and Molech on the hill facing Jerusalem. *1 Kings 11:4–8*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Solomon.

Old Testament

1 Kings 1–11; 2 Chronicles 1–9	The two main accounts of his reign
1 Chronicles 22:6–10	A son, "a man of rest," will build the temple
Proverbs 1:1; 25:1	Proverbs credited to him; Hezekiah's men copied some
Nehemiah 13:26	"Even him did outlandish women cause to sin"
Echo: Deuteronomy 17:16–17	A king must not multiply horses, wives or gold

New Testament

Matthew 1:6–7	In the line from David to Jesus
Matthew 6:29	"Even Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these"
Matthew 12:42	"A greater than Solomon is here"
Acts 7:47–48	Solomon built a house, but God dwells not in temples

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Solomon ask for at Gibeon, and what did God give him (1 Kings 3:5–14)?
2. *Understand:* Solomon was wise, yet his heart turned. How is being wise different from staying faithful?
3. *Apply:* Solomon's heart turned slowly. What small compromise could lead you where you do not want to go?
4. *Apply:* If God said to you, "Ask what I shall give thee," what would you ask for, and why?

74 The Queen of Sheba

A foreign queen who traveled far to test Solomon's wisdom, and went home praising Israel's God.

The Queen of Sheba ruled a wealthy land far to the south of Israel. She heard of Solomon's fame "concerning the name of the LORD," and came with a great caravan to test him with hard questions. Solomon answered everything she asked. Seeing his wisdom, his house and his worship, she confessed that "the half was not told me," and blessed the LORD. Scripture does not give her name. Yet Jesus held her up as an example: she traveled far to hear Solomon, and "a greater than Solomon" had now come.

At a glance

Name	Not given; "the queen of the south" (Matthew 12:42)
Homeland	Sheba, likely southwest Arabia (Yemen); some say Ethiopia
When	During Solomon's reign, c. 970–931 BC; year not given
Came with	Camels bearing spices, gold and precious stones
Gift to Solomon	120 talents of gold and many spices (1 Kings 10:10)
Key people	Solomon
New Testament	Matthew 12:42; Luke 11:31

"Howbeit I believed not the words, until I came, and mine eyes had seen it: and, behold, the half was not told me."

1 Kings 10:7, KJV

The life of The Queen of Sheba

Scripture gives no dates or ages for the queen. Her visit came sometime during Solomon's reign (c. 970–931 BC), after his fame had spread widely.

In Sheba

Hears of Solomon

News reaches her of Solomon's fame "concerning the name of the LORD." She decides to test him for herself with hard questions. *1 Kings 10:1; 2 Chronicles 9:1*

The journey

Arrives in Jerusalem

She comes with a very great train of camels bearing spices, gold and precious stones. She talks with Solomon about all that is in her heart. *1 Kings 10:2*

At the court

Tests and sees

Solomon answers all her questions; nothing is hidden from him. She sees his wisdom, his house, his food, his servants and his offerings, and "there was no more spirit in her." *1 Kings 10:3–5*

Before leaving

Blesses Israel's God

She says the reports were true and "the half was not told me." She blesses the LORD for setting Solomon on Israel's throne and gives rich gifts. *1 Kings 10:6–10*

Going home

Receives all she desires

Solomon gives her all she desires and asks for, beyond the gifts he gives her from his royal bounty. Then she turns and goes back to her own country with her servants. *1 Kings 10:13; 2 Chronicles 9:12*

Group notes

Key activities

1 Kings 10 and 2 Chronicles 9 tell the same story in almost the same words. Compare them side by side.

1. **Sought the truth for herself.** She did not rest on reports but came to see and hear. *1 Kings 10:1, 6–7*
2. **Asked hard questions.** She came "to prove him with hard questions," and spoke with him of all that was in her heart. *1 Kings 10:1–3*
3. **Observed carefully.** She took in his wisdom, his house, his table, his servants and his worship at the house of the LORD. *1 Kings 10:4–5*
4. **Admitted she was wrong.** "I believed not the words, until I came, and mine eyes had seen it." *1 Kings 10:7*
5. **Praised God.** "Blessed be the LORD thy God, which delighted in thee, to set thee on the throne of Israel." *1 Kings 10:9*
6. **Gave generously.** She gave a hundred and twenty talents of gold and more spices than ever came again. *1 Kings 10:10*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the queen.

Old Testament

1 Kings 10:1–13; 2 Chronicles 9:1–12	The two accounts of her visit
Psalm 72:10, 15	"The kings of Sheba and Seba shall offer gifts"
Isaiah 60:6	"All they from Sheba shall come"
Echo: Ruth 1:16; 2 Kings 5:15	Outsiders who honor Israel's God

New Testament

Matthew 12:42; Luke 11:31	She came "from the uttermost parts of the earth"
Echo: Matthew 2:11	Wise men bring gold, frankincense and myrrh
Echo: Acts 8:27–39	An Ethiopian official hears the gospel

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the queen see in Jerusalem, and how did she respond (1 Kings 10:4–9)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus said "a greater than Solomon is here." What was he saying about himself, and about those who would not listen to him?
3. *Apply:* The queen brought her hard questions. What hard questions would you like to bring to God?
4. *Apply:* She traveled a long way to hear wisdom. What effort are you willing to make this week to hear from God?

75 Rehoboam

Solomon's son, who took the wrong advice and lost ten tribes in a single day.

Rehoboam was the son of Solomon and the first king of Judah after the kingdom divided. He came to the throne at forty-one, heir to the richest court Israel had known. The northern tribes asked him to lighten the heavy load his father had laid on them. He listened to his young friends instead of his father's older advisers and answered harshly. Ten tribes walked away and made Jeroboam I their king. Rehoboam spent the rest of his seventeen-year reign fortifying a smaller kingdom, drifting from God, and paying tribute to an Egyptian invader. Chronicles adds that he humbled himself when judgment came, and God eased his hand.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Rechavam*, often rendered "the people is enlarged"
Family	Son of Solomon and Naamah, an Ammonite woman (1 Kings 14:21)
Crowned	Age 41, c. 931 BC (1 Kings 14:21)
Reign	17 years in Jerusalem, c. 931–913 BC
Key places	Shechem, Jerusalem, the fortified cities of Judah
Key people	Jeroboam I, Shemaiah, Shishak of Egypt, his son Abijah
Main passages	1 Kings 12:1–24; 14:21–31; 2 Chronicles 10–12
New Testament	Named as "Roboam" in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:7)

"And he did evil, because he prepared not his heart to seek the LORD."

2 Chronicles 12:14, KJV

The life of Rehoboam

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology for the divided kingdom. Years are counted from the start of his reign.

c. 931 BC
Age 41

Goes to Shechem

After Solomon's death, all Israel gathers at Shechem to make Rehoboam king. Jeroboam, back from Egypt, speaks for the tribes: ease the heavy yoke, and we will serve you. *1 Kings 11:43–12:5*

c. 931 BC
Three days later

Rejects the elders

The old men who served Solomon urge him to serve the people. His young friends urge him to be harsher still. He takes their advice and threatens to chastise the tribes with scorpions. *1 Kings 12:6–15*

c. 931 BC
Soon after

The kingdom splits

The northern tribes reject David's house. They stone Adoram, his taskmaster, and Rehoboam flees to Jerusalem by chariot. He musters 180,000 men for war, but Shemaiah tells him to stand down, and he obeys. *1 Kings 12:16–24*

c. 931–928 BC
Years 1–3

Strengthens Judah

He fortifies cities across Judah and Benjamin. Priests and Levites from the north move south, and for three years the kingdom walks in the way of David and Solomon. *2 Chronicles 11:5–17*

c. 926 BC
5th year

Shishak invades

Once secure, Rehoboam and Judah forsake God's law. Shishak of Egypt takes the fortified cities and strips the temple and palace, including Solomon's gold shields. The leaders humble themselves, and God spares Jerusalem. *1 Kings 14:25–28; 2 Chronicles 12:1–12*

c. 913 BC
Age 58

Dies

After seventeen years marked by constant war with Jeroboam, he is buried in the city of David. His son Abijah reigns in his place. *1 Kings 14:29–31; 2 Chronicles 12:13–16*

Key activities

Kings tells the story of the split and Judah's sin. Chronicles adds his building, his large family, and his repentance when Shishak came.

1. **Went to Shechem to be crowned.** He went north to Shechem, the old meeting place of the tribes, where all Israel had gathered to make him king. *1 Kings 12:1*
2. **Asked for time and advice.** He sent the people away for three days and consulted both the old men and the young men. *1 Kings 12:5–11*
3. **Answered roughly.** He told the people, "my father made your yoke heavy, and I will add to your yoke." Ten tribes rebelled that day. *1 Kings 12:12–16*
4. **Obeyed the word to stand down.** When Shemaiah said, "this thing is from me," Rehoboam and his army went home instead of fighting. *1 Kings 12:21–24; 2 Chronicles 11:1–4*
5. **Built a line of fortresses.** He fortified Bethlehem, Lachish, Hebron and other towns, and stocked them with food, oil, wine, shields and spears. *2 Chronicles 11:5–12*
6. **Welcomed exiles from the north.** Priests, Levites and faithful people who rejected Jeroboam's calves came to Jerusalem to worship. *2 Chronicles 11:13–17*
7. **Built a large household.** He had eighteen wives and sixty concubines. He loved Maachah, Absalom's daughter, most and chose her son Abijah as heir. *2 Chronicles 11:18–23*
8. **Forsook the law.** Once strong, he and all Israel with him forsook God's law. Judah built high places and images on every high hill. *1 Kings 14:22–24; 2 Chronicles 12:1*
9. **Humbled himself.** When Shemaiah announced judgment through Shishak, the king and princes said, "The LORD is righteous." God granted them some deliverance. *2 Chronicles 12:5–7, 12*
10. **Replaced gold with brass.** He made brass shields to replace the gold ones Shishak had carried off. *1 Kings 14:26–28*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rehoboam.

Old Testament

1 Kings 11:29–39	Ahijah foretells ten tribes torn from Solomon's son
1 Kings 12; 14:21–31; 2 Chronicles 10–12	The two main accounts
1 Kings 12:15	"The cause was from the LORD," fulfilling Ahijah's word
1 Kings 15:6	War with Jeroboam all their days
2 Chronicles 13:7	Abijah calls him "young and tenderhearted"
Echo: Proverbs 15:1	"A soft answer turneth away wrath"

New Testament

Matthew 1:7	"Roboam" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: Mark 10:42–44	The great must be servants, as the elders advised

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did the older men advise, and what did the young men advise (1 Kings 12:6–11)?
2. *Understand:* The text says the split was Rehoboam's choice and also "from the LORD" (1 Kings 12:15, 24). How can both be true?
3. *Apply:* Whose advice do you tend to seek when you face a hard decision? Do they ever tell you what you would rather not hear?
4. *Apply:* Rehoboam drifted from God once he felt strong (2 Chronicles 12:1). What habit would keep you close to God in success?

76 Jeroboam I

The gifted rebel who was offered a lasting kingdom, then traded it for two golden calves.

Jeroboam son of Nebat was the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel. He began as a capable officer in Solomon's building works. A prophet told him God would give him ten tribes and, if he obeyed, a dynasty as secure as David's. The promise came true when the tribes broke from Rehoboam. But Jeroboam feared that worship in Jerusalem would turn his people's hearts, so he set up golden calves at Bethel and Dan. That choice shaped the north for two centuries: later kings walked in "the sins of Jeroboam the son of Nebat, who made Israel to sin."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yarovam*. The meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Nebat of Zereda and Zeruah, a widow (1 Kings 11:26)
Rose as	Solomon's officer over the house of Joseph's labour
Reign	22 years over the north, c. 931–910 BC (1 Kings 14:20)
Key places	Egypt, Shechem, Penuel, Tirzah, Bethel, Dan
Key people	Solomon, Ahijah, Rehoboam, the man of God from Judah
New Testament	Not named

> *"Whereupon the king took counsel, and made two calves of gold, and said unto them, It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem: behold thy gods, O Israel, which brought thee up out of the land of Egypt."*
>
> 1 Kings 12:28, KJV

The life of Jeroboam I

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. Scripture does not date the events before Solomon's death.

Under Solomon

Rises through hard work

Solomon sees the young man is industrious and puts him over the labour of the house of Joseph. *1 Kings 11:26–28*

Under Solomon

The torn garment

The prophet Ahijah tears his new garment into twelve pieces and gives Jeroboam ten, promising a lasting house if he obeys. *1 Kings 11:29–39*

Late in Solomon's reign

Flees to Egypt

Jeroboam lifts up his hand against the king. Solomon seeks to kill him, so he flees to Shishak until Solomon dies. *1 Kings 11:26–27, 40*

c. 931 BC

Made king of Israel

After Rehoboam's harsh answer, the northern tribes call Jeroboam to their assembly and make him king. *1 Kings 12:2–3, 20*

c. 931 BC
Year 1

Golden calves

Fearing his people will turn back to David's house, he sets up calves at Bethel and Dan, with his own priests and feast. *1 Kings 12:25–33*

At Bethel

The man of God

A prophet from Judah cries out against the altar. Jeroboam's hand dries up and is healed, yet he does not turn. *1 Kings 13:1–6, 33–34*

Later

His son falls sick

His wife goes in disguise to Ahijah, who announces the end of Jeroboam's house. The boy dies. *1 Kings 14:1–18*

c. 910 BC
22nd year

Dies

Defeated by Abijah of Judah, he never recovers. The LORD strikes him, and Nadab reigns after him. *1 Kings 14:19–20; 2 Chronicles 13:1–20*

Key activities

Kings treats the calves as the root sin of the northern kingdom. Almost every later northern king is measured against "the sins of Jeroboam."

1. **Worked hard for Solomon.** His energy and ability won him a senior post over the labourers of Ephraim and Manasseh. *1 Kings 11:28*
2. **Received a conditional promise.** God offered him "a sure house" like David's, if he would keep God's statutes and commandments. *1 Kings 11:37–38*
3. **Led the tribes' appeal.** He and the assembly asked Rehoboam to lighten the heavy service Solomon had imposed. *1 Kings 12:3–4*
4. **Built up his kingdom.** He fortified Shechem as his capital and also built Penuel across the Jordan. *1 Kings 12:25*
5. **Reasoned from fear.** He told himself that worship in Jerusalem would turn his people back to Rehoboam, and that they would kill him. *1 Kings 12:26–27*
6. **Made two golden calves.** He set one in Bethel and one in Dan, and the people went to worship before them. *1 Kings 12:28–30*
7. **Invented a religion.** He built shrines on high places, made priests from people who were not Levites, and set a feast in a month "which he had devised of his own heart." *1 Kings 12:31–33*
8. **Refused to turn back.** Even after the sign at Bethel, he kept appointing priests for the high places. This became the sin that cut off his house. *1 Kings 13:33–34*
9. **Sought a prophet in secret.** When his son fell ill, he sent his wife in disguise to Ahijah instead of going himself. *1 Kings 14:1–4*
10. **Fought Judah.** He waged war with Rehoboam and then Abijah, and was defeated in battle. *1 Kings 15:6–7; 2 Chronicles 13:3–20*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jeroboam.

Old Testament

1 Kings 11:26–14:20; 2 Chronicles 10–13	The main accounts of his life
1 Kings 15:29–30	Baasha destroys Jeroboam's house, as Ahijah said
1 Kings 22:52; 2 Kings 10:29	Later kings walk in Jeroboam's way
2 Kings 17:21–23	His sin named as the root of the north's fall
2 Kings 23:15–18	Josiah tears down the Bethel altar (1 Kings 13:2)
Hosea 8:5–6; Amos 7:10–13	Prophets condemn the calf and Bethel
Echo: Exodus 32:1–8	Aaron's golden calf at Sinai

New Testament

Echo: Acts 7:39–41	Israel "rejoiced in the works of their own hands"
Echo: John 4:19–24	Worship "in spirit and in truth"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Jeroboam give himself for making the calves (1 Kings 12:26–28)?
2. *Understand:* God promised Jeroboam "a sure house" if he obeyed (1 Kings 11:38). Why did he not trust it?
3. *Apply:* Jeroboam said going to Jerusalem was "too much." Where are you tempted to make faith more convenient?
4. *Apply:* Fear drove Jeroboam's biggest decision. What fear is shaping a choice in front of you, and what would trusting God look like?

77 Asa

A reforming king who trusted God against a vast army, then leaned on men in his later years.

Asa, Solomon's great-grandson, was the third king of Judah after the kingdom divided, and reigned forty-one years. He began well. He tore down idols, removed his own grandmother as queen mother because of her idol, and led Judah to renew its covenant with God. When a huge army from Cush marched against him, he prayed a short, honest prayer and God gave the victory. But later, facing a smaller threat from Israel, he paid a pagan king for help, and jailed the prophet who rebuked him. His life asks whether faith that starts strong will finish strong.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Asa*. The meaning is uncertain; some suggest "healer"
Family	Son of Abijah (Abijam); father of Jehoshaphat (1 Kings 15:8, 24)
Queen mother	Maachah, whom he removed (1 Kings 15:10, 13)
Reign	41 years in Jerusalem, c. 911–870 BC (1 Kings 15:10)
Key places	Jerusalem, the Kidron valley, Mareshah, Ramah
Key people	Azariah, Hanani the seer, Zerah, Baasha, Ben-hadad
New Testament	Named in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:7–8)

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to shew himself strong in the behalf of them whose heart is perfect toward him."

2 Chronicles 16:9, KJV

The life of Asa

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. Years are counted from the start of his reign. Chronicles' "thirty-sixth year" (2 Chronicles 16:1) is a known puzzle; see the next page.

c. 911 BC
Year 1

Becomes king

After his father Abijah's short reign, Asa takes the throne of Judah. He does what is right in God's eyes, as David his father did. *1 Kings 15:8–11; 2 Chronicles 14:1–2*

c. 911–901 BC
Years 1–10

Reform and rest

He removes foreign altars, images and groves, and commands Judah to seek God. The land is quiet for ten years, and he builds fortified cities. *2 Chronicles 14:1–7*

Before his 15th year

Victory over Zerah

Zerah the Ethiopian comes against Judah with a huge army. Asa cries to God at Mareshah, and Judah routs the invaders and carries off great spoil. *2 Chronicles 14:9–15*

c. 896 BC
15th year

Covenant renewed

Stirred by the prophet Azariah, Asa removes more idols and gathers Judah and many from the north. They swear with shouting to seek God with all their heart. *2 Chronicles 15:1–15*

Later in his reign

Buys help from Syria

When Baasha of Israel fortifies Ramah on Judah's border, Asa sends temple silver and gold to Ben-hadad of Syria. Ben-hadad attacks the north, and Baasha withdraws. *1 Kings 15:16–22; 2 Chronicles 16:1–6*

Soon after

Rebuked by Hanani

The seer Hanani says he trusted Syria instead of God. Asa is angry, puts the seer in prison, and oppresses some of the people. *2 Chronicles 16:7–10*

c. 872–870 BC
Years 39–41

Disease and death

His feet become severely diseased, yet he seeks physicians rather than God. He dies in his forty-first year and is buried with great honour. *1 Kings 15:23–24; 2 Chronicles 16:12–14*

Key activities

2 Chronicles 16:1 dates Baasha's move to Asa's 36th year, but 1 Kings 16:8 says Baasha died in Asa's 26th year. Some scholars count the 36 years from the division of the kingdom, and others suspect a copying error.

1. **Cleared away idols.** He took away foreign altars, high places, images and groves, and told Judah to seek the God of their fathers. *2 Chronicles 14:2–5*
2. **Built in peace.** He used the quiet years to fortify cities with walls, towers, gates and bars. *2 Chronicles 14:6–7*
3. **Prayed before battle.** Facing Zerah's army, he prayed, "help us, O LORD our God; for we rest on thee." *2 Chronicles 14:11*
4. **Listened to a prophet.** Azariah told him, "The LORD is with you, while ye be with him." Asa took courage and acted. *2 Chronicles 15:1–8*
5. **Removed his grandmother.** He deposed Maachah as queen mother because of her idol in a grove. He cut it down and burned it by the brook Kidron. *1 Kings 15:13; 2 Chronicles 15:16*
6. **Led a covenant renewal.** Judah and settlers from Ephraim, Manasseh and Simeon gathered in Jerusalem, sacrificed, and swore to seek God. *2 Chronicles 15:9–15*
7. **Bribed a foreign king.** He sent treasure from the temple and palace to Ben-hadad to break Syria's treaty with Baasha. *1 Kings 15:18–20; 2 Chronicles 16:2–4*
8. **Imprisoned the messenger.** When Hanani rebuked him, Asa raged and put him in the prison house. *2 Chronicles 16:7–10*
9. **Sought physicians, not God.** In his final illness he looked only to doctors for help. *2 Chronicles 16:12*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Asa.

Old Testament

1 Kings 15:8–24; 2 Chronicles 14–16	Two accounts; Chronicles is fuller
1 Kings 15:14	High places remained, yet his heart was perfect with the LORD
1 Kings 22:43	Jehoshaphat walks in the ways of Asa his father
Jeremiah 41:9	The pit Asa dug against Baasha, still known later
Echo: Psalm 20:7	"Some trust in chariots, and some in horses"
Echo: Jeremiah 17:5	"Cursed be the man that trusteth in man"

New Testament

Matthew 1:7–8	In the royal line of Jesus
Echo: 2 Timothy 4:7	"I have finished my course"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Compare Asa's prayer in 2 Chronicles 14:11 with his actions in 2 Chronicles 16:1–4. What changed?
2. *Understand:* Hanani says God looks for people "whose heart is perfect toward him" (2 Chronicles 16:9). What does that mean, since Asa was far from sinless?
3. *Apply:* Asa trusted God in a crisis but not in a smaller problem. Where do you rely on yourself because a problem seems small?
4. *Apply:* Asa reacted angrily to correction. Who has permission to tell you hard truths, and how do you usually respond?

78 Ahab

A strong, able king who sold himself to evil, and whom God still met with warnings and mercy.

Ahab, son of Omri, was the seventh king of the northern kingdom of Israel. By worldly standards he was a success. He ruled from a splendid capital at Samaria, won battles against Syria, and made alliances by marriage with Phoenicia and Judah. But Scripture judges him by another standard. He married Jezebel, brought Baal worship into the heart of Israel, and let his wife murder an innocent man for a vineyard. Again and again God sent prophets to him. Ahab listened just enough to show he knew the truth, but never enough to change course.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Achav*, usually taken to mean "father's brother"
Family	Son of Omri; husband of Jezebel; father of Ahaziah, Joram, Athaliah
Reign	22 years in Samaria, c. 874–853 BC (1 Kings 16:29)
Key places	Samaria, Jezreel, Mount Carmel, Aphek, Ramoth-gilead
Key people	Jezebel, Elijah, Obadiah, Naboth, Ben-hadad, Micaiah
Death	Struck by a random arrow at Ramoth-gilead (1 Kings 22:34)
New Testament	Not named. Jezebel's name is used in Revelation 2:20

> *"But there was none like unto Ahab, which did sell himself to work wickedness in the sight of the LORD, whom Jezebel his wife stirred up."*
>
> 1 Kings 21:25, KJV

The life of Ahab

Dates are approximate (BC). Kings does not date the middle events, so they follow the text's order.

c. 874 BC

King and Jezebel's husband

Ahab succeeds Omri in Samaria. He marries Jezebel of the Zidonians and builds Baal a temple and altar. *1 Kings 16:28–33*

c. 860s BC

The drought

Elijah announces no dew or rain but by his word. Ahab searches every nation for him. *1 Kings 17:1; 18:1–16*

Third year of drought

Mount Carmel

Fire falls on Elijah's sacrifice, Baal's prophets are killed, and rain returns as Ahab rides to Jezreel. *1 Kings 18:17–46*

Syrian wars

Two victories

Guided by a prophet, Ahab defeats Ben-hadad twice, but spares him under a treaty, and a prophet condemns it. *1 Kings 20:1–43*

Later

Naboth's vineyard

Jezebel has Naboth stoned, and Ahab takes his vineyard. At Elijah's word of judgment, Ahab humbles himself. *1 Kings 21:1–29*

c. 853 BC
22nd year

Dies at Ramoth-gilead

With Jehoshaphat as ally and ignoring Micaiah, he fights in disguise. A random arrow kills him. *1 Kings 22:1–40*

Group notes

Key activities

Outside the Bible, an inscription of the Assyrian king Shalmaneser III names "Ahab the Israelite" among the kings who fought him at Qarqar in 853 BC, with 2,000 chariots. Scripture does not mention this battle.

1. **Married for alliance.** He married Jezebel, a Phoenician princess, and built Baal a temple in Samaria. *1 Kings 16:31–33*
2. **Hunted for Elijah.** He made every nation swear they had not hidden the prophet. *1 Kings 18:10*
3. **Blamed the messenger.** "Art thou he that troubleth Israel?" Elijah said Ahab was the real troubler. *1 Kings 18:17–18*
4. **Reported to Jezebel.** After Carmel he told his wife all Elijah had done, and she vowed to kill the prophet. *1 Kings 19:1–2*
5. **Answered a boast.** "Let not him that girdeth on his harness boast himself as he that putteth it off." *1 Kings 20:10–11*
6. **Spared his enemy.** He called Ben-hadad "my brother" and let him go. A prophet said Ahab's life would go for his. *1 Kings 20:31–43*
7. **Sulked over a vineyard.** When Naboth would not sell, Ahab lay on his bed and would not eat. *1 Kings 21:1–4*
8. **Took what was not his.** Told Naboth was dead, he went at once to take the vineyard. *1 Kings 21:15–16*
9. **Humbled himself.** At Elijah's word he tore his clothes, fasted, and went softly. God delayed the disaster to his son's days. *1 Kings 21:27–29*
10. **Hated the true prophet.** He said of Micaiah, "I hate him; for he doth not prophesy good concerning me, but evil." *1 Kings 22:8*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Ahab.

Old Testament

1 Kings 16:28–22:40; 2 Chronicles 18	The main account of his reign
2 Kings 9–10	Jehu judges Ahab's house, as Elijah foretold
2 Kings 8:18, 27	"The house of Ahab" leads Judah's kings astray
2 Kings 21:3, 13	Manasseh makes a grove "as did Ahab"
Micah 6:16	"All the works of the house of Ahab"
Echo: Leviticus 25:23	Family land not sold for ever, so Naboth refused

New Testament

Luke 4:25; James 5:17	His reign's drought: "three years and six months"
Revelation 2:20	Jezebel's name used for a false teacher

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Ahab react when Naboth refused to sell his vineyard (1 Kings 21:1–4)?
2. *Understand:* God delayed judgment when Ahab humbled himself (1 Kings 21:27–29). What does that show about God?
3. *Apply:* Ahab hated Micaiah because he never said anything good about him (1 Kings 22:8). Whose honest words do you avoid, and why?
4. *Apply:* Ahab let Jezebel do the dirty work, then took the vineyard. Is there a wrong you quietly benefit from?

79 Jezebel

The foreign queen who brought Baal to Israel's throne and used power without conscience.

Jezebel was a princess of Sidon who married Ahab, king of Israel. She set out to make Baal the god of Israel. She fed hundreds of Baal's prophets at her own table and hunted down the prophets of the LORD. After Elijah's victory on Mount Carmel, one message from her sent him fleeing. When Ahab could not buy Naboth's vineyard, she arranged a mock trial and had Naboth stoned. Elijah foretold a shameful end for her, and years later Jehu fulfilled it at Jezreel. Her name became a byword, and the book of Revelation uses it for a false teacher who led God's people astray.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Izevel*. The meaning is debated
Family	Daughter of Ethbaal, king of the Zidonians; wife of Ahab (1 Kings 16:31)
Children	Mother of King Joram (2 Kings 9:22), and probably of King Ahaziah (1 Kings 22:52)
When	Queen of Israel c. 874–853 BC; queen mother until her death c. 841 BC
Key places	Sidon (Zidon), Samaria, Jezreel
Key people	Ahab, Elijah, Naboth, Jehu, the prophets of Baal
New Testament	Her name is used for a false prophetess at Thyatira (Revelation 2:20)

> *"And Jezebel his wife said unto him, Dost thou now govern the kingdom of Israel? arise, and eat bread, and let thine heart be merry: I will give thee the vineyard of Naboth the Jezreelite."*
>
> 1 Kings 21:7, KJV

The life of Jezebel

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. Scripture does not say when she married Ahab or how old she was.

By c. 874 BC

Marries Ahab

A Phoenician princess, daughter of Ethbaal of Sidon, marries Ahab of Israel. Ahab begins to serve Baal and builds a temple and altar for him in Samaria. *1 Kings 16:31–32*

c. 860s BC

Kills the LORD's prophets

Jezebel cuts off the prophets of the LORD, and Obadiah hides a hundred of them in caves. Meanwhile, 450 prophets of Baal and 400 prophets of the groves eat at her table. *1 Kings 18:4, 13, 19*

After Carmel

Threatens Elijah

Ahab tells her about the fire from heaven and the death of Baal's prophets. She swears to kill Elijah by the same time the next day, and the prophet runs for his life. *1 Kings 19:1–3*

Later

Plots against Naboth

Finding Ahab sulking, she writes letters in his name, arranges false witnesses, and has Naboth stoned. Elijah declares that the dogs will eat Jezebel by the wall of Jezreel. *1 Kings 21:5–23*

c. 853–841 BC

Queen mother

After Ahab dies, his sons Ahaziah and Joram reign in turn. She remains a powerful presence, and Jehu later names her idolatry as the reason there can be no peace. *1 Kings 22:51–53; 2 Kings 9:22*

c. 841 BC

Dies at Jezreel

She paints her face, dresses her hair, and taunts Jehu from a window. Her own servants throw her down. When men go to bury her, only her skull, feet and palms remain. *2 Kings 9:30–37*

Key activities

Scripture never shows Jezebel in worship or in private. It shows her using power. Read her story alongside Ahab's, because each shaped the other.

1. **Brought Baal to court.** Through her marriage, Baal worship became the royal religion in Samaria. Kings says she "stirred up" Ahab to evil. *1 Kings 16:31–33; 21:25*
2. **Persecuted the prophets.** She cut off the prophets of the LORD, and some survived only because Obadiah hid them. *1 Kings 18:4, 13*
3. **Fed the prophets of Baal.** Eight hundred and fifty prophets of Baal and of the groves ate at her table. *1 Kings 18:19*
4. **Vowed to kill Elijah.** Her message began, "So let the gods do to me, and more also," and Elijah fled to the wilderness. *1 Kings 19:2–3*
5. **Mocked her husband.** "Dost thou now govern the kingdom of Israel?" she asked, and took matters into her own hands. *1 Kings 21:5–7*
6. **Used the law to murder.** She sealed letters with Ahab's seal, proclaimed a fast, and set two worthless men to accuse Naboth of blaspheming God and the king. *1 Kings 21:8–14*
7. **Faced death defiantly.** She greeted Jehu with a taunt: "Had Zimri peace, who slew his master?" *2 Kings 9:30–31*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jezebel.

Old Testament

1 Kings 16:31–33	Her marriage brings Baal worship into Israel
1 Kings 21:25	Ahab's wickedness, "whom Jezebel his wife stirred up"
2 Kings 9:7	Jehu to avenge the prophets' blood "at the hand of Jezebel"
1 Kings 21:23; 2 Kings 9:36–37	The dogs at Jezreel, foretold and fulfilled
2 Kings 9:22	Her "whoredoms" and "witchcrafts," likely idolatry
Echo: Proverbs 14:1	The foolish woman plucks down her house

New Testament

Revelation 2:20–23	"That woman Jezebel" at Thyatira, likely a symbolic name
Echo: Mark 6:17–28	Herodias seeks the death of John the Baptist

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What steps did Jezebel take to get Naboth's vineyard (1 Kings 21:8–14)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jezebel's name was chosen as a warning to the church in Revelation 2:20?
3. *Apply:* Jezebel used a fast and a court to do evil. Where can good-looking processes hide wrong motives, even in you?
4. *Apply:* Jezebel "stirred up" Ahab. Whom do you influence most, and which way are you stirring them?

80 Elijah

The prophet of fire who stood alone against Baal, then met God in a still small voice.

Elijah of Gilead burst onto the scene when Baal worship had become the religion of Ahab and Jezebel's court. He announced a drought, was fed by ravens and a foreign widow, and called down fire on Mount Carmel. Then, worn out and afraid, he asked God to let him die. God fed him, met him at Horeb, and sent him back to work. Scripture records no death for Elijah; he was taken up in a whirlwind. The prophets promised his return, and the New Testament sees it in John the Baptist and shows Elijah talking with Jesus at the transfiguration.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Eliyahu*, "my God is the LORD"
Home	"The Tishbite," of the inhabitants of Gilead (1 Kings 17:1)
When	Prophet in the northern kingdom, c. 860s–850s BC
Kings he faced	Ahab and Ahaziah; a letter to Jehoram of Judah
Key places	Cherith, Zarephath, Mount Carmel, Horeb, the Jordan
Key people	Ahab, Jezebel, the widow of Zarephath, Obadiah, Elisha
Appearance	"An hairy man," with a leather belt (2 Kings 1:8)
New Testament	Called Elias; often linked with John the Baptist

"And Elijah came unto all the people, and said, How long halt ye between two opinions? if the LORD be God, follow him: but if Baal, then follow him. And the people answered him not a word."

1 Kings 18:21, KJV

The life of Elijah

Dates are approximate (BC). Most events are undated and follow the text's order.

c. 860s BC

Announces the drought

Elijah tells Ahab there will be no dew or rain except at his word, then God sends him into hiding. *1 Kings 17:1*

During the drought

Cherith and Zarephath

Ravens feed him by the brook. Then a widow's flour and oil never run out, and her son is raised. *1 Kings 17:2–24*

Third year

Mount Carmel and rain

Baal's prophets cry all day unanswered; Elijah prays, and fire falls. Then a great rain ends the drought. *1 Kings 18:1–46*

Soon after

Flight to Horeb

Fleeing Jezebel, he asks to die. An angel feeds him, and at Horeb God speaks in a still small voice. *1 Kings 19:1–18*

On the way back

Calls Elisha

He throws his mantle over Elisha, who leaves his oxen to follow him. *1 Kings 19:19–21*

Later in Ahab's reign

Confronts Ahab

After Naboth's murder, Elijah meets Ahab in the stolen vineyard with a word of judgment. *1 Kings 21:17–29*

c. 852–850 BC

Final acts

He rebukes Ahaziah for consulting Baal-zebub. Then, across the Jordan, he is taken up by a whirlwind. *2 Kings 1:1–2:12*

Group notes

Key activities

Elijah's story has two sides: bold public victories and private exhaustion. Both are told honestly. 2 Chronicles 21:12–15 records a letter from Elijah to Jehoram of Judah; how this fits the timing of his departure is debated.

1. **Stood before a king.** He spoke God's word to Ahab plainly: "As the LORD God of Israel liveth, before whom I stand." *1 Kings 17:1*
2. **Lived by daily provision.** He drank from a brook and ate what ravens brought, then lived on a widow's handful of flour. *1 Kings 17:2–16*
3. **Prayed for a dead boy.** He carried the widow's son upstairs, stretched himself on him three times, and cried to God. The child revived. *1 Kings 17:17–24*
4. **Challenged a divided people.** On Carmel he asked, "How long halt ye between two opinions?" *1 Kings 18:21*
5. **Mocked Baal's silence.** At noon he taunted the prophets of Baal: perhaps their god was talking, travelling or asleep. *1 Kings 18:26–29*
6. **Rebuilt the LORD's altar.** He repaired the broken altar with twelve stones, one for each tribe, and prayed a short prayer. *1 Kings 18:30–38*
7. **Prayed for rain.** He bowed down with his face between his knees and sent his servant to look seven times. *1 Kings 18:42–44*
8. **Asked to die.** Under a juniper tree he said, "It is enough; now, O LORD, take away my life." *1 Kings 19:4*
9. **Heard the still small voice.** At Horeb God was not in the wind, the earthquake or the fire, but in "a still small voice." *1 Kings 19:11–13*
10. **Passed on the mantle.** He called Elisha and later asked what he could do for him before he was taken away. *1 Kings 19:19–21; 2 Kings 2:9–10*
11. **Confronted injustice.** He told Ahab that dogs would lick his blood where they had licked Naboth's. *1 Kings 21:17–24*
12. **Was taken up.** A chariot of fire and horses of fire parted him from Elisha, and he went up by a whirlwind into heaven. *2 Kings 2:11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Elijah.

Old Testament

1 Kings 17:1 – 2 Kings 2:12	The main account of his ministry
2 Chronicles 21:12–15	His letter warns Jehoram of Judah
Malachi 4:5	"Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet"
Echo: Exodus 34:28	Like Moses, forty days with God at Horeb

New Testament

Matthew 11:14; Luke 1:17	John the Baptist, "in the spirit and power of Elias"
John 1:21	Asked "Art thou Elias?" John answers, "I am not"
Matthew 17:1–4	With Moses at the transfiguration
Luke 4:25–26	Jesus recalls Elijah's visit to a foreign widow
Romans 11:2–5	The seven thousand who had not bowed to Baal
James 5:17–18	"A man subject to like passions as we are"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God give Elijah under the juniper tree before he gave him any new instructions (1 Kings 19:5–8)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God spoke in a still small voice rather than in wind, earthquake or fire (1 Kings 19:11–13)?
3. *Apply:* Elijah crashed right after his greatest victory. When have you felt low after a high point?
4. *Apply:* Elijah thought he alone was faithful, but there were seven thousand (1 Kings 19:18). Whom could you reach out to this week?

81 The widow of Zarephath

A poor foreign widow who shared her last meal and saw God keep her alive.

The widow of Zarephath lived in the country of Sidon, the homeland of Queen Jezebel and a centre of Baal worship. During the great drought of Ahab's reign she was down to her last handful of flour. She was gathering sticks for one final meal when Elijah, a stranger and an Israelite, asked her to feed him first. She did, and her flour and oil lasted until the rain came. Later, when her son died, Elijah prayed and the boy lived again. Scripture never tells us her name. Yet Jesus chose her story to show that God's mercy reaches beyond Israel, and his hometown was furious.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture
Home	Zarephath, a town that "belongeth to Zidon" (1 Kings 17:9)
Family	A widow with one son (1 Kings 17:12)
When	During the drought in Ahab's reign, c. 860s BC
Key people	Elijah; her son
Main passages	1 Kings 17:8–24; Luke 4:25–26
New Testament	Mentioned by Jesus as a widow of "Sarepta" (Luke 4:26)

> *"And the woman said to Elijah, Now by this I know that thou art a man of God, and that the word of the LORD in thy mouth is truth."*
>
> 1 Kings 17:24, KJV

The life of The widow of Zarephath

Dates are approximate. The drought falls in Ahab's reign (c. 874–853 BC), probably in the 860s BC. Kings gives no exact year.

During the drought

God's command

When the brook Cherith dries up, God sends Elijah to Zarephath. He says he has "commanded a widow woman there to sustain thee." She does not yet know it. *1 Kings 17:7–9*

At the city gate

Meets Elijah

She is gathering sticks when a stranger asks for water and a piece of bread. She has only a handful of flour and a little oil, and she expects to eat it with her son and then die. *1 Kings 17:10–12*

That day

Bakes for the prophet first

Elijah tells her not to fear. She should make him a small cake first, trusting God's promise that her flour and oil will last until the rain. She does as he says. *1 Kings 17:13–15*

Many days

The jar does not run out

Through the long drought the flour and oil keep lasting. They feed her, her household and Elijah, "according to the word of the LORD, which he spake by Elijah." *1 Kings 17:15–16*

Later

Her son dies

Her son falls sick until there is no breath left in him. In her grief she asks whether the prophet has come to call her sin to remembrance and slay her son. *1 Kings 17:17–18*

The same day

Her son is raised

Elijah carries the boy to his upstairs room, stretches himself on him three times, and cries to God. The child revives, and she confesses that Elijah is a man of God. *1 Kings 17:19–24*

Key activities

She was a Gentile living in Baal's own country. Yet she speaks of "the LORD thy God" (1 Kings 17:12) and acts on the word of his prophet.

1. **Helped a stranger.** When Elijah asked for water, she went to fetch it, though water was scarce. *1 Kings 17:10–11*
2. **Told the truth about her need.** She did not pretend. She had "not a cake, but an handful of meal in a barrel, and a little oil in a cruse." *1 Kings 17:12*
3. **Gave first.** She made Elijah's cake before her own, trusting a promise she could not yet see. *1 Kings 17:13–15*
4. **Opened her home.** Elijah stayed in an upstairs room of her house for many days. *1 Kings 17:15, 19*
5. **Brought her grief to the prophet.** When her son died, she poured out her grief and fear honestly to Elijah. *1 Kings 17:17–18*
6. **Confessed her faith.** Receiving her son alive, she declared that the word of the LORD in Elijah's mouth was truth. *1 Kings 17:23–24*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the widow.

Old Testament

1 Kings 17:8–24	The only account of her life
Obadiah 1:20	Zarephath as a boundary in a promise of return
Echo: 2 Kings 4:1–37	Elisha multiplies a widow's oil and raises a son
Echo: Deuteronomy 10:18	God defends the widow and loves the stranger

New Testament

Luke 4:25–26	"Unto none of them was Elias sent, save unto Sarepta"
Luke 4:28–29	Nazareth's synagogue, enraged, tries to throw Jesus off a cliff
Echo: Luke 7:11–17	Jesus raises a widow's only son at Nain
Echo: Mark 12:41–44	A poor widow gives "all her living"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What exactly did Elijah ask the widow to do, and what did he promise (1 Kings 17:13–14)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus used her story in his hometown sermon (Luke 4:25–29). Why would a foreign widow be such a pointed example?
3. *Apply:* She gave from almost nothing. What is one thing, however small, that you could give this week before you feel you have enough?
4. *Apply:* In her grief she blamed herself and the prophet (1 Kings 17:18). How do you tend to react when trouble comes even after you have obeyed God?

82 Obadiah, Ahab's steward

A quiet believer in a wicked court who hid a hundred prophets under the queen's nose.

Obadiah ran King Ahab's royal household, one of the highest offices in Israel, in a court where Jezebel was killing the LORD's prophets. Yet he "feared the LORD greatly." While the queen hunted the prophets, Obadiah hid a hundred of them in caves and fed them through a famine. Meeting Elijah, he is glad, afraid and a little defensive at once. He did not resign in protest, but he did not bow to Baal either.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Obadyahu*, "servant of the LORD"
Position	The "governor of his house," Ahab's palace steward (1 Kings 18:3)
Faith	"Feared the LORD greatly," from his youth (1 Kings 18:3, 12)
When	Ahab's reign, during the drought, c. 860s BC
Key people	Ahab, Jezebel, Elijah, the hundred prophets
Not the same as	The prophet Obadiah, most scholars think
New Testament	Not named

"For it was so, when Jezebel cut off the prophets of the LORD, that Obadiah took an hundred prophets, and hid them by fifty in a cave, and fed them with bread and water."

1 Kings 18:4, KJV

The life of Obadiah, Ahab's steward

Dates are approximate. The drought falls in Ahab's reign (c. 874–853 BC), probably in the 860s BC. Kings gives no exact year.

Ahab's reign

Serves at court

Obadiah is governor over King Ahab's house, a senior royal official. Yet Scripture says he feared the LORD greatly and had done so since he was young. *1 Kings 18:3, 12*

When Jezebel strikes

Hides a hundred prophets

As Jezebel cuts off the prophets of the LORD, Obadiah takes a hundred of them. He hides them by fifty in a cave and feeds them with bread and water. *1 Kings 18:4, 13*

Third year of drought

Searches for grass

The famine in Samaria is severe. Ahab and Obadiah divide the land between them and go looking for springs and grass to keep the horses and mules alive. *1 Kings 18:1–6*

On the road

Meets Elijah

Elijah suddenly stands before him. Obadiah recognizes him, falls on his face, and is told to go and tell Ahab, "Behold, Elijah is here." *1 Kings 18:7–8*

The same hour

Pleads his fear

Obadiah fears that the Spirit will carry Elijah away and Ahab will kill the messenger. He reminds Elijah how he saved the prophets. Elijah swears to appear before Ahab that day. *1 Kings 18:9–15*

That day

Brings Ahab

Obadiah goes to Ahab and tells him, and Ahab goes to meet Elijah. The meeting leads straight to the contest on Mount Carmel. *1 Kings 18:16–20*

Key activities

Scripture never says whether Ahab or Jezebel knew of Obadiah's faith. The text simply sets his fear of God beside his high office and lets both stand.

1. **Feared God in a hostile court.** He served a king who worshipped Baal, yet he kept faith with the LORD. *1 Kings 18:3*
2. **Hid a hundred prophets.** At great personal risk, he hid them in caves while Jezebel was killing the LORD's prophets. *1 Kings 18:4*
3. **Fed them through a famine.** He kept them supplied with bread and water when food and water were scarce. *1 Kings 18:4, 13*
4. **Did his job faithfully.** He went out on the king's errand to search for grass and water. *1 Kings 18:5–6*
5. **Honoured the prophet.** When he met Elijah, he fell on his face and called him "my lord Elijah." *1 Kings 18:7*
6. **Spoke his fear honestly.** He told Elijah plainly that the errand could cost him his life. *1 Kings 18:9–14*
7. **Carried the message.** Once Elijah promised to appear, Obadiah went and told Ahab. *1 Kings 18:15–16*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names this Obadiah.

Old Testament

1 Kings 18:1–16	This is the only account of his life.
1 Kings 19:18	God tells Elijah that seven thousand in Israel have not bowed to Baal. Elijah felt alone, but Obadiah and the prophets he hid show that he never was.
Echo: Genesis 41:40	Joseph ran Pharaoh's house
Echo: Daniel 6	Daniel served pagan kings without bowing

New Testament

Echo: Hebrews 11:38	God's people "in dens and caves of the earth"
Echo: Philippians 4:22	Believers "of Caesar's household"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Obadiah describe himself and his past to Elijah (1 Kings 18:12–13)?
2. *Understand:* Obadiah served Ahab and also protected God's prophets. Was he compromising or being wise? What in the text helps you decide?
3. *Apply:* Obadiah worked inside a system run by people who opposed God. Where do you live or work under leaders who do not share your faith? What does faithfulness look like there?
4. *Apply:* Obadiah's courage was quiet and practical: bread and water, day after day. Who needs quiet, practical help from you this week?

83 Jehoshaphat

A godly king who taught his people God's law, prayed his way out of disaster, and kept making friends with the wrong family.

Jehoshaphat, son of Asa, was one of Judah's best kings. He sought God, sent teachers across the land with the book of the law, and reformed the courts. When a vast army invaded, he admitted he did not know what to do and turned to God in prayer, and Judah won without striking a blow. Yet he tied his family to Ahab's by marriage, fought beside Ahab, and later partnered with Ahab's sons. A prophet asked him, "Shouldest thou help the ungodly?" His story shows real faith beside a real weakness, and how alliances shape later generations.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yehoshafat*, "the LORD has judged"
Family	Son of Asa and Azubah; father of Jehoram (1 Kings 22:42, 50)
Crowned	Age 35 (1 Kings 22:42)
Reign	25 years, c. 872–848 BC, first as co-regent with Asa
Key places	Jerusalem, Ramoth-gilead, En-gedi, Berachah, Ezion-geber
Key people	Ahab, Micaiah, Jehu son of Hanani, Jahaziel, Elisha
New Testament	Named as "Josaphat" in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:8)

"O our God, wilt thou not judge them? for we have no might against this great company that cometh against us; neither know we what to do: but our eyes are upon thee."

2 Chronicles 20:12, KJV

The life of Jehoshaphat

Dates are approximate (BC). He probably reigned with his sick father Asa from c. 872 BC, alone from c. 870 BC.

c. 872–870 BC
Age 35

Becomes king

He begins to reign in the fourth year of Ahab of Israel. He walks in the first ways of David, seeks God rather than the Baals, and strengthens Judah against Israel. *1 Kings 22:41–43; 2 Chronicles 17:1–6*

3rd year of his reign

Sends out teachers

He sends princes, Levites and priests through the cities of Judah, carrying the book of the law of the LORD and teaching the people. *2 Chronicles 17:7–9*

Early reign

Alliance with Ahab

Rich and honoured, he joins himself to Ahab by marriage. His son Jehoram marries Ahab's daughter, a match that will bring Baal worship into Judah's royal house. *2 Chronicles 18:1; 2 Kings 8:18*

c. 853 BC

Ramoth-gilead

He joins Ahab against Syria. Syrian captains mistake him for Ahab; he cries out, and God turns them away. *1 Kings 22:1–38; 2 Chronicles 18:1–34*

After the battle

Rebuked, then reforms

Jehu son of Hanani rebukes him for helping the ungodly. Jehoshaphat goes out among the people to bring them back to God and sets judges in every fortified city. *2 Chronicles 19:1–11*

Later

Victory without a battle

Moab, Ammon and men of Mount Seir invade. He proclaims a fast and prays with all Judah. Singers lead the army out, and the invaders destroy one another. *2 Chronicles 20:1–30*

c. 848 BC

Dies

After twenty-five years as king he is buried with his fathers in the city of David. His son Jehoram reigns in his place. *1 Kings 22:50; 2 Chronicles 21:1*

Key activities

Kings says the high places were not taken away (1 Kings 22:43), while Chronicles says he removed them (2 Chronicles 17:6), then also notes they remained (2 Chronicles 20:33). Many readers think he removed some, or removed pagan shrines while others survived.

1. **Taught the law.** He sent officials and Levites through Judah to teach from the book of the law. *2 Chronicles 17:7–9*
2. **Made a risky alliance.** He told Ahab, "I am as thou art, and my people as thy people." *1 Kings 22:4; 2 Chronicles 18:3*
3. **Asked for a true prophet.** After about four hundred prophets all promised victory, he asked, "Is there not here a prophet of the LORD besides?" *1 Kings 22:5–8*
4. **Took correction.** After Jehu's rebuke he went out himself, from Beersheba to Mount Ephraim, to bring the people back to God. *2 Chronicles 19:1–4*
5. **Reformed justice.** He told the judges, "ye judge not for man, but for the LORD," and warned them against bribes. *2 Chronicles 19:5–11*
6. **Prayed in helplessness.** Facing invasion, he stood in the temple and admitted, "neither know we what to do." *2 Chronicles 20:3–13*
7. **Sent singers ahead.** He appointed singers to go before the army, praising God's mercy. *2 Chronicles 20:20–22*
8. **Built ships that broke.** He joined Ahaziah of Israel in a shipping venture. A prophet warned him, and the ships were wrecked. *2 Chronicles 20:35–37; 1 Kings 22:48–49*
9. **Marched against Moab.** He joined Joram of Israel and the king of Edom. Elisha helped them only for Jehoshaphat's sake. *2 Kings 3:4–27*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jehoshaphat.

Old Testament

1 Kings 22:41–50; 2 Chronicles 17–20	The two main accounts
1 Kings 22:43	He walked in the ways of Asa his father
2 Chronicles 19:2	"Shouldest thou help the ungodly?"
2 Kings 3:14	Elisha heeds Joram only for Jehoshaphat's sake
2 Chronicles 21:12	Elijah rebukes Jehoram for leaving his father's ways
Echo: 1 Samuel 17:47	"The battle is the LORD's," as at 2 Chronicles 20:15

New Testament

Matthew 1:8	"Josaphat" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: 2 Corinthians 6:14	"Be ye not unequally yoked together"
Echo: Acts 16:25–26	Paul and Silas sing in prison

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did Jehoshaphat admit in his prayer (2 Chronicles 20:12)?
2. *Understand:* Jehoshaphat was a godly king, yet he kept joining himself to Ahab's family. Why might a good person keep making the same mistake?
3. *Apply:* "Neither know we what to do: but our eyes are upon thee." Where do you need to pray that prayer this week?
4. *Apply:* Jehoshaphat's alliances affected his children and grandchildren. What partnership or friendship in your life needs a hard look?

84 Elisha

Elijah's successor, a prophet of practical mercy who saw the unseen armies of God.

Elisha was a farmer's son ploughing a field when Elijah threw a prophet's mantle over him. He left home, served Elijah, and asked for a double portion of his spirit. For more than fifty years he was God's prophet in the northern kingdom, through the reigns of several kings. Where Elijah's ministry was marked by fire and confrontation, Elisha's was often marked by help for ordinary people. He purified a spring, filled a widow's jars with oil, raised a boy to life, fed a crowd, healed a Syrian general, and made an iron axe head float. He also anointed kings and advised armies. Even after his death, a dead man who touched his bones came back to life.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Elisha*, "God is salvation" or "my God saves"
Family	Son of Shaphat, of Abel-meholah (1 Kings 19:16)
When	Called under Ahab; prophet c. 850–795 BC, until the reign of Joash (Jehoash) of Israel
Key places	Abel-meholah, Jericho, Bethel, Shunem, Samaria, Dothan, Damascus
Key people	Elijah, Gehazi, the Shunammite woman, Naaman, Hazael, Jehu, Jehoshaphat
Death	Of an illness, in the reign of Joash king of Israel (2 Kings 13:14, 20)
New Testament	Called Eliseus; named once by Jesus (Luke 4:27)

"And he answered, Fear not: for they that be with us are more than they that be with them."

2 Kings 6:16, KJV

The life of Elisha

Dates are approximate (BC). The stories of 2 Kings 4–8 are undated and may not be in time order.

c. 850s BC

Called from the plough

Elijah throws his mantle over him. Elisha kills his oxen, feeds the people, and follows Elijah. *1 Kings 19:16, 19–21*

c. 850 BC

Receives the mantle

He asks for a double portion of Elijah's spirit, sees him taken up, and parts the Jordan with his mantle. *2 Kings 2:1–15*

Early ministry

Jericho and Bethel

He heals Jericho's spring with salt. Youths mock him near Bethel, and two bears maul forty-two of them. *2 Kings 2:19–25*

Probably under Joram

Mercy and healing

He multiplies a widow's oil, raises the Shunammite's son, and heals the Syrian general Naaman. *2 Kings 4:1–5:27*

Syrian wars

Dothan and Samaria

At Dothan his servant sees chariots of fire. In Samaria's terrible siege he promises food by the next day. *2 Kings 6:8–7:20*

c. 842–841 BC

Hazael and Jehu

He weeps as he tells Hazael he will be king, then sends a young prophet to anoint Jehu. *2 Kings 8:7–15; 9:1–10*

c. 795 BC

Death and burial

After his burial, a dead man thrown into his tomb touches his bones and revives. *2 Kings 13:14–21*

Group notes

Key activities

Scholars debate whether "little children" in 2 Kings 2:23 were children or young men, since the Hebrew words can cover both. The account itself is brief and hard, and readers differ on how to understand it.

1. **Left everything to follow.** He burned his ploughing equipment, cooked the oxen, and went after Elijah. *1 Kings 19:19–21*
2. **Asked for a double portion.** When Elijah offered him a request, he said, "let a double portion of thy spirit be upon me." *2 Kings 2:9–10*
3. **Took up the mantle.** He struck the Jordan and asked, "Where is the LORD God of Elijah?" The waters parted. *2 Kings 2:13–14*
4. **Healed bad water.** He threw salt into Jericho's spring, and the water became wholesome. *2 Kings 2:19–22*
5. **Filled a widow's jars.** A prophet's widow faced losing her sons to a creditor. Her little oil filled every jar she could borrow. *2 Kings 4:1–7*
6. **Raised a dead boy.** He prayed and stretched himself on the Shunammite's son, and the child sneezed seven times and opened his eyes. *2 Kings 4:32–37*
7. **Fed a hungry crowd.** He had twenty barley loaves set before a hundred men, and they ate and had some left. *2 Kings 4:42–44*
8. **Refused payment.** He would take no gift from Naaman, and he confronted Gehazi for secretly taking one. *2 Kings 5:15–27*
9. **Made iron float.** When a borrowed axe head fell into the Jordan, he threw in a stick and the iron swam. *2 Kings 6:1–7*
10. **Opened his servant's eyes.** He prayed, "LORD, I pray thee, open his eyes, that he may see," and the mountain was full of chariots of fire. *2 Kings 6:15–17*
11. **Fed his enemies.** He led blinded Syrian raiders into Samaria, then told the king to feed them and send them home. *2 Kings 6:18–23*
12. **Wept over Israel's future.** He fixed his gaze on Hazael and wept, knowing the evil Hazael would do. *2 Kings 8:11–13*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Elisha.

Old Testament

1 Kings 19:16–21; 2 Kings 2–13	The main accounts of his life
1 Kings 19:16	Anointed "to be prophet in thy room"
2 Kings 8:4–5	"All the great things that Elisha hath done"
2 Kings 13:14	Joash: "O my father, my father, the chariot of Israel"
Echo: Joshua 3:14–17	Like Joshua, he crosses the Jordan to succeed

New Testament

Luke 4:27	None cleansed "saving Naaman the Syrian"
Echo: John 6:9–13	Jesus feeds thousands with barley loaves
Echo: Romans 12:20	"If thine enemy hunger, feed him"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Elisha's servant see before and after Elisha prayed (2 Kings 6:15–17)?
2. *Understand:* Many of Elisha's miracles meet everyday needs: a debt, a pot of stew, a borrowed axe. What does that suggest about God?
3. *Apply:* Elisha left his oxen and his family's farm to follow God's call. What might God be asking you to leave behind, or to take up?
4. *Apply:* Elisha fed the soldiers who came to capture him. Who is one person you could treat with unexpected kindness this week?

85 The Shunammite woman

A generous woman who made room for God's prophet and would not let go when her son died.

The Shunammite woman of Shunem was wealthy enough for Scripture to call her "a great woman." She began inviting the passing prophet Elisha to meals, then she and her husband built him a small room of his own. She asked for nothing, yet God gave her a son. Years later the boy died in her lap. She set out at once for the prophet, told all who asked, "It is well," and would not leave Elisha until he came. Her son lived again. Her story shows quiet generosity and fierce faith.

At a glance

Name	Not given. She is known by her town, Shunem
Described as	"A great woman," meaning wealthy or prominent (2 Kings 4:8)
Family	An older husband; one son, born as Elisha promised
Home	Shunem, in the tribe of Issachar (Joshua 19:17–18)
When	Elisha's ministry, probably under Joram, c. 852–841 BC
Key people	Elisha, Gehazi, her husband, her son, the king of Israel
New Testament	Not named

> *"Run now, I pray thee, to meet her, and say unto her, Is it well with thee? is it well with thy husband? is it well with the child? And she answered, It is well."*
>
> 2 Kings 4:26, KJV

The life of The Shunammite woman

Scripture gives no dates. Her story falls within Elisha's ministry (c. 850–795 BC), probably during the reign of Joram (c. 852–841 BC). The famine lasts seven years.

Elisha's travels

Welcomes the prophet

Whenever Elisha passes through Shunem, she urges him to stop and eat at her home. She tells her husband she believes he is a holy man of God. *2 Kings 4:8–9*

Soon after

Builds him a room

She suggests they make a little room on the wall, with a bed, a table, a stool and a candlestick. Elisha can rest there whenever he comes. *2 Kings 4:10–11*

One visit

A son is promised

Elisha wants to repay her. She asks for nothing, but Gehazi notes that she has no son and her husband is old. Elisha promises a son, and the next year she gives birth. *2 Kings 4:12–17*

Years later

Her son dies

Out in the field with the reapers, the boy cries, "My head, my head." He dies on his mother's knees at noon. She lays him on the prophet's bed and rides to Mount Carmel. *2 Kings 4:18–25*

The same day

Her son is raised

She refuses to leave Elisha, so he comes himself. He prays and stretches himself on the child, who sneezes seven times and opens his eyes. *2 Kings 4:26–37*

Seven years

Famine and exile

Elisha warns her that God has called for a seven-year famine. She takes her household to live in the land of the Philistines. *2 Kings 8:1–2*

On her return

Land restored

She comes to the king to plead for her house and land just as Gehazi is telling him her story. The king restores everything, plus the harvest income of the years away. *2 Kings 8:3–6*

Key activities

Scripture tells us little about her husband. When she hurries off, he only asks why she is going to the prophet on an ordinary day (2 Kings 4:22–23). She carries the grief and the hope largely alone.

1. **Showed persistent hospitality.** She "constrained him to eat bread," and afterward he stopped there whenever he passed by. *2 Kings 4:8*
2. **Planned practical care.** She thought ahead about what a travelling prophet would need and provided it. *2 Kings 4:10*
3. **Was content.** Offered a favour from the king or the army captain, she answered, "I dwell among mine own people." *2 Kings 4:13*
4. **Guarded her heart.** When told she would have a son, she begged Elisha, "do not lie unto thine handmaid." *2 Kings 4:16*
5. **Spoke faith in grief.** To her husband she said, "It shall be well," and to Gehazi, "It is well." *2 Kings 4:23–26*
6. **Refused to let go.** She caught Elisha by the feet and said, "As the LORD liveth, and as thy soul liveth, I will not leave thee." *2 Kings 4:27–30*
7. **Obeyed a warning.** She left her home and land when Elisha told her a famine was coming. *2 Kings 8:1–2*
8. **Asked for justice.** She went to the king herself to claim her house and land. *2 Kings 8:3–6*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names her.

Old Testament

2 Kings 4:8–37	and **2 Kings 8:1–6.** These are the only accounts of her life.
Echoes	Sarah is promised a son "according to the time of life" (Genesis 18:10–14), the same phrase Elisha uses (2 Kings 4:16). Elijah raises the son of the widow of Zarephath (1 Kings 17:17–24).

New Testament

Hebrews 11:35	"Women received their dead raised to life again." Many readers see her, and the widow of Zarephath, in these words.
Echoes	Jesus raises a widow's son at Nain, a village close to Shunem (Luke 7:11–17). "He that receiveth a prophet in the name of a prophet shall receive a prophet's reward" (Matthew 10:41). "Be not forgetful to entertain strangers" (Hebrews 13:2).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did she say to her husband, to Gehazi and to Elisha after her son died (2 Kings 4:22–28)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think she kept saying "It is well" when her son lay dead at home?
3. *Apply:* She made a room with a bed, a table, a stool and a lamp. What practical hospitality could you offer someone this month?
4. *Apply:* She would not let Elisha go (2 Kings 4:30). What need should you keep bringing to God instead of giving up?

86 Naaman

A proud Syrian general who was healed when he humbled himself and washed in the Jordan.

Naaman commanded the army of Syria, Israel's enemy to the north. He was powerful, honoured and brave, but he had leprosy. A young Israelite girl, taken captive in a raid and now serving his wife, told her mistress about a prophet in Samaria who could heal him. Naaman arrived at Elisha's door with horses, chariots and a fortune in gifts. The prophet did not even come out. He sent a message: go and wash in the Jordan seven times. Naaman stormed off in a rage. It took his own servants to talk him round. When he obeyed, his skin became like a child's, and he confessed that there was no God in all the earth but in Israel. Jesus later used his healing to show that God's grace reaches outsiders.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Naaman*, "pleasant"
Position	Captain of the host of the king of Syria (2 Kings 5:1)
Condition	"A mighty man in valour, but he was a leper" (2 Kings 5:1)
When	Elisha's ministry, probably in the reign of Joram of Israel, c. 852–841 BC
Key places	Damascus, Samaria, the Jordan River
Key people	The captive Israelite girl, the king of Syria, the king of Israel, Elisha, Gehazi
New Testament	Named by Jesus in Nazareth (Luke 4:27)

> *"Then went he down, and dipped himself seven times in Jordan, according to the saying of the man of God: and his flesh came again like unto the flesh of a little child, and he was clean."*
>
> 2 Kings 5:14, KJV

The life of Naaman

Scripture gives no date. The kings of Syria and Israel are not named in 2 Kings 5. They were probably Ben-hadad and Joram, c. 852–841 BC.

Before the story

A great commander

Naaman is highly honoured by his king, because through him the LORD has given victory to Syria. He is a mighty man of valour, but he has leprosy. *2 Kings 5:1*

In his household

A servant girl speaks

Syrian raiders have taken a young girl from Israel, and she now serves Naaman's wife. She says she wishes her master could meet the prophet in Samaria, who would heal him. *2 Kings 5:2–4*

A royal letter

Sent to Israel

The king of Syria sends Naaman with a letter and rich gifts to the king of Israel. The king tears his clothes, fearing a trap, but Elisha asks for Naaman to be sent to him. *2 Kings 5:5–8*

At Elisha's door

Angry at the cure

Elisha sends a messenger: wash in the Jordan seven times. Naaman is furious. He expected a ceremony, and he thinks Damascus has better rivers. His servants gently persuade him. *2 Kings 5:9–13*

At the Jordan

Healed

He dips himself seven times, and his flesh becomes like a little child's. He returns to Elisha, confesses Israel's God, and asks for earth to take home for worship. *2 Kings 5:14–19*

On the road

Gehazi's lie

Elisha's servant runs after him and invents a need for silver and clothing. Naaman gladly gives double. Gehazi is struck with Naaman's leprosy. *2 Kings 5:20–27*

Key activities

Naaman's story turns on unnamed, lowly people. A captive girl, a messenger and his own servants point him to healing, while two kings can do nothing.

1. **Listened to a servant girl.** He took the word of a young captive seriously enough to tell his king. *2 Kings 5:2–4*
2. **Went in style.** He brought ten talents of silver, six thousand pieces of gold and ten changes of clothing. *2 Kings 5:5, 9*
3. **Took offence.** He expected Elisha to come out, call on his God, and strike his hand over the place. He said, "Are not Abana and Pharpar, rivers of Damascus, better than all the waters of Israel?" *2 Kings 5:11–12*
4. **Heeded his servants.** They asked, "if the prophet had bid thee do some great thing, wouldest thou not have done it?" *2 Kings 5:13*
5. **Obeyed and was healed.** He dipped seven times in the Jordan, just as the man of God had said. *2 Kings 5:14*
6. **Confessed the true God.** "Behold, now I know that there is no God in all the earth, but in Israel." *2 Kings 5:15*
7. **Asked for earth and pardon.** He took two mules' load of earth and asked pardon for bowing beside his master in the house of Rimmon. Elisha said, "Go in peace." *2 Kings 5:17–19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Naaman.

Old Testament

2 Kings 5:1–27	This is the only account of his life.
Leviticus 13–14	The law for leprosy and for cleansing a healed leper.
Echo: Isaiah 45:22	Salvation for "all the ends of the earth"

New Testament

Luke 4:27	None cleansed "saving Naaman the Syrian"; Nazareth is enraged
Echo: Luke 17:11–19	Of ten lepers healed, only a Samaritan gives thanks
Echo: John 9:7	A blind man washes in Siloam and comes back seeing

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Naaman expect Elisha to do, and why was he so angry (2 Kings 5:11–12)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Elisha refused Naaman's gifts, and why was Gehazi's lie so serious?
3. *Apply:* Naaman almost missed healing because the cure was too simple and too humbling. Where does pride keep you from doing something simple that God asks?
4. *Apply:* A servant girl and a few servants changed Naaman's life. Who might God use you to point toward him this week?

87 Jehu

The furious charioteer who wiped out Ahab's house and Baal worship, but never gave God his whole heart.

Jehu was an army commander when a young prophet sent by Elisha anointed him king, to carry out God's judgment on the house of Ahab. He acted with frightening speed. In days he killed King Joram of Israel and King Ahaziah of Judah, had Jezebel thrown from a window, and saw to the deaths of Ahab's seventy sons. Then he trapped Baal's worshippers in one temple and destroyed them. God commended him. Yet Jehu kept Jeroboam's golden calves, and nearly a century later Hosea announced judgment for the bloodshed at Jezreel.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yehu*, probably "the LORD is he"
Family	Son of Jehoshaphat, son of Nimshi (2 Kings 9:2)
Before king	A captain of the army at Ramoth-gilead (2 Kings 9:5)
Reign	28 years in Samaria, c. 841–814 BC (2 Kings 10:36)
Key places	Ramoth-gilead, Jezreel, Samaria, the house of Baal
Key people	Elisha, Joram, Ahaziah, Jezebel, Jehonadab
Dynasty	Four generations after him on Israel's throne (2 Kings 10:30; 15:12)
New Testament	Not named

"But Jehu took no heed to walk in the law of the LORD God of Israel with all his heart: for he departed not from the sins of Jeroboam, which made Israel to sin."

2 Kings 10:31, KJV

The life of Jehu

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. 2 Kings 9–10 appears to cover only a few days or weeks.

Years before

Named by God

At Horeb, God tells Elijah to anoint "Jehu the son of Nimshi" king over Israel. The task passes to Elisha's circle years later. *1 Kings 19:15–17*

c. 841 BC

Anointed at Ramoth-gilead

A young prophet sent by Elisha takes Jehu into an inner room and pours oil on his head. He charges him to strike down the house of Ahab. The captains proclaim him king. *2 Kings 9:1–13*

Soon after

Kills two kings

Jehu drives furiously to Jezreel. He shoots Joram of Israel through the heart and has his body thrown into Naboth's field. Ahaziah of Judah is wounded as he flees and dies at Megiddo. *2 Kings 9:14–29*

That day

Jezebel's death

At Jezreel, Jezebel mocks him from a window. Jehu calls out, "Who is on my side? who?" Her servants throw her down, and Elijah's word about the dogs is fulfilled. *2 Kings 9:30–37*

The following days

Ends Ahab's line

He writes to the leaders in Samaria, and they send him the heads of Ahab's seventy sons. He also kills Ahab's officials, Ahaziah's relatives and all who remain of Ahab's house. *2 Kings 10:1–17*

In Samaria

Destroys Baal worship

Pretending to be a greater servant of Baal than Ahab, he gathers Baal's worshippers into their temple and has them killed. The temple is torn down. *2 Kings 10:18–28*

c. 841–814 BC

Reigns 28 years

He keeps Jeroboam's golden calves at Bethel and Dan. God begins to cut Israel short, and Hazael of Syria takes all the land east of the Jordan. *2 Kings 10:29–36*

Key activities

God commends Jehu for carrying out his word against Ahab's house (2 Kings 10:30), yet Hosea later condemns "the blood of Jezreel" (Hosea 1:4). Readers differ on how to hold these together. Many think Jehu did what God commanded but went beyond it, or did it for his own ends.

1. **Accepted the call.** When his fellow officers asked why the prophet came, he told them, and they made him king on the spot. *2 Kings 9:11–13*
2. **Drove furiously.** The watchman knew him from a distance: "the driving is like the driving of Jehu the son of Nimshi; for he driveth furiously." *2 Kings 9:20*
3. **Fulfilled Elijah's word.** He had Joram's body cast into Naboth's field, recalling God's judgment for Naboth's blood. *2 Kings 9:24–26*
4. **Judged Jezebel.** He called for allies at the window, and she was thrown down. *2 Kings 9:32–37*
5. **Wiped out Ahab's house.** He left none of Ahab's family, great men or priests in Jezreel. *2 Kings 10:6–11*
6. **Boasted of his zeal.** He told Jehonadab, "Come with me, and see my zeal for the LORD." *2 Kings 10:15–16*
7. **Destroyed Baal worship.** He tricked the worshippers of Baal, killed them, and turned Baal's temple into a latrine. *2 Kings 10:18–28*
8. **Kept the calves.** He did not turn from the golden calves at Bethel and Dan. *2 Kings 10:29, 31*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jehu.

Old Testament

1 Kings 19:16–17	God names Jehu as the one who will judge
2 Kings 9–10	The main account of his rise and reign
2 Chronicles 22:7–9	God brought Ahaziah of Judah to Jehu
2 Kings 10:30; 15:12	Four generations on the throne, promised and kept
Hosea 1:4	God will avenge "the blood of Jezreel" on Jehu's house
Echo: Numbers 25:10–13	Phinehas praised for zeal against idolatry

New Testament

Echo: Romans 10:2	Some have "a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge"
Echo: Matthew 15:8	Honouring God with lips, the heart far away

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jehu remove from Israel, and what did he leave in place (2 Kings 10:28–31)?
2. *Understand:* How can Jehu be commended by God (2 Kings 10:30) and still be condemned in Hosea 1:4?
3. *Apply:* Jehu said, "see my zeal for the LORD." When is your zeal for God really zeal for being seen?
4. *Apply:* Jehu cleared out Baal but kept the calves. What is one "calf" you have kept, a habit or loyalty you have never given up to God?

88 Athaliah

The daughter of Ahab who seized David's throne and tried to wipe out his line.

Athaliah was a princess of the northern kingdom, a daughter of King Ahab, married into the royal family of Judah. Through her, the worship of Baal that Ahab's house had spread in Israel came south to Jerusalem. She was queen to one king of Judah and mother and counsellor to the next. When her son Ahaziah was killed in Jehu's revolt, she killed the royal heirs and ruled Judah herself for six years. She is the only woman in Scripture to reign over Judah. Yet one baby grandson was hidden from her in the temple. Her story is a dark one, but it shows God keeping his promise to David when that promise hung by a single thread.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Atalyahu*, usually explained as "the LORD is exalted"
Family	Daughter of Ahab and granddaughter of Omri, kings of Israel (2 Kings 8:18, 26); wife of Jehoram king of Judah; mother of Ahaziah
Reign	Six years over Judah, c. 841–835 BC (2 Kings 11:3)
Key places	Jerusalem; the temple; the house of Baal in Jerusalem
Key people	Jehoram, Ahaziah, Jehosheba, the young Joash, Jehoiada the priest
Main passages	2 Kings 8:16–27; 11:1–20; 2 Chronicles 22:1–23:21
New Testament	Not named

"And when Athaliah the mother of Ahaziah saw that her son was dead, she arose and destroyed all the seed royal."

2 Kings 11:1, KJV

The life of Athaliah

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture does not say when she was born or married, or who her mother was.

Before c. 848 BC
Marriage

A royal alliance

King Jehoshaphat of Judah makes an alliance with Ahab by marriage. Athaliah becomes the wife of his son Jehoram, who walks in the ways of Ahab's house. *2 Kings 8:16–18; 2 Chronicles 18:1; 21:6*

c. 841 BC
Her son's reign

Counsellor to evil

Her son Ahaziah becomes king of Judah and reigns one year. Chronicles says his mother was his counsellor to do wickedly. *2 Kings 8:25–27; 2 Chronicles 22:2–4*

c. 841 BC
Jehu's revolt

Her son is killed

Jehu, anointed to destroy the house of Ahab, kills Ahaziah along with Joram king of Israel. Jehu also kills Ahaziah's relatives. *2 Kings 9:27; 10:12–14*

c. 841 BC
Seizes power

Destroys the royal heirs

Athaliah kills the royal family of Judah and takes the throne. But Jehosheba, a king's daughter and Ahaziah's sister, hides the baby Joash. *2 Kings 11:1–2; 2 Chronicles 22:10–11*

c. 841–835 BC
Six years

Rules over Judah

She reigns over the land while Joash is hidden in the house of the LORD. Chronicles says her sons broke into the temple and gave its holy things to Baal. *2 Kings 11:3; 2 Chronicles 24:7*

c. 835 BC
Seventh year

"Treason, Treason."

Jehoiada crowns Joash in the temple. Athaliah hears the shouting, comes in, and tears her clothes. She is led out and put to death by the horse gate. *2 Kings 11:4–16; 2 Chronicles 23:12–15*

Key activities

2 Kings 8:26 calls Athaliah "the daughter of Omri," while 2 Kings 8:18 says Jehoram's wife was Ahab's daughter. In Hebrew, "daughter" can mean a female descendant, so she was probably Ahab's daughter and Omri's granddaughter.

1. **Married into David's line.** Her marriage tied Judah's royal house to Ahab's, and her husband Jehoram "walked in the way of the kings of Israel." *2 Kings 8:18; 2 Chronicles 21:6*
2. **Counselled her son.** Chronicles says she was Ahaziah's counsellor "to do wickedly." *2 Chronicles 22:3*
3. **Destroyed the royal family.** When her son died, she killed the heirs to the throne so that she could rule. *2 Kings 11:1; 2 Chronicles 22:10*
4. **Reigned six years.** She ruled Judah from Jerusalem, the only woman to do so. *2 Kings 11:3*
5. **Promoted Baal.** A house of Baal stood in Jerusalem with its own priest, Mattan. Her sons stripped the temple of the LORD for Baal. *2 Kings 11:18; 2 Chronicles 24:7*
6. **Cried treason and fell.** She saw the boy king by the pillar, rent her clothes, and cried "Treason, Treason." She was slain outside the temple. *2 Kings 11:13–16*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Athaliah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 8:16–27; 2 Chronicles 21:5–22:4	Her husband's and son's reigns
2 Kings 11:1–20; 2 Chronicles 22:10–23:21	Her reign and death
2 Chronicles 24:7	Called "that wicked woman"; her sons broke into God's house
2 Kings 8:19	God spares Judah for David's sake, a lasting light
Echo: 2 Kings 9:30–37	Jezebel dies in Jehu's revolt that same year
Echo: 2 Samuel 7:16	David's house and kingdom established for ever

New Testament

Echo: Matthew 2:13–16	Herod tries to kill a royal child, who is kept safe
Echo: Matthew 1:1–16	David's royal line traced to Jesus

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Athaliah do when she learned her son was dead (2 Kings 11:1)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the writers of Kings and Chronicles cared so much that one baby from David's line survived?
3. *Apply:* Athaliah's family shaped her, and she shaped her son. What influences, good or bad, have been passed down in your family?
4. *Apply:* Jehosheba acted quietly and bravely. Who around you needs protecting, and what is one thing you could do for them?

89 Joash and Jehoiada

A rescued boy king and the faithful priest who raised him, and what happened when the priest was gone.

Joash was the only royal heir to escape Athaliah's massacre. His aunt Jehosheba hid him in the temple for six years. Her husband, Jehoiada the high priest, then risked everything to crown the seven-year-old and restore David's line. While Jehoiada lived, Joash did well and repaired the temple. But after the old priest died, Joash turned to idols and even had Jehoiada's son stoned in the temple court. Their story asks whether a borrowed faith will hold when the mentor is gone.

At a glance

Names	Joash (Jehoash), "the LORD has given"; Jehoiada, "the LORD knows"
Joash's family	Son of Ahaziah and Zibiah; father of Amaziah (2 Kings 12:1, 21)
Jehoiada's family	Husband of Jehosheba; father of Zechariah (2 Chronicles 24:20)
Reign	Crowned at 7; reigned 40 years, c. 835–796 BC
Key places	The temple in Jerusalem; the house of Baal
Key people	Athaliah, Jehosheba, Zechariah, Hazael king of Syria
Main passages	2 Kings 11–12; 2 Chronicles 22:10–24:27
New Testament	Possibly Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:51 (see page 4)

"And Jehoash did that which was right in the sight of the LORD all his days wherein Jehoiada the priest instructed him."

2 Kings 12:2, KJV

The life of Joash and Jehoiada

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture dates Joash's temple repairs to his 23rd year but does not date Jehoiada's death.

c. 841 BC
Infant

Rescued and hidden

Athaliah destroys the royal family. Jehosheba steals away baby Joash with his nurse and hides him in the temple for six years. *2 Kings 11:1–3; 2 Chronicles 22:10–12*

c. 835 BC
Age 7

Crowned in the temple

Jehoiada shows the captains the king's son and crowns him. The people shout, "God save the king." *2 Kings 11:4–12, 21; 2 Chronicles 23:1–11*

c. 835 BC
First year

Covenant renewed

Jehoiada makes a covenant between the LORD, king and people. Athaliah is killed and Baal's house torn down. *2 Kings 11:13–20; 2 Chronicles 23:12–21*

c. 813 BC
23rd year

The temple repaired

Jehoiada sets a chest with a hole in its lid by the altar, and the gifts pay the workers. *2 Kings 12:4–16; 2 Chronicles 24:4–14*

Later in the reign
Age 130

Jehoiada dies

The old priest dies full of days. He is buried among the kings, because he had done good in Israel. *2 Chronicles 24:15–16*

After Jehoiada's death

Joash turns away

Judah's princes bow to the king, and he listens to them. They leave the temple and serve idols. Joash has Zechariah, Jehoiada's son, stoned for rebuking them. *2 Chronicles 24:17–22*

c. 796 BC
Age 47

Joash is killed

Hazael of Syria threatens Jerusalem, and Joash buys him off with the temple's treasures. Later his own servants kill him in his bed. *2 Kings 12:17–21; 2 Chronicles 24:23–27*

Key activities

Kings and Chronicles tell Joash's story differently. Kings focuses on the temple repairs and says little about his decline. Chronicles adds the idolatry after Jehoiada's death and the stoning of Zechariah.

1. **Jehoiada protected the heir.** He and his wife kept the boy hidden in the temple for six years. *2 Kings 11:3; 2 Chronicles 22:11–12*
2. **Jehoiada crowned the king.** He armed the guards with David's own spears and shields and set the crown and the testimony on Joash. *2 Kings 11:9–12*
3. **Jehoiada renewed the covenant.** He bound king and people to be the LORD's people and led them in breaking down Baal's house. *2 Kings 11:17–18*
4. **Joash did right while taught.** He did right "all his days wherein Jehoiada the priest instructed him." The high places remained. *2 Kings 12:2–3*
5. **Joash pressed for repairs.** He challenged Jehoiada and the priests over the slow work. *2 Kings 12:6–8; 2 Chronicles 24:5–6*
6. **They set up the chest.** The people gave gladly, and honest workmen restored the house of the LORD. *2 Kings 12:9–15; 2 Chronicles 24:8–14*
7. **Joash turned to idols.** After Jehoiada died, the king listened to the princes, and Judah served groves and idols. *2 Chronicles 24:17–18*
8. **Joash killed Jehoiada's son.** Zechariah warned, "because ye have forsaken the LORD, he hath also forsaken you." He was stoned in the temple court at the king's command. *2 Chronicles 24:20–22*
9. **Joash paid off Hazael.** He sent the temple's hallowed things and gold to the king of Syria. *2 Kings 12:17–18*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Joash or Jehoiada.

Old Testament

2 Kings 11:1–12:21	Kings: the crowning and the temple repairs
2 Chronicles 22:10–24:27	Chronicles adds Joash's turning after Jehoiada died
2 Chronicles 24:22	Joash "remembered not the kindness" and slew his son
Jeremiah 29:26	A priest "in the stead of Jehoiada"; possibly another man
Echo: 1 Samuel 2:18–21	Samuel also grew up in God's house
Echo: 2 Kings 22:1–2	Josiah, another boy king who began well

New Testament

Matthew 23:35; Luke 11:51	"Zacharias" slain; many say Jehoiada's son, some the prophet
Matthew 1:8	Joash is skipped in Matthew's genealogy
Echo: Hebrews 13:7	Remember faithful leaders, "whose faith follow"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words describe how long Joash did right (2 Kings 12:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Joash's faith did not survive Jehoiada's death?
3. *Apply:* Who has been a Jehoiada for you? How could you thank them or pass on what they gave you?
4. *Apply:* What would help your faith stand on its own, not only when strong believers are around you?

90 Jonah

The runaway prophet who learned that God's mercy is wider than his own.

Jonah was a prophet of the northern kingdom in the days of King Jeroboam II. At home he brought good news: God would restore Israel's borders. But when God sent him to Nineveh, the great city of Israel's enemy Assyria, Jonah ran the other way. A storm, a great fish and a second call brought him to Nineveh at last. He preached, and the whole city repented. Instead of rejoicing, Jonah was angry, because he had known all along that God was gracious. The book ends with God's question to him, still unanswered. Jesus pointed to Jonah as a sign of his own death and resurrection, and to Nineveh as a people who repented when they heard.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yonah*, "dove"
Family	Son of Amittai (Jonah 1:1; 2 Kings 14:25)
Home	Gath-hepher in Zebulun (2 Kings 14:25; Joshua 19:13)
When	Reign of Jeroboam II of Israel, c. 793–753 BC
Key places	Joppa, the sea, Nineveh
Key people	Jeroboam II, the sailors, the king and people of Nineveh
Main passages	Jonah 1–4; 2 Kings 14:23–27
New Testament	Matthew 12:39–41; 16:4; Luke 11:29–32

> *"And should not I spare Nineveh, that great city, wherein are more than sixscore thousand persons that cannot discern between their right hand and their left hand; and also much cattle?"*
>
> Jonah 4:11, KJV

The life of Jonah

Dates are approximate (BC). The book of Jonah does not say when he went to Nineveh. Christians differ on how to read it: most have read it as history, while some read it as a teaching story built around a real prophet.

c. 790–760 BC
Reign of Jeroboam II

A word of hope

Jonah foretells that Israel's borders will be restored from the entering of Hamath to the Dead Sea. Jeroboam II wins them back, as the LORD had spoken. *2 Kings 14:23–27*

Date uncertain

Called and runs

God tells Jonah to go and cry against Nineveh. He goes down to Joppa, pays the fare, and boards a ship for Tarshish, fleeing "from the presence of the LORD." *Jonah 1:1–3*

At sea

The storm

A great wind threatens the ship while Jonah sleeps below. The lot falls on him. He tells the sailors to throw him overboard, and the sea grows calm. *Jonah 1:4–16*

Three days and three nights

In the great fish

The LORD prepares a great fish to swallow Jonah. From inside it he prays, and the fish casts him out on dry land. *Jonah 1:17–2:10*

At Nineveh

The second call

The word of the LORD comes a second time. Jonah walks into the great city and cries, "Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown." *Jonah 3:1–4*

At Nineveh

The city repents

The people believe God, fast and put on sackcloth. The king sits in ashes and orders everyone to turn from violence. God relents and spares them. *Jonah 3:5–10*

East of the city

Anger and the gourd

Jonah is angry and asks to die. God grows a plant to shade him, then sends a worm to kill it, and asks whether Jonah does well to be angry. *Jonah 4:1–11*

Key activities

The Hebrew says "a great fish," not a whale. The King James New Testament says "whale's belly" (Matthew 12:40), translating a Greek word for a large sea creature. Tarshish was probably far to the west, perhaps in Spain.

1. **Prophesied good news.** He spoke the word that Israel's lost borders would return, even under a king who did evil. *2 Kings 14:25–27*
2. **Ran from God.** Told to go east to Nineveh, he went west toward Tarshish. *Jonah 1:1–3*
3. **Slept through the storm.** While the pagan sailors prayed to their gods, he lay fast asleep in the ship. *Jonah 1:5–6*
4. **Confessed his faith.** He told the sailors, "I fear the LORD, the God of heaven, which hath made the sea and the dry land." *Jonah 1:8–10*
5. **Gave himself up.** He told them to throw him into the sea. They did, the storm stopped, and the sailors feared the LORD and made vows. *Jonah 1:11–16*
6. **Prayed from the deep.** Inside the fish he gave thanks and declared, "Salvation is of the LORD." *Jonah 2:1–9*
7. **Obeyed the second time.** He went to Nineveh and delivered a short, blunt warning. *Jonah 3:1–4*
8. **Saw a city repent.** From the king down, Nineveh turned from its evil ways, and God spared it. *Jonah 3:5–10*
9. **Complained about mercy.** He said he had fled because he knew God was "gracious ... and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness." *Jonah 4:1–3*
10. **Sulked outside the city.** He built a shelter and waited to see what would happen to Nineveh. *Jonah 4:5*
11. **Was questioned by God.** God used a plant, a worm and a hot east wind to show Jonah his own heart. *Jonah 4:6–11*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Jonah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 14:23–27	His only mention outside his book: home and prophecy
Jonah 1–4	The full account of his mission to Nineveh
Jonah 4:2; Exodus 34:6; Joel 2:13	Jonah quotes God's classic self-description
Nahum 1:1; 3:1–7	Nineveh's fall foretold; it fell in 612 BC
Echo: 1 Kings 19:3–4	Elijah also ran and asked to die

New Testament

Matthew 12:39–41; Luke 11:29–32	"The sign of the prophet Jonas"; "a greater than Jonas is here"
Matthew 16:4	No sign but the sign of Jonas
Echo: Mark 4:35–41	Jesus sleeps in a storm and calms the sea
Echo: Acts 10:5–35	At Joppa, Peter is sent to Gentiles
Tradition	A tomb of Jonah at Nebi Yunus, Mosul (tradition only)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reason did Jonah give for running away (Jonah 4:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the book ends with God's question instead of Jonah's answer?
3. *Apply:* Is there a person or group you would secretly rather God did not bless? What would it take to pray for them this week?
4. *Apply:* Jonah obeyed the second time. Where is God giving you a second chance to do something you avoided?

91 Amos

A shepherd from Judah who thundered for justice in Israel's richest days.

Amos was not a professional prophet. He was a herdsman and a tender of sycomore fig trees from Tekoa, a small town in Judah. Around 760 BC God called him north to the kingdom of Israel. Under King Jeroboam II, Israel was strong and wealthy, and its worship was busy. But the rich were crushing the poor, courts were bought, and religion had become a show. Amos said plainly that God would not accept songs and sacrifices from people who trampled the needy. When the priest of Bethel told him to go home, Amos refused to be silenced. His book ends with a promise that God would one day raise up David's fallen house.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Amos*, often explained as "burden-bearer"
Home	Tekoa, in the hills of Judah south of Bethlehem (Amos 1:1)
Work	Herdman and "gatherer of sycomore fruit" (Amos 7:14)
When	Days of Uzziah of Judah and Jeroboam II of Israel, "two years before the earthquake," c. 760 BC (Amos 1:1)
Key places	Bethel, Samaria, Tekoa
Key people	Jeroboam II; Amaziah the priest of Bethel
Main passages	Amos 1–9
New Testament	Acts 7:42–43; 15:15–17

"But let judgment run down as waters, and righteousness as a mighty stream."

Amos 5:24, KJV

The life of Amos

Dates are approximate (BC). The earthquake in Amos 1:1 was remembered for centuries (Zechariah 14:5). Many scholars link it to signs of a strong earthquake found at sites such as Hazor, dated c. 760 BC.

Before his call
At Tekoa

Herdsman and farmer

Amos keeps flocks and tends sycomore figs. He is no prophet and no prophet's son. *Amos 1:1; 7:14*

c. 762 BC
Two years before the earthquake

Called north

The LORD takes him from following the flock and says, "Go, prophesy unto my people Israel." *Amos 1:1; 7:15*

c. 762 BC
In Israel

Judgment on the nations

He announces judgment on Israel's neighbours, then on Judah, and finally on Israel itself, for three transgressions and for four. *Amos 1:3–2:16*

In Israel

Visions of judgment

He sees locusts and fire and pleads for Israel, and God relents. Then he sees a plumbline, and God says he will not pass by them again. *Amos 7:1–9*

At Bethel

Confronted by the priest

Amaziah reports him to the king and orders him back to Judah. Amos answers with a word of judgment on Amaziah and on Israel. *Amos 7:10–17*

c. 760 BC
Two years later

The earthquake

The earthquake comes, remembered long after as the one in the days of Uzziah. *Amos 1:1; Zechariah 14:5*

Group notes

Key activities

Amos was from Judah but preached in Israel. That made him an outsider, which is part of why Amaziah told him to go home.

1. **Left his flocks.** God called an ordinary working man, and he went. *Amos 7:14–15*
2. **Spoke to the nations.** He named the cruelties of Damascus, Gaza, Tyre, Edom, Ammon and Moab, then turned the same judgment on Judah and Israel. *Amos 1:3–2:16*
3. **Defended the poor.** He condemned those who "sold the righteous for silver, and the poor for a pair of shoes." *Amos 2:6–7; 5:11–12*
4. **Rebuked empty worship.** He said God hated their feasts and would not hear their songs while justice was missing. *Amos 5:21–24*
5. **Called them to seek God.** "Seek ye me, and ye shall live," the LORD said through him. *Amos 5:4–6, 14–15*
6. **Prayed for Israel.** At the vision of locusts he cried, "O Lord GOD, forgive, I beseech thee." At the vision of fire he pleaded again. Both times God relented. *Amos 7:1–6*
7. **Stood his ground at Bethel.** When told to flee, he explained that the LORD had sent him and gave the priest God's word. *Amos 7:10–17*
8. **Promised restoration.** He foretold that God would raise up "the tabernacle of David that is fallen" and plant his people in their land. *Amos 9:11–15*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Amos.

Old Testament

Amos 1–9	The book of his prophecies and visions
2 Kings 14:23–29	The reign of Jeroboam II, his setting
Zechariah 14:5	The earthquake "in the days of Uzziah" remembered
Echo: Hosea 1:1	Hosea spoke to Israel in the same years
Echo: Micah 6:8; Isaiah 1:11–17	Justice and mercy over empty worship

New Testament

Acts 7:42–43	Stephen quotes Amos 5:25–27 on wilderness idolatry
Acts 15:15–17	James quotes Amos 9:11–12 on including the Gentiles
Echo: James 5:1–6	A warning to rich oppressors that sounds like Amos
Echo: Matthew 5:23–24	Be reconciled before bringing your gift

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Amos say about himself when Amaziah told him to go home (Amos 7:14–15)?
2. *Understand:* Why would God reject worship from people who were cheating the poor (Amos 5:21–24)?
3. *Apply:* Amos spoke up though he was an outsider. Where might God be asking you to speak up for someone?
4. *Apply:* Look at your money and time. What is one concrete way to do justice this month?

92 Hosea

The prophet whose broken marriage became a picture of God's faithful love.

Hosea prophesied to the northern kingdom of Israel in its last decades, from the prosperous days of Jeroboam II to the years before Samaria fell. God told him to marry Gomer and to give their children names that were messages to the nation. Gomer was unfaithful to him. Later God told him to love her again and buy her back. Hosea's home became a living sermon: Israel had run after other gods as an unfaithful wife runs after lovers, yet God would not let her go. His book is full of grief and anger, but also tenderness. "How shall I give thee up, Ephraim?" asks the LORD. Jesus twice quoted Hosea's message: "I will have mercy, and not sacrifice."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Hoshea,* "salvation"
Family	Son of Beeri; husband of Gomer, daughter of Diblaim (Hosea 1:1, 3)
Children	Jezreel, Lo-ruhamah and Lo-ammi (Hosea 1:4–9)
When	Days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah of Judah, and Jeroboam II of Israel, c. 755–715 BC (Hosea 1:1)
Audience	The northern kingdom, often called Ephraim
Main passages	Hosea 1–14
New Testament	Matthew 2:15; 9:13; 12:7; Romans 9:25–26; 1 Peter 2:10

"For I desired mercy, and not sacrifice; and the knowledge of God more than burnt offerings."

Hosea 6:6, KJV

The life of Hosea

Dates are approximate (BC). Hosea tells us almost nothing about his life apart from his marriage, and he does not date its events.

c. 755 BC
Under Jeroboam II

The call and the marriage

The word of the LORD comes to Hosea. God tells him to marry, and he takes Gomer as his wife, as a sign of Israel's unfaithfulness. *Hosea 1:1–3*

The following years

Three children named

A son is named Jezreel, for the bloodshed of Jehu's house. A daughter is named Lo-ruhamah, "not pitied." A son is named Lo-ammi, "not my people." *Hosea 1:3–9*

Later

Buys back his wife

God tells him to love a woman who has been unfaithful. He buys her for fifteen pieces of silver and some barley and asks her to be faithful to him. *Hosea 3:1–3*

c. 750–725 BC
Israel in turmoil

Warns a failing nation

Kings are murdered one after another, and Israel turns to Egypt and Assyria for help. Hosea calls this unfaithfulness to God. *Hosea 7:7–11; 8:4, 9*

c. 722 BC
Fall of Samaria

The warnings come true

Assyria captures Samaria and takes Israel into exile, as Hosea had warned. Scripture does not say whether he lived to see it. *Hosea 13:16; 2 Kings 17:5–6*

Group notes

Key activities

Christians have read Hosea's marriage in different ways. Some think Gomer was already unfaithful when Hosea married her. Others think she became unfaithful later and the story is told looking back. Most think the woman in chapter 3 is Gomer, though the text does not name her.

1. **Obeyed a hard command.** He married Gomer as God told him, knowing his marriage would carry a message. *Hosea 1:2–3*
2. **Named his children as signs.** Their names warned Israel of judgment. God then promised to reverse them: "Ye are the sons of the living God." *Hosea 1:4–10; 2:23*
3. **Spoke of God as a husband.** God promised to win Israel back and said, "I will betroth thee unto me for ever." *Hosea 2:14–20*
4. **Loved his wife again.** He bought her back and waited for her, a picture of God waiting for Israel. *Hosea 3:1–5*
5. **Accused the priests.** "My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge," he said, because the priests had rejected knowledge. *Hosea 4:1–9*
6. **Named Israel's folly.** He warned that those who sow the wind will reap the whirlwind. *Hosea 7:11; 8:7*
7. **Showed God's heart.** God had loved Israel as a child and called his son out of Egypt, and could not give Ephraim up. *Hosea 11:1–9*
8. **Called Israel home.** He ended with an invitation: "O Israel, return unto the LORD thy God," and God's promise, "I will heal their backsliding." *Hosea 14:1–4*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Hosea.

Old Testament

Hosea 1–14	The book of his marriage and prophecies
2 Kings 14:23–17:23	Israel's last kings and the fall of Samaria
Echo: Jeremiah 3:1–14; Ezekiel 16	God's people as an unfaithful wife

New Testament

Matthew 9:13; 12:7	Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6: "I will have mercy, and not sacrifice"
Matthew 2:15	"Out of Egypt have I called my son" applied to Jesus
Romans 9:25–26; 1 Peter 2:10	"Not my people" become God's people
1 Corinthians 15:55	Paul's cry over death echoes Hosea 13:14
Luke 23:30; Revelation 6:16	Calling on the mountains, as in Hosea 10:8
Echo: Ephesians 5:25–27; Revelation 19:7	The church as Christ's bride

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Hosea do in Hosea 3:1–3, and what did it cost him?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God chose a marriage to picture his bond with his people?
3. *Apply:* God wants mercy more than routine (Hosea 6:6). Where has your faith become routine?
4. *Apply:* Whom do you need to keep loving though they hurt you? What is one step you could take?

93 Uzziah

A strong and gifted king whose pride carried him into the temple and out again a leper.

Uzziah, also called Azariah, became king of Judah at sixteen and reigned fifty-two years, one of the longest reigns in Judah's history. For most of it he did what was right. He sought God, and God made him prosper. He won wars, rebuilt Elath, fortified Jerusalem, dug wells, and loved farming. But success went to his head. He walked into the temple to burn incense, a task God had given only to the priests, and he was struck with leprosy on the spot. He spent his last years shut away while his son ruled for him. The year he died, Isaiah saw the true King on his throne.

At a glance

Names	Uzziah, "the LORD is my strength"; also Azariah (2 Kings 15:1)
Family	Son of Amaziah and Jecoliah; father of Jotham (2 Chronicles 26:1–3)
Reign	52 years from age 16, c. 792–740 BC, with co-regencies
Key places	Jerusalem, Elath, the temple
Key people	Zechariah his adviser; Azariah the priest; Jotham; Isaiah
Main passages	2 Kings 14:21–22; 15:1–7; 2 Chronicles 26
New Testament	Named as "Ozias" in Matthew 1:8–9

> *"But when he was strong, his heart was lifted up to his destruction: for he transgressed against the LORD his God, and went into the temple of the LORD to burn incense upon the altar of incense."*
>
> 2 Chronicles 26:16, KJV

The life of Uzziah

Dates are approximate (BC). Many scholars think Uzziah reigned alongside his father Amaziah at first, and that Jotham took over the daily rule after Uzziah became a leper. Scripture does not date the incense incident.

c. 792 BC
Age 16

Made king
The people of Judah make Uzziah king in place of his father Amaziah. *2 Kings 14:21; 2 Chronicles 26:1, 3*

Early reign

Rebuilds Elath
He builds Elath on the Red Sea and restores it to Judah. *2 Kings 14:22; 2 Chronicles 26:2*

In the days of Zechariah

Seeks God and prospers
He seeks God while Zechariah, a man with "understanding in the visions of God," guides him. As long as he seeks the LORD, God makes him prosper. *2 Chronicles 26:4–5*

His strong years

Wars and building
He defeats the Philistines and Arabians, receives gifts from the Ammonites, builds towers, digs wells, and equips a large army with new machines. *2 Chronicles 26:6–15*

c. 750 BC
Probably

Struck with leprosy
Proud and strong, he enters the temple to burn incense. The priests resist him. As he rages, leprosy breaks out on his forehead. *2 Chronicles 26:16–20*

c. 750–740 BC
Last years

Lives apart
He lives in a separate house until his death, while his son Jotham rules the palace and judges the people. *2 Kings 15:5; 2 Chronicles 26:21*

c. 740 BC
Age 68

Dies
He is buried in a field near the royal tombs, "for they said, He is a leper." That year Isaiah sees the Lord on his throne. *2 Chronicles 26:22–23; Isaiah 6:1*

Key activities

The Zechariah who guided Uzziah is not the later prophet Zechariah. Only priests descended from Aaron could burn incense in the holy place (Exodus 30:7–8; Numbers 16:40).

1. **Sought God.** He did right in the LORD's sight and sought God in the days of Zechariah. *2 Chronicles 26:4–5*
2. **Won back territory.** He fought the Philistines, broke down the walls of Gath, Jabneh and Ashdod, and built cities of his own. *2 Chronicles 26:6–8*
3. **Built and farmed.** He built towers in Jerusalem and the desert, dug many wells, and kept herds and vineyards, "for he loved husbandry." *2 Chronicles 26:9–10*
4. **Armed Judah.** He organized a trained army and made machines "invented by cunning men" to shoot arrows and great stones from the towers. *2 Chronicles 26:11–15*
5. **Grew proud.** Once he was strong, his heart was lifted up. *2 Chronicles 26:15–16*
6. **Took the priest's role.** He went into the temple to burn incense. Azariah and eighty priests told him it belonged only to the priests. *2 Chronicles 26:16–18*
7. **Raged and was struck.** He grew angry with the censer in his hand, and leprosy rose on his forehead. He hurried out, for the LORD had struck him. *2 Chronicles 26:19–20*
8. **Ended his days apart.** He lived as a leper, cut off from the house of the LORD, until he died. *2 Chronicles 26:21*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Uzziah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 14:21–22; 15:1–7	The short account, where he is called Azariah
2 Chronicles 26	The full account, including his pride and leprosy
2 Chronicles 26:22	Isaiah wrote his acts; that record is lost
Isaiah 1:1; 6:1	Isaiah dates his ministry and vision by Uzziah
Amos 1:1; Hosea 1:1; Zechariah 14:5	Other prophets date events by him
Echo: 1 Samuel 13:8–14	Saul offered a sacrifice not his to offer
Echo: Numbers 16:1–40	Korah's men took censers and died

New Testament

Matthew 1:8–9	"Ozias" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: James 4:6	"God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble"
Echo: Hebrews 7:1–3; 8:1	Jesus, King and true high priest

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How long did Uzziah prosper, according to 2 Chronicles 26:5?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think success made Uzziah proud instead of grateful?
3. *Apply:* Uzziah's trouble started when he was strong. Where are you most at risk of pride?
4. *Apply:* Who is a Zechariah for you, helping you seek God? How could you stay close to them?

94 Isaiah

The prophet who saw the Lord high and lifted up, and spoke of judgment, comfort and a coming King.

Isaiah son of Amoz prophesied in Jerusalem for about forty years or more, through the reigns of four kings of Judah. His ministry began with a vision of God's holiness in the temple, and his answer, "Here am I; send me," has echoed through the centuries. He confronted King Ahaz when fear drove him toward Assyria. He stood beside King Hezekiah when the Assyrian army surrounded Jerusalem. He warned of judgment on Judah and the nations, yet he also spoke some of Scripture's most tender words of comfort. His book looks ahead to a child called Immanuel, a Prince of Peace, and a suffering servant wounded for others. The New Testament quotes him more than any other prophet.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yeshayahu*, "the LORD saves"
Family	Son of Amoz; married to "the prophetess"; sons Shear-jashub and Maher-shalal-hash-baz (Isaiah 1:1; 7:3; 8:3)
When	Days of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, c. 740–c. 680 BC (Isaiah 1:1)
Key places	Jerusalem; the temple; the upper pool
Key people	Ahaz, Hezekiah, Sennacherib's officer the Rabshakeh
Main passages	Isaiah 1–66; 2 Kings 19–20; 2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:20, 32
New Testament	Quoted often, as "Esaias" (for example Matthew 3:3; Luke 4:17–19; John 12:38–41; Acts 8:28–35)

"Also I heard the voice of the Lord, saying, Whom shall I send, and who will go for us? Then said I, Here am I; send me."

Isaiah 6:8, KJV

The life of Isaiah

Dates are approximate (BC). The events of Isaiah 38–39 are placed around 701 BC because Hezekiah was given fifteen more years. Some date them a little earlier.

c. 740 BC
Year Uzziah died

The vision and call

Isaiah sees the Lord on a throne and seraphim crying, "Holy, holy, holy." A live coal touches his lips, and he answers God's call. *Isaiah 6:1–13*

c. 735 BC
Reign of Ahaz

The sign of Immanuel

Syria and Israel threaten Jerusalem. Isaiah meets Ahaz at the upper pool with his son and urges him to trust God. He gives the sign of a child called Immanuel. *Isaiah 7:1–16*

c. 734 BC
Soon after

A son as a sign

His wife bears a son named Maher-shalal-hash-baz. Before the boy can talk, Assyria will plunder Damascus and Samaria. *Isaiah 8:1–4*

c. 711 BC
Year of Ashdod

Walks barefoot

When Assyria attacks Ashdod, Isaiah goes stripped and barefoot for three years. It is a sign that Egypt and Ethiopia will be led away captive. *Isaiah 20:1–6*

c. 701 BC
Sennacherib's invasion

God will defend the city

Hezekiah sends to him in distress. Isaiah answers that the Assyrian king will not enter Jerusalem. That night the angel of the LORD strikes the camp. *2 Kings 19:1–7, 20–37*

c. 701 BC
Hezekiah's illness

Death, then life

Isaiah tells the king to set his house in order. After Hezekiah prays, Isaiah brings word of fifteen more years and a sign on the sundial. *2 Kings 20:1–11; Isaiah 38:1–8*

c. 701 BC
Envoys from Babylon

A warning of exile

Hezekiah shows his treasures to visitors from Babylon. Isaiah foretells that everything will one day be carried there. *2 Kings 20:12–19; Isaiah 39:1–8*

Key activities

Many scholars think later prophets wrote or completed chapters 40–66; many others hold that Isaiah wrote the whole book.

1. **Saw God's holiness.** In the temple he saw the Lord "high and lifted up" and cried, "Woe is me! for I am undone." *Isaiah 6:1–5*
2. **Answered the call.** Cleansed by the live coal, he offered himself: "Here am I; send me." *Isaiah 6:6–8*
3. **Called for justice.** He told Judah to relieve the oppressed. "Though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow." *Isaiah 1:16–18*
4. **Challenged a frightened king.** He urged Ahaz to trust God instead of foreign powers. "If ye will not believe, surely ye shall not be established." *Isaiah 7:1–9*
5. **Gave signs through his family.** He said that he and his children were "for signs and for wonders in Israel." *Isaiah 7:3; 8:1–4, 18*
6. **Foretold a royal child.** A child would be born, called Wonderful, Counsellor, the mighty God, the everlasting Father, the Prince of Peace. *Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–10*
7. **Acted out a warning.** He walked barefoot for three years to warn against trusting Egypt. *Isaiah 20:2–6*
8. **Strengthened Hezekiah.** When Jerusalem was besieged, he told the king not to be afraid and prayed with him. *2 Kings 19:6–7; 2 Chronicles 32:20*
9. **Brought news of healing.** He announced Hezekiah's death, then his recovery. *2 Kings 20:1–7*
10. **Recorded history.** He wrote the acts of Uzziah and of Hezekiah. *2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:32*
11. **Spoke comfort.** "Comfort ye, comfort ye my people, saith your God." *Isaiah 40:1–11, 28–31*
12. **Described the suffering servant.** "He was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities." *Isaiah 52:13–53:12*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Isaiah.

Old Testament

Isaiah 1–66	His book of prophecy, history (36–39) and poetry
2 Kings 19–20; 2 Chronicles 32:20, 32	His part in Hezekiah's reign
2 Chronicles 26:22	He wrote an account of Uzziah's reign
Echo: Micah 4:1–3	Swords into plowshares, as in Isaiah 2:2–4
Echo: Jeremiah 1:9; Ezekiel 2:8–3:4	God puts his words in their mouths

New Testament

Matthew 1:22–23	Isaiah 7:14 fulfilled; some see a first fulfilment too
Matthew 3:3	John is "the voice of one crying in the wilderness"
Luke 4:16–21	In Nazareth Jesus reads Isaiah 61:1–2 as fulfilled
John 12:38–41	Isaiah saw Christ's glory and spoke of him
Acts 8:28–35	From Isaiah 53, Philip preaches Jesus
Tradition	Later writings say he was sawn in two (cf. Hebrews 11:37)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Isaiah see and hear before he said, "Here am I; send me" (Isaiah 6:1–8)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think a vision of God's holiness made Isaiah feel "undone" before it made him ready to serve?
3. *Apply:* Ahaz trusted a powerful ally more than God. What do you lean on when you are afraid?
4. *Apply:* Isaiah spoke hard truth and deep comfort. Who needs one of those from you this week?

95 Micah

A country prophet who named the sins of the powerful and pointed to a ruler from Bethlehem.

Micah came from Moresheth, a small town in the lowlands of Judah, far from the palaces of Jerusalem. He prophesied in the days of Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, at the same time as Isaiah. He saw what the powerful were doing to ordinary families: seizing fields and houses, bribing judges, and hiring prophets to say what they wanted to hear. Micah warned that Samaria would fall and that even Jerusalem would be ploughed like a field. A century later, his words were remembered at Jeremiah's trial, because King Hezekiah had listened and repented. Micah also foretold a ruler from little Bethlehem, and he summed up God's will in one of the Bible's best-known sentences: do justly, love mercy, walk humbly with God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Mikhah*, short for "Who is like the LORD?"
Home	Moresheth, probably Moresheth-gath in the lowlands of Judah (Micah 1:1, 14)
When	Days of Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah, c. 735–700 BC (Micah 1:1)
Audience	Samaria and Jerusalem, the two capitals (Micah 1:1)
Key people	Hezekiah; the prophet Isaiah, his contemporary
Main passages	Micah 1–7; Jeremiah 26:17–19
New Testament	Matthew 2:5–6; 10:35–36

"He hath shewed thee, O man, what is good; and what doth the LORD require of thee, but to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with thy God?"

Micah 6:8, KJV

The life of Micah

Dates are approximate (BC). Micah does not date his individual messages, so the order below is partly a best guess.

Before his call
At Moresheth

A man from the lowlands

Micah grows up in a farming town southwest of Jerusalem, close to the border with the Philistines. *Micah 1:1, 14*

c. 735 BC
Days of Jotham

The word comes

The word of the LORD comes to Micah concerning Samaria and Jerusalem. *Micah 1:1*

Before 722 BC
Warning to the north

Samaria will fall

He announces that Samaria will become a heap in the field, and that the same judgment is coming to the gate of Jerusalem. *Micah 1:2–9*

c. 715–701 BC
Days of Hezekiah

Zion will be ploughed

He warns that Jerusalem will be ploughed like a field for its leaders' sins. Hezekiah fears the LORD and prays, and the disaster is held back. *Micah 3:9–12; Jeremiah 26:18–19*

Undated

A ruler from Bethlehem

He foretells that a ruler in Israel will come from Bethlehem Ephratah, "whose goings forth have been from of old, from everlasting." *Micah 5:2–5*

c. 609 BC
About a century later

Quoted to save Jeremiah

When priests and prophets demand Jeremiah's death, some elders recall Micah's words and Hezekiah's response. *Jeremiah 26:1, 16–19, 24*

Group notes

Key activities

Micah 4:1–3 closely matches Isaiah 2:2–4. Scholars differ on whether one prophet borrowed from the other or both used an older saying. Micah is also a different man from Micaiah, who spoke to King Ahab (1 Kings 22).

1. **Lamented his people's ruin.** He said he would wail and go stripped and barefoot because Judah's wound was incurable. *Micah 1:8–9*
2. **Exposed land grabs.** He condemned those who lie awake planning evil and at morning light seize fields and houses. *Micah 2:1–2*
3. **Confronted leaders.** He rebuked rulers who judged for bribes, priests who taught for hire, and prophets who divined for money. *Micah 3:1–11*
4. **Spoke with God's power.** Unlike the false prophets, he said he was full of power by the Spirit of the LORD, to declare Israel's sin. *Micah 3:5–8*
5. **Promised peace.** He foresaw a day when nations would "beat their swords into plowshares" and everyone would sit under his own vine and fig tree. *Micah 4:1–4*
6. **Pointed to Bethlehem.** He foretold a ruler from the small town of Bethlehem who would shepherd God's people. *Micah 5:2–4*
7. **Summed up God's will.** Not endless sacrifices, but justice, mercy and humble walking with God. *Micah 6:6–8*
8. **Waited for God.** "Therefore I will look unto the LORD; I will wait for the God of my salvation." *Micah 7:7*
9. **Praised God's mercy.** "Who is a God like unto thee, that pardoneth iniquity?" He will cast all their sins "into the depths of the sea." *Micah 7:18–19*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Micah.

Old Testament

Micah 1–7	The book of his prophecies
Jeremiah 26:17–19	Elders quote Micah 3:12 and help save Jeremiah's life
Echo: Isaiah 2:2–4	The same vision of peace, in the same years
Echo: Amos 5:24	Justice to "run down as waters"

New Testament

Matthew 2:5–6	Micah 5:2 tells Herod where the Christ would be born
John 7:42	The Christ comes "out of the town of Bethlehem"
Matthew 10:35–36	Jesus uses Micah 7:6 on divided households
Echo: Matthew 23:23	"Judgment, mercy, and faith," the weightier matters
Echo: Hebrews 8:12	God remembers our sins no more

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things does God require in Micah 6:8?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Micah links worship so closely with how people treat their neighbours?
3. *Apply:* Which of the three, justice, mercy or humility, is hardest for you right now? What would one step look like?
4. *Apply:* Micah's words changed a king. Whose words has God used to change your direction, and whom could you encourage this week?

96 Hezekiah

The king who trusted God when the Assyrian army stood at Jerusalem's walls.

Hezekiah was the son of Ahaz, one of Judah's worst kings, yet he became one of its best. In his first month as king he reopened the temple his father had shut, cleansed it, and called all Israel to keep the Passover. He smashed idols and even the bronze serpent Moses had made, because people were burning incense to it. When Sennacherib of Assyria invaded and demanded surrender, Hezekiah spread the enemy's letter before the LORD and prayed, and Jerusalem was saved. When he fell ill, he wept and prayed, and God gave him fifteen more years. Pride later led him to show off his treasures to Babylon's envoys. But Scripture says no king of Judah trusted the LORD like him.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Chizqiyahu*, "the LORD strengthens"
Family	Son of Ahaz and Abi; father of Manasseh (2 Kings 18:2)
Reign	29 years from age 25, c. 715–686 BC (some say from c. 729)
Key places	Jerusalem, the temple, Lachish, the Gihon spring
Key people	Isaiah, Micah, Sennacherib, the Rabshakeh, Merodach-baladan
Main passages	2 Kings 18–20; 2 Chronicles 29–32; Isaiah 36–39
New Testament	Named as "Ezekias" in Matthew 1:9–10

> *"He trusted in the LORD God of Israel; so that after him was none like him among all the kings of Judah, nor any that were before him."*
>
> 2 Kings 18:5, KJV

The life of Hezekiah

Dates are approximate (BC). 2 Kings 18:13 fits an accession c. 715 BC; 2 Kings 18:9–10 leads some to date it c. 729 BC, perhaps as co-regent.

c. 715 BC
Age 25

Becomes king
Hezekiah succeeds Ahaz and does right in the sight of the LORD, as David had done. *2 Kings 18:1–3; 2 Chronicles 29:1–2*

c. 715 BC
First month

Reopens the temple
He repairs the temple doors and has the priests and Levites cleanse the house. Worship is restored. *2 Chronicles 29:3–36*

Early in his reign

Passover for all Israel
He invites everyone from Beersheba to Dan. Many in the north mock, but some come, and there is great joy. *2 Chronicles 30:1–27*

Early in his reign

Tears down idols
He removes the high places and destroys the bronze serpent, calling it Nehushtan. *2 Kings 18:4; 2 Chronicles 31:1*

c. 701 BC
14th year

Sennacherib invades
Assyria takes Judah's fortified cities. Hezekiah pays heavy tribute, but an army still comes to Jerusalem. *2 Kings 18:13–17*

c. 701 BC
Under siege

Prayer and deliverance
The Rabshakeh mocks Judah's God. Hezekiah prays, and the angel of the LORD strikes the Assyrian camp. *2 Kings 18:17–19:37*

c. 701 BC
Age about 39

Sick unto death
Isaiah tells him to set his house in order. Hezekiah weeps and prays, and God adds fifteen years to his life. *2 Kings 20:1–11; Isaiah 38:1–22*

c. 686 BC
Age 54

Dies
He is buried with honour, and his son Manasseh reigns in his place. *2 Kings 20:21; 2 Chronicles 32:33*

Key activities

Sennacherib's own records say he shut Hezekiah up in Jerusalem "like a bird in a cage," but they do not claim that he took the city. Carvings of his siege of Lachish survive from his palace at Nineveh.

1. **Reopened God's house.** In his first month he opened the temple doors and restored worship. *2 Chronicles 29:3–19*
2. **Invited the whole nation.** He called Judah and the remnant of the north to one Passover in Jerusalem. *2 Chronicles 30:1–12*
3. **Prayed for the unready.** For those who ate unclean he prayed, "The good LORD pardon every one." *2 Chronicles 30:17–20*
4. **Broke the bronze serpent.** He destroyed a holy relic from Moses' day because it had become an idol. *2 Kings 18:4*
5. **Threw off Assyria's yoke.** The LORD was with him, and he rebelled against the king of Assyria and defeated the Philistines. *2 Kings 18:7–8*
6. **Prepared the city.** He stopped the outside springs, rebuilt the wall, and piped water into Jerusalem. *2 Kings 20:20; 2 Chronicles 32:2–5, 30*
7. **Encouraged his people.** "With him is an arm of flesh; but with us is the LORD our God to help us, and to fight our battles." *2 Chronicles 32:6–8*
8. **Spread the letter before God.** He took Sennacherib's letter into the temple and prayed that all kingdoms would know the LORD. *2 Kings 19:14–19*
9. **Wept and was healed.** He turned his face to the wall and prayed. God said, "I have heard thy prayer, I have seen thy tears." *2 Kings 20:2–6*
10. **Showed off his treasures.** He showed Babylon's envoys everything; Isaiah warned it would all go to Babylon. *2 Kings 20:12–19; 2 Chronicles 32:25–26, 31*
11. **Preserved wisdom.** His officials copied out a collection of Solomon's proverbs. *Proverbs 25:1*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Hezekiah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 18–20; 2 Chronicles 29–32; Isaiah 36–39	Three accounts of his reign
Isaiah 38:9–20	His psalm after recovering from illness
Proverbs 25:1	Proverbs "which the men of Hezekiah ... copied out"
Jeremiah 26:18–19	Elders recall that he heeded Micah's warning
Hosea 1:1; Micah 1:1	Prophets who ministered in his reign
Echo: 2 Chronicles 20:1–12	Jehoshaphat also prayed before a great army

New Testament

Matthew 1:9–10	"Ezekias" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: Hebrews 5:7	Jesus prayed "with strong crying and tears"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Hezekiah do with Sennacherib's letter (2 Kings 19:14–19)?
2. *Understand:* Hezekiah trusted God under siege but grew proud after he was healed. Why is success sometimes harder to handle than trouble?
3. *Apply:* What "letter" or threat could you spread out before God in prayer this week?
4. *Apply:* Hezekiah broke even a relic from Moses once it became an idol. Is there something good in your life that has taken God's place?

97 Manasseh

Judah's most wicked king, who was humbled in chains and found that God still hears.

Manasseh was the son of good King Hezekiah, but he undid almost everything his father had done. He became king at twelve and reigned fifty-five years, longer than any other king of Judah. He set up altars to Baal and the stars inside the temple, practised sorcery, made his children pass through the fire, and filled Jerusalem with innocent blood. Kings says his sins sealed Judah's fate. Yet Chronicles adds a surprising turn. Taken to Babylon in chains by the Assyrians, Manasseh humbled himself and prayed, and God brought him home. He spent his last years trying to repair the damage.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Menashsheh,* "causing to forget" (Genesis 41:51)
Family	Son of Hezekiah and Hephzibah; father of Amon (2 Kings 21:1, 18)
Reign	55 years from age 12, c. 697–642 BC, probably first with his father
Key places	Jerusalem, the temple, the valley of Hinnom, Babylon
Key people	Hezekiah, Amon, the prophets, the king of Assyria
Main passages	2 Kings 21:1–18; 2 Chronicles 33:1–20
New Testament	Named as "Manasses" in Matthew 1:10

> *"And prayed unto him: and he was intreated of him, and heard his supplication, and brought him again to Jerusalem into his kingdom. Then Manasseh knew that the LORD he was God."*
>
> 2 Chronicles 33:13, KJV

The life of Manasseh

Dates are approximate (BC). Many scholars think Manasseh reigned with his father from c. 697 BC and alone from c. 686 BC. Scripture does not say when he was taken to Babylon.

c. 697 BC
Age 12

Becomes king

Manasseh begins his reign of fifty-five years in Jerusalem. *2 Kings 21:1; 2 Chronicles 33:1*

c. 686 BC
Sole king

Undoes his father's reforms

He rebuilds the high places, raises altars to Baal, makes an Asherah pole, and worships the stars, even in the temple courts. *2 Kings 21:2–7; 2 Chronicles 33:2–7*

During his reign

Deaf to the prophets

The LORD warns through his prophets that he will wipe Jerusalem "as a man wipeth a dish." Manasseh and his people will not listen. *2 Kings 21:10–15; 2 Chronicles 33:10*

During his reign

Innocent blood

He sheds so much innocent blood that Jerusalem is filled with it from one end to the other. *2 Kings 21:16*

Date unknown

Captive and humbled

The captains of the king of Assyria bind him with fetters and carry him to Babylon. In distress he humbles himself and prays, and God restores him to Jerusalem. *2 Chronicles 33:11–13*

After his return

Repairs the damage

He removes the foreign gods from the temple, restores the LORD's altar, and commands Judah to serve the LORD. He also strengthens Jerusalem's walls. *2 Chronicles 33:14–17*

c. 642 BC
Age 67

Dies

He is buried in the garden of his own house, and his son Amon reigns. *2 Kings 21:18; 2 Chronicles 33:20*

Key activities

Kings does not mention Manasseh's repentance. It stresses that his sins were so great that judgment on Judah could not be turned back (2 Kings 23:26; 24:3–4). Chronicles adds his captivity and prayer. The two accounts stand side by side.

1. **Rebuilt what his father tore down.** He restored the high places Hezekiah had destroyed. *2 Kings 21:3*
2. **Defiled the temple.** He built altars for the host of heaven in both temple courts and set a carved idol in the house of God. *2 Kings 21:4–7; 2 Chronicles 33:4–7*
3. **Gave his children to the fire.** He made his children pass through the fire in the valley of the son of Hinnom and turned to witchcraft and mediums. *2 Kings 21:6; 2 Chronicles 33:6*
4. **Led Judah astray.** He led the people to do more evil than the nations God had driven out. *2 Kings 21:9; 2 Chronicles 33:9*
5. **Shed innocent blood.** He "shed innocent blood very much, till he had filled Jerusalem from one end to another." *2 Kings 21:16*
6. **Humbled himself in chains.** In Babylon he "besought the LORD his God, and humbled himself greatly." *2 Chronicles 33:11–12*
7. **Knew the LORD was God.** God heard him and brought him home, and he learned who God really was. *2 Chronicles 33:13*
8. **Tried to undo the harm.** He removed the idols, restored true worship, and built up Jerusalem's defences. The people still sacrificed at the high places, though now to the LORD. *2 Chronicles 33:14–17*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Manasseh.

Old Testament

2 Kings 21:1–18; 2 Chronicles 33:1–20	The two accounts of his reign
2 Kings 23:26; 24:3–4	Judah's fall traced to his sins and innocent blood
Jeremiah 15:4	Exile "because of Manasseh the son of Hezekiah"
2 Chronicles 33:18–19	His prayer recorded among the kings and seers
Echo: 1 Kings 21:27–29	Ahab humbled himself, and judgment was delayed
Echo: Isaiah 1:18	Sins as scarlet made "white as snow"

New Testament

Matthew 1:10	"Manasses" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: Luke 15:17–24	The prodigal comes to himself and goes home
Echo: 1 Timothy 1:15–16	The chief of sinners, shown mercy as a pattern

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What happened to Manasseh in Babylon, and what did he do there (2 Chronicles 33:11–13)?
2. *Understand:* Manasseh was forgiven, yet the harm he did lived on after him. How do both of those things fit together?
3. *Apply:* Is there anyone you think is too far gone for God? How does Manasseh's story challenge that?
4. *Apply:* Manasseh tried to repair what he had broken. Is there something you need to put right, and what is the first step?

98 Josiah

The boy king who found the Book of the Law and turned Judah back to God.

Grandson of Manasseh, the most wicked of Judah's kings, Josiah became its most wholehearted reformer. Named in prophecy three centuries before his birth, he took the throne at eight. When a forgotten scroll of God's Law was found in the temple, he wept, gathered the nation, and led the most thorough return to God in Judah's history.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yoshiyahu*, "the LORD supports" or "the LORD heals"
Family	Son of King Amon; mother Jedidah (2 Kings 22:1)
Reign	c. 640–609 BC; crowned at 8, reigned 31 years
Death	Age 39, in battle against Pharaoh Neco at Megiddo
Sons	Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Zedekiah (1 Chronicles 3:15)
Key people	Hilkiah, Shaphan, Huldah, Jeremiah, Zephaniah
Main passages	2 Kings 22–23; 2 Chronicles 34–35
New Testament	Named once, in Jesus' genealogy (Matthew 1:10–11)

"And like unto him was there no king before him, that turned to the LORD with all his heart, and with all his soul, and with all his might … neither after him arose there any like him."

2 Kings 23:25, KJV

The life of Josiah

Dates are approximate (BC). Years count from the start of his reign.

c. 930 BC
300 yrs before

Prophesied by name
A man of God at Bethel foretells that a son of David named Josiah will burn priests' bones on Jeroboam's altar. *1 Kings 13:1–3*

c. 640 BC
Age 8

Crowned king
After servants assassinate his father Amon, the people of the land make young Josiah king. *2 Kings 21:23–22:1*

c. 632 BC
Age 16

Begins to seek God
While still young, he begins to seek the God of David his father. *2 Chronicles 34:3*

c. 628 BC
Age 20

Purges the land
He tears down high places, Asherah poles and idols in Judah, Jerusalem and the northern tribes. *2 Chronicles 34:3–7*

c. 627 BC
13th year

Jeremiah is called
The word of the LORD comes to young Jeremiah; Zephaniah also prophesies. *Jeremiah 1:1–2; Zephaniah 1:1*

c. 622 BC
Age 26

The Book is found
Hilkiah finds the Book of the Law in the temple. Josiah hears it, tears his clothes, and consults Huldah. *2 Kings 22:3–20*

c. 622 BC
18th year

Covenant and Passover
He reads the Book to all the people, cleanses the land, and keeps a Passover unmatched since Samuel. *2 Kings 23:1–25*

c. 609 BC
Age 39

Death at Megiddo
Ignoring Pharaoh Neco's warning, he is shot by archers and dies. Jeremiah laments him. *2 Chronicles 35:20–25*

Key activities

Kings tells the reforms after the Book is found; Chronicles puts the first purge six years earlier.

1. **Sought God while young.** His faith began as a personal search at sixteen. *2 Chronicles 34:3*
2. **Purged Judah and the north.** He broke down altars, Asherah poles and images and ground them to dust. *2 Chronicles 34:3–7*
3. **Repaired the temple.** He paid workers so trusted that no accounting was asked. *2 Kings 22:3–7*
4. **Heard the Book and wept.** He tore his clothes when the rediscovered Law was read to him. *2 Kings 22:8–13*
5. **Inquired of Huldah.** Judgment would come, but not in his days, because his heart was tender. *2 Kings 22:14–20*
6. **Renewed the covenant.** He read the whole Book aloud and pledged the nation to keep it. *2 Kings 23:1–3*
7. **Cleansed the temple.** He burned the vessels made for Baal, Asherah and the stars in the Kidron fields. *2 Kings 23:4–7*
8. **Ended the high places.** He deposed idol priests and tore down shrines, including Solomon's. *2 Kings 23:5, 8–9, 13–14*
9. **Stopped child sacrifice and the occult.** He defiled Topheth and removed the mediums and household idols. *2 Kings 23:10–12, 24*
10. **Fulfilled prophecy at Bethel.** He burned bones on Jeroboam's altar but spared the prophet's tomb. *2 Kings 23:15–20*
11. **Kept the great Passover.** There had been none like it since Samuel. *2 Kings 23:21–23; 2 Chronicles 35:1–19*
12. **Fell at Megiddo.** He would not heed Pharaoh Neco's warning, and he was shot and died. *2 Chronicles 35:20–24*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Josiah.

Old Testament

1 Kings 13:1–3	Named in prophecy; fulfilled in 2 Kings 23:15–18
2 Kings 21:23–23:30	The main account of his reign
2 Chronicles 33:25–35:27	The parallel account, with the Passover in detail
1 Chronicles 3:14–15	Son of Amon; his four sons
Jeremiah 1:2; Zephaniah 1:1	Prophets of his reign
Jeremiah 22:15–16	Praised for justice to the poor
Zechariah 12:11	Mourning at Megiddo, often linked to his death

New Testament

Matthew 1:10–11	In Jesus' line; "Jechonias" is his grandson
Luke 3:23–38	Luke traces the line through Nathan, so Josiah is absent
Echo: John 2:13–17	A son of David cleanses the temple
Echo: Luke 22:7–20	The Passover fulfilled

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Josiah do the moment he heard the Book of the Law (2 Kings 22:11–13)?
2. *Understand:* Huldah said judgment would still come. Why do you think Josiah reformed the nation anyway?
3. *Apply:* Josiah broke with his family's pattern. What habit would you like to break with God's help?
4. *Apply:* Is there a "lost book" in your life, such as Scripture or prayer? What is one step toward it this week?

99 Huldah

The prophetess the king's men consulted when the Book of the Law was found.

Huldah lived in Jerusalem in the days of King Josiah. She was married to Shallum, the keeper of the royal wardrobe, and Scripture calls her "the prophetess." In 622 BC, workers repairing the temple found the Book of the Law. When it was read to Josiah, he tore his clothes in grief and sent his highest officials to ask the LORD what it meant. They went to Huldah. Her answer was clear and brave. Judgment would come on Jerusalem, just as the Book said. But because the king's heart was tender, the disaster would not come in his lifetime. Her words moved Josiah to lead the nation in renewing its covenant with God.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Chuldah*, often explained as "weasel" or "mole"
Family	Wife of Shallum son of Tikvah, keeper of the wardrobe (2 Kings 22:14)
Home	Jerusalem, in "the college," probably a newer district
When	Josiah's eighteenth year, c. 622 BC
Key people	Josiah, Hilkiah the priest, Shaphan the scribe, Ahikam, Achbor, Asahiah
Main passages	2 Kings 22:8–20; 2 Chronicles 34:14–28
New Testament	Not named

"Because thine heart was tender, and thou hast humbled thyself before the LORD … and hast rent thy clothes, and wept before me; I also have heard thee, saith the LORD."

2 Kings 22:19, KJV

The life of Huldah

Dates are approximate (BC) and agree with the Josiah chapter. All we know of Huldah comes from one scene, told twice.

Before c. 622 BC
In Jerusalem

A prophetess at home

Huldah lives in Jerusalem's second quarter with her husband Shallum, who keeps the wardrobe, probably the royal or temple robes. *2 Kings 22:14; 2 Chronicles 34:22*

c. 622 BC
Josiah's 18th year

The Book is found

Hilkiah the high priest finds the Book of the Law in the temple. Shaphan reads it to the king, who tears his clothes. *2 Kings 22:8–13*

c. 622 BC
The same year

The king's men come

Josiah sends Hilkiah, Shaphan, Ahikam, Achbor and Asahiah to inquire of the LORD. They go to Huldah. *2 Kings 22:12–14; 2 Chronicles 34:20–22*

c. 622 BC
Her answer

Judgment and mercy

She says the Book's curses will fall on Jerusalem, because the people have forsaken God. But Josiah will be gathered to his grave in peace. *2 Kings 22:15–20; 2 Chronicles 34:23–28*

c. 622 BC
Soon after

The covenant renewed

The king gathers the people, reads the Book to them, and makes a covenant to follow the LORD. *2 Kings 23:1–3*

c. 609 and 586 BC
Years later

Her words come true

Josiah dies before the disaster, and Jerusalem falls to Babylon about 36 years after her prophecy. *2 Kings 23:29–30; 25:8–10*

Group notes

Key activities

Huldah said Josiah would go to his grave "in peace," yet he died in battle (2 Kings 23:29). Most readers take her words to mean he would die before the disaster fell, which he did.

1. **Was sought out.** The king's highest officials came to her for the word of the LORD. *2 Kings 22:14*
2. **Spoke with authority.** She began, "Thus saith the LORD God of Israel, Tell the man that sent you to me." *2 Kings 22:15*
3. **Confirmed the Book.** She said all the words of the Book the king had read would come true. *2 Kings 22:16–17*
4. **Did not soften judgment.** She named the reason plainly: the people had forsaken God and burned incense to other gods. *2 Kings 22:17*
5. **Spoke mercy to the king.** Because Josiah had humbled himself and wept, God had heard him. *2 Kings 22:18–20*
6. **Set reform in motion.** Her message led straight to the covenant renewal and the cleansing of the land. *2 Kings 23:1–25*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Huldah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 22:14–20	and **2 Chronicles 34:22–28.** The two accounts of her prophecy.
2 Kings 23:1–3	The covenant renewal that followed.
Echoes	Miriam and Deborah were earlier prophetesses (Exodus 15:20; Judges 4:4). Isaiah's wife is called "the prophetess" (Isaiah 8:3). God promised to pour out his Spirit so that "your sons and your daughters shall prophesy" (Joel 2:28).

New Testament

Echoes	Anna the prophetess speaks of the child Jesus in the temple (Luke 2:36–38). Peter quotes Joel's promise at Pentecost (Acts 2:16–18). Philip the evangelist had four daughters who prophesied (Acts 21:9).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What were the two parts of Huldah's message (2 Kings 22:15–20)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Josiah's officials trusted Huldah to tell them the truth?
3. *Apply:* Huldah gave an unwelcome message faithfully. When have you needed to say something true but hard? How did you do it?
4. *Apply:* Josiah's tender heart mattered to God. What would it look like for you to respond to Scripture with that kind of heart this week?

100 Jeremiah

The weeping prophet who warned Jerusalem for forty years and promised a new covenant.

Jeremiah was a young man from a priestly family in Anathoth when God called him in King Josiah's thirteenth year. For about forty years, through Judah's last kings, he warned that Babylon would destroy Jerusalem unless the people turned back to God. Few listened. He was beaten, put in the stocks, thrown into a muddy cistern and accused of treason. He wept and argued honestly with God. Yet he bought a field during the siege as a sign of hope, and foretold a new covenant written on the heart. He saw Jerusalem fall and ended his days in Egypt.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yirmeyahu*, perhaps "the LORD lifts up"
Family	Son of Hilkiah, priest of Anathoth; unmarried (Jeremiah 1:1; 16:2)
When	c. 627 BC to after Jerusalem's fall in 586 BC
Key places	Anathoth, Jerusalem, the court of the prison, Egypt
Key people	Baruch, Jehoiakim, Zedekiah, Ebed-melech, Gedaliah
Main passages	Jeremiah 1–52; 2 Chronicles 35:25; 36:12, 21
New Testament	Matthew 2:17–18; 16:14; Hebrews 8:8–12

"Before I formed thee in the belly I knew thee; and before thou camest forth out of the womb I sanctified thee, and I ordained thee a prophet unto the nations."

Jeremiah 1:5, KJV

The life of Jeremiah

Dates are approximate (BC). The book is not in time order, so entries gather events from different chapters.

c. 627 BC
13th year of Josiah

Called as a youth

He says he is only a child. God touches his mouth and sets him over nations. *Jeremiah 1:1–10*

c. 609 BC
Start of Jehoiakim's reign

The temple sermon

He warns that the temple will not save lawbreakers. Priests demand his death, but Ahikam protects him. *Jeremiah 7:1–15; 26:1–24*

c. 605–604 BC
Jehoiakim's 4th–5th years

The scroll burned

Baruch reads Jeremiah's words in the temple. The king cuts up the scroll and burns it, and Jeremiah dictates it again. *Jeremiah 36:1–32*

c. 594 BC
4th year of Zedekiah

The yoke

Jeremiah wears a yoke and tells the nations to serve Babylon. Hananiah breaks it and dies that year. *Jeremiah 27:2–12; 28:1–17*

c. 588 BC
During the siege

Prison and the cistern

Arrested as a deserter, he is lowered into a muddy cistern, and Ebed-melech pulls him out. *Jeremiah 37:11–38:13*

c. 587 BC
10th year of Zedekiah

Buys a field

From prison he buys his cousin's field at Anathoth as a sign that fields will again be bought. *Jeremiah 32:1–15*

c. 586 BC
Jerusalem falls

Set free

The Babylonians release him, and he stays with Gedaliah at Mizpah. *Jeremiah 39:1–14; 40:1–6*

After c. 586 BC
In Egypt

Carried away

After Gedaliah is murdered, the survivors flee to Egypt and take Jeremiah and Baruch with them. *Jeremiah 41:1–43:7; 44:1*

Key activities

Jeremiah is often called "the weeping prophet." Tradition names him as the author of Lamentations, though the book itself does not name its author.

1. **Accepted a hard call.** He felt too young, but God said, "Behold, I have put my words in thy mouth." *Jeremiah 1:6–9*
2. **Preached at the temple gate.** He told Judah to amend their ways, and warned that the temple had become "a den of robbers." *Jeremiah 7:1–11*
3. **Acted out God's message.** He used a linen girdle, a potter's clay, a broken bottle and a wooden yoke as signs. *Jeremiah 13:1–11; 18:1–6; 19:1–11; 27:2*
4. **Suffered for the truth.** Pashur the priest had him beaten and put in the stocks. *Jeremiah 20:1–2*
5. **Poured out his heart.** He complained bitterly to God, yet said the word was like "a burning fire shut up in my bones." *Jeremiah 20:7–18*
6. **Wrote to the exiles.** He told them to build houses, plant gardens and seek the peace of Babylon, for they would return after seventy years. *Jeremiah 29:4–14*
7. **Promised a new covenant.** God would write his law in their hearts and remember their sin no more. *Jeremiah 31:31–34*
8. **Bought a field in a war zone.** He paid for land the Babylonians were about to take, trusting that nothing was too hard for God. *Jeremiah 32:6–27*
9. **Spoke plainly to a weak king.** He told Zedekiah in secret that surrender to Babylon would save the city. *Jeremiah 38:14–23*
10. **Stayed with those left behind.** Offered a place in Babylon, he chose to stay with those left in the land. *Jeremiah 40:1–6*
11. **Warned against fleeing to Egypt.** He told the survivors to remain in Judah, but they would not listen. *Jeremiah 42:7–43:4*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Jeremiah.

Old Testament

Jeremiah 1–52	His book of prophecies, laments and history
2 Chronicles 35:25	He wrote a lament for Josiah
2 Chronicles 36:12, 21–22; Ezra 1:1	Zedekiah ignored him; the return fulfilled his word
Daniel 9:2	Daniel reads his prophecy of seventy years
Echo: Ezekiel 1:1–3	The same message to the exiles in Babylon

New Testament

Matthew 2:17–18	Rachel weeping (Jeremiah 31:15) and Bethlehem's children
Matthew 16:14	Some thought Jesus was "Jeremias"
Matthew 21:13	"A den of thieves," echoing Jeremiah 7:11
Luke 22:20; Hebrews 8:8–12	The new covenant; Hebrews quotes Jeremiah 31:31–34
Tradition	Later writers say he was stoned in Egypt; Scripture is silent

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What excuse did Jeremiah give, and how did God answer it (Jeremiah 1:6–9)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God had Jeremiah buy a field just before Jerusalem fell (Jeremiah 32:6–15)?
3. *Apply:* Jeremiah told God exactly how he felt. What would it look like for you to be that honest with God in prayer?
4. *Apply:* The exiles were told to seek the good of the city where they lived. What is one way you could do that where you live?

101 Habakkuk

The prophet who argued with God and learned to rejoice when everything failed.

Habakkuk is different from most prophets. Instead of carrying God's word to the people, he brings the people's questions to God. He lived in Judah shortly before the Babylonian invasions, and he was troubled by the violence and injustice he saw around him. Why did God not act? God's answer shocked him: he was raising up the Chaldeans, the Babylonians, to judge Judah. That raised a harder question. How could a holy God use a nation more wicked than Judah? Habakkuk climbed his watchtower to wait. God told him that "the just shall live by his faith." His book ends with a song of trust that has comforted believers in hard times ever since.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Chavaqquq*, possibly from a word meaning "embrace"
Family	Not recorded
Title	"Habakkuk the prophet" (Habakkuk 1:1; 3:1)
When	Probably c. 605 BC, as Babylon rose to power (dates of c. 610–600 BC are also proposed)
Key places	Judah; his watchtower; the temple (Habakkuk 2:1, 20)
Main passages	Habakkuk 1–3
New Testament	Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:37–38; Acts 13:40–41

"Yet I will rejoice in the LORD, I will joy in the God of my salvation."

Habakkuk 3:18, KJV

The life of Habakkuk

Dates are approximate (BC). Habakkuk gives no date or king. Most scholars place him around the time Babylon defeated Egypt at Carchemish in 605 BC (Jeremiah 46:2). His book is a conversation, so the entries follow its order.

c. 605 BC
Before the invasion

"How long?"

Habakkuk cries out that he sees violence, strife and injustice, and God does not seem to hear or save. *Habakkuk 1:1–4*

c. 605 BC
God's first answer

The Chaldeans are coming

God says he is raising up the Chaldeans, "that bitter and hasty nation," and Judah will not believe it even when told. *Habakkuk 1:5–11*

c. 605 BC
His second complaint

Why use the wicked?

He asks how a God of purer eyes than to behold evil can let a more wicked nation swallow a more righteous one. *Habakkuk 1:12–17*

On the watchtower

Waiting for God

He decides to stand on his watch and see what God will say. God tells him to write the vision plainly and wait for it, for it will surely come. *Habakkuk 2:1–4*

After the vision

A prayer and a song

He prays, "in wrath remember mercy," recalls God's mighty deeds, and resolves to rejoice in God even if every crop fails. *Habakkuk 3:1–19*

Group notes

Key activities

Habakkuk 2:4 has been read in several ways. The Hebrew word for "faith" can also mean "faithfulness." Paul quotes the verse to show that the righteous live by trusting God.

1. **Asked God hard questions.** "O LORD, how long shall I cry, and thou wilt not hear!" *Habakkuk 1:2–4*
2. **Received a shocking answer.** God said he would do a work that Judah would not believe: send the Babylonians. *Habakkuk 1:5–6*
3. **Pressed his case.** He appealed to God's holiness: "Thou art of purer eyes than to behold evil." *Habakkuk 1:12–13*
4. **Waited on the watchtower.** "I will stand upon my watch, and set me upon the tower, and will watch to see what he will say unto me." *Habakkuk 2:1*
5. **Wrote the vision plainly.** God told him to write it on tablets so that anyone could read it and run. *Habakkuk 2:2–3*
6. **Heard the heart of the answer.** The proud will fall, but "the just shall live by his faith." *Habakkuk 2:4*
7. **Announced five woes.** He pronounced woe on greed, violence, cruelty and idolatry. "The earth shall be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD." *Habakkuk 2:6–20*
8. **Sang his trust.** Though the fig tree fail and the fields yield no food, he would rejoice in the God of his salvation. *Habakkuk 3:17–19*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Habakkuk.

Old Testament

Habakkuk 1–3	The book of his complaints, God's answers and his prayer.
Echoes	Jeremiah also asked why the wicked prosper (Jeremiah 12:1). Job and many psalmists bring honest complaints to God (Job 23:3–4; Psalm 13:1). "Be still, and know that I am God" (Psalm 46:10).

New Testament

Romans 1:17	and **Galatians 3:11.** Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4, "The just shall live by faith," at the heart of his teaching on the gospel.
Hebrews 10:37–38	Hebrews quotes Habakkuk 2:3–4 to encourage believers to wait patiently for Christ.
Acts 13:40–41	Paul warns his hearers with Habakkuk 1:5: "Behold, ye despisers, and wonder, and perish."
Echoes	Paul and Silas sing in prison at midnight (Acts 16:25). Paul learned to be content in every circumstance (Philippians 4:11–13).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What two questions did Habakkuk ask God (Habakkuk 1:2–4, 12–13)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God answered Habakkuk with a call to faith instead of a full explanation?
3. *Apply:* What question would you most like to bring to God right now? What would it look like to wait on the watchtower with it?
4. *Apply:* Finish Habakkuk's sentence for your own life: "Although … yet I will rejoice in the LORD." What would you write?

102 Zedekiah

Judah's last king, who kept asking for God's word but never found the courage to obey it.

Zedekiah was a son of good King Josiah. Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon put him on the throne after carrying his nephew Jehoiachin into exile, and even gave him his royal name. For eleven years he ruled a shrinking kingdom caught between Babylon and Egypt. Again and again he sent for Jeremiah and asked, in secret, whether there was any word from the LORD. There was, and it did not change: submit to Babylon and live. But Zedekiah feared his own officials more than he trusted God. He broke his oath to Nebuchadnezzar and rebelled. Jerusalem fell, the temple burned, and Zedekiah was blinded and led away to Babylon in chains.

At a glance

Name	Born Mattaniah; renamed Zedekiah, "the LORD is righteous"
Family	Son of Josiah and Hamutal; uncle of Jehoiachin (2 Kings 24:17–18)
Reign	11 years from age 21, c. 597–586 BC
Key places	Jerusalem, the plains of Jericho, Riblah, Babylon
Key people	Jeremiah, Nebuchadnezzar, Ebed-melech, the princes of Judah
Main passages	2 Kings 24:17–25:7; Jeremiah 21; 27; 32–39
New Testament	Not named

"And he did that which was evil in the sight of the LORD his God, and humbled not himself before Jeremiah the prophet speaking from the mouth of the LORD."

2 Chronicles 36:12, KJV

The life of Zedekiah

Dates are approximate (BC) and agree with the Josiah and Jeremiah chapters. Some date the fall of Jerusalem to 587 BC. Scripture does not say when Zedekiah died.

c. 597 BC
Age 21

Made king by Babylon

Nebuchadnezzar takes Jehoiachin to Babylon and makes his uncle Mattaniah king, changing his name to Zedekiah. He makes him swear by God to stay loyal. *2 Kings 24:15–18; 2 Chronicles 36:10–13*

c. 594 BC
4th year

Tempted to rebel

Envoys from nearby kingdoms come to Jerusalem. Jeremiah wears a yoke and tells Zedekiah to serve the king of Babylon and live. *Jeremiah 27:3, 12–15; 28:1*

c. 589 BC
Late in his reign

Rebels

Zedekiah breaks his oath and rebels against Nebuchadnezzar, apparently hoping for help from Egypt. *2 Kings 24:20; 2 Chronicles 36:13; Ezekiel 17:15*

c. 588 BC
9th year

The siege begins

Nebuchadnezzar's army surrounds Jerusalem and builds siege works around it. *2 Kings 25:1; Jeremiah 39:1*

c. 588–586 BC
During the siege

Secret meetings

Zedekiah asks Jeremiah privately for God's word and is told to surrender. He lets his officials throw Jeremiah into a cistern, then allows his rescue. *Jeremiah 37:16–21; 38:1–28*

c. 586 BC
11th year

Flight and capture

Famine grips the city and the wall is broken. Zedekiah flees by night but is caught in the plains of Jericho. At Riblah his sons are killed before his eyes, and he is blinded. *2 Kings 25:2–7; Jeremiah 39:2–7*

After c. 586 BC
In Babylon

Dies a prisoner

He is taken to Babylon in chains and kept in prison until the day of his death. *Jeremiah 52:11*

Key activities

2 Kings 24:17 calls Zedekiah Jehoiachin's "father's brother," while 2 Chronicles 36:10 calls him his "brother," a word that can mean any close relative. Many scholars think Zedekiah's royal name echoes Jeremiah's promise of a coming king called "THE LORD OUR RIGHTEOUSNESS" (Jeremiah 23:5–6).

1. **Swore loyalty to Babylon.** He took an oath in God's name to serve Nebuchadnezzar. *2 Chronicles 36:13; Ezekiel 17:13*
2. **Sent to inquire of the LORD.** He asked Jeremiah to pray for the city and to ask whether God would save it. *Jeremiah 21:1–2; 37:3*
3. **Freed the slaves, then took them back.** He led Jerusalem in a covenant to free Hebrew slaves, but the owners soon took them back. *Jeremiah 34:8–11*
4. **Asked in secret.** He brought Jeremiah from prison and asked, "Is there any word from the LORD?" *Jeremiah 37:17*
5. **Gave way to his officials.** He handed Jeremiah over to the princes, who put him in a cistern. *Jeremiah 38:4–6*
6. **Feared people more than God.** He admitted he was afraid of the Jews who had gone over to the Babylonians. *Jeremiah 38:19–20*
7. **Rebelled and fled.** He broke his oath, and when the city fell he ran and was captured. *2 Kings 24:20–25:6*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Zedekiah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 24:17–25:7; 2 Chronicles 36:10–21	His reign and Jerusalem's fall
Jeremiah 21; 27; 32–39; 52	Jeremiah's many dealings with him
Jeremiah 34:4–5	Promised death in peace, not by the sword
Ezekiel 12:12–13	Brought to Babylon, "yet shall he not see it"
Ezekiel 17:11–21	The parable of two eagles condemns his broken oath
Echo: 1 Samuel 15:24	Saul also feared the people and disobeyed

New Testament

Matthew 1:11–12	The carrying away to Babylon, in Jesus' line
Echo: James 1:22	"Be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only"
Echo: Mark 15:15	Pilate knew the right thing but gave way

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What question did Zedekiah ask Jeremiah, and what was the answer (Jeremiah 37:17)?
2. *Understand:* Zedekiah kept asking for God's word. Why do you think he never acted on it?
3. *Apply:* Is there something God has already made clear to you that you are still hoping he will change? What would obedience look like?
4. *Apply:* Whose opinion do you fear most? How could you keep that fear from steering your choices this week?

103 Nebuchadnezzar

The proud king of Babylon who destroyed Jerusalem and learned that "the most High ruleth."

Nebuchadnezzar, Babylon's greatest king, carried Judah into exile. He besieged Jerusalem three times, took its young nobles to Babylon, and at last burned the temple. Jeremiah calls him God's "servant," a tool of judgment on a nation that would not turn back. Yet Daniel shows another side. Through dreams, a fiery furnace and a season of madness, this mighty king met the God of his captives, and his story ends with a letter of praise in his own name. Pride can be broken and still end in worship.

At a glance

Name	Babylonian *Nabu-kudurri-usur*; also spelled Nebuchadrezzar
Family	Son of Nabopolassar (from Babylonian records, not the Bible)
Reign	About 43 years, c. 605–562 BC
Capital	Babylon, on the Euphrates River
Key people	Daniel and his three friends; Jehoiachin; Zedekiah; Jeremiah
Main passages	Daniel 1–4; 2 Kings 24–25; 2 Chronicles 36
Successor	Evil-merodach (2 Kings 25:27)
New Testament	Not named

"Now I Nebuchadnezzar praise and extol and honour the King of heaven, all whose works are truth, and his ways judgment: and those that walk in pride he is able to abase."

Daniel 4:37, KJV

The life of Nebuchadnezzar

Dates are approximate (BC). Daniel 1:1 and Jeremiah 25:1 date the first siege a year apart, probably counting years differently. Daniel 3 and 4 give no dates.

c. 605 BC
Year he becomes king

Victory and first captives

He defeats Pharaoh Neco at Carchemish, then takes temple vessels and young nobles from Jerusalem, among them Daniel and his friends. *Jeremiah 46:2; Daniel 1:1–6*

c. 603 BC
2nd year

The dream of the great image

When his wise men cannot tell his dream, he orders them killed. Daniel reveals it, and the king honours Daniel's God. *Daniel 2:1–49*

Date not given

The golden image

He sets up a golden image on the plain of Dura. Three Jews refuse to bow, survive the furnace, and the king blesses their God. *Daniel 3:1–30*

c. 597 BC
8th year

Jehoiachin taken

After Jehoiakim rebels, he carries away King Jehoiachin, ten thousand captives and the temple treasures, and makes Zedekiah king. *2 Kings 24:1, 10–17*

c. 586 BC
19th year

Jerusalem destroyed

Zedekiah rebels. After a long siege the city falls, and Nebuzar-adan burns the temple and breaks down the walls. *2 Kings 25:1–11*

Later in his reign

Humbled and restored

He boasts of the Babylon he has built and is driven out to live like an animal until he acknowledges that God rules. *Daniel 4:28–37*

Group notes

Key activities

Babylonian records do not mention the king's madness. Some scholars link Daniel 4 with an old Jewish text about a later king, Nabonidus, who spent years away from Babylon. Others read it as Nebuchadnezzar's own testimony, just as Daniel presents it.

1. **Took Jerusalem's best young men.** He besieged Jerusalem, took temple vessels to his god's house, and had noble youths trained in Babylonian learning. *Daniel 1:1–7*
2. **Demanded the impossible.** He ordered his wise men to tell him his dream as well as its meaning, and he condemned them all when they could not. *Daniel 2:1–13*
3. **Honoured Daniel's God.** After Daniel explained the dream, the king confessed that his God was "a God of gods, and a Lord of kings." *Daniel 2:46–49*
4. **Built an idol and a furnace.** He commanded everyone to bow to a golden image. When three Jews refused, he threw them into a furnace heated seven times hotter. *Daniel 3:1–23*
5. **Crushed Judah's revolts.** He took Jehoiachin and the temple treasures to Babylon, set up Zedekiah, and finally destroyed the city and temple. *2 Kings 24:10–17; 25:1–10*
6. **Spared Jeremiah.** He gave orders that the prophet be treated well and not harmed. *Jeremiah 39:11–12*
7. **Fell through pride.** He boasted, "Is not this great Babylon, that I have built," and lost his reason and his throne for a time. *Daniel 4:29–33*
8. **Praised the King of heaven.** Restored, he sent a letter to all nations telling what God had done to him. *Daniel 4:1–3, 34–37*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Nebuchadnezzar.

Old Testament

2 Kings 24–25; 2 Chronicles 36:6–21	His campaigns and Jerusalem's fall
Jeremiah 25:9; 27:6	God calls him "my servant," his tool of judgment
Ezekiel 26:7; 29:18–20	"A king of kings" against Tyre; Egypt as wages
Daniel 1–4	His dealings with Daniel and his friends
Daniel 5:18–21	Daniel reminds Belshazzar how he was humbled
Ezra 1:7; 5:12	Cyrus sends back the vessels he took

New Testament

Echo: Luke 1:52	"He hath put down the mighty from their seats"
Echo: Revelation 18:2	Babylon, proud human power, falls

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What words did Nebuchadnezzar use about himself in Daniel 4:30, and what words did he use about God in Daniel 4:37?
2. *Understand:* Jeremiah calls this pagan king God's "servant" (Jeremiah 27:6). What does that tell us about who is really in charge of history?
3. *Apply:* Nebuchadnezzar praised God after each crisis, then drifted back to pride. Where do you see that same pattern in your own life?
4. *Apply:* What is one success this week that you could thank God for out loud, instead of taking the credit?

104 Ezekiel

The priest in exile who saw God's glory leave Jerusalem and promised new hearts and dry bones brought to life.

Ezekiel was a priest who lived out his calling far from the temple. Carried to Babylon with King Jehoiachin in 597 BC, he was called five years later in a blazing vision by the river Chebar. For over twenty years he spoke to the exiles. Before Jerusalem fell, he warned that it would not be spared, acting out its siege and not mourning his own wife's death. After the fall his message turned to hope: a true shepherd, a new heart, dry bones rising, and a new temple where God would live among his people.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Yechezqel*, "God strengthens"
Family	A priest, son of Buzi; widowed in the siege (Ezekiel 1:3; 24:18)
Exile	Taken to Babylon with Jehoiachin, c. 597 BC
Home	Tel-abib, by the river Chebar in Babylonia (Ezekiel 3:15)
Ministry	c. 593–571 BC, by his own dates
Key people	The exiled elders; Jehoiachin; Nebuchadnezzar
Main passages	Ezekiel 1–3; 8–11; 18; 24; 34; 36–37; 40–48
New Testament	Not named; often echoed in Revelation

"A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh."

Ezekiel 36:26, KJV

The life of Ezekiel

Dates are approximate (BC). Ezekiel counts his years from the exile of King Jehoiachin in 597 BC, so "the fifth year" is c. 593 BC.

c. 597 BC *With Jehoiachin*

Carried into exile

Ezekiel is among the captives taken to Babylon and settles at Tel-abib by the river Chebar. *2 Kings 24:14–16; Ezekiel 1:2–3; 3:15*

c. 593 BC *5th year of exile*

Called by the river

He sees living creatures, wheels full of eyes and the glory of the Lord on a throne. God gives him a scroll to eat. *Ezekiel 1:1–3:15*

c. 592 BC *6th year*

Taken to Jerusalem in a vision

The Spirit shows him idols in the temple courts. Then he watches God's glory leave the temple and the city. *Ezekiel 8:1–4; 10:18–19; 11:22–24*

c. 588 BC *9th year*

The siege begins, and his wife dies

Babylon surrounds Jerusalem. His wife, "the desire of thine eyes," dies, and he is told not to mourn openly. *Ezekiel 24:1–2, 15–18*

c. 585 BC *12th year*

News of the fall

A survivor arrives: "The city is smitten." God opens Ezekiel's mouth, and his message turns toward hope. *Ezekiel 33:21–22*

c. 573 BC *25th year*

The vision of a new temple

In vision he is shown a new temple in careful detail and sees the glory of the Lord return and fill it. *Ezekiel 40:1–4; 43:1–5*

c. 571 BC *27th year*

His last dated word

God promises Egypt to Nebuchadnezzar as wages for Tyre. Scripture does not record Ezekiel's death. *Ezekiel 29:17–20*

Key activities

God made Ezekiel "dumb" for a time and opened his mouth when Jerusalem fell (Ezekiel 3:26–27; 33:22). Readers differ on whether he was wholly silent or spoke only God's messages.

1. **Saw the glory of God.** By the river Chebar he saw a storm of fire, four living creatures and a throne, and he fell on his face. *Ezekiel 1:4–28*
2. **Ate the scroll.** God gave him a scroll full of "lamentations, and mourning, and woe," and it tasted "as honey for sweetness." *Ezekiel 2:8–3:3*
3. **Became a watchman.** God made him responsible to warn the wicked and the righteous alike. *Ezekiel 3:16–21; 33:1–9*
4. **Acted out the siege.** He drew Jerusalem on a tile and lay on his left side 390 days, his right 40. *Ezekiel 4:1–17*
5. **Shaved his head.** He burned, cut and scattered his hair in thirds as a sign for the city. *Ezekiel 5:1–4*
6. **Saw the glory depart.** He watched the glory of the Lord leave the temple for the mountain east of the city. *Ezekiel 10:18–19; 11:22–23*
7. **Taught personal responsibility.** "The soul that sinneth, it shall die," yet God has no pleasure in anyone's death. *Ezekiel 18:1–4, 30–32*
8. **Became a living sign.** When his wife died, he did not mourn in public, as a sign of the shock coming to Judah. *Ezekiel 24:15–24*
9. **Promised a true shepherd.** He condemned selfish leaders and promised "my servant David" over God's sheep. *Ezekiel 34:1–24*
10. **Preached a new heart.** He promised cleansing water, a new heart and God's own Spirit within his people. *Ezekiel 36:24–28*
11. **Prophesied to dry bones.** In a valley of bones, he spoke God's word, and breath came into them. *Ezekiel 37:1–14*
12. **Saw the river from the temple.** Water flowed from the new temple, growing deeper and bringing life wherever it went. *Ezekiel 47:1–12*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Ezekiel.

Old Testament

Ezekiel 1:3; 24:24	The only verses naming him: "Ezekiel is unto you a sign"
Ezekiel 1:1	"The thirtieth year": perhaps his age (Numbers 4:3); debated
2 Kings 24:10–16	The deportation of 597 BC that brought him to Babylon
Jeremiah 29:1–7	Jeremiah's letter to the exiles in the same years
Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3	He names Daniel as a model of righteousness
Echo: Jeremiah 31:31–34	The new covenant, like his new heart

New Testament

Echo: John 10:11	"I am the good shepherd" (compare Ezekiel 34)
Echo: John 3:5	"Born of water and of the Spirit" (Ezekiel 36:25–27)
Echo: Revelation 4:6–8; 10:9–10; 22:1–2	Living creatures, scroll, river

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Ezekiel see and hear by the river Chebar before God gave him his task (Ezekiel 1:26–2:3)?
2. *Understand:* Ezekiel saw God's glory in Babylon, far from the temple. What would that have meant to the exiles?
3. *Apply:* Ezekiel was a watchman who had to warn people. Is there someone you need to speak to honestly and kindly this week?
4. *Apply:* The exiles said, "Our bones are dried, and our hope is lost" (Ezekiel 37:11). Where do you need God to breathe new life?

105 Daniel

The young exile who stayed faithful in Babylon for nearly seventy years, through kings, lions and visions of God's kingdom.

Daniel was taken from Jerusalem to Babylon as a youth and never came home. Trained to serve a pagan king and given a Babylonian name, he held on to the God of Israel from his first meal to his last vision. He explained kings' dreams, read the writing on the wall, prayed when prayer was against the law, and was kept safe among lions. He served Babylonian and Persian rulers for about seventy years without fault. His visions look past the empires of his day to a kingdom that "shall never be destroyed."

At a glance

Name	"God is my judge"; renamed Belteshazzar (Daniel 1:7)
Family	Of Judah's royal or noble youth; parents not named (Daniel 1:3–6)
Taken to Babylon	As a youth, c. 605 BC
Served	Nebuchadnezzar, Belshazzar, Darius the Mede and Cyrus
Friends	Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah (Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego)
Last dated vision	The third year of Cyrus, c. 536 BC (Daniel 10:1)
Main passages	Daniel 1–12; Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3
New Testament	"Daniel the prophet" (Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14)

"But Daniel purposed in his heart that he would not defile himself with the portion of the king's meat, nor with the wine which he drank."

Daniel 1:8, KJV

The life of Daniel

Dates are approximate (BC). The book is partly arranged by theme; Belshazzar's first year (c. 553 BC) is uncertain.

c. 605–602 BC
As a youth

Taken to Babylon and tested

Chosen to train for the king's court and renamed Belteshazzar, Daniel refuses the king's food. After ten days he and his friends look healthier than the rest. *Daniel 1:1–20*

c. 603 BC
Nebuchadnezzar's 2nd year

The king's dream revealed

Facing death with the wise men, Daniel prays. God shows him the dream, and the king makes him ruler over Babylon's province. *Daniel 2:1–49*

c. 553 BC
Belshazzar's 1st year

Four beasts and the Son of man

He sees four beasts, then "one like the Son of man" receive an everlasting kingdom. *Daniel 7:1–14*

c. 539 BC
The night Babylon falls

The writing on the wall

Daniel, now old, reads God's verdict at Belshazzar's feast. That night Belshazzar is killed. *Daniel 5:1–31*

c. 539 BC
Darius's 1st year

Praying over the seventy years

Reading Jeremiah, he confesses his people's sins, and Gabriel brings the vision of the seventy weeks. *Daniel 9:1–27*

Under Darius, date not given

The lions' den

Trapped by a law against prayer, he prays anyway and is thrown to the lions. God shuts their mouths. *Daniel 6:1–28*

c. 536 BC
Cyrus's 3rd year

The last vision

By the Tigris he receives his final vision and is told to "go thou thy way till the end be." *Daniel 10:1–4; 12:13*

Key activities

Christians differ over when Daniel was written: traditionally by Daniel in the 500s BC; many modern scholars say its final form dates to about 165 BC, under Antiochus IV.

1. **Resolved not to defile himself.** He asked for vegetables and water instead of the king's food. *Daniel 1:8–16*
2. **Excelled in learning.** God gave him "understanding in all visions and dreams." *Daniel 1:17–20*
3. **Prayed with his friends.** Facing death, they sought mercy from "the God of heaven." *Daniel 2:17–23*
4. **Gave God the credit.** "There is a God in heaven that revealeth secrets." *Daniel 2:27–45*
5. **Spoke hard truth kindly.** He urged Nebuchadnezzar to turn from his sins and show mercy to the poor. *Daniel 4:19–27*
6. **Turned down rewards.** He told Belshazzar to keep his gifts, then read the writing and its judgment plainly. *Daniel 5:17–28*
7. **Served without fault.** His rivals could find no corruption in his work, only his faithfulness to his God. *Daniel 6:3–5*
8. **Kept praying.** When the law forbade it, he knelt at his open window toward Jerusalem three times a day, "as he did aforetime." *Daniel 6:10*
9. **Survived the lions.** God sent his angel and shut the lions' mouths, and King Darius praised "the living God." *Daniel 6:16–27*
10. **Confessed his people's sin.** He prayed, "we do not present our supplications before thee for our righteousnesses, but for thy great mercies." *Daniel 9:3–19*
11. **Received visions of the end.** He saw empires rise and fall, and he was promised that many who sleep in the dust will awake. *Daniel 7–8; 10–12*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Daniel.

Old Testament

Daniel 1–12	The main account of his life and visions
Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3	With Noah and Job; some think an older hero Danel
Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10	The seventy years Daniel studied (Daniel 9:2)

New Testament

Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14	Jesus cites "Daniel the prophet"
Matthew 26:64	"Coming in the clouds of heaven," from Daniel 7:13
Hebrews 11:33	Heroes of faith who "stopped the mouths of lions"
Echo: Revelation 13; John 5:28–29	Daniel's beasts; the dead rising
Tradition	Susanna and Bel and the Dragon are Greek additions (Apocrypha)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Daniel do once the law against prayer was signed (Daniel 6:10)?
2. *Understand:* Daniel served pagan kings well but would not break God's law. How did he draw the line?
3. *Apply:* Daniel "purposed in his heart" before the test. What decision could you settle now?
4. *Apply:* His prayer habit was in place long before the lions. What daily habit could you start or protect?

106 Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego

Three young exiles who would not bow, and who found God with them in the fire.

Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah were young men of Judah taken to Babylon with Daniel and renamed Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego. King Nebuchadnezzar set up a huge golden image and ordered everyone to bow. The three refused, with one of Scripture's bravest statements of faith: God is able to save us, "but if not," we still will not bow. Thrown into a blazing furnace, they walked in the fire with a fourth figure and came out without even the smell of fire.

At a glance

Hebrew names	Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah (Daniel 1:6)
New names	Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-nego (Daniel 1:7)
Family	Of Judah, among the young nobles (Daniel 1:3–6)
When	Taken c. 605 BC; the furnace is not dated
Key people	Daniel, Nebuchadnezzar, Ashpenaz
Main passages	Daniel 1; 2:17–18, 49; 3
New Testament	Not named; compare Hebrews 11:34

> *"If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace … But if not, be it known unto thee, O king, that we will not serve thy gods, nor worship the golden image which thou hast set up."*
>
> Daniel 3:17–18, KJV

The life of Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego

Dates are approximate (BC). Daniel 3 gives no date for the golden image. It is not certain how long after Daniel 2 it took place.

c. 605 BC
As youths

Taken and renamed

Nebuchadnezzar takes young nobles from Jerusalem to train for his court. Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah are among them, along with their friend Daniel. The chief official gives them Babylonian names: Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-nego. *Daniel 1:1–7*

c. 605–602 BC
Three years of training

Faithful at the table

With Daniel they ask for vegetables and water instead of the king's food. After ten days they look healthier than the others. At the end, the king finds them wiser than all his advisers. *Daniel 1:8–20*

c. 603 BC
Nebuchadnezzar's 2nd year

Praying for mercy

When the king orders all wise men killed, Daniel asks his three friends to pray. God reveals the dream. At Daniel's request, the king sets them over the affairs of the province of Babylon. *Daniel 2:17–18, 49*

Date not given

They will not bow

Accused by certain Chaldeans, the three refuse to worship the golden image. They tell the king that God is able to save them, "but if not," they still will not serve his gods. *Daniel 3:1–18*

The same day

Through the fire

Bound and thrown into a furnace so hot it kills the soldiers, they walk free with a fourth figure. They come out unharmed, and the king praises their God and promotes them. *Daniel 3:19–30*

Key activities

Nebuchadnezzar says the fourth figure in the fire was "like the Son of God" (Daniel 3:25, KJV). The Aramaic can also be read "a son of the gods," and the king later calls him God's "angel" (Daniel 3:28). Many Christians have seen here an appearance of Christ before his birth. Others see an angel sent by God.

1. **Stayed faithful at the king's table.** With Daniel they asked to eat vegetables and drink water, and God blessed them with health and wisdom. *Daniel 1:11–17*
2. **Served well in Babylon.** They stood before the king, and later they managed the affairs of the province of Babylon. *Daniel 1:19–20; 2:49*
3. **Prayed in a crisis.** They sought mercy from the God of heaven when every wise man faced death. *Daniel 2:17–18*
4. **Refused to bow.** When the music played and the crowds fell down, they stayed on their feet. *Daniel 3:8–12*
5. **Answered the king calmly.** They said they did not need to defend themselves. God was able to deliver them, but even if he did not, they would not worship the image. *Daniel 3:16–18*
6. **Walked in the fire.** Bound and thrown into the furnace, they were seen walking loose with a fourth figure, unharmed. *Daniel 3:19–25*
7. **Came out unharmed.** Not a hair was singed, and "the smell of fire" had not passed on them. The king blessed their God. *Daniel 3:26–30*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name the three friends.

Old Testament

Daniel 1:6–7, 11, 19	Named among the youths trained with Daniel
Daniel 2:17–18, 49	They pray with Daniel and are promoted
Daniel 3:1–30	The golden image and the furnace
Echo: Exodus 20:4–5	God's law forbids bowing to any image
Echo: Isaiah 43:2	"When thou walkest through the fire, thou shalt not be burned"

New Testament

Hebrews 11:34	Those who "quenched the violence of fire," often taken as them
Echo: Acts 5:29	"We ought to obey God rather than men"
Echo: 1 Peter 4:12	Do not be surprised at "the fiery trial"
Tradition	The Greek "Song of the Three," in the Apocrypha, not the Hebrew text

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What exactly did the three friends say to the king in Daniel 3:16–18?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think "but if not" matters so much? What does it show about their faith?
3. *Apply:* Where do you feel pressure to "bow" to something at work, at school or online? What would standing firm look like?
4. *Apply:* The three faced the fire together. Who could you stand beside this week when their faith is being tested?

107 Belshazzar

The last ruler of Babylon, who feasted while his kingdom fell and was "weighed in the balances, and ... found wanting."

Belshazzar ruled Babylon in its final years. On the night the city fell, he threw a great feast for a thousand of his lords. With the wine flowing, he sent for the gold and silver cups that Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the temple in Jerusalem, and his guests drank from them while praising their idols. Suddenly the fingers of a man's hand appeared and wrote on the palace wall. None of his wise men could read it. The aged Daniel was brought in. He reminded the king how God had humbled Nebuchadnezzar and told him that God had now weighed him and found him wanting. That same night Belshazzar was killed, and Babylon passed to the Medes and Persians. His story is a sober warning about pride that will not learn.

At a glance

Name	Babylonian *Bel-shar-usur*, usually explained as "Bel, protect the king"
Family	Nebuchadnezzar his "father" (Daniel 5:2); records say son of Nabonidus
Position	Ruled for his father; could offer only "third ruler" (Daniel 5:7)
When	Ruled from c. 553 BC (uncertain); died 539 BC
Key people	Daniel; "the queen"; Darius the Mede
Main passages	Daniel 5; 7:1; 8:1
New Testament	Not named

"TEKEL; Thou art weighed in the balances, and art found wanting."

Daniel 5:27, KJV

The life of Belshazzar

Dates are approximate (BC). Scripture dates two of Daniel's visions by Belshazzar's reign. The start of that reign is uncertain but is usually placed c. 553 BC.

c. 553 BC
1st year

A vision in his reign

In the first year of Belshazzar, Daniel dreams of four beasts from the sea and of one like the Son of man who receives an everlasting kingdom. Daniel writes the dream down. *Daniel 7:1–14*

c. 551 BC
3rd year

Another vision

In his third year, Daniel sees a ram and a goat, a vision of kingdoms to come. The ram's two horns are later explained as "the kings of Media and Persia." *Daniel 8:1–4, 20*

c. 539 BC
The last night

The feast

Belshazzar gives a feast for a thousand lords. He orders the temple vessels brought, and his court drinks from them while praising gods of gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood and stone. *Daniel 5:1–4*

The same night

The writing on the wall

Fingers of a man's hand appear and write on the plaster near the lampstand. The king turns pale and his knees knock. His wise men cannot read it, and the queen reminds him of Daniel. *Daniel 5:5–16*

The same night

Weighed and found wanting

Daniel refuses the king's gifts and reads the message: MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN. Belshazzar keeps his word and honours Daniel, but that same night he is killed. Darius the Mede takes the kingdom. *Daniel 5:17–31*

Group notes

Key activities

Who was "Darius the Median" (Daniel 5:31)? He has not yet been found in records outside the Bible. Some identify him with Cyrus himself, some with Cyrus's governor Gubaru, and some with a Median king. Others think the book uses a different tradition. The text simply says he took the kingdom at about sixty-two.

1. **Threw a great feast.** He feasted with a thousand lords on the very night his kingdom would fall. *Daniel 5:1*
2. **Mocked the God of Israel.** He drank from the holy vessels taken from Jerusalem and praised idols. *Daniel 5:2–4*
3. **Saw the hand.** When the fingers wrote on the wall, he was terrified: "the joints of his loins were loosed, and his knees smote one against another." *Daniel 5:5–6*
4. **Offered rich rewards.** He promised scarlet robes, a gold chain and third place in the kingdom to anyone who could read the writing. *Daniel 5:7, 16*
5. **Ignored the lesson he knew.** Daniel told him, "thou his son, O Belshazzar, hast not humbled thine heart, though thou knewest all this." *Daniel 5:18–23*
6. **Honoured Daniel.** Even after hearing his doom, he kept his word and clothed Daniel in scarlet. *Daniel 5:29*
7. **Died that night.** "In that night was Belshazzar the king of the Chaldeans slain." *Daniel 5:30*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Belshazzar.

Old Testament

Daniel 5:1–31	This is the main account of his feast and death.
Daniel 7:1; 8:1	Two of Daniel's visions are dated by his reign.
Daniel 4:28–37	This is the humbling of Nebuchadnezzar that Belshazzar knew about and ignored.
Isaiah 21:5, 9	and **Jeremiah 51:39, 57.** These prophecies of Babylon's fall mention feasting and drunken princes. Many readers see them fulfilled on Belshazzar's last night.
Echoes	"Pride goeth before destruction, and an haughty spirit before a fall" (Proverbs 16:18).

New Testament

Echoes	The rich fool plans to "eat, drink, and be merry," but God says, "this night thy soul shall be required of thee" (Luke 12:19–20). "God is not mocked" (Galatians 6:7). "Babylon is fallen, is fallen" (Revelation 14:8).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Belshazzar do with the vessels from God's temple, and what did his guests praise (Daniel 5:2–4)?
2. *Understand:* Daniel says Belshazzar "knewest all this." Why is knowing the truth and ignoring it so serious?
3. *Apply:* What lesson from someone else's life, or from your own past, do you need to take seriously now?
4. *Apply:* Belshazzar treated holy things as party cups. What is something God has given you that you want to treat with more respect this week?

108 Cyrus

The Persian king whom God called "my shepherd," who sent the exiles home to rebuild the temple.

Cyrus founded the Persian Empire. In 539 BC his forces took Babylon, and within a year he decreed that any Jew who wished could go home and rebuild the house of the Lord. He even sent back the vessels Nebuchadnezzar had taken. Cyrus was not an Israelite and did not follow Israel's God alone. Yet Isaiah names him God's "shepherd" and "anointed," called "though thou hast not known me." Cyrus shows that God can move the heart of any ruler to carry out his promises.

At a glance

Name	Persian *Kurush*; Hebrew *Koresh*; "Cyrus the Great"
Family	Son of Cambyses of Anshan (from records outside the Bible)
Reign	King of Persia c. 559–530 BC; of Babylon from 539 BC
Titles	"My shepherd" (Isa 44:28); "his anointed" (Isa 45:1)
Famous act	Decree of 538 BC to rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:1–4)
Key people	Daniel, Sheshbazzar, Zerubbabel, Jeshua the priest
Main passages	Isaiah 44:28–45:13; Ezra 1; 6:3–5; 2 Chr 36:22–23
New Testament	Not named

"That saith of Cyrus, He is my shepherd, and shall perform all my pleasure: even saying to Jerusalem, Thou shalt be built; and to the temple, Thy foundation shall be laid."

Isaiah 44:28, KJV

The life of Cyrus

Dates approximate (BC). Traditionally Isaiah son of Amoz named Cyrus about 150 years ahead; many scholars date Isaiah 40–55 to a later prophet in the exile, in the 540s BC.

Before his reign

Called by name

Through the prophet, God names Cyrus as his shepherd and anointed, who will subdue nations and order Jerusalem and the temple rebuilt. *Isaiah 44:28–45:7*

c. 559 BC
Becomes king

Rise of Persia

Cyrus becomes king of Anshan. Within twenty years he conquers the Medes, Lydia and much of the east, "to subdue nations before him." *Isaiah 45:1–3*

c. 539 BC
Babylon falls

The Medes and Persians take Babylon

On the night of Belshazzar's feast, Babylon falls to the Medes and Persians, as the writing on the wall foretold. Daniel continues to serve in the new government and prospers "in the reign of Cyrus the Persian." *Daniel 5:28–31; 6:28*

c. 538 BC
1st year over Babylon

The decree

God stirs his spirit, and Cyrus proclaims in writing across his kingdom that the Jews may return and build the house of God. He orders the costs paid from the royal treasury. *Ezra 1:1–4; 6:3–5; 2 Chronicles 36:22–23*

c. 538/537 BC
The journey home

The vessels return

Cyrus has his treasurer, Mithredath, count out 5,400 gold and silver vessels from Babylon's temple. They are handed to Sheshbazzar, prince of Judah, who carries them home with the returning exiles. *Ezra 1:7–11; 5:14–15*

c. 536 BC
3rd year

Daniel's last vision

Daniel's final vision, beside the Tigris River, is dated by Cyrus's reign. Meanwhile, enemies in Judah hire counsellors to slow the temple work throughout his reign. Cyrus dies c. 530 BC. *Daniel 10:1, 4; Ezra 4:4–5*

Key activities

Did Cyrus believe in Israel's God? In Ezra 1:2 he says "the LORD God of heaven" gave him his kingdoms. On the Cyrus Cylinder he gives Marduk the credit. Many think he honoured each people's god in its own terms. Isaiah says God used him "though thou hast not known me."

1. **Was called before he knew God.** God named him, held his right hand, and "girded" him for his work. *Isaiah 45:1–5*
2. **Conquered Babylon.** His rise ended the empire that had destroyed Jerusalem, as Daniel had told Belshazzar. *Daniel 5:28–31*
3. **Proclaimed the return.** He invited any of God's people to "go up to Jerusalem" and build the house of the Lord God of Israel. *Ezra 1:1–4*
4. **Sent back the temple vessels.** He returned the gold and silver vessels Nebuchadnezzar had taken. *Ezra 1:7–11*
5. **Paid for the rebuilding.** His decree set the temple's size and ordered the expenses paid from the king's house. He also allowed cedar to be brought from Lebanon. *Ezra 3:7; 6:3–5*
6. **Kept Daniel in service.** Daniel continued "unto the first year of king Cyrus" and prospered in his reign. *Daniel 1:21; 6:28*
7. **Left a lasting decree.** Years later, when the temple work was challenged, the record of his decree was found and protected the builders. *Ezra 5:13–17; 6:1–5*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Cyrus.

Old Testament

Isaiah 44:28–45:13	Named God's shepherd and anointed to rebuild Jerusalem
2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–4	His decree fulfils Jeremiah's word; the Hebrew Bible's traditional last words
Ezra 3:7; 4:3, 5; 5:13–17; 6:3–5, 14	His decree is the builders' legal ground
Daniel 1:21; 6:28; 10:1	Daniel serves into his reign
Echo: Proverbs 21:1; Jeremiah 29:10	The king's heart in God's hand; seventy years

New Testament

Echo: John 19:11; Romans 13:1	Earthly power given "from above"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does God say he will do for Cyrus in Isaiah 45:1–4, and why?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God chose a foreign king, rather than an Israelite, to send his people home?
3. *Apply:* Is there a leader or authority in your life you find hard to trust? How might God be at work even there?
4. *Apply:* Cyrus's decree opened a door, but each family still had to choose to go. What open door is God setting before you right now?

109 Zerubbabel

The prince of David's line who led the exiles home and rebuilt the temple, "not by might, nor by power."

Zerubbabel, a grandson of King Jehoiachin, led the first large group of exiles home with Jeshua the high priest. Together they rebuilt the altar and laid the foundation of a new temple, while old men wept and the young shouted for joy. Then opposition stopped the work for about sixteen years. In 520 BC Haggai and Zechariah stirred him to begin again, and God promised his hands would finish it. The temple was completed in 516/515 BC. He appears in both family lines of Jesus, a sign that God kept David's line alive through the exile.

At a glance

Name	Probably Babylonian, often explained as "seed of Babylon"
Family	Son of Shealtiel, grandson of Jehoiachin (Ezra 3:2; 1 Chr 3:17–19)
Role	Governor of Judah under the Persians (Haggai 1:1)
When	Returned c. 538/537 BC; temple finished 516/515 BC
Key people	Jeshua (Joshua) the high priest, Haggai, Zechariah, Darius
Main passages	Ezra 2–6; Haggai 1–2; Zechariah 4
New Testament	"Zorobabel" in Jesus' family lines (Matt 1:12–13; Luke 3:27)

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the LORD of hosts."

Zechariah 4:6, KJV

The life of Zerubbabel

Dates approximate (BC): a start under Cyrus, a long delay, completion under Darius I. Chronicles lists Zerubbabel as a son of Pedaiah, Shealtiel's brother.

c. 538/537 BC — *After Cyrus's decree*

Leads the exiles home

Zerubbabel heads the leaders who return from Babylon. The company numbers 42,360, besides 7,337 servants. *Ezra 2:1–2, 64–67*

c. 537/536 BC — *7th month*

The altar rebuilt

With Jeshua he rebuilds the altar, and daily sacrifices begin again, though the people fear their neighbours. *Ezra 3:1–6*

c. 536 BC — *2nd year*

The foundation laid

Priests blow trumpets; many shout for joy, while old men who saw the first temple weep aloud. *Ezra 3:8–13*

c. 536–520 BC — *Years of delay*

Work stops

He refuses help from the local peoples, who then frighten the builders and hire counsellors against them. *Ezra 4:1–5, 24*

c. 520 BC — *Darius's 2nd year*

Back to work

Haggai rebukes the people for neglecting God's house. Zerubbabel, Joshua and the people obey and begin again. *Haggai 1:1–15; Ezra 5:1–2*

c. 520 BC — *9th month*

God's signet

God promises to make Zerubbabel "as a signet." Zechariah adds that his hands will finish the house. *Haggai 2:20–23; Zechariah 4:6–10*

c. 516/515 BC — *Darius's 6th year*

The temple finished

The house is dedicated with joy. Zerubbabel is not named there, and his later life is not recorded. *Ezra 6:14–16*

Key activities

Ezra 5:16 says that Sheshbazzar laid the temple's foundation, while Ezra 3 and Zechariah 4:9 credit Zerubbabel. Some think they were the same man with two names. Others think Sheshbazzar was the first governor and Zerubbabel led the actual work.

1. **Led the first return.** He is named first among the leaders who brought the exiles home. *Ezra 2:1–2*
2. **Put worship first.** Before any walls or houses, he helped rebuild the altar and restore the daily offerings. *Ezra 3:2–6*
3. **Laid the foundation.** He organised the Levites to oversee the work and led the celebration. *Ezra 3:8–11*
4. **Refused a compromise.** He told the local peoples, "Ye have nothing to do with us to build an house unto our God." *Ezra 4:1–3*
5. **Obeyed God's word.** When Haggai spoke, Zerubbabel, Joshua and the people "obeyed the voice of the LORD their God." *Haggai 1:12–14*
6. **Took courage.** God told him, "be strong, O Zerubbabel … for I am with you." *Haggai 2:4*
7. **Finished the work.** The temple rose in spite of an official inquiry, completing what his hands had begun. *Ezra 5:2–5; 6:14–15; Zechariah 4:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Zerubbabel.

Old Testament

Ezra 2:2; 3:2, 8; 4:2–3; 5:2	He leads the return and the rebuilding
Nehemiah 7:7; 12:1, 47	Remembered as leader of the first return
1 Chronicles 3:17–19	In David's royal line through Jehoiachin
Haggai 1:1, 12, 14; 2:2, 4, 21–23	Governor and God's chosen signet
Zechariah 4:6–10	"Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit"
Echo: Zechariah 4:14	"Two anointed ones," often taken as Zerubbabel and Joshua

New Testament

Matthew 1:12–13; Luke 3:27	"Zorobabel," ancestor of Jesus in both lines
Echo: 1 Corinthians 3:10–11	The foundation "which is Jesus Christ"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Zerubbabel and Jeshua build first, and why do you think they started there (Ezra 3:1–6)?
2. *Understand:* Why would God say "Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit" to a man leading a building project?
3. *Apply:* Zerubbabel's work stalled for sixteen years. Is there something God gave you to do that you have set aside? What would restarting look like?
4. *Apply:* Some wept because the new temple looked small. Where are you tempted to despise "the day of small things"?

110 Haggai and Zechariah

Two prophets who got a discouraged people building again, one with plain rebukes and one with visions of hope.

By 520 BC the temple's foundation had lain untouched for about sixteen years while the exiles built their own homes. Then God raised up two prophets. Haggai spoke short, direct messages: "Consider your ways." Within weeks the work began again. Zechariah, from a priestly family, called the people to return to the Lord and spoke of a King "lowly, and riding upon an ass." The temple was finished in 516/515 BC.

At a glance

Names	Haggai, probably "festive"; Zechariah, "the Lord remembers"
Family	Zechariah, "son of Berechiah, the son of Iddo" (Zech 1:1)
When	Haggai: 520 BC. Zechariah: 520 to at least 518 BC
Task	To stir the people to finish the temple and renew their faith
Key people	Zerubbabel the governor; Joshua the high priest; Darius I
Main passages	Ezra 5:1–2; 6:14; Haggai 1–2; Zechariah 1–14
New Testament	Hebrews 12:26; Zechariah in the Gospels' passion accounts

> *"And the elders of the Jews builded, and they prospered through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet and Zechariah the son of Iddo."*
>
> Ezra 6:14, KJV

The life of Haggai and Zechariah

Dates approximate (BC), counted by the reign of Darius I (from 522 BC).

c. 520 BC
6th month

The first message

Haggai says the people live in panelled houses while God's house lies in ruins. Within the month, the work begins again. *Haggai 1:1–15; Ezra 5:1–2*

c. 520 BC
7th month

The promise of glory

To those who think the new temple is "as nothing," Haggai says God will shake the nations and fill this house with greater glory. *Haggai 2:1–9*

c. 520 BC
8th month

Zechariah's first word

Zechariah calls the people not to be like their fathers: "Turn ye unto me … and I will turn unto you." *Zechariah 1:1–6*

c. 520 BC
9th month

Haggai's last messages

Haggai warns that unclean hearts make offerings unclean, promises blessing, and calls Zerubbabel God's signet. *Haggai 2:10–23*

c. 519 BC
11th month

The night visions

Zechariah sees visions by night, usually counted as eight, including a man measuring Jerusalem and a golden lampstand. *Zechariah 1:7–6:8*

c. 518–515 BC
Fasting and finishing

Mercy, then a finished temple

Zechariah answers a question about fasting: God wants justice, mercy and truth. The temple is finished in Darius's sixth year. *Zechariah 7:1–8:23; Ezra 6:14–15*

Group notes

Key activities

Zechariah 9–14 has no dates and a different style from chapters 1–8. Many scholars think these chapters come from a later prophet. Others hold that Zechariah wrote the whole book, perhaps later in his life.

1. **Haggai confronted misplaced priorities.** "Is it time for you ... to dwell in your cieled houses, and this house lie waste?" *Haggai 1:3–11*
2. **Haggai encouraged the builders.** He brought one short message from God: "I am with you, saith the LORD." *Haggai 1:13; 2:4–5*
3. **Haggai promised greater glory.** God would fill the plain new house with glory and "give peace" in it. *Haggai 2:6–9*
4. **Haggai taught about holiness.** Using questions for the priests, he showed that holiness does not rub off, but uncleanness does. *Haggai 2:10–19*
5. **Zechariah called for repentance.** He urged the people to turn back to God instead of repeating their fathers' mistakes. *Zechariah 1:1–6*
6. **Zechariah saw God's care in visions.** The Lord would be "a wall of fire" around Jerusalem, rebuke Satan and clothe Joshua in clean garments. *Zechariah 2:5; 3:1–5*
7. **Zechariah crowned Joshua as a sign.** He set crowns on the high priest's head and spoke of "the man whose name is The BRANCH," who would build the temple. *Zechariah 6:9–15*
8. **Zechariah put mercy above ritual.** He told the people to "shew mercy and compassions every man to his brother." *Zechariah 7:4–10*
9. **Zechariah announced a humble King.** "Thy King cometh unto thee ... lowly, and riding upon an ass." *Zechariah 9:9*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name them.

Old Testament

Ezra 5:1–2; 6:14	Their preaching helps the builders finish the temple
Nehemiah 12:4, 16	Iddo's priestly family among those who returned
Echo: Jeremiah 23:5	Zechariah's BRANCH echoes Jeremiah's righteous Branch

New Testament

Hebrews 12:26–27	Quotes Haggai 2:6 on God shaking heaven and earth
Matthew 21:4–5; 26:31	Jesus fulfils Zechariah 9:9 and quotes 13:7
Matthew 27:9–10	Thirty pieces of silver recall Zechariah 11:12–13
John 19:37; Revelation 1:7	"Him whom they pierced," from Zechariah 12:10
Matthew 23:35	"Zacharias son of Barachias": this prophet? Readers differ

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What were the people doing while God's house lay in ruins (Haggai 1:3–9)?
2. *Understand:* Why might God send a blunt prophet and a visionary one together?
3. *Apply:* "Consider your ways." Where is your time or money going that needs rethinking?
4. *Apply:* Fasting without mercy misses the point. What act of mercy can you do this week?

III Esther

The orphan who became queen of Persia and risked her life to save her people, "for such a time as this."

Esther was a Jewish orphan in the Persian capital of Shushan, raised by her cousin Mordecai. Chosen as queen by King Ahasuerus, she kept her Jewish identity secret. Then the king's chief official, Haman, won a decree to wipe out every Jew in the empire. Though going uninvited could mean death, after fasting she went in, won his favour, and at two banquets exposed Haman's plot. Her people were saved, and Purim still remembers it. The book never names God, yet his hand seems behind every turn.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew Hadassah, "myrtle"; Esther, perhaps "star" (Esther 2:7)
Family	Daughter of Abihail; raised by her cousin Mordecai (Esther 2:7, 15)
Husband	Ahasuerus, usually identified with Xerxes I (486–465 BC)
Became queen	c. 479 BC, in the king's seventh year (Esther 2:16–17)
Home	Shushan (Susa), the Persian royal city
Key people	Mordecai, Ahasuerus, Haman, Hegai, Hatach, Vashti
Legacy	The feast of Purim (Esther 9:26–32)
New Testament	Not named; the book is not quoted

> *"For if thou altogether holdest thy peace at this time, then shall there enlargement and deliverance arise to the Jews from another place … and who knoweth whether thou art come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"*
>
> Esther 4:14, KJV

The life of Esther

Dates approximate (BC), counted from Xerxes I; the Greek version calls the king Artaxerxes.

c. 483 BC
3rd year

The queen is deposed

Queen Vashti refuses the king's summons, and his advisers urge him to give her place to another. *Esther 1:3, 10–19*

Before she became queen

Brought to the palace

Esther is gathered with other young women. Hegai favours her, and on Mordecai's advice she hides her people. *Esther 2:7–11*

c. 479 BC
7th year, 10th month

Crowned queen

After twelve months of preparation she goes to the king, who loves her above all and crowns her. *Esther 2:12–18*

c. 479–474 BC
As queen

A plot uncovered

Esther reports, in Mordecai's name, a plot by two doorkeepers to kill the king. *Esther 2:19–23*

c. 474 BC
12th year, 1st month

A decree of death

Haman obtains a decree against the Jews. Esther calls a three-day fast: "if I perish, I perish." *Esther 3:7–4:17*

Three days later

Two banquets

The king holds out his sceptre to her. At her second banquet she names "this wicked Haman," and he is hanged. *Esther 5:1–8; 7:1–10*

c. 474–473 BC
3rd to 12th months

Deliverance and Purim

Esther pleads for a second decree; the Jews defend themselves, and Purim is confirmed. *Esther 8:3–17; 9:1–32*

Group notes

Key activities

The book of Esther never mentions God, prayer or the temple. Yet a string of "coincidences," from a sleepless king to perfectly timed banquets, turns the plot upside down. Many readers see here God's hidden care for his people.

1. **Won favour in a hard place.** Esther "obtained favour in the sight of all them that looked upon her," from Hegai to the king. *Esther 2:9, 15, 17*
2. **Honoured the man who raised her.** Even as queen, she still followed Mordecai's advice, "like as when she was brought up with him." *Esther 2:10, 20*
3. **Saved the king's life.** She passed on Mordecai's warning of an assassination plot and gave him the credit. *Esther 2:21–23*
4. **Sought the facts.** When Mordecai put on sackcloth, she sent Hatach, the attendant the king had given her, to learn exactly what was wrong. *Esther 4:4–9*
5. **Named the risk honestly.** She told Mordecai that anyone who came to the king uncalled could be put to death. *Esther 4:10–11*
6. **Called a fast.** She asked the Jews of Shushan to fast three days, and she and her maids fasted too. *Esther 4:15–16*
7. **Went in uninvited.** She put on her royal robes and stood in the inner court, and the king held out his sceptre. *Esther 5:1–3*
8. **Waited for the right moment.** Rather than blurt out her request, she hosted two banquets and let the king's curiosity grow. *Esther 5:4–8; 7:1–2*
9. **Spoke up for her people.** "Let my life be given me at my petition, and my people at my request." *Esther 7:3–6*
10. **Pleaded with tears.** Even after Haman's death, she fell at the king's feet: "how can I endure to see the evil that shall come unto my people?" *Esther 8:3–6*
11. **Fixed Purim in writing.** With Mordecai she wrote "with all authority" to confirm the feast for every generation. *Esther 9:29–32*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Esther. Tradition: Greek additions (in the Apocrypha) add prayers and name God; a traditional tomb stands in Hamadan, Iran.

Old Testament

Esther 1–10	The only book that tells her story
Ezra 4:6	"Ahasuerus," probably the same king as her husband
Esther 9:26–32	"The decree of Esther" confirms Purim
Echo: Genesis 41:37–45; Daniel 2:48	Like Joseph and Daniel, serving in a foreign court
Echo: Exodus 17:14–16; 1 Samuel 15:8	Haman the Agagite recalls the war with Amalek

New Testament

Echo: Mark 6:23	Herod's "half of my kingdom" echoes Esther 5:3
Echo: Hebrews 4:16	Believers may "come boldly unto the throne of grace"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Mordecai give Esther for going to the king (Esther 4:13–14)?
2. *Understand:* God is never named in Esther. How can we still see him at work in the story?
3. *Apply:* Esther found herself in a position she did not choose. Where has God placed you "for such a time as this"?
4. *Apply:* Esther prepared with fasting and patience before she spoke. Is there a hard conversation you need to prepare for this week? How will you get ready?

112 Mordecai

The Jew at the king's gate who raised Esther, would not bow to Haman, and rose to be second only to the king.

Mordecai was a Jewish official in the Persian royal city of Shushan who raised his orphaned cousin Esther as his own daughter. From the king's gate he uncovered a plot to kill the king. When he refused to bow to Haman, Haman plotted to destroy all the Jews. Mordecai put on sackcloth and urged Esther to act "for such a time as this." In the end the king gave him Haman's place, and he wrote the decree that saved his people. He and Esther set up the feast of Purim.

At a glance

Name	Probably Babylonian; many link it to the god Marduk
Family	"The son of Jair ... the son of Kish, a Benjamite" (Esther 2:5)
Relation to Esther	Her cousin, who adopted her (Esther 2:7, 15)
Position	The king's gate; later "next unto king Ahasuerus"
When	Reign of Ahasuerus, usually Xerxes I (486–465 BC)
Key people	Esther, Ahasuerus, Haman, Hatach, Bigthan and Teresh
Main passages	Esther 2–10
New Testament	Not named

> *"For Mordecai the Jew was next unto king Ahasuerus, and great among the Jews, and accepted of the multitude of his brethren, seeking the wealth of his people, and speaking peace to all his seed."*
>
> Esther 10:3, KJV

The life of Mordecai

Dates approximate (BC). Esther 2:6 says someone "carried away" with Jeconiah in 597 BC: Mordecai himself or his great-grandfather Kish. If Mordecai, he would have been very old by Xerxes' reign.

Before Esther became queen

Adopts his cousin

Mordecai brings up the orphaned Esther as his daughter and daily checks on her at the palace. *Esther 2:5–11*

c. 479–474 BC
At the king's gate

Saves the king's life

He uncovers a plot by two doorkeepers. It is recorded, but he receives no reward. *Esther 2:19–23*

c. 474 BC
12th year

Refuses to bow

The king promotes Haman and commands everyone at the gate to bow to him. Mordecai will not. When Haman learns that Mordecai is a Jew, he plots to destroy all the Jews. *Esther 3:1–6*

c. 474 BC
The same month

Sackcloth and a challenge

Mordecai tears his clothes and cries out in the city. He sends Esther a copy of the decree and urges her to plead with the king: "who knoweth whether thou art come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" *Esther 4:1–17*

The night before the second banquet

Honoured by his enemy

That night the sleepless king hears the record of Mordecai's loyalty and learns he was never rewarded. Haman, who came to ask for Mordecai's death, must lead him through the city on the king's horse. *Esther 6:1–12*

c. 474–473 BC
Given Haman's place

The new decree and Purim

The king gives Mordecai the signet ring he took from Haman. Mordecai writes a decree letting the Jews defend themselves and goes out in royal robes. Afterwards he sends letters setting up the yearly feast of Purim. *Esther 8:1–2, 9–17; 9:20–23*

Key activities

Why would Mordecai not bow? The text says only that "he had told them that he was a Jew" (Esther 3:4). Some think bowing to Haman seemed too close to worship. Others point to an old feud: Haman was an Agagite, perhaps descended from Agag, king of Amalek, while Mordecai came from the family of Kish, like King Saul (1 Samuel 15).

1. **Adopted an orphan.** He took his cousin Esther "for his own daughter" when her parents died. *Esther 2:7*
2. **Watched over her.** He walked by the women's court every day "to know how Esther did." *Esther 2:11*
3. **Exposed a plot.** He uncovered a plan to kill the king and passed it on through Esther. *Esther 2:21–23*
4. **Refused to bow.** He would not bow to Haman, even when the king's servants pressed him day after day. *Esther 3:2–4*
5. **Mourned openly.** He put on sackcloth and ashes and "cried with a loud and a bitter cry." *Esther 4:1–2*
6. **Challenged Esther.** He warned her that silence would not save her and trusted that deliverance would come "from another place." *Esther 4:13–14*
7. **Stayed humble when honoured.** After his ride through the city in royal robes, he "came again to the king's gate." *Esther 6:10–12*
8. **Wrote the counter-decree.** With the king's ring he wrote letters allowing the Jews to stand for their lives. *Esther 8:9–11*
9. **Set up Purim.** He wrote to all the Jews to keep two days of feasting, gifts and "gifts to the poor" every year. *Esther 9:20–22*
10. **Worked for his people's good.** As second to the king, he sought "the wealth of his people." *Esther 10:3*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Mordecai.

Old Testament

Esther 2–10	This is the main account of his life.
Ezra 2:2	and **Nehemiah 7:7.** A Mordecai returned with Zerubbabel. He is probably a different man.
Echoes	Like Joseph, Mordecai receives the king's ring, royal robes and a public parade (Genesis 41:42–43). His ancestor Kish shares a name with Saul's father (1 Samuel 9:1). "Whoso diggeth a pit shall fall therein" (Proverbs 26:27).

New Testament

Echoes	"Whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted" (Luke 14:11). Mary sings that God "hath put down the mighty from their seats" (Luke 1:52).
Tradition	By the time 2 Maccabees was written, in the second or first century BC, Purim was also called Mordecai's day (2 Maccabees 15:36, in the Apocrypha).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Mordecai do each day after Esther was taken into the palace (Esther 2:11)?
2. *Understand:* Mordecai said deliverance would come "from another place" if Esther stayed silent. What does that show about his faith?
3. *Apply:* Mordecai raised a child who was not his own. Who could you invest in, encourage or look out for this month?
4. *Apply:* Mordecai's good deed went unrewarded for years. How do you keep doing right when no one notices?

113 Haman

The proud official who plotted to destroy the Jews and was hanged on the gallows he built for Mordecai.

Haman was the most powerful official at the Persian court. King Ahasuerus promoted him above all the other princes and ordered everyone to bow to him. One man, Mordecai the Jew, would not. Haman's wounded pride grew into a plan to kill every Jew in the empire. He cast lots to choose the day, offered the king a fortune in silver, and got the decree sealed with the king's own ring. Yet Haman's plans turned against him at every step. He was made to honour the very man he hated, and he was exposed at Queen Esther's banquet. In the end he was hanged on his own gallows. His story shows how pride and hatred can destroy the one who carries them.

At a glance

Name	Probably Persian or Elamite. Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Hammedatha the Agagite; wife Zeresh; ten sons (Esther 3:1; 5:10; 9:7–10)
Position	Chief of the king's princes, with his seat set above them all (Esther 3:1)
Known as	"The Jews' enemy" (Esther 3:10; 8:1; 9:24)
When	In the reign of Ahasuerus (usually Xerxes I). His plot came in the king's 12th year, c. 474 BC
Death	Hanged on the gallows he had made for Mordecai (Esther 7:10)
New Testament	Not named

"So they hanged Haman on the gallows that he had prepared for Mordecai. Then was the king's wrath pacified."

Esther 7:10, KJV

The life of Haman

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the usual identification of Ahasuerus with Xerxes I (486–465 BC). Esther 3–7 covers less than a year of Haman's life.

Before c. 474 BC
Promoted

Raised above all the princes

King Ahasuerus promotes Haman, son of Hammedatha the Agagite, and sets his seat above all the princes. The king commands his servants at the gate to bow before him. Mordecai refuses. *Esther 3:1–4*

c. 474 BC
12th year, 1st month

The plot

Full of wrath, Haman decides to destroy all Mordecai's people. Lots are cast to choose the day. He offers ten thousand talents of silver, and the king gives him his ring. *Esther 3:5–11*

c. 474 BC
13th day, 1st month

The decree

Letters go out to every province ordering all Jews killed on the thirteenth of Adar. Then "the king and Haman sat down to drink; but the city Shushan was perplexed." *Esther 3:12–15*

The first banquet

Gallows for Mordecai

Haman leaves the queen's banquet overjoyed, until he sees Mordecai at the gate, who will not stand up for him. At home his wife and friends advise a gallows fifty cubits high. He has it built. *Esther 5:9–14*

The next day

Forced to honour Mordecai

Haman comes to ask for Mordecai's death, but the king asks him how to honour a man. Thinking he means himself, Haman describes a royal parade and must then lead Mordecai through the streets. *Esther 6:4–13*

The second banquet

Exposed and hanged

At the second banquet Esther names "this wicked Haman" as the enemy of her people. He falls on her couch begging for his life, but the king orders him hanged on his own gallows. *Esther 7:1–10*

Key activities

Haman is called "the Agagite." Many readers link this to Agag, king of the Amalekites, whom Saul spared (1 Samuel 15:8–9). That would make his hatred part of an ancient feud between Amalek and Israel. Others think "Agagite" names a Persian family or place.

1. **Rose to power.** The king promoted him and set his seat above all the princes. *Esther 3:1*
2. **Demanded honour.** He was full of wrath when Mordecai did not bow. *Esther 3:2–5*
3. **Hated a whole people.** He "thought scorn to lay hands on Mordecai alone" and set out to destroy all the Jews. *Esther 3:6*
4. **Slandered and bribed.** He told the king that "a certain people" did not keep the king's laws, and he offered to pay for their destruction. *Esther 3:8–9*
5. **Drank while the city was troubled.** After the decree went out, he sat down to drink with the king while Shushan was left in confusion. *Esther 3:15*
6. **Could not enjoy success.** He boasted of his riches and his sons, then said, "Yet all this availeth me nothing, so long as I see Mordecai the Jew." *Esther 5:11–13*
7. **Assumed the honour was his.** He thought, "To whom would the king delight to do honour more than to myself?" *Esther 6:6*
8. **Fell on his own trap.** He was hanged on the gallows he had built, and his plot returned "upon his own head." *Esther 7:9–10; 9:25*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Haman.

Old Testament

Esther 3–7	This is the main account of his rise and fall.
Esther 8:1–7; 9:10–14, 24–25	His house is given to Esther, his decree is overturned, and his ten sons die.
Echoes	Saul spared Agag, king of the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15:8–9, 32–33). "He made a pit, and digged it, and is fallen into the ditch which he made" (Psalm 7:15). "Pride goeth before destruction" (Proverbs 16:18).

New Testament

Echoes	"Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap" (Galatians 6:7). "God resisteth the proud" (James 4:6). "Whosoever hateth his brother is a murderer" (1 John 3:15).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Haman say to his wife and friends about all his riches and honours (Esther 5:11–13)?
2. *Understand:* How did one man's refusal to bow grow into a plan to destroy a whole people? What does that show about pride and anger?
3. *Apply:* Is there one person or slight that you keep thinking about, the way Haman kept seeing Mordecai? What would it take to let it go?
4. *Apply:* Haman could not enjoy all he had. What good things in your life can you thank God for this week, instead of focusing on what is missing?

114 Ezra

The priest and scribe who set his heart to study God's Law, live it and teach it to a people starting over.

Ezra was a priest descended from Aaron and a scholar of the Law of Moses. In 458 BC the Persian king Artaxerxes sent him from Babylon to Jerusalem with gifts for the temple and a commission to teach God's Law. He led a second group of exiles home, trusting God rather than soldiers. Finding that many had married into the surrounding peoples and their worship, he confessed the nation's sin as his own and led a painful reform. Later he read the Law aloud while the Levites helped the people understand. His life shows the power of God's Word taken seriously.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Ezra*, "help"
Family	A priest, "the son of Seraiah," descended from Aaron (Ezra 7:1–5)
Role	"A ready scribe in the law of Moses" (Ezra 7:6)
Came to Jerusalem	c. 458 BC, the seventh year of Artaxerxes I (Ezra 7:7–8)
Key people	Artaxerxes, Shechaniah, the Levites, Nehemiah
Main passages	Ezra 7–10; Nehemiah 8; 12:26, 36
Tradition	Jewish tradition credits him with gathering the Scriptures
New Testament	Not named

"For Ezra had prepared his heart to seek the law of the LORD, and to do it, and to teach in Israel statutes and judgments."

Ezra 7:10, KJV

The life of Ezra

Dates approximate (BC). Most date Ezra's arrival to 458 BC (Artaxerxes I); some prefer 398 BC, after Nehemiah. The text presents them working together (Nehemiah 8:9).

c. 458 BC
7th year of Artaxerxes

Sent by the king

Artaxerxes grants Ezra silver, gold and supplies, and power to appoint judges and teach the Law. *Ezra 7:6, 11–26*

c. 458 BC
1st month

Fasting by the river Ahava

Ezra sends for Levites and, ashamed to ask the king for soldiers, proclaims a fast for protection. *Ezra 8:15–23*

c. 458 BC
5th month

Safe arrival

The company reaches Jerusalem unharmed, for "the hand of our God was upon us." *Ezra 7:8–9; 8:31–36*

c. 458–457 BC
Soon after

Grief and reform

Told of mixed marriages, Ezra tears his garments and prays. The people gather in heavy rain, and the cases are examined. *Ezra 9:1–10:44*

c. 445/444 BC
7th month

Reading the Law

Ezra reads the Book from morning to midday, and the people keep the Feast of Tabernacles with joy. *Nehemiah 8:1–18*

Later

At the dedication of the wall

"Ezra the scribe" goes before one of the two great companies on the walls. *Nehemiah 12:26, 31–43*

Group notes

Key activities

Ezra's reform in chapter 10 is hard for many modern readers. The Law forbade such marriages because they would turn Israel to other gods (Deuteronomy 7:3–4). Christians differ on how it applies today. Paul tells a believer not to leave an unbelieving spouse who is willing to stay (1 Corinthians 7:12–14).

1. **Set his heart on God's Word.** He prepared himself to seek the Law, to do it and to teach it, in that order. *Ezra 7:10*
2. **Gave God the credit.** He praised God for putting it in the king's heart to beautify the temple. *Ezra 7:27–28*
3. **Recruited Levites.** He would not set out until Levites and temple servants had joined the group. *Ezra 8:15–20*
4. **Trusted God for protection.** He had told the king, "The hand of our God is upon all them for good that seek him," so he fasted instead of asking for soldiers. *Ezra 8:21–23*
5. **Handled money with care.** He weighed the treasure into the priests' hands and had it weighed and recorded again in Jerusalem. *Ezra 8:24–34*
6. **Grieved over sin.** He tore his clothes and sat "astonied" until the evening sacrifice. *Ezra 9:3–4*
7. **Confessed as one of the people.** He prayed, "O my God, I am ashamed and blush to lift up my face to thee." *Ezra 9:5–15*
8. **Led a hard reform.** Urged by Shechaniah, he called the people to confess and separate from the marriages. *Ezra 10:1–17*
9. **Read the Law aloud.** Standing on "a pulpit of wood," he opened the Book, and all the people stood. *Nehemiah 8:1–6*
10. **Made the Word clear.** He and the Levites "read in the book in the law of God distinctly, and gave the sense." *Nehemiah 8:7–8*
11. **Restored a forgotten feast.** He read the Law every day of the Feast of Tabernacles, kept as it had not been since Joshua. *Nehemiah 8:13–18*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Ezra. Jewish tradition credits him with fixing the Scriptures and writing Chronicles; 1 and 2 Esdras (Apocrypha) bear his name.

Old Testament

Ezra 7–10	His own account, much of it in the first person
Nehemiah 8:1–18	Reads the Law and leads the Feast of Tabernacles
Nehemiah 12:26, 36	Named with Nehemiah; leads a procession on the wall
Nehemiah 12:1, 13	An earlier priest Ezra, a different man
Echo: Deuteronomy 31:10–12; 2 Kings 23:1–3	The Law read to all the people

New Testament

Echo: Luke 4:16–21; 24:27	Jesus reads and opens the Scriptures
Echo: James 1:22	"Be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What three things did Ezra set his heart to do (Ezra 7:10)?
2. *Understand:* Why did the people weep at the Law, and why were they told to rejoice (Nehemiah 8:9–12)?
3. *Apply:* Ezra studied, obeyed, then taught. Which do you most need to grow in this week?
4. *Apply:* Ezra trusted God rather than soldiers. Where do you need to trust God over your own safety nets?

115 Nehemiah

The king's cupbearer who prayed, planned and rebuilt Jerusalem's walls in fifty-two days.

Nehemiah was cupbearer to the Persian king Artaxerxes I. Hearing that Jerusalem's walls lay in ruins, he wept and prayed. Then, with a quick silent prayer, he asked the king to send him to rebuild the city. As governor he rallied the people, and despite enemies the wall was finished in fifty-two days. He also defended the poor and later cleansed the temple. His memoir is full of short prayers: "Remember me, O my God, for good."

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Nechemyah*, "the Lord comforts"
Family	Son of Hachaliah; brother of Hanani (Nehemiah 1:1–2; 7:2)
Role	Cupbearer to Artaxerxes I, then governor (Neh 1:11; 5:14)
When	Came c. 445/444 BC; governor twelve years, to c. 433/432 BC
Enemies	Sanballat, Tobiah the Ammonite, Geshem (Nehemiah 2:19)
Key people	Hanani, Ezra, Eliashib the high priest
Main passages	Nehemiah 1–13
New Testament	Not named

> *"Then answered I them, and said unto them, The God of heaven, he will prosper us; therefore we his servants will arise and build: but ye have no portion, nor right, nor memorial, in Jerusalem."*
>
> Nehemiah 2:20, KJV

The life of Nehemiah

Dates approximate (BC), counted from Artaxerxes I (465–424 BC); scholars differ by a year.

c. 446/445 BC
20th year, Chisleu

Bad news from Jerusalem

In Shushan, Nehemiah hears that Jerusalem's wall is broken down. He weeps, fasts and prays. *Nehemiah 1:1–11*

c. 445 BC
20th year, Nisan

The king's question

When the king asks why he is sad, he prays silently, then asks to be sent to rebuild. *Nehemiah 2:1–8*

c. 445/444 BC
On arrival

A night inspection

He views the ruined walls by night, and the leaders answer, "Let us rise up and build." *Nehemiah 2:11–20*

c. 445/444 BC
During the building

Trowel, sword and justice

He arms the builders against attack and makes the nobles return what they took from the poor. *Nehemiah 4:1–23; 5:1–13*

c. 445/444 BC
25th of Elul

The wall finished

Despite traps and threats, the wall is completed in fifty-two days, "wrought of our God." *Nehemiah 6:1–16*

c. 433/432 BC and later

Second term and reforms

Returning to Jerusalem, he throws out Tobiah's goods, guards the Sabbath and confronts mixed marriages. *Nehemiah 13:4–31*

Group notes

Key activities

Nehemiah could be fierce. When he found Jews married to foreign wives, he "contended with them, and cursed them, and smote certain of them, and plucked off their hair" (Nehemiah 13:25). Some readers admire his zeal for God. Others see a leader whose methods went too far. The text records it without comment.

1. **Wept and prayed first.** He mourned for days and confessed the sins of Israel, including his own family's. *Nehemiah 1:4–11*
2. **Prayed on the spot.** When the king asked what he wanted, he sent up a silent prayer before he answered. *Nehemiah 2:4–5*
3. **Planned ahead.** He asked for letters of safe passage and for timber for the gates, the wall and his house. *Nehemiah 2:7–8*
4. **Looked before he spoke.** He inspected the walls by night and told no one his plan until he knew the facts. *Nehemiah 2:12–16*
5. **Rallied the people.** He shared how God's hand had been on him, and they said, "Let us rise up and build." *Nehemiah 2:17–18*
6. **Organised the work.** Families, priests and even goldsmiths each built a section, many near their own homes. *Nehemiah 3:1–32*
7. **Prayed and posted guards.** "We made our prayer unto our God, and set a watch against them day and night." *Nehemiah 4:9*
8. **Armed the builders.** Each worked with one hand and held a weapon with the other. *Nehemiah 4:13–18*
9. **Stopped injustice.** He forced the nobles to stop charging their own people interest and to return their land. *Nehemiah 5:1–13*
10. **Refused his allowance.** For twelve years he did not take the governor's food allowance, "because of the fear of God." *Nehemiah 5:14–19*
11. **Would not be distracted.** He answered his enemies, "I am doing a great work, so that I cannot come down." *Nehemiah 6:1–14*
12. **Dedicated the wall with joy.** Two great choirs walked the walls, and "the joy of Jerusalem was heard even afar off." *Nehemiah 12:27–43*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Nehemiah. Tradition: 2 Maccabees 2:13 (Apocrypha) says he founded a library of sacred books.

Old Testament

Nehemiah 1–13	His own memoir, mostly in the first person
Nehemiah 8:9; 10:1; 12:26, 47	Named governor ("Tirshatha") alongside Ezra
Ezra 2:2; Nehemiah 3:16	Two other men named Nehemiah
Echo: Psalm 127:1	"Except the LORD build the house ..."

New Testament

Echo: John 2:13–16	Jesus clears the temple, as Nehemiah threw out Tobiah's goods
Echo: Luke 14:28	Counting the cost before building

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Nehemiah do in the moment between the king's question and his answer (Nehemiah 2:4–5)?
2. *Understand:* Nehemiah both prayed and set a guard (Nehemiah 4:9). How do trusting God and taking practical action fit together?
3. *Apply:* Nehemiah was moved by news of broken walls far away. What need is God stirring your heart about, and what first step could you take?
4. *Apply:* His enemies tried to pull him away from "a great work." What distractions keep you from what God has given you to do, and how can you say no to one this week?

116 Malachi

The last prophet of the Old Testament, who called a tired people back to God and promised a messenger to prepare the way.

Malachi spoke to Judah about a century after the first exiles came home. The temple stood, but the excitement was gone. Priests offered blind and sick animals, husbands broke faith with their wives, and people held back their tithes. Malachi answered with sharp conversations: God speaks, the people push back with "Wherein?", and God explains. Beneath the rebukes is a tender message: "I have loved you, saith the LORD." He promised a messenger to prepare the way and pointed to Elijah, a promise the New Testament sees fulfilled in John the Baptist.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew *Mal'akhi,* "my messenger"; perhaps a title
Family	Not given
When	Probably c. 430 BC, near Nehemiah's time (rough)
Audience	Priests and people of Judah under a Persian governor (Mal 1:8)
Style	Usually counted as six "disputes" answering "Wherein?"
Last words	A promise to send "Elijah the prophet" (Malachi 4:5–6)
New Testament	Quoted of John the Baptist (Mark 1:2; Luke 1:17) and Romans 9:13

"Behold, I will send my messenger, and he shall prepare the way before me: and the Lord, whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple … saith the LORD of hosts."

Malachi 3:1, KJV

The life of Malachi

Malachi gives no dates and no personal details. Most place him c. 430 BC because the temple is standing, a governor rules, and he deals with the same problems Nehemiah faced. The entries below set his message in its setting.

c. 516/515 BC
Before Malachi

The temple rebuilt

The second temple is finished and dedicated with joy, and the priests and Levites are set in their places. More than eighty years later, Malachi speaks to the priests who serve at its altar. *Ezra 6:15–18*

c. 445/444 BC
Before Malachi

A covenant signed

Under Nehemiah and Ezra, the people promise in writing not to intermarry with idol worshippers, to bring their firstfruits and tithes, and not to neglect God's house. Malachi's hearers have broken these promises. *Nehemiah 10:28–39*

c. 430 BC (rough)
Malachi's ministry

Broken promises

Malachi confronts careless priests, blemished sacrifices, broken marriages, marriage to idol worshippers and withheld tithes. These are the same sins Nehemiah fought on his return, which is why many date the two men close together. *Malachi 1:6–2:16; 3:7–10; Nehemiah 13:10–29*

c. 430 BC (rough)
Malachi's last words

Remember and wait

Malachi urges the people to remember the law of Moses and promises that Elijah the prophet will come before the great day of the Lord, to turn the hearts of fathers and children to each other. *Malachi 4:4–6*

About four centuries later

The messenger announced

An angel tells the priest Zechariah (Zacharias in the KJV) that his son John will go before the Lord "in the spirit and power of Elias," just as Malachi foretold. *Luke 1:13–17*

Key activities

Some scholars think "Malachi" is a title, "my messenger," taken from Malachi 3:1, rather than the prophet's name. The Greek Old Testament translates it as "his messenger." An old Jewish tradition identified Malachi with Ezra. Most readers simply take it as the prophet's name.

1. **Declared God's love.** He began with God's words, "I have loved you," and answered the people's doubt about it. *Malachi 1:2–5*
2. **Rebuked worthless offerings.** He told the priests they would not dare offer blind and lame animals to their governor. *Malachi 1:6–14*
3. **Called priests back to their calling.** "The priest's lips should keep knowledge," for he is God's messenger. *Malachi 2:1–9*
4. **Defended faithful marriage.** He warned against breaking faith with "the wife of thy youth," for God "hateth putting away." *Malachi 2:13–16*
5. **Promised the Lord's coming.** God would send his messenger, and then come like "a refiner's fire." *Malachi 3:1–5*
6. **Called the people to return.** "Return unto me, and I will return unto you." He urged them to bring the whole tithe and test God's faithfulness. *Malachi 3:7–12*
7. **Encouraged the faithful.** Those who feared the Lord spoke together, and "a book of remembrance was written before him." *Malachi 3:16–18*
8. **Pointed to the dawn.** For those who fear God, "the Sun of righteousness" will rise "with healing in his wings." *Malachi 4:1–3*

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Malachi. Tradition counts him the last prophet; the "four hundred silent years" before John is not a Bible phrase.

Old Testament

Malachi 1:1	The only verse that names him
Nehemiah 10:28–39; 13:10–29	The same problems in Nehemiah's day
Echo: Genesis 25:23; Isaiah 40:3	Jacob chosen; a voice preparing the way

New Testament

Matthew 11:10; Mark 1:2; Luke 7:27	Malachi 3:1 applied to John the Baptist
Luke 1:17	John comes "in the spirit and power of Elias"
Matthew 11:14; 17:10–13	Jesus says John is the Elijah to come
Romans 9:13	Paul quotes Malachi 1:2–3 on Jacob and Esau

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did the people answer when God said, "I have loved you" (Malachi 1:2)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God cared so much about the quality of the people's offerings (Malachi 1:6–14)?
3. *Apply:* Malachi's hearers had grown bored with God. Where has your faith become routine, and what could renew it?
4. *Apply:* Malachi 3:16 says the faithful "spake often one to another." Who could you encourage in their faith this week?